

AN ADULT EPIC FANTASY NOVEL

THE MARCH BENEATH NINE MOUNTAINS



T. K. ARVEN

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Part I

Chapter 1 — The Mountain Takes a Step

Korra Vaun hung beneath the bridge with one boot hooked through a rope stirrup and her right hand pressed against a shedstone rib.

“Third drum,” she called.

Above her, Sava struck the testing frame. The note traveled through the bridge in a clean descending hum. Six loaded grain carts stood wheel to wheel across the span, their drivers waiting on the far ledge. The bridge bowed twelve finger-widths, held, then gave back four. Within tolerance. Korra shifted her palm toward the next joint and felt for the loose chatter that would mean a badly seated pin.

Instead, a pulse rose through the cliff.

It struck too soon.

Kharad’s settling tremors came slowly enough for a bridge crew to finish a meal between them. This one arrived while the echo of the last still clung to Korra’s jaw. Heat passed through the shedstone, followed by a pressure that made her molars ache.

“Clear the deck,” she said.

The cart drivers did not move. They had heard caution in her voice, not alarm.

Korra kicked free of the stirrup and caught the climbing line. “Get those wagons off my bridge. Now.”

Sava knew the difference. Her aunt slashed the release rope on the eastern testing frame, dropping its timber crossbar across the approach. “Drivers, downhill. Leave the loads if a wheel binds.”

The first cart rolled. The second driver hauled his team around too hard and clipped a parapet rope. Korra climbed past the knot without looking down at the gorge. Below, the lower orchards fell away in green shelves toward the western haze. Harth rose above them in stacked districts: dark foundation walls, pale roofs, lichen terraces, cistern towers, and the old imperial keep on the highest shoulder. Every map put the city on a mountain named Kharad. Maps liked nouns that stayed where surveyors left them.

A second pressure gathered under Korra’s hand.

This time the stone rib twisted.

The bridge did not fail. Its eastern anchorage moved six paces north while the western ledge dropped. Ropes snapped tight. A pylon foot tore free and flung chips across the deck. One grain cart slid sideways, its axle screaming against stone.

Korra reached the upper rail as the world tilted.

Not shook. Tilted.

The gorge swung beneath her. Orchard walls leaned outward. Far above, Harth's bell towers described a slow arc against the sky. A roof came loose and skated across three terraces before bursting into tiles. The air filled with masonry dust and the startled roar of twelve thousand voices arriving at once.

Kharad lifted.

For one impossible stretch of breath, the western landscape sank below the mountain's shoulder. Ridges appeared where the horizon had been. Then a sound deeper than thunder rolled from somewhere under the farms. Korra felt the immense transfer of weight through every rope in the span.

The footfall struck.

A shock traveled east. Bridge anchors jumped in their sockets. Korra wrapped both forearms around the upper cable and watched the loaded cart tip toward the gorge.

"Cut the trace!" she shouted.

The driver stared at his horses.

Sava reached him first. She sliced the rear trace, then the forward one. Two grain bins tore away with the cart and dropped. The horses fell against the rail but remained on the bridge. Korra hauled herself over the cable, crawled to the driver, and drove her shoulder into his hip until he moved.

"Downhill ledge," she said. "Take the teams. Do not wait for the grain."

A third tremor ran beneath them, smaller and ragged. Korra counted the bridge's rebounds. One, two, a sickening lateral sway, then recovery.

"Can it hold?" Sava asked.

"For people. No wagons." Korra pulled the copper whistle from her collar. Three short blasts called every Vaun hand within hearing to route duty. "Strip the test loads. Set crossing ropes at both ends. Anyone coming down from Harth goes over in groups of thirty."

A man in an imperial gray coat stumbled onto the western approach. Warden Pel Marr had lost his cap and gained a stripe of blood down one cheek. "Close this span. Foundation collapse below Brass Market. We need an inspection."

"You can inspect it after the city crosses."

"This route falls under ward authority during a structural emergency."

Korra pointed at the horizon. Dust climbed in a long curtain beyond the western escarpment, forty kilometers of slope shedding loose stone. "Name that structure."

Marr looked. His mouth worked once before discipline found it.

"A local subsidence," he said. "Possibly several linked faults."

"Faults do not take steps."

The first civilians reached the ledge: orchard workers with sap baskets still tied to their backs, children barefoot from the Green Mantle sleeping rooms, two elders carrying a third between them. Behind those came a surge dense enough to crush anyone who fell.

Korra seized Marr's gray collar. "You want authority? Hold that approach to thirty at a time. If your wardens draw steel on this bridge, I will throw you off it."

His eyes settled on the old burn crossing her forearm. Recognition followed. Kestrel Cut had taught imperial officers her name, though never the lesson she wished they had learned.

Marr unclipped his baton and raised it toward the crowd. "Thirty! Families remain together. No carts, no market goods. Keep the western landing open."

Korra released him and ran uphill.

Harth had changed shape. Long terraces designed to drain south now sloped east. Cistern water rushed along streets that had never carried a stream. A row of dye houses leaned against one another, their roof beams groaning in sequence. People poured from doorways and chose whatever direction the body ahead had chosen.

That could kill them faster than falling stone.

At the first junction, Korra climbed a fountain plinth. "Brass Market is closed. Lower orchards take the bridge road. Crown district, use North Steps. Anyone from the dye houses follows the blue cord."

No blue cord existed yet. She pulled the sash from a stunned courier, tied it around a lamp post, and sent him to find every bolt of blue cloth in the dyers' lane.

"You stole my sash," he said.

"I promoted it."

The joke steadied him enough to run.

Sava came up from the bridge with six Vaun riggers. Korra divided them without ceremony. Two went to North Steps with coil rope. Two checked the retaining walls beneath Brass Market. Sava took the remaining pair toward the western cistern, where a crack had opened wide enough to swallow runoff.

"Where will you be?" her aunt asked.

"Where people stop moving."

"That describes half the city."

"Then start with the half on fire."

A grain yard below Red Hook had caught from a toppled kiln. Pela Orr stood at its gate, beating sparks from her coat while laborers rolled barrels away from the flames. She had tied a wet flour sack over her hair. Three armed store clerks guarded the intact granary doors.

"Korra," Pela called. "Tell these men grain burns whether thieves touch it or

not.”

The senior clerk held up an ivory inventory seal. “Emergency release requires the factor’s mark and a ward countersign.”

“I am the factor,” Pela said.

“Your district seal is inside.”

Beyond him, heat shimmered around the counting room.

Korra took the ivory tab, snapped it against the gatepost, and handed back both pieces. “Now it requires nothing. Open the eastern bins. Wet every sack you can carry. Move them to the bridge camps.”

The clerk reached for her arm. Pela stepped between them.

“Choose,” Pela said. “You can guard ashes or carry food.”

He looked toward the counting room. A roof beam collapsed in a bloom of sparks. He unlocked the granary.

Another pulse climbed through the street. Unlike the first, it faltered midway, a contraction that could not complete. The paving stones rose under Korra’s boots and settled crooked. She heard screams uphill.

The Bellward lodging house had folded into the street.

Its front wall lay flat beneath a fan of beams and plaster. People clawed at the wreckage with bare hands. Korra found a surviving stair stringer, tested its load, then put eight workers along it. They raised enough debris for two children to crawl free. A woman trapped at the waist directed them toward a nursery room farther inside.

“My legs can wait,” she said. “There were six in the room.”

Korra did not promise. She marked the woman’s position with red chalk and sent a rigger through a gap beside the chimney. They found four children alive. The fifth had died beneath a cupboard. The sixth did not answer.

A warden arrived with a casualty slate and orders to clear the lane for soldiers.

“Clear another lane,” Korra told him.

“The garrison commander needs access to the lower gate.”

“Then his soldiers can lift.”

Perhaps the city’s tilt had loosened more than stone. The warden obeyed. Twenty imperial spearmen set aside shields and raised the lodging-house beam while the woman beneath it bit through a leather strap. Her legs came free broken and bloodless. Pela’s grain porters carried her toward a lichen clinic on a flour door.

By midday the counting began.

Numbers reached Korra as names first. Three masons in Brass Market. Seven orchard workers below the western wall. An entire household of nine under a

cistern stair. The child by the nursery cupboard. Two bridge hands killed when a maintenance span peeled from the cliff. More arrived from alleys she had not seen.

Harth's registry listed 12,480 residents at dawn. It did not include caravan crews camped outside the foundation wall or seasonal pickers sleeping in orchard sheds. Korra ordered separate slates rather than letting unregistered people disappear into a convenient total.

At the south terrace, a crowd had stalled before a crack across the road. The gap measured only four paces, but hot air breathed from it. A mason had thrown a door over the opening. People hesitated at the dark warmth below.

Korra crossed first on hands and knees. The door flexed. She anchored a rope around a rain post and returned for a boy whose father had frozen at the edge.

"Look at my shoulder," she told the boy. "Nothing else."

"What is down there?"

"I don't know."

His father flinched at the answer.

Korra kept her voice level. "I know this board holds one child and one pathwright. That will do for now."

They crossed. The father followed. Once the first family reached the far side, the crowd began moving again.

The lichen clinic occupied three connected orchard houses. Its floors had slipped at different angles, so healers lashed treatment tables to ceiling roots and worked with their knees braced against walls. Korra entered through an upstairs window because the door had jammed beneath its lintel. The broken woman from Bellward lay beside a vintner with a crushed chest. Four children waited under one blanket, each holding a corner as if assigned to keep it from escaping.

A Green Mantle healer caught Korra by the wrist. Pale diagnostic lichen covered his scalp and shoulders, its outer threads browned by dust. "Stop sending people here. The lower root bed burned after the first pulse. We have twenty places and sixty-one patients."

"Where can you move them?"

"Nowhere level."

"Level is gone. Tell me what you need."

The healer looked around as another stretcher came through the window. "Shade. Water that hasn't crossed the dye quarter. Routes without stairs for the chest injuries."

Korra spread her route board across a tilted potting shelf. The city plan already lied: alleys had narrowed, southbound drains ran east, and three marked courtyards held fallen roofs. She crossed out the North Steps for litters. The suspended bridge could flex, but its western approach rose too sharply for bearers

carrying broken legs. That left the old mule trace behind the glassworks, a route the ward office had closed after a retaining wall cracked six years ago.

"Has anyone checked Glass Trace?" she asked.

A clinic porter shook his head. "Wardens chained it."

"Good. That means crowds haven't tested it for us."

She took two riggers, a coil of blue cord, and the least frightened of Hollen's spearmen. They reached the chained gate through an alley full of spilled apples. The imperial lock resisted the rigger's hammer. Korra gave the soldier a stone chisel.

"You're asking me to break a ward seal."

"I'm telling you a physician needs a litter road."

"My sergeant will dock my pay."

"Give me his name. I'll dock his bridge access."

The soldier put his weight behind the chisel. The lock split.

Glass Trace clung to the outer slope beneath a wall of blue-black slag blocks. Its first turn had survived. The second had lost half its width to the gorge, while the inner half remained seated on ancient shedstone ribs. Korra crawled along it with a tapping mallet. Each blow returned a clear note until the final bend, where a hidden void swallowed the sound.

She marked the danger in red and built a bypass through the abandoned cooling sheds. Workers cleared broken glass into baskets rather than sweeping it downhill onto houses. Sava sent four bridge ribs and a tension drum from the testing span. By the time the clinic's first litter arrived, the route had hand ropes, shaded pauses, and a rule that no bearer team passed another on the narrow turn.

The injured woman from Bellward traveled first. Her face had gone gray, but she remained conscious. "The sixth child?" she asked Korra.

Rescuers had found him beneath the nursery wall after the woman left. He had not survived.

Korra knelt beside the litter. A commander could delay truth for calm, and a pathwright could call the delay necessary until it became a habit. "He died before we reached the room," she said. "Four came out alive. The fifth died by the cupboard."

The woman shut her eyes. One hand tightened around the litter rail. "Their names are Jessa, Cori, Pell, and Min. The living ones. Don't count only the dead."

Korra wrote all four names on the route board. She added the two dead children beneath them, then ordered a porter to keep the list with the clinic group. Numbers moved crowds. Names kept the movement from consuming its reason.

By late afternoon, fires smoldered under wet grain sacks and rescue crews had searched every reported collapse twice. The casualty slate held fifty-four dead.

Eleven more remained missing beyond the western retaining wall, but witnesses had seen them enter an upper pasture before the movement. Korra refused to merge uncertain lives into the death count.

Commander Hollen met her beneath the keep. He wore polished armor over a dust-streaked shirt and had arranged his wardens in a line wide enough to imply stability.

"The regency has declared a linked foundation incident," he said. "Harth will remain under garrison administration. Civilian movement beyond district boundaries is suspended."

"People need to leave the upper terraces before another pulse."

"They need order."

"They need routes."

"The Sable Stair will close at sunset. No departures until labor rolls, tax stores, and military supplies have been secured."

Korra stared at him. The Sable Stair carried the safest eastern descent from Kharad's shoulder. Every lesser road had narrower cuts, decayed spans, or exposure to falling plate. Closing it trapped the city above the one route broad enough for carts and clinic litters.

"You counted supplies before bodies," she said.

"I have fifty-four confirmed dead because unauthorized movement clogged rescue lanes."

"You have fifty-four dead because the ground stood up."

Hollen lowered his voice. "Careful, Captain Vaun. Panic has weight. Your language adds to it."

She could hear Kestrel Cut in the sentence. Eighteen years earlier, an officer had praised her bridge because imperial cavalry crossed it six hours ahead of schedule. Harrow Camp's families had received no schedule at all. Efficiency had carried armed men perfectly. She had spent half her life pretending the route had remained innocent.

Sava arrived with a cracked helmet under one arm. "Western cistern secured. North Steps can take foot traffic, not loaded carts."

Hollen addressed her instead. "Architect Vaun, does your company accept temporary city command?"

Sava glanced at Korra. "Ask the captain."

The offered authority carried a hook. Accept it, and the garrison could blame Vaun pathwrights for every blocked lane. Refuse it, and Hollen would close crossings in the name of control.

Korra looked downhill. Wardens already hauled iron barriers toward the Sable Stair. Families waited beside bundles they had packed without permission.

"I accept evacuation command," she said. "Civilian routes and bridge crews answer to me until the ground holds for three full pulse intervals. Supply guards answer to you. Any warden who blocks a medical litter loses his barrier."

Hollen's expression narrowed. "The Stair still closes."

"Then put your name on that order where everyone can read it."

He did.

Sunset turned the dust copper. Korra walked beyond the last houses to an old Vaun roadstone set beside a path the empire had paved over. Generations of pathwrights had pressed route marks into its shedstone face. Rain had softened many. One remained sharp: two roads dividing around a hollow, neither line crowned above the other.

She knelt and set her palm against it.

The next pulse came in less than a minute.

Through loose paving and buried foundation ribs, it reached the marker as a broad pressure. Korra expected fracture noise. Instead she felt a gathering, a push held too long against resistance, then a shudder that traveled away beneath the eastern slope. Pain had no single frequency, yet every bridge builder learned the vibration of a rope cutting into wood, a pin grinding against a hole too small for it, a loaded span asking to be released.

This carried that shape, vast enough to dwarf the city.

Korra kept her hand down until the roadstone cooled. The pulse did not give her a word. It did not explain what had moved or why. It only repeated the held pressure and sent the shudder east.

Behind her, chains rattled as imperial troops sealed the Sable Stair.

She rose, marked the roadstone with evacuation blue, and sent runners to every district with the first night order: three assembly grounds, no single queue, clinic litters before property carts. Then she walked back toward Harth to prepare twelve thousand people for the next step.

Chapter 2 — Physician of the Lichen Crown

Thalen Iri cut the burned mantle away one thread at a time while the treatment floor rolled beneath his knees.

“Stay awake,” he told the orchard worker.

“I’m trying.”

“Try by telling me what you touched.”

“A root brace. When the terrace moved.” Her teeth clicked between words. “I grabbed it before the children fell.”

The lichen along her left palm had blackened to the wrist. No flame had reached her. Each ruined filament curled inward around a line of gray skin, as if heat had traveled from the stone into the symbiosis and stopped only where flesh carried no cultivated growth.

Thalen slid a wet bone comb under the next fused strand. The worker hissed. He separated healthy green from dead black and passed the comb to his assistant.

“Cool rinse, no dormancy tincture. Mark her for pulse observation.”

The orchard house serving as their clinic leaned downhill. Every table had been lashed to a root column. Patients lay shoulder to shoulder on bark mats, their bodies angled toward the eastern wall. Outside, bridge crews shouted route numbers. Dust filtered through the living roof and dulled the colored lichen panels that gave Green Mantle its name.

A pressure passed through the floor.

Every cultivated thread on Thalen’s scalp tightened.

The sensation lasted only three heartbeats. The patient beneath his hands arched hard enough to strain the table ropes. Across the clinic, six Ilaith healers cried out together. Their mantles carried the same abrupt contraction, a resonance burn delivered through contact with Kharad’s root-fed terraces.

Thalen put both palms over the worker’s forearm until her shaking eased. He had treated kiln lesions, winter dormancy rot, quarry dust scarring, and the slow silvering that came when an old mantle no longer exchanged enough air. This injury belonged to none of them.

He knew its pattern.

For twenty-two years he had called lesser versions harmless settling.

A porter pushed through the clinic screen. “Physician Iri, the lower root beds have gone copper. Keeper Seln says the color is spreading.”

Thalen looked toward his senior assistant, Eshai. She had worked beside him for thirty-eight seasons and could read a silence as carefully as fever.

“Take the hand,” he said. “Do not apply White Canopy masking culture.”

Eshai's gaze sharpened. "You prescribed that culture after the winter pulse."

"I was wrong."

The words left a clean cut behind them. He had no time to examine it.

He crossed the clinic and ducked through a door grown low beneath braided roots. The diagnostic garden occupied a shaded terrace behind the orchard houses. Narrow beds of listening lichen ran in nine concentric arcs around a central shedstone basin. Green Mantle physicians had used them for generations to measure water movement, soil strain, and the deep vibrations they described to imperial surveyors as mountain settling.

Every bed had changed color.

The outer arcs showed rust. The inner ones had gone dark violet, their fronds flattened toward the east. At the center, water jumped in the basin without spilling, each ripple beginning beneath the stone rather than at its edge.

Keeper Seln knelt beside the fourth arc with a measuring frame. "Interval is forty-seven breaths. It was nine minutes yesterday."

"Depth?"

"Past the longest root."

Thalen removed his gloves. His own mantle stirred against his shoulders, pale green filaments tasting moisture and air. He pressed two fingers to the listening bed.

Pain entered as compression.

No voice accompanied it. No image rose from the stone. The lichen transmitted only pattern: pressure driven inward at one location, resistance around it, then a radiating shock each time the pressure met a living pulse. Kharad's movement had made that rhythm violent, but the structure had existed long before today.

Thalen followed the contraction through three cycles. His fingertips went cold. A high ringing gathered behind his ears.

Seln pulled his hand away. "You'll lose consciousness."

"Bring the current sheet."

The keeper fetched a waxed green folio from the instrument cabinet. Today's raw marks ran across it in black: interval, amplitude, root reaction, mantle burn, directional distortion. Thalen laid it beside the public sheet already prepared for the ward office.

The public record showed mild variation.

His correction marks had lowered amplitude by half and spread the intervals into a reassuring average. He had made the alterations at dawn, before Kharad moved, repeating a method so practiced that his hand had scarcely paused. The numbers had been dishonest then. Beside the violet beds, they looked obscene.

Seln read both sheets. "These cannot describe the same day."

"They do."

"Who corrected the public copy?"

Thalen heard stretchers arriving at the clinic. He saw Eshai's expression when he had admitted a single wrong prescription. Twenty-two years could not fit into the answer Seln wanted.

"I did."

The keeper sat back on his heels. "Today?"

"Today, and before."

"How far before?"

A bell rang from the guest court, three measured notes demanding the ranking physician. Orinel Thyr had arrived from Orun six days earlier to inspect Green Mantle's annual culture allotment. She had spent the visit praising their orchards while cutting their access to the diagnostic strains those orchards required.

Thalen rolled the raw sheet closed. "Keep every instrument running. Admit no imperial clerk without Eshai present."

"You haven't answered."

"I will. First I have to keep someone from making the answer disappear."

Before he answered the guest bell, Thalen ordered Seln to bring the oldest uncorrected growth plates from the bed house. The keeper returned with a cedar tray of translucent lichen membranes, each dried at the end of a diagnostic season. Their colored veins preserved pulse amplitude more faithfully than copied numbers. Court reports could be amended; living growth had already made its record.

They laid the newest plate over one from twenty-three years earlier. The branching discoloration aligned at the center but extended twice as far today. Another plate, taken the year before Senri's descent, carried a narrow violet thread from the same point toward the eastern edge.

"That line doesn't appear in the public atlas," Seln said.

"I removed it from the tracing."

The keeper looked at him across the basin. "Because you thought the bed had been contaminated?"

"Because Orinel said an unconfirmed direction would close the lower orchards for structural review. Four hundred workers would have lost their plots."

"Did they keep the plots?"

"For that season."

"And after?"

Thalen knew the answer. Root owners had absorbed most of those beds within six years, citing erratic yields. The workers he had protected from one closure lost

their claims by quieter means.

A shout rose from the clinic. Two porters carried in a boy with his arms locked around a chunk of broken foundation root. The stone had fused to the lichen across his chest. Each pulse tightened his body around it.

Thalen ran back. "Do not pull."

The boy's father had both hands on the core, trying to wrench it free. "It's crushing him."

"It has hooked the mantle. Pulling will take skin."

Thalen slid a mirror beneath the warm stone. Fine white filaments from the child's chest had entered pores in its surface and burned there. He could cut the mantle, but the next contraction might tear the wound before he tied the vessels. Leaving the stone against him risked carrying resonance deeper.

"Eshai, support his shoulders. Seln, bring the basin frame."

They set a curved shedstone bar across the table and wedged the fused core beneath it. Safe shedstone could carry a shaped vibration without answering like living material. Thalen struck the bar softly with a tuning spoon. The first note made the boy vomit. The second loosened three burned filaments. He changed the contact point and tried a lower tone.

The foundation fragment released its heat in a sudden breath. Eshai lifted the boy while Thalen cut the remaining dead threads. Blood welled across the child's chest, dark beneath the pale mantle. His father held the rinse bowl and wept without sound.

"What did he touch?" Thalen asked when the wound lay dressed.

"A spike came through our cellar wall. He thought his sister was under it."

"Was she?"

"She got out through the coal window."

Thalen examined the broken fragment in the mirror. One face showed ordinary foundation mortar. The other carried narrow red veins and a drilled channel blackened by old metal. Warmth persisted despite the separation from the terrace.

"Store this away from the patients," he told Eshai. "Clay cradle. No iron shelf."

The father caught his sleeve. "Will my boy's mantle grow back?"

"Some of it. The scarred patch may not take a graft."

"Why did a foundation stone burn him?"

Thalen glanced toward the clerks' court. A harmless-settling statement would turn this injury into unfortunate contact with a damaged support. The lie already had a place prepared for it.

"Because the stone came from living tissue," he said. "I do not yet know why it sat inside your wall."

The father absorbed the answer. Fear followed, then anger. Neither could be treated with a tincture.

Thalen returned to the garden and wrapped the newest growth membrane around the raw pulse sheet. If an official seized the written marks, the lichen plate would still carry amplitude and direction. He handed the tray of older membranes to Seln.

"Move these to the clinic cistern cache. Tell Eshai exactly what they show."

"Are you preserving evidence or medicine?"

"Today they require the same care."

The summons sounded again from the guest court, three notes demanding the ranking physician.

The guest court had lost none of its composure. Root-braided walls flexed with Kharad's tremors. Low benches remained fixed around a clear pool, and attendants gathered fallen blossom petals before they could stain the water. Orinel sat beneath a white lichen canopy brought from Orun in sealed clay trays. Age had silvered the edges of her mantle without thinning it.

Two imperial ward clerks waited behind her.

"Thalen," Orinel said. "You smell of burned culture."

"People are burned."

"So I have heard. Sit."

He remained standing.

Orinel dismissed the clerks with a glance. They moved beyond the screen but not out of hearing. Thalen had once admired her ability to create privacy without claiming it existed.

"The garrison requires a diagnostic statement," she said. "Green Mantle families require access to an orderly evacuation. Those needs can support each other."

"Kharad's pulse accelerated below one minute. Root beds show focused compression and radiating pain. This does not meet harmless-settling criteria."

Her mantle did not move. "The criteria account for post-collapse exaggeration."

"The reading began before the collapse."

"Then amend the interval without changing the classification."

Thalen placed the public sheet on the low table. "I already changed too much."

Orinel studied the roll without opening it. "You changed what stewardship required."

"Did Senri?"

That reached her. A faint contraction moved along the white threads at her temples.

"Your sister had courage," Orinel said. "She also had a talent for converting

partial readings into absolute demands.”

“She died below the maintenance line.”

“She died because she descended during an unstable cycle after being ordered to wait.”

“And her final diagnostic?”

“Unconfirmed.”

Thalen had heard the answer for twenty-five years. In earlier seasons it sounded like professional caution. Today he heard the work hidden inside the word: a report denied instruments, witnesses dispersed, cultures sealed, conclusions made impossible to confirm.

Orinel poured water into two cups. The pool shivered beneath them, although neither cup did.

“Listen to me as your teacher,” she said. “Harth’s roads cannot carry everyone at once. The Green Mantle root owners maintain medicines used across the western courts. If their movement becomes entangled with general labor evacuation, cultures that took centuries to breed will be trampled in an afternoon. The garrison will reserve canopy passage if our statement prevents panic.”

“Which canopy?”

“Do not make class accusation where triage is required.”

“Low-root workers carry those culture beds.”

“They will travel with assigned trays.”

“Families?”

Orinel’s pause answered.

Thalen touched the edge of his own mantle. Senri had taught him to trim it when he entered apprenticeship. She had laughed at his fear of cutting living threads and told him that care without injury existed only in ceremonial paintings.

“How long have you known the pulse centers below the throat terraces?” he asked.

“Kharad contains many deep stresses.”

“That did not answer me.”

“I will not discuss sealed diagnostics during an emergency.”

Orinel pushed the second cup toward him. “Issue the harmless-settling statement. I will secure eighty Green Mantle places on the first protected descent through Sable Stair, including your clinic cultures.”

“Eighty out of how many?”

“Enough to preserve the court.”

The clinic held sixty-one patients from one district. Harth held thousands. Orinel offered survival as an institutional sample, carefully chosen to reproduce the

people who had chosen it.

Thalen left the cup untouched.

"I need to verify the root beds," he said.

"You need to decide whether truth serves the living when spoken without capacity."

He turned at the screen.

Orinel's voice followed him. "If you alter the classification, White Canopy will suspend diagnostic cultures to this terrace. No burn strain. No dormancy stabilizer. No graft lichen. Consider what your honesty will cost patients who never signed your argument."

Thalen stopped. She had trained him too well. Every threat arrived clothed in a body he might fail to heal.

"I have considered that cost for twenty-two years," he said. "I failed to consider who paid for my quiet."

He returned to the clinic archive while the next pulse bent the orchard trunks eastward.

Green Mantle kept records in living cabinets grown around ceramic sleeves. Recent sheets occupied the outer rings. Sealed cases sank inward as new wood formed over them. Senri's diagnostic file lay beneath twenty-five growth bands and an imperial closure plate.

Thalen sent the archive attendant to fetch fresh rinse water. Once alone, he used a graft knife to cut around the plate. The living cabinet bled clear sap. He hated damaging a cultivated archive, which made the act feel greater than the damage itself.

The ceramic sleeve resisted. He worked it free with both hands and set it on the floor.

Senri's notes smelled of mineral oil and old lichen. Her script crossed the pages in narrow angled lines. Early entries described pressure at intervals, warmth below the shoulder, and an unexplained dead zone in maintenance maps. The final page had been folded around a strip of diagnostic growth, now dry and brown.

Thalen read the last notation twice.

Compression converges beneath the anterior throat terrace. The major ironwork does not stabilize the pulse. It enters it. Pain increases at the throat-nail during every commanded brace from the upper gallery. The patient withdraws east against resistance.

Below that, Senri had added one line in hurried ink.

If the court calls this settling, ask what keeps striking the same wound.

Thalen leaned against the cabinet. The archive seemed to move around him,

though Kharad held still through that pulse interval.

He knew of foundation spikes. Every physician on a settled mountain did. Imperial histories described them as dead anchors driven into fault lines three centuries ago. Senri's note named something else: a throat-nail, major ironwork inside a pulse channel, linked to a command above.

A noise came from the doorway.

Eshai stood there holding the raw pulse sheet he had left in the root garden. "The ward clerks asked for this."

"Did they see it?"

"No." She looked at the opened sleeve. "Is that Senri's?"

He handed her the final page.

Eshai read without expression. When she finished, she touched the burned edge of her own mantle where the clinic pulse had struck. "You knew?"

"Not this."

"You knew enough to alter the readings."

"Yes."

"How many years?"

"Twenty-two years."

Her hand lowered. "My son worked the lower roots for fourteen."

Thalen remembered the young man's funeral after a maintenance fever. The court had called it mold exposure.

"I will open every sheet," he said.

"Later?"

The question carried no anger. That made it harder.

"No," he said. "But first I need evidence they cannot classify away."

Eshai folded Senri's note and put it inside her coat rather than returning it to him. "Then I keep the older evidence. You take today."

He accepted the judgment. It also protected the note if he failed.

Together they moved through the clinic. Thalen assigned senior care to Eshai, gave Seln authority over the listening beds, and ordered masking cultures locked unless a named patient chose pain relief after hearing that the strain could obscure diagnosis. He copied dosage keys for apprentices whom White Canopy might soon cut off.

At the final table, the orchard worker with the burned hand slept beneath damp cloth. Healthy mantle threads already angled away from the damaged skin. They could save her arm. They could not return what resonance had killed.

Thalen packed a bone comb, three listening cultures, a flask of cooling wash,

chalk, and a hand lamp. He slid the unedited pulse sheet beneath his traveling mantle, close enough that its waxed edge scratched his chest.

Outside, the sky over Harth had turned red with dust. Blue cords marked emergency routes through the orchards. Imperial soldiers stood at every upper stair, counting bundles and people separately.

The maintenance descent began behind a root-owner's pavilion. Its iron gate bore three official seals and an older Ilaith warning mark. Thalen cut the court seal. He left the imperial ones hanging from the broken chain so no one could mistake the breach for an accident.

Warm air rose from below. With it came a pulse shaped around one repeated wound.

Thalen lit his lamp and started down toward Kharad's throat.

Chapter 3 — The Bridle Engineer

Meris Tal put her thumb knuckle against the crown's third brace joint and found two millimeters of space where her drawing allowed one.

"Who seated this ring?" she asked.

No one in the operator gallery answered.

Eight technicians stood behind the contact chairs, each wearing a gray felt hood and copper grounding bands at wrist and ankle. A ninth person occupied the central chair. Operator Hale had both palms resting on dead shedstone plates while the live command contacts remained raised above his fingers. Through the observation window, the modular bridle crown filled the chamber below: three iron arcs around a fresh-corestone hub, linked by joints designed to expand as the array warmed.

Meris measured the gap again. Her right hand lacked the last two fingertips, but the thumb knuckle had survived quarry work, war contracts, and seven years of this design. It did not flatter officers.

"Two millimeters," she said. "At command heat, this ring will climb the pin."

Gallery Master Venn cleared his throat. "The field crew installed to your issued tolerance."

"My issued tolerance appears in blue ink. That ring carries red."

She crouched beside the assembly. A direction plate lay under the joint, thin enough to hide beneath the locking flange. Its teeth engaged a second gear track cut into the crown base. Meris had not designed either part.

"Raise all contacts," she ordered.

Venn glanced toward the gallery doors. "The Regent's test schedule calls for first transmission before noon."

"Then noon can wait for the machine."

A signal lamp above the doors changed from amber to white.

Every technician straightened.

Regent Ivara Cend entered without ceremonial guards. Two military engineers followed carrying sealed drawing cases. Dust marked the hem of Ivara's dark coat, evidence of the tremor that had reached Avenor less than an hour earlier. Her iron-gray braid lay over her left shoulder. She habitually angled her right ear toward speakers, protecting the hearing the Lorn Collapse had left her.

"Continue," Ivara said.

Meris held up the unauthorized plate. "This part converts brace load into directional bias."

"Yes."

"You approved it?"

"I ordered it."

The directness displaced Meris's prepared accusation. "A brace command distributes weight. Direction requires successive load across independent contacts. The crown cannot distinguish intended turn from a fracture response at this amplitude."

"That distinction belongs to your calibration."

"It belongs to anatomy we have not mapped."

Ivara moved to the observation window. Beyond the lower chamber, banks of message needles copied pulses arriving through a continuous chain of imperial anchor stone. Kharad lay far west, yet its latest movement had driven three needles off their slates. One quivered against its stop.

"We do not have time for a complete anatomy," Ivara said. "Kharad has moved. Harth reports mass structural failure. Six spring districts show accelerated loss."

"Then send evacuation orders."

"They are sent. We will also keep the ground from moving again."

Meris looked toward Operator Hale. He had begun flexing his fingers against the chair arms.

"My test protocol uses a low-amplitude return tone into inert foundation anchors," she said. "No live command."

"Your protocol tested seven years of parts. Today we test purpose."

A military engineer opened one of the drawing cases. Inside lay a command plate engraved with four simple marks: HALT, BRACE, TURN, STRIKE. Meris felt the old quarry scars in her right hand tighten.

She had designed the modular bridle crown after seeing evacuation estimates for a waking city. One crown could be carried in sections, fitted around an existing control hub, and tuned slowly enough to let roads detach before the first full step. Her reports discussed stabilization intervals, not military verbs.

"Those marks cannot make the system understand an order," she said.

"No," Ivara replied. "They make operators repeat a usable vibration."

"Pain can also produce repeatable vibration."

"Pain does not relieve us of preventing catastrophe."

The Regent signaled Venn.

Technicians lowered the central contact onto Hale's left palm. He swallowed. The shedstone plate beneath his right hand began to hum.

Meris stepped between the chair and the control levers. "The ring is out of tolerance."

"Then correct it," Ivara said.

Refusal here would stop the test for minutes, perhaps an hour. Another engineer would file the ring, likely without understanding which surface needed clearance. Meris could leave and preserve the claim that this use had never gained her consent. The crown would still transmit.

She took a scraper from her belt and dressed the lower edge of the ring. Three passes reduced the contact face. She changed the spring washer, seated the pin, and measured one millimeter.

"Mechanical tolerance restored," she said. "I do not certify a live brace."

"Record Engineer Tal's objection," Ivara told a clerk.

The command plate slid into the crown.

Hale's breathing accelerated. He had operated quarry resonators for eleven years and volunteered for bridle training after the Crown promised double pension to his husband. Meris had interviewed every first cohort operator. She knew which joints already hurt in winter and which families depended on the pay.

"Contact at one-quarter amplitude," Venn said.

A technician lowered the second plate.

The crown answered with a note beneath hearing. Meris felt it through the bolts in the floor. Message needles rose along the wall, carrying the transmission west through old anchor lines.

"Return tone present," a reader called. "Interval fifty-two breaths. Irregular rise."

Ivara's attention sharpened. "Brace."

Venn put his hand on the command lever.

Meris caught his wrist. "One-eighth step first."

"The order specifies operational amplitude."

"The machine does not care who signed the order."

For once, Ivara allowed the delay. "One-eighth."

Venn moved the lever.

Hale convulsed against the chair straps. A harsh triple beat struck the gallery floor. On the message wall, Kharad's return needle jumped, stopped, then hammered three short lines into the slate. The bridle crown's second arc shifted against its pins as directional teeth forced unequal load into a command intended to brace.

"Cut contact," Meris said.

"Hold," Ivara ordered.

"The return is stuttering."

"Can it brace?"

"Any structure can be forced to hold until it breaks."

A technician shouted. Hale's left hand had gone rigid beneath the contact. Gray tracery spread from the nail beds toward his first knuckles. His smallest finger no longer bent.

Meris struck the emergency release with her shortened hand. The contact arms flew upward. Their counterweights slammed into the gallery frame.

Hale sagged. The crown below continued humming for four breaths before heat bled out of the corestone hub.

"Medical team," Meris called.

Two lichen attendants entered from the rear station. They wrapped Hale's fingers in warmed cloth and checked circulation with a needle. No blood came from the smallest fingertip.

Ivara watched the treatment. Her expression held no surprise.

"You knew," Meris said.

"We observed mineral traces during preliminary nail work."

"You observed stone creep and proceeded to operator trials?"

"We rotated personnel."

A clean phrase could hide a multitude of hands.

Hale opened his eyes. "Did it take?"

Meris moved beside him. "The command transmitted. Your left fingers have mineralization."

"How long?"

She would not borrow the Regent's language. "The damaged tissue will not return to flesh. We can slow further spread by ending contact."

"My husband gets the pension if I complete the test period."

Ivara spoke from the window. "He will receive it today."

Hale studied her, then Meris. "Because I completed it?"

"Because you served," Ivara said.

He turned his face away.

The medical team carried him out with his rigid hand secured against his chest. Venn ordered the chair cleaned. Meris reached for the command plate, but one of the military engineers closed the lower chamber controls.

"That piece remains installed," he said.

"Then the crown remains unsafe."

Meris followed the attendants as far as the treatment bay. Hale lay behind a canvas screen while a physician warmed his forearm in circulated water. His husband, Jorin, had been waiting in the operator families' room. He came through the opposite door wearing a mason's apron and stopped when he saw the gray

lines.

"What did the contact do?" Jorin asked.

Hale answered before Meris could. "Earned the pension."

Jorin looked at her. "Can he work?"

"Not live contact. Possibly calibration after circulation settles."

"With that hand?"

"I don't know yet."

A payroll clerk arrived carrying a narrow contract box. He had moved faster than the physician because Ivara's promise needed to become paper before anyone could dispute its terms. The clerk unfolded Hale's service agreement and pointed to a compensation line.

"Completion payment, household pension, and permanent-injury allotment. The Regent has waived the remaining trial days."

Jorin read the figure. "This allotment buys six months of heat."

"It follows the quarry schedule for loss of one finger."

"He hasn't lost one." Jorin held Hale's rigid hand carefully. "You don't know where this stops."

The clerk looked to Meris for a classification.

She had signed the original hazard table. At the time, animal tissue tests showed mineral deposits within two joints of contact. No one had disclosed that three maintenance workers developed gray tracery after servicing an old nail gallery. The missing evidence surfaced only now in Ivara's calm admission.

"Write progressive resonance injury," Meris said. "Open medical costs. No final limb classification until ninety days after last exposure."

"I have no code for open costs."

"Then leave the line unclosed."

"The treasury system will reject it."

"Send it back with the rejected crown test."

Venn appeared at the bay entrance. "Engineer Tal, the Regent is waiting."

"So is this family."

Hale raised his uninjured hand. "Go. If they run another contact, stop them doing it blind."

Jorin did not thank her. He should not have needed her intervention to obtain uncertainty written honestly.

On the way back to the gallery, Meris opened the operator intake cabinet. Twenty-four contracts filled the first rack. Most belonged to quarry workers, bridge tuners, and foundation listeners from districts below Avenor. The same

neighborhoods had supplied bodies for dangerous infrastructure since before she could read a survey. Her own father lost a foot blasting drainage galleries under the capital. Officials called the payment generous because it exceeded a tenement laborer's annual wage.

Meris removed Hale's contract and marked the false phrase temporary cold response in red. She crossed it out on the blank forms beneath. Venn watched her alter the stack.

"You cannot revise personnel terms without treasury authority."

"I can refuse to certify machinery tested through fraudulent consent."

"That stops the field crown."

"It stops the next operator from touching it under a lie."

He lowered his voice. "If Kharad moves again while we argue over wording, what do you call those deaths?"

"Deaths caused by movement." Meris put the contracts back. "If we conceal injury to maintain staffing, those belong to us."

The distinction did not comfort her. It merely kept separate things from being used to absolve one another.

Below the gallery, technicians inspected the direction plate. A tooth had polished bright where unequal load forced it against the track. Meris descended and took a wax impression. The contact patch covered less than half the designed face. At full amplitude, pressure would shear the tooth and send fragments into the corestone hub. A broken plate might release the command. It might also lock the hub at its last frequency.

She wrote both outcomes on the test slate.

The military engineer read over her shoulder. "Strike the second possibility. It has not occurred."

"Neither has safe operational amplitude."

"You are documenting speculation."

"I am documenting a failure mode."

"Under wartime authority, language that reduces operator confidence can be sealed."

Meris handed him the wax impression. "Metal doesn't lose confidence. Measure it."

He did, and could not dispute the missing contact. The direction plate remained installed, but its first live test now carried a recorded mechanical failure beside the human injury. Evidence did not end the order. It denied the order a clean history.

Ivara gestured toward the adjoining calculation room. "Walk with me."

Maps covered its walls, not political maps with colored borders but structural surveys of settled ground. Avenor spread over Orun's upper plates in six dense

districts. Fortress lines crossed Volda's northern ridge. Harth occupied a small inked patch on Kharad's shoulder. Springs appeared as blue points, many crossed out.

A framed piece of stone hung beside the western survey. Its face carried names and a date forty years old.

"Lorn," Ivara said.

Meris knew the public memorial. The Lorn Collapse killed twenty-three thousand when a deep fault opened beneath the old river city. Imperial engineering schools taught it as proof that unregulated settlement and primitive anchoring invited disaster.

"You survived it," Meris said.

"At sixteen. My mother heard the first alarm and sent me toward the north steps. She went back for my brothers. The second collapse erased the steps, the house, and twelve streets." Ivara touched no name. "Every official with authority waited for complete information. Surveyors disputed fault direction. Ward captains refused to empty districts without signed orders. Lorn had six hours. Indecision used every one."

Meris studied the fracture map. "A command crown would not have saved a city over a collapsing fault."

"No. A government willing to impose movement might have."

"You are imposing movement on Kharad."

"I am imposing a brace."

"The direction plate turned it."

"By less than the width of this room."

"At one-eighth amplitude."

Ivara faced her. "Engineer, I do not confuse this instrument with mercy. I call it preferable to uncontrolled death. Kharad has demonstrated that old anchors cannot hold. If another settled range wakes, we require the means to direct it away from cities, bridges, and reservoirs."

"Or toward an enemy."

"An enemy will not refrain from occupying the only safe route because our motives remain pure."

There it stood: the military use neither denied nor named. Meris looked across the three marked surveys. Kharad, Volda, Orun. Lines linked their existing galleries through anchor relays. A three-part symbol had been drawn at the center.

"My crown has one live hub," she said. "These lines show three."

"The modular design permits expansion."

"Not simultaneous command."

“Your calculations suggest otherwise.”

“My calculations describe load sharing during sequential waking.”

“Then adapt them.”

Ivara gave her an hour to inspect the restricted plate before the field sections departed. The Regent’s trust had a sharp practical edge: Meris remained the person most likely to prevent failure, so knowledge became another way to bind her to the work.

She entered the secure drawing room alone.

The linkage plan spread across six sheets. Volda’s crown served as the force amplifier. Orun’s deep anchors provided a stable return. Kharad, already moving, would become the first live directional test. Once linked, a command inserted at any one gallery could be reinforced through the other two.

The design did not come from Meris’s office. Military engineers had combined her modular joints with old throat-channel surveys and White Canopy pain-masking specifications. Yet her tolerances appeared in every margin. Her seven years of careful work made the weapon buildable.

She set a blank maintenance sheet over the plan and rubbed graphite across the raised ink. Lines emerged in reverse. She repeated the process for the key joints, then rolled the thin copies inside the hollow handle of her measuring square.

A clerk waited beyond the door. “Any corrections?”

“Many.”

Meris marked three true errors in red: an overloaded return bus, inadequate heat venting, and a brace joint impossible to service once the field crown had been installed. For the third, she drew a removable wedge and locking pin. A crew could extract the wedge under load, separating the direction plate from the core hub without dismantling the full crown.

The clerk frowned. “A permanent rivet would be stronger.”

“Until grit enters the track. Then you need access.”

“Could the joint release during command?”

“Only if someone removes the pin.”

That answer satisfied an engineer trained to think accidents carried no hands.

Meris took the revised sheet to the fabrication chamber. Field sections lay on padded wagons: crown arcs, contact arms, corestone hub, cooling frames, and the command plate under armed guard. She personally fitted the wedge into the third brace joint. Its locking pin slid cleanly under her thumb.

Venn approached while crews tightened transport chains. “Hale’s hand?”

“Permanent damage. Extent uncertain.”

“He knew the contract.”

"The contract called mineralization a temporary cold response."

"I didn't write it."

"No. You only benefited from believing it."

He looked toward the guards. "What happens now?"

Meris closed her tool case. "You rotate every operator after one transmission. No one with gray tracery touches a live plate again."

"The Regent ordered operational readiness."

"Then give her operators who can still move their hands."

Venn agreed because the instruction served his schedule. Responsibility often traveled farther when disguised as efficiency.

At dusk, orders arrived under Ivara's seal. Meris would accompany the field crown west to Sable Stair. Sarn cavalry had secured the pass. Harth's evacuation remained restricted, and Kharad's next pulse interval continued to shorten.

She stood beside the lead wagon while rain covers came down over the machinery. Beneath canvas, the crown's iron arcs resembled bridge ribs built for a span no one should cross. She had designed each joint so crews could assemble the whole array quickly. She had spent years calling that achievement readiness.

The operator gallery behind her rang its change bell. Hale's empty chair waited for another pair of hands.

Meris checked the hidden plans inside her measuring square, then climbed onto the wagon beside the removable brace joint. The military escort closed around the convoy, and the field crown began its journey toward Kharad.

Chapter 4 — Orcs Under an Imperial Banner

Beroch Sarn found blood beneath the seventh mare's saddle blanket.

He held up two fingers. The inspection line stopped from one end of the Sable Stair yard to the other. One hundred and sixty cavalry horses stood in morning dust, heads high at every pulse underfoot. Riders waited beside them in blue-black coats, lower tusks marked with Sarn clay. Above the yard, imperial banners snapped from the pass towers.

"Whose tack?" Beroch asked.

Trooper Vask stepped forward. "Mine, Commander."

"You cleaned it?"

"At midnight."

"Did you fit it at dawn?"

Vask hesitated. "The mare fought the girth."

"So you pulled harder."

Beroch peeled the blanket back. A seam had folded against the horse's withers. Kharad's first step had frightened every animal in the company, and a frightened rider sought certainty in tight leather. The result remained blood, whatever intention went into the buckle.

"Walk her to remount lines," he said. "You take the chestnut gelding and spend your next restitching this pad."

"Commander, I can ride her."

"The question concerns whether she can carry you."

Vask bowed his head and led the mare away.

Beroch continued down the line. He checked girths with a flat hand, felt hooves for heat, and made riders empty decorative weight from saddlebags. The Sarn basalt cavalry had earned imperial praise by arriving fed, mounted, and exact. Praise fed no winter herd. The Sarn charter did: protected pasture along three warm valleys, grain rights during bad foaling years, and places for Sarn children in Cendar schools.

Those terms had survived four regents because Sarn commanders treated ink as another border to patrol.

Captain Yara met him at the final horse. "North tower reports movement from Harth. Several thousand gathering behind the first barrier."

"Armed?"

"Bridge tools, farm hooks, some hunting bows. Vaun crews in front."

"Imperial strength?"

“Two ward companies at the gate, ours in the yard, ninety lancers on the lower road. River claim riders seen beyond the east cut.”

The last detail mattered. River Rauk families had disputed Sarn ferry tolls for three generations and would happily describe an imperial failure as proof that chartered drumholds deserved no route authority. Shared tusks had never settled a toll.

A pulse rolled under the yard. Horses stamped in a ragged wave. Beroch put one hand against the nearest mare’s neck until her eye softened. The tower mortar shed a line of grit.

“Keep riders on the ground,” he said. “No charge formation on moving stone. Pikes guard the gate. Cavalry protects the lower road from opportunists.”

Yara glanced at the banner above them. “The garrison requested mounted intimidation.”

“They may request a painting.”

An imperial courier entered the yard at a gallop and nearly lost his horse when the paving tilted. Beroch waited until the man dismounted before accepting the sealed tube.

The order carried Commander Hollen’s mark and the regency’s emergency counterseal. Sable Stair would remain closed to unregistered evacuation until Harth’s labor rolls, taxable stores, bridge assets, and skilled maintenance rosters had been copied. Sarn cavalry would prevent removal of strategic materials. Persons attached to priority clinics could pass by ward list.

Beroch read it twice.

“Does the order give a number?” Yara asked.

“No.”

“A time?”

“No.”

“Then it means hold until another order.”

“It means someone neglected to bind his own convenience.”

The courier shifted. “Commander Hollen expects immediate compliance.”

Beroch turned the document over. “Where are the schooling dependents classified?”

“Sir?”

“Sarn children resident in imperial academies. Emergency transport and family notice fall under clause twelve of the charter. Your order closes routes used by their kin and reallocates ward clerks to labor copying. What protection has the garrison assigned?”

“I was given a tube.”

“Then carry a question back in it.”

He wrote on the reverse: Sarn compliance acknowledged subject to clauses four, nine, and twelve. Confirm pasture access, schooling dependents, and kin communication remain protected during closure. He signed with his full rank and pressed blue clay beneath the words.

The courier stared at the note. “This delays action.”

“My riders already hold the Stair. Paper has not delayed them.”

Beyond the yard wall, a crowd began striking tools against stone. The beat carried no single drumhold rhythm. Farmers used shovels, pathwrights used mallets, clinic porters used empty water cups. Their message required no shared tradition.

Open.

Beroch mounted the chestnut gelding Vask had surrendered and rode to the upper gate.

Korra Vaun stood on a grain cart before the barrier. He recognized her from Kestrel Cut reports and later route disputes: compact, broad-faced, copper studs at both temples, old burn on the right forearm. Blue evacuation cords crossed her coat. Behind her waited families in district groups rather than one mass. She had left lanes for litters and water carriers. Good crowdcraft could make defiance look inevitable.

Imperial wardens held rectangular shields across the gate. Sarn pikers stood two paces behind them, leaving enough room to lower weapons without trapping the first rank.

Beroch stopped his horse on the inner side. “Captain Vaun.”

“Commander Sarn.” Her gaze dropped to the banner on his lance. “You brought pasture law to a locked stair.”

“I brought people who can hold it without stabbing whoever shouts loudest.”

“Then tell them to step aside.”

“Your labor rolls are being copied.”

“Kharad does not care about rolls.”

“You know what Kharad cares about?”

“I know it moved again before dawn. The upper terrace split another handspan.”

She held up a route slate. Three paths had been marked from Harth toward the pass. Two ended at known collapses. The third ran through Sable Stair.

“We have clinic litters, children from the glass district, and four hundred people sleeping under walls that shifted last night,” she said. “Open the gate for foot traffic. Keep carts if Hollen needs property to feel safe.”

The ward captain objected. “No departures before registry. Anyone passing now can vanish from tax and labor claims.”

Korra looked at him. "That is what departure means."

Murmurs traveled through the crowd.

Beroch dismounted. Speaking from horseback would turn negotiation into display. "Captain Vaun, the order puts bridge assets under military control."

"My bridge assets."

"Built partly under imperial contracts."

"Paid contracts transfer work, not ownership of every tool a Rauk hand touches."

"Clause nine says route matériel may be requisitioned during declared structural emergency."

"Clause nine of whose agreement?"

"The Sarn charter."

Her mouth tightened. "Then requisition Sarn bridges."

"Our kits are holding the lower road."

"And mine could open two eastern cuts before Kharad moves again."

Beroch had seen the carts behind her: tension drums, fitted shedstone ribs, collapsible pylons. Enough material for three medium spans if used well. Enough for one fortified crossing if the garrison seized it.

"Where would you take the people?" he asked.

"Off the unstable terraces first. We can decide farther east once they are not under roofs."

"River claim riders wait below. If they seize your kits, they control every ferry approach by sunset."

"They offered ferries."

"They offered a debt."

"So does the empire."

"Mine has terms."

Korra leaned down from the cart. "Your terms hold because Cendar prefers you to the people contesting your pasture. When preference changes, paper burns."

Sarn pikers heard her. Several shifted their grips.

Beroch kept his voice even. "Vaun roads cross Sarn winter land without toll under that paper."

"Because we negotiated witness passage before your charter existed."

"River families contest that account."

"River families contest sunlight if they can charge a ferry fee for it."

A few people laughed. The pressure at the gate eased, then tightened when the ground trembled.

Stone cracked above the western tower. A facing block dropped onto the parapet and burst. Horses screamed in the yard. The crowd surged one pace.

Beroch raised his arm. Sarn pikers lifted their weapons vertically rather than lowering points. Wardens braced shields. Korra jumped from the cart and turned her back on the soldiers.

“Hold your groups!” she shouted. “If you push, the litters cannot move. Glass district sits. Orchard crews stay standing.”

Her people obeyed in pieces, enough to prevent a crush.

A child crawled under the grain cart. His mother tried to follow, caught between wheels and bodies. One imperial warden reached over the barrier, seized the child’s coat, and lifted him through. The ward captain struck the man’s arm with a baton.

“No unlisted passage.”

Beroch took the baton from him.

The captain’s face whitened. “Commander.”

“Your order authorizes force to protect the closure. It does not authorize hitting my line.”

“He broke the barrier.”

“He prevented a child being crushed against it.”

Korra watched Beroch carry the boy to the inner yard. She said nothing while he returned for the mother and opened one shield-width of space.

That gap changed the argument. Every parent saw it. Every soldier understood that closing it would require a deliberate act rather than passive obedience.

Beroch called Yara forward. “Establish a child and litter lane along the north wall. One accompanying adult for children under ten. Record names after passage, not before. No property carts.”

The ward captain sputtered. “The closure order has no exception.”

“It protects priority clinics.”

“These families are not clinic-listed.”

“Every child under falling masonry has a medical priority until examined.”

Korra stepped close enough that only the front ranks heard. “Open it to everyone on foot.”

“No.”

“You know the gate may fail.”

“I know the lower road cannot hold an unmeasured crowd, armed River riders, and panicked carts together.”

“Then let my bridge company reinforce it.”

"The kits stay."

Her expression hardened. "You will pass children, keep their parents divided, and confiscate the tools that could give them another route."

"One adult goes with each young child."

"Older siblings?"

"Family groups through age fourteen. I will write that limit under my seal."

"Why fourteen?"

"Because the imperial labor code begins at fifteen, and Hollen cannot claim I removed registered workers contrary to his order."

Korra stared at him for a long moment, then caught herself before patience became surrender. "You know exactly how ugly this is."

"I know exact ugliness leaves room to fight a line. Vague mercy closes when an officer changes his mind."

"Give me two bridge kits."

"No."

"One."

"Not while River claim riders hold the east cut."

"I can move the kit under escort."

"I will inspect the cut first."

"By then another terrace may go."

"Yes." The admission tasted of iron. "That risk belongs in my decision."

"No. The people under the terrace carry it."

Korra turned away before anger pushed her into an attack neither side wanted. She began calling family groups toward the narrow lane.

For the next three hours, Beroch stood at the barrier and made the exception function. Ward clerks tried to stop unregistered orchard children. He overruled them. A Green Mantle root owner claimed twelve culture bearers as dependents while leaving their families behind. Beroch made the owner choose one tray so the other eleven workers could pass with kin. Two Vaun riggers disguised bridge pins as walking staffs. He recognized the fitted heads and let them through because the order named kits, not private tools.

Korra noticed. Her thanks amounted to no more than a slight lowering of her chin.

The River riders tested the lower approach near noon. Forty came under ocher pennants and demanded access to the impounded bridge carts, claiming old ferry salvage rights. Beroch sent thirty mounted Sarn troopers down the stable side of the road while pikes held the narrow cut. No charge followed. Horses on moving ground gave negotiation a practical advantage over glory.

Their spokeswoman, Davi Rusk, halted beyond lance reach. "Those kits came through River markets."

"They belong to Vaun companies," Beroch said.

"Then release them."

"To you?"

"To the road."

"Name the toll you plan to charge at east ferry."

Davi smiled around a broken lower canine. "Less than Cendar charges Sarn for its dignity."

His riders muttered. Beroch let the insult pass. "Withdraw beyond the marker and I will guarantee no kit enters imperial stores before tomorrow's noon."

"You guarantee with an imperial banner overhead."

"I guarantee under Sarn witness."

That still held weight among people who despised his alliance. Davi accepted because a public Sarn breach would strengthen River claims more than forty riders could.

The bridge carts had become a second front by the time Beroch climbed back to the yard. Imperial quartermasters had hitched four teams to the Vaun wagons. Sarn guards stood across the traces with pikes grounded, while a lieutenant waved a requisition ledger at Yara.

"Commander Hollen ordered strategic assets moved inside the keep," the lieutenant said when Beroch approached.

"Show me the signed transfer."

"The closure order covers bridge matériel."

"It places the material under military control. My company currently provides that control."

"The keep offers secure storage."

"Against whom?"

The lieutenant glanced toward the upper gate. "The crowd."

"Those carts have survived beside the crowd since dawn. Your teams appeared after River riders withdrew."

Beroch inspected the hitch. Quartermasters had looped ordinary tow chain through a shedstone tension drum. The first hard pull would scar the tuned rim and make a future bridge sing off pitch.

"Unhook them," he ordered.

"I answer to the garrison."

"And I answer for the pass defense named in your garrison's order." Beroch

tapped the ledger. "Write that you attempted to relocate Vaun property without a transfer inventory and attached iron chain directly to tuned stone. Add the names of your teamsters. Then I will send your request for review."

No quartermaster wanted their name beside damaged strategic equipment. The lieutenant looked at Yara, hoping for a softer reading. She took out her own slate.

"I have the first teamster as Cal Venn," she said. "Second?"

The hitches came off.

Korra had watched from beyond the barrier. When the quartermasters left, she called through the gate, "You defend tools better than people."

"Tools cannot walk themselves out of bad custody."

"People can, if you open the chain."

A Vaun rigger beside her held up a fitted pin. "The drums will need retuning after that iron."

Beroch crouched by the nearest rim. A shallow scrape crossed its lower edge. "Can it carry load?"

"If we file and sound it."

"Come through with two witnesses. You return when the work ends."

The ward captain objected, but Beroch admitted the rigger under the same maintenance clause Hollen had used for seizure. A Sarn farrier brought fine files. Vaun hands tuned the drum while Sarn guards kept imperial teams away. Their crafts shared more vocabulary than their politics: seat, strain, listen, release.

The rigger finished and chalked a Vaun route mark over the scrape. "You could have kept this from happening by releasing the cart."

"I could have delivered it to River claim riders, who arrived prepared to take it."

"Davi came because she heard you had seized it."

Beroch considered that cause. Sarn reports had described the riders as opportunists gathering before dawn. Perhaps they had. Perhaps Hollen's closure made every movement around the pass look like an attempt to profit from what the empire held.

"Tell Captain Vaun the kits remain complete," he said.

"Tell her yourself. She prefers witnesses to couriers."

The rigger crossed back. Beroch ordered each cart inventoried jointly by one Sarn guard and one Vaun owner. Control did not become justice through careful counting, but a public list made theft harder for every side.

When Beroch returned uphill, he found Hollen's reply waiting. The garrison confirmed general charter protections "subject to emergency necessity." No specific assurance named the children at imperial schools.

Yara read the sentence over his shoulder. "They gave us air."

"They gave themselves air."

"What do we do?"

Beroch folded the page along its weakest line. Some Sarn sons and daughters studied willingly in Avenor. Others remained there because school places doubled as hostages against their parents' obedience. The charter called them dependents, never leverage. Precise language could preserve a people. It could also train them not to name what everybody knew.

"We hold the gate," he said.

Yara did not hide her disappointment. "After that answer?"

"Our children sleep under imperial roofs. Our winter mares foal on protected grass. River riders wait for those fields, and Vaun crews would cross them without asking whether our herds survive the crossing. We do not pretend refusal costs only us."

"Nor obedience."

"No."

Below, the child lane remained open. By dusk, seven hundred and six young people, accompanying kin, and clinic patients had passed the barrier. Beroch kept the count separate from any final evacuation roll because households might reunite or return before Kharad moved again. The Vaun bridge carts remained behind the gate under Sarn guard, untouched by imperial quartermasters.

Korra approached after the last clinic litter. Dust had turned her blue cords gray.

"You bought time for Hollen," she said.

"I bought passage inside his order."

"People cannot live inside wording."

"Mine do."

"They live on pasture."

"Protected by wording."

A low pulse moved through Sable Stair. The stone under them leaned east, then settled. Both looked toward Harth. At that distance the city appeared intact, towers and terraces fixed in evening light. Beroch no longer trusted the picture.

Korra rested a hand on the nearest bridge cart. "When the next movement comes, I take these."

"If you take them through my line, people die fighting over tools."

"Then move your line."

She walked back toward the crowd camps.

Beroch assembled his officers beneath the imperial banner. He read Hollen's order aloud, followed by his unanswered charter questions. No one mistook the distinction.

“We serve the line tonight,” he told them. “Children and litters continue under the exception. Bridge kits remain Sarn-guarded. Quartermasters remove nothing. If an imperial officer asks for an action, demand the clause and write the name of every witness.”

Vask, wearing his restitched saddle pad over one shoulder, asked, “Do we trust the charter more than the Regent?”

Beroch looked at the chains across Sable Stair and the families camped beyond them.

“Trust is gratitude expected in advance,” he said. “We have terms. Make Cendar spend ink each time it wants more.”

He ordered double watches at the gate and a private courier east to confirm the safety of every Sarn child in imperial schooling. Then he walked the horse line himself, because another pulse had begun under Kharad and frightened animals did not care which banner promised protection.

Chapter 5 — The City on a Tilting Back

Korra drove the escape-line pin through a roof beam while the terrace slid beneath the house.

“Slack!” Sava shouted from the upper lane.

Korra struck the release tooth with her mallet. The tension drum paid out rope in a fast controlled hiss. Six people hanging from the line dropped half a body length, then swung clear as the house’s foundation wall peeled away. Clay bricks vanished into the orchard below. The roof remained caught between two root columns, tilted steep enough that the last child could not climb.

“Wrap your wrists,” Korra called.

The girl clung to the line with both hands. “I can’t reach it.”

Korra lay belly-down over the roof ridge. Old tiles broke beneath her knees. She lowered the mallet by its wrist loop.

“Put one arm through.”

The child obeyed. Korra drew her close enough to catch a coat seam, then rolled away from the edge. The roof settled another finger-width with a grinding noise from below.

Sava hauled them onto the upper lane. “You set that line too short.”

“The house used to be closer.”

“Houses make poor agreements.”

On Day 3, Harth had acquired gradients where streets once ran level. Families tied furniture to walls and slept outdoors beside buildings they still called home. Kharad had not taken a second full step, yet every pulse shifted weight eastward. Orchard terraces cracked along old foundation seams. Water climbed one drain and poured down another.

Korra cut the child free. “Blue route to the kiln yard. Stay with your six.”

“My mother said we wait for Grandfather.”

“Name?”

“Torren Pell.”

Sava checked the district slate. “Already at the south shelter. Red mark, walking injury.”

The girl ran uphill rather than down, trusting information over slope.

Three route colors crossed the city now. Blue cords led toward the suspended bridge and clinic camps. Red marked North Steps for unburdened walkers. Yellow followed Glass Trace through the old cooling sheds. None could carry Harth alone. Together they kept one broken wall from trapping everyone.

At the kiln yard, Pela Orr stood inside a square of grain sacks with forty angry residents around her. Two cistern carts waited by the gate. One had a cracked axle. The other held enough clean water for perhaps six hundred people through the night.

A potter pushed forward. "Brass Market took two sacks per household."

"Brass Market lost its bakery stores," Pela said.

"They have merchant cellars."

"Collapsed merchant cellars."

"You expect our children to eat fairness?"

"No. I expect them to eat grain." Pela pointed at the measured piles. "Every route receives by people, not district wealth. Clinic gets double water until their cistern line clears. Households with private wells declare them or lose public allotment tomorrow."

A store clerk recognized Korra. "Captain, order her to release the east bin. We have ward carts coming."

"Who will drive them?" Korra asked.

"Registered carters."

"Half the registered carters are carrying litters."

"The grain belongs under seal."

Pela held up the broken ivory tab from Red Hook. "This seal?"

The crowd laughed without warmth.

Korra climbed onto the damaged cistern cart. "Listen. We have two problems. Food must leave Harth before the next large movement. People must leave without being crushed under food carts. Pela decides allotment. Sava decides wagon loads. I decide which road can carry them. No one steals because no one gets to call private panic a public rescue."

A Vaun rigger raised her hand. "What about the ward store above Crown Lane?"

"We inventory it with witnesses and open it."

"Wardens will fight."

"Then they can do it while carrying sacks."

Pela divided the kiln yard into work lines. Households filled water by marked cup. Grain teams built thirty-person loads instead of letting strong families take full sacks. Sava stripped the cracked cistern cart to its frame and transferred its tank onto two low orchard sledges, reducing axle load. Decisions stayed visible on a board nailed to the gate.

Korra watched a wealthy root owner surrender two private barrels after neighbors named the well under his courtyard. No hero broke a granary and scattered abundance. There was too little abundance for the story people liked to

tell about justice. Every extra cup came from another person's night.

Commander Hollen arrived with ward escorts before noon. He carried a route plan inked in imperial black.

"We can end this disorder," he said.

The plan sent all civilian movement along a single reinforced line from Crown Lane to Sable Stair. Ward checkpoints divided its length. Grain carts traveled first, registered labor families second, everyone else after roll confirmation.

Korra read it twice because bad plans deserved accurate refusal.

"Crown Lane crosses the west retaining arch," she said. "That arch opened yesterday."

"Engineers braced it overnight."

"With fresh anchor spikes."

"It carries four times the capacity of your side routes."

"Until it does not."

Hollen tapped the schedule. "One road permits protection, accounting, and steady flow. Your three colors split wardens and confuse residents."

"Kestrel Cut permitted steady flow."

His eyes narrowed. "This is not Harrow Camp."

At nineteen, Korra had argued for that bridge in the same language Hollen now used. One efficient route. One protected crossing. One command structure that could move bodies faster than uncertainty. Imperial cavalry crossed first because officers defined urgency. Families at Harrow Camp found the bridge occupied when they fled.

"A single road gives whoever holds it the power to decide what counts as urgent," she said.

"The government has that power."

"The ground just disputed you."

Hollen's wardens shifted. Sava stepped beside Korra with the loading slate tucked under one arm. Pela continued measuring grain. Their refusal did not pause civilian work.

"The Sable Stair lane passed seven hundred and six under Commander Sarn's exception," Hollen said. "I will count those toward a controlled evacuation ceiling of 2,110. The remaining 1,404 move by Crown Lane after registry."

Korra fixed the arithmetic in memory. The total matched what bridge camps could shelter east of the pass before the next supply convoy arrived. The method did not.

"Those 2,110 still count," she said. "They leave by three routes. Your clerks can copy names at assembly grounds after movement. No one queues under a leaning

wall for a stamp.”

“I can close your cord routes.”

“You have enough wardens to close them or enough to help the evacuation. Choose.”

Hollen chose argument until a deep pulse rattled every grain cup on Pela’s tables. The kiln chimney leaned, paused, and dropped its upper stones into the empty lane Hollen’s plan had designated for second-hour labor movement.

Dust covered the black ink.

Korra handed the plan back. “Three routes.”

By afternoon, district leaders had divided the remaining evacuation places without pretending the number covered everyone. Clinic patients received priority. Homes under measured movement came next. Families could surrender a place to remain together in Harth camps, and the surrender went onto the public board rather than disappearing into a clerk’s favor. Pela assigned six hundred grain loads across route cohorts. Sava put every cart through a live axle check.

The blue cohort left first. Korra walked ahead of it across the suspended bridge, stopping groups while the span recovered between loads. Below, the gorge exhaled dust with each pulse.

Red route moved in smaller sets along North Steps. Yellow carried litters and children through Glass Trace. Ward clerks sat at the receiving ends, copying names from route slates after people reached open ground.

A man tried to enter the yellow line with three trunks lashed to a handcart. “Tools,” he said. “My livelihood.”

Korra opened the first trunk. Carved cabinets filled it.

“Choose one hand load.”

“I paid twelve years for these.”

“The litter behind you carries a person who may have twelve minutes.”

He looked at the patient, then at his furniture. He took a small carving kit and left the trunks beside the wall. Pela marked them for later salvage rather than allowing the crowd to strip them.

Movement continued after dark under shielded lamps. By midnight, 1,288 people had reached the outer camps, including Beroch’s earlier lane count. The number remained provisional until household slates reconciled duplicates. Korra wanted 2,110 clear before another full step. She had no authority over the pulse that set the deadline.

A route dispute woke the blue camp before second watch ended. Forty glassworkers had reached the bridge with a kiln sledge loaded in pieces, each firebrick numbered for reassembly. The bridge marshal refused the weight. The workers refused to leave the kiln that employed three linked households.

Korra met them at the approach. Their forewoman, Nara Pell, put a soot-blackened hand on the sledge. "If we go east without this, we arrive as mouths. With it, we can trade glass in two weeks."

"The bridge takes people and food tonight."

"Food lasts until it's eaten."

"So does a route until it breaks."

Nara pointed to two grain carts waiting behind the cohort. "One of those weighs more."

"It feeds six hundred."

"This feeds forty for years."

Korra could not dismiss the argument as property panic. Evacuation plans liked bodies stripped of futures because a person carrying nothing fit cleaner arithmetic. She walked around the disassembled kiln, tested a brick, and checked the bridge slate. Its next three recovery intervals had margin if the grain carts crossed singly.

"Six foundation bricks," she said. "The numbered arch keys. One bag of tools. Everything else stays cached under blue witness."

"We need twelve."

"You need a bridge beneath them."

Nara chose eight bricks and surrendered a place in the current cohort for the extra two. Her sister remained behind with her, while the other households crossed. Pela marked the arrangement so neither woman vanished from later allocation. Their choice cost shelter places now and preserved some chance of work later. No official could call it efficient.

At yellow route, a different problem waited. Hollen's clerks had copied a dead woman's name into the 1,288 and omitted three live children traveling under one blanket. Korra stopped the count until ward, Vaun, and clinic slates matched. The correction reduced the confirmed total by one, then added three. She ordered all cohort numbers treated as working figures until the final Stair crossing. Arithmetic could organize survival only if nobody used uncertainty to erase a body.

Near dawn, a red-route runner found her at the bridge anchorage. "Foundation breach below Brass Market. Warm stone."

Korra took Sava and three riggers uphill. Thalen Iri waited beside a collapsed retaining wall, his pale mantle stained with clinic smoke. With him crouched a Noll listener Korra had seen repairing drainage tunnels before the first movement. Brass ear funnels covered both ears. They pressed a small hammer against exposed foundation stone and listened through its handle.

"Kivik Noll," the listener said without looking up. "I was promised a quiet wall. Your city has broken the contract."

"Korra Vaun. File the complaint after sunrise."

A foundation spike had torn halfway out of the wall. It measured taller than a person, black iron around a stone core. Mortar clung to its upper length. Below that, wet red veins crossed the exposed material.

Korra put her hand near it. Heat touched her palm without contact.

“Corestone,” Thalen said. “Living tissue.”

“Mountains do not have tissue.”

His expression carried exhaustion rather than argument. “This one has a pulse injury.”

Kivik tapped three times. The hammer returned a hollow sequence from beyond the wall. “Shaft behind it. Old maintenance work, sealed from this side. The spike shifted when the terrace leaned.”

Another contraction passed through the foundation. The iron spike moved outward a handspan.

The wall split.

Warm liquid welled along the fissure, too dark for water and bright with suspended mineral grains. It ran over Korra’s boot. Her sole tingled where it touched.

Sava swore softly. “If that spike pulls free, the terrace may go.”

“Or the pressure behind it may ease,” Thalen said.

Korra looked at him. “You knew this sat here?”

“I knew of foundation anchors. I did not know their core remained alive.” He carried a waxed sheet beneath his mantle, protected from dust and rain. “I know the pain converges lower, toward the throat terraces.”

Kivik removed one ear funnel. “There is an open shaft. Narrow. Hot. Whoever sealed it disliked witnesses.”

Above them, route bells announced the next blue cohort. The evacuation could continue under Sava and Pela for one interval. If the spike tore loose without warning, three districts might lose their foundation. Korra had spent two days solving each visible failure while something beneath Harth carried every load.

She gave Sava the master route board. “Hold the three colors. Do not let Hollen merge them.”

“Where are you going?”

Korra tied a blue cord around the exposed spike, marking danger and custody in one loop. Thalen opened his hand lamp. Kivik tested the fissure with a collapsible brass rod.

“Into the wall,” Korra said.

The Noll listener found a foothold beyond the blood-warm crack. Thalen followed. Korra went last, leaving Harth’s bells and the evacuation count behind as the fissure closed around their light.

Chapter 6 — Nine Nails in Living Stone

Kivik Noll stopped crawling and held up a closed fist.

Thalen froze behind them. Korra's hand lamp cast all three shadows along the maintenance shaft, their outlines bent by sweating stone. The passage measured scarcely wider than Kivik's shoulders. Warm mineral liquid ran through a channel beside Thalen's knee.

Kivik pressed a brass ear funnel against the wall. Their other hand rested on a short hammer with two unequal heads, one shedstone and one layered copper.

"Void ahead," they whispered. "Old support ribs. One has detached."

"How far?" Korra asked.

"Sound says eight paces. Heat says I dislike all eight."

The shaft pulsed.

Pressure closed around Thalen's chest. His mantle flattened from scalp to collarbone, every lichen thread aligning toward the deeper dark. Fine grit fell from overhead. Kivik counted under their breath until the vibration passed.

"Interval forty-three breaths," Thalen said.

"You physicians count slowly," Korra replied.

"You pathwrights anticipate."

"We prefer arriving before failure."

Kivik turned enough to show one brass funnel. "You can compare professions outside the living furnace."

They advanced. The old ribs proved to be shedstone braces fitted into cut slots, Noll work from at least a century earlier. Imperial masons had sealed the maintenance records, but the joins carried tiny guild cuts: maker, load, contract term, right of refusal. Someone had chiseled the refusal marks away.

At the detached rib, Kivik wedged their counter-hammer between stone and floor. A soft strike sent a clean tone through the brace. The rib flexed back toward its socket.

"Move on my third tap," they said. "Do not touch the wet channel."

The first tap lifted the rib. The second held it. At the third, Korra crawled across the open section, followed by Thalen. Heat rose through his gloves. The void below breathed in time with Kharad's pulse.

Kivik crossed last and released the hammer. The brace settled behind their boots.

"Guild tool?" Korra asked.

"Counter-hammer. Made to interrupt a bad resonance before a tunnel crew

becomes a memorial entry.”

“Can it stop whatever is moving this shaft?”

“It can stop a note. Mountains exceed contract scale.”

They reached an iron door grown half inside the wall. No hinges showed. Ilaith lichen covered its seams in a pale gray mat.

Thalen brought the lamp close. The culture had long flat fronds with blue undersides, a strain cultivated to absorb diagnostic spikes. White Canopy physicians used it around surgery beds when pain threatened dormancy shock. Green Mantle received small annual trays under strict inventory.

“This should not grow here,” he said.

Korra touched the air above it without making contact. “Poison?”

“Masking culture. It takes a pain signal and spreads it into lower background noise.”

“So it heals?”

“No. It makes the reading easier to endure.”

“For whom?”

Thalen cut a narrow sample. Dark fluid welled from the severed threads. The culture had rooted through mortar into warm stone beyond. Its growth rings showed repeated grafting, not an accidental escape from a clinic bed.

“For those measuring from above,” he said.

Kivik found a maintenance socket below the lichen. Their smallest brass key fit after two turns. “Noll pattern. Older than me, younger than the original cut. Our guild serviced this door.”

“Your records?” Korra asked.

“Sealed by client privilege, then lost in a fire which showed unusual respect for imperial files.”

The lock opened inward.

Heat struck them hard enough to force Thalen back. Beyond lay a chamber shaped like the inside of a throat, its walls curved and veined. A black iron assembly descended from the ceiling into a column of exposed corestone. Bands wider than a person’s chest held the spike upright. Cables ran from its upper collar into conduits leading toward the city.

The living stone around the iron had grown inward, trying to close a wound that could not close. Each pulse drove red light along mineral veins. The pale lichen absorbed the brightest flare, browned, and slowly returned to gray.

Korra entered first. Her route instinct read the chamber as structure: she tested the floor with her mallet, marked a cracked edge, and found the safest line around the central wound.

Thalen could only look.

Senri had stood here. Perhaps not in this chamber, but close enough to feel what he now felt through his mantle: compression at the iron point, withdrawal east, exhaustion after every failed pull. Her note had called Kharad a patient. Thalen had let a court call the symptom settlement.

Kivik crouched beside a collar plate. "Imperial installation script."

Mineral deposit covered most of the letters. Korra used a shedstone wedge to lift the crust without scratching metal. Lines emerged under their lamps.

FOUNDATION RESTRAINT NETWORK, YEAR 312 OF CONTINUANCE.

Below the heading ran nine entries with location codes and names:

KHARAD. VOLD. ORUN. ESSETH. MORRA. GALN. TIRAVA. OSK. BEL.

Each carried a matching designation: principal throat restraint.

"Nine throat-nails," Thalen said.

Korra read the list again. "Nine places like this?"

"One on each name," Kivik said. "The plate treats them as installations, not ranges."

A service recess opened behind the collar supports. Kivik squeezed inside and found a rack of ceramic tablets protected from chamber heat by old ventilation skins. Most carried imperial maintenance stamps. A few had Noll guild corners broken away, the traditional mark that workers disputed the recorded terms.

They handed the first tablet to Korra. "Read the common script."

She angled it toward the lamp. "Brace cycle, upper city. Return variance acceptable. Root damage superficial."

Thalen examined the date. The entry came from twenty-two years earlier, the first season he altered a public pulse sheet. He remembered the raw reading: a sudden amplitude rise after a garrison foundation test, followed by three days of discolored clinic cultures. Orinel had called the correlation politically dangerous.

"Next," he said.

The second tablet described a direction test thirteen years ago. Four maintenance workers reported fever and numbness. Their condition had been reassigned to fungal exposure. Kivik's mouth tightened as Korra read the names.

"Noll?" she asked.

"Two. The others were quarry conscripts." Kivik copied the names onto the inner cuff of their sleeve. "Guild ledger lists that crew as contract withdrawn by client. We were told they left the route."

"Did they?"

"No memorial entries. No return contracts."

The next three tablets showed escalating use of pain-masking cultures after every command trial. White Canopy shipment marks appeared in the margins. Thalen recognized batch codes from strains he had prescribed in the Green Mantle clinic. Waste cultures, Orinel had told him, should be returned to central stores for safe disposal. Some had come here instead.

He cut two mature lichen lobes from separate sides of the chamber and sealed them with corresponding tablet flakes. Evidence required more than outrage. A court could call one sample contamination. Different graft ages, matched to recorded commands, proved maintenance.

Korra watched his labels. "Can these survive outside?"

"For several days if kept cool and dark. Longer in a root bed."

"Can your court take them?"

"My court can make them vanish."

"Then Pela holds one."

The choice stung because it made sense. "Give Eshai another. She knows the diagnostic strains."

Kivik tapped the back wall. The tone returned from a small cavity. They pried free a service box containing nine narrow metal gauges. Each bore one of the names on the plate. Kharad's gauge had worn grooves at the brace and direction frequencies. Volda's carried recent polishing oil. Orun's remained dark with older residue.

"Someone prepared at least one other line," Korra said.

"Prepared," Kivik agreed. "No proof they used it."

Thalen touched none of the gauges. "Can we remove them?"

"We can, but an empty rack announces discovery."

"So does a broken maintenance door," Korra said.

"True. Yet confusion buys time. Take the Kharad gauge. Leave an untuned replacement."

Kivik selected a blank from their repair roll, filed its end against the chamber floor, and rubbed it with old collar oil. The imitation would fail careful inspection but pass a hurried inventory. Korra wrapped the real gauge in route cloth and stored it with the pulse sheet.

Thalen traced the installation plate's title. "Year 312 of Continuance. The empire counts three centuries of keeping a wound open as stability."

"Do not turn it into a sermon," Korra said. "We need to know what they can do with the apparatus coming up the road."

Kivik pointed to the command conduits. "Brace. Halt, perhaps direction. Simple pulses. A living body this large will not accept a surveyor's detailed itinerary."

"Listening doesn't let us answer it?"

"No," Thalen said. "We sense compression and withdrawal. Kharad does not hear my language through a hand on stone."

"Could an open road matter?"

"Possibly. Directional distortion runs east. I cannot tell desire from escape."

Korra accepted the limit without asking him to dress it as certainty. She sketched the chamber, marked conduit angles, and measured the throat-nail against her own height. Their evidence now had material, record, and geometry. None of it told twelve thousand residents how to live through the next pulse.

Thalen unfolded his copied transcript of Senri's final note. He had written it before leaving the archive, while Eshai kept the original. Her description of the anterior throat terrace aligned with the chamber geometry. The command conduits ran exactly where she marked them.

Korra looked from the page to him. "How old?"

"Twenty-five years."

"You had this and still came into the wall without telling us?"

"I found it yesterday."

"What did you have before yesterday?"

The chamber contracted.

A deep vibration passed through the nail. Pale lichen darkened, swallowing the first sharp edge. Thalen braced until the wave faded.

Korra did not repeat the question. She waited.

"I had readings," he said. "Focused pain, increasing amplitude, eastward distortion. I altered the public sheets."

"For how long?"

"Twenty-two years."

Kivik lowered their funnel.

Korra's face became still. "You changed numbers that said the ground under twelve thousand people could move."

"I changed numbers that said it suffered. I did not know it could rise."

"You knew enough to keep the truth inside your court."

"Yes."

"Why?"

At every earlier confession, Thalen had reached for context. Green Mantle medicine depended on White Canopy cultures. Structural review threatened workers' plots. Panic could kill. Unconfirmed diagnosis required caution. Each reason contained truth, and he had arranged those truths around his choice until no one could see it.

"To protect the court," he said.

"Which part?"

"The part that held my office."

The answer left no shield.

Korra picked up the installation plate's edge and examined the fastenings. "You can help prove this. You do not get to ask proof to forgive you."

"I am not asking."

"You will."

He thought of Orinel offering eighty places and calling it preservation. "Then do not let me."

A metallic knock traveled down the upper conduit.

Kivik stood immediately. "That came from outside."

Another knock followed, then a descending tone that made the nail collar vibrate. Fresh red light gathered around the embedded corestone.

"Command transmission," Thalen said.

"You know its shape?" Korra asked.

"Senri recorded a commanded brace."

The third tone entered.

Kharad's throat closed around the nail.

Thalen hit the floor. Pain tore through his mantle, not as heat but as forced alignment. Every filament tried to grow toward the iron. Korra caught the chamber wall. Her fingers slipped in warm mineral fluid. Kivik screamed through clenched teeth and dragged the counter-hammer from their belt.

The collar bands tightened. A crack opened across the entry floor.

"Out!" Korra shouted.

Their return path lay beyond the crack. The maintenance door had shifted half closed. Thalen tried to rise, but a second command drove his shoulder down.

Kivik crawled toward the collar plate.

"What are you doing?" he called.

"Interrupting a note."

"The hammer cannot stop this."

"It does not need to stop Kharad." Kivik set the copper head against an exposed conduit. "Only the person hurting Kharad."

They struck once.

The counter-tone snapped through the chamber. It carried a high uneven beat designed to spoil a steady industrial resonance. The command faltered. Red light scattered into the surrounding veins.

Korra crossed the cracked floor and forced the maintenance door wider. "Again!"

Kivik struck a second time. Copper layers in the hammer head separated with a bright ringing. The upper conduit spat sparks. Thalen felt the lichen mask release its stored vibration in a single wave. Gray fronds blackened against the wall.

He tore a strip from his mantle wrap, covered his hand, and ripped Senri's growth sample free. They needed material proof of concealment. The roots resisted until his shoulder burned.

A lower band shifted on the throat-nail.

"Leave it," Korra said.

Thalen pulled once more. The sample came away with a clot of warm mineral tissue. He sealed it in a clay packet and followed her through the door.

Kivik remained at the conduit. The next commanded tone had begun, lower than the last. Their damaged hammer could not produce the same counter-frequency again.

"Different head," Thalen said.

Kivik flipped the tool to shedstone and struck the floor rib rather than the metal. The resulting vibration traveled around the chamber through the old maintenance supports. It did not cancel the command. It made the doorframe answer out of sequence.

The throat-nail stuttered.

Korra reached back, seized Kivik's harness, and hauled them across as the chamber floor split along the red vein.

They crawled toward the detached support rib. Behind them, the command found its rhythm again. The shaft squeezed laterally. Mortar burst from the ceiling.

At the void crossing, the old rib had fallen completely out of its socket. Eight paces of shaft floor hung over darkness.

Korra lay flat and examined the walls. "No time to reseal it."

"How much load can the left lip take?" Kivik asked.

"One person moving. Maybe."

"Physician first. He carries paper."

"I carry a hammer worth more than his paper."

Thalen pulled the waxed pulse sheet from beneath his wrap. "Korra takes both."

She accepted the sheet and sample packet. "Then you cross."

The lip measured three fingers wide. Thalen pressed his back to one wall, boots against the other, and edged over the void. Heat rose from below in waves. Halfway across, a command pulse struck. His left boot slipped.

Korra caught his wrist. Pain shot through his shoulder. Kivik braced her harness

from behind until Thalen found the lip again.

He reached solid floor. Korra passed him the evidence, then crossed with the slow balance of a bridge worker. Kivik tied the counter-hammer to a cord and sent it over separately before moving.

The shaft buckled while they crossed. Kivik jumped the last pace. A section of floor dropped, taking the old rib into darkness.

"No return through this passage," they said.

"Good," Korra replied. "I had begun to dislike it."

They followed a ventilation branch upward. Its old leather skins had rotted, leaving narrow iron hoops around a rising bore. Kivik climbed first and listened at each junction. Twice they changed direction to avoid voids. Once a pulse drove all three against the wall until the bore stopped turning.

Thalen's mantle rang with pain long after the direct vibration faded. Listening caused fatigue and tinnitus; the command itself had traveled through the chamber, not through an operator contact. He checked his fingers for gray tracery anyway. None appeared.

They emerged behind a disused bathhouse two terraces below Crown Lane. Dawn had turned the city pale. Evacuation bells sounded blue, red, yellow. Sava's route crews still moved.

A new sound came from the east: iron-rimmed wagons and cavalry escorts climbing the imperial road.

Korra reached the avenue first. The convoy bore crown components under dark canvas. Meris Tal rode on the lead wagon beside a jointed iron arc. Beroch's Sarn guards opened the inner barrier for the military train while holding civilians beyond the opposite chain.

"What is that?" Korra asked.

Kivik put an ear funnel toward the covered machinery. "A bad contract with many moving parts."

Thalen felt a low residue in the living lichen sample. It answered the convoy's approach with a faint involuntary twitch.

He separated the evidence before they entered sight of the imperial line. Korra kept the raw sheet and Kharad gauge. Kivik tucked one sealed culture beneath the removable lining of an ear-funnel case. Thalen retained Senri's copy and the second graft sample. If guards searched one of them, no single seizure could erase the whole account. The division also denied Thalen sole custody of records he had once controlled. Pela and Eshai would receive the samples at separate route stations, with Sava witnessing both transfers.

"Command apparatus," he said. "Linked to the nail."

Korra took the raw pulse sheet back from him and tucked it under her coat. "Then we get this through Sable Stair before they bury the reading."

“Who will believe it?”

“People waiting behind a locked gate do not require much persuasion that someone values control over their bodies.”

They moved downhill toward the evacuation camps. Thalen carried Senri’s copied words and the sealed lichen sample. Kivik kept the scarred counter-hammer at their belt. Behind them, the field crown rolled into Harth, and another command began gathering in Kharad’s throat.

Chapter 7 — Battle at the Sable Stair

Korra drove a blue pin through the evacuation slate beside number 1,937.

“One hundred seventy-three remain,” she told the route captains. “Forty-two clinic patients. Sixty-one children and their family carriers. Seventy workers from the upper foundations. We move them in that order.”

Dawn found Sable Stair under three separate occupations. Civilians held the western approach in district groups. Beroch’s Sarn cavalry controlled the pass yard and bridge carts. Imperial engineers filled the inner gate with iron, cable, and fresh corestone from Meris Tal’s field crown.

Kharad’s pulse came every thirty-eight breaths.

At each contraction, the broad Stair changed pitch. Its ancient shedstone steps crossed the eastern shoulder in twenty-seven descending turns. Cracks now ran through the upper six. A retaining tower leaned away from the cliff, held by two Vaun tension lines Sava had rigged during the night.

Korra checked the first clinic litter. The patient had a chest crush and could not tolerate a hurried descent. Four bearers stood at the corners, two relief carriers behind.

“You stop at turns four, eleven, and nineteen,” she said. “If the ground moves, set the litter down before you brace yourselves.”

The lead bearer nodded. “Sarn lane?”

“Open for now.”

Across the barrier, Beroch supervised pike positions on foot. Horses remained saddled in the lower yard, riders beside them. He had learned Kharad’s movement faster than Hollen’s ward officers, who still tried to make mounted patrols use the upper turns.

Korra climbed the grain cart that served as her route platform. “Blue clinic cohort, move.”

Bells repeated the order down the line. Ward clerks began counting as litters passed through the gate. Vaun witnesses kept their own slate. Pela stood at the eastern receiving station to reconcile both.

The first eleven patients cleared before the pulse.

Pressure rose under Korra’s boots. The field crown answered from inside the yard with a low metallic hum. Its canvas covers had been removed. Three iron arcs surrounded a dark hub. Operators sat in traveling chairs behind a shield wall, palms beneath raised contacts.

Meris moved between the arcs, checking every pin with the knuckle of her right thumb. She wore an imperial engineer’s gray coat, but dust and sleeplessness had reduced its authority. When she reached the third brace joint, she looked toward

Korra.

The glance lasted one breath. Meris tapped the lower locking pin twice.

Kivik, waiting beside the blue line with their ear funnels hidden under a hood, saw it too.

"Removable," they murmured.

"You can reach it?" Korra asked.

"Through a shield wall, two engineer crews, and Commander Hollen's charming regard? Easily."

The pulse faded. Korra sent the next six litters.

Hollen arrived at the barrier with an arrest order. He read out Korra's name, Thalen's, and Kivik's. Charges included theft of sealed records, sabotage of foundation works, and incitement against lawful evacuation control.

"No arrest crosses the active route," Korra called. "Your wardens can wait until the 2,110 count closes."

"The field crown will stabilize Kharad before further passage," Hollen replied. "All movement stops during command trial."

Korra looked at Beroch. "Your exception covers clinic patients."

"It does," he said.

"Then keep the lane open."

Beroch read the command sheet a clerk handed him. His scarred lip drew tight. "New order. Full closure during brace."

"Seventeen litters are already on the Stair."

"I can see them."

"Can your Regent?"

"She can count consequences beyond this pass."

"So can I. Forty-two minus seventeen leaves twenty-five patients under the next unstable walls."

Beroch turned to Hollen. "Delay brace until active litters clear turn six."

"The operator interval is fixed."

"Then you chose it badly."

Hollen signaled the crown gallery.

Contacts descended onto four operators' palms.

Meris raised both hands. "Return tone is not settled."

"Proceed," the gallery master said.

Korra heard the command enter Kharad.

The sound did not travel through air. It tightened the roadstone studs at her

temples and made the Stair's shedstone ribs vibrate against their bedding. A single heavy beat drove downward from the crown. Another followed before the first could dissipate.

Kharad resisted.

The upper Stair rose nearly a pace. Turn three drove into the retaining tower. Steps split under the litter teams. One bearer fell between the rail ropes and swung over the slope, still attached by his route harness.

"Set litters!" Korra shouted.

The bearers lowered patients. Vaun crews clipped recovery lines into the outer rail. Sarn pikers abandoned formation to catch two children sliding across the yard.

The crown sent another brace.

Instead of holding, the Stair folded along turn six. A wedge of paving dropped, leaving a five-pace gap between the upper yard and the lower descent. Seventeen litters, three route crews, and sixty Sarn soldiers now stood below the break. The remaining civilians waited above.

"Cut command!" Meris shouted.

One operator screamed. Gray tracery appeared at the base of his thumb.

Hollen ordered the contact held.

Korra jumped from the cart. "Sava, secure upper edge. Kivik with me. Thalen stays on casualties."

Beroch stepped into her path. "The yard closes."

"Your soldiers are trapped below."

"I will recover them."

"With what bridge?"

His gaze went to the impounded Vaun carts.

Both moved at once.

Korra's riggers surged toward the kits from the western side. Sarn guards formed a half circle around the wagons. No one had drawn a blade yet. The first fight began with hands on wheel rims, shoulders against pike shafts, and two groups trying to own the same tool before the next pulse.

"Release one cart," Korra told Beroch.

"Under Sarn operation."

"Your crews do not know Vaun drums."

"Then your crews work under my line."

"My people do not enter a weapon ring to ask permission for each pin."

"Nor do mine surrender the pass because you found urgency."

Below the gap, a litter patient began convulsing. Thalen shouted instructions

from the upper edge to a Green Mantle healer trapped on the far side.

Korra pointed. "That is my authority."

"That is need," Beroch said. "Do not confuse it with a crown."

The answer struck close enough to slow her anger. He wanted the same distinction and still held the cart.

"Joint operation," she said. "Vaun tunes. Sarn guards the flanks. No imperial quartermaster touches the kit."

Beroch looked toward Hollen, who had ordered wardens to advance on the evidence holders. Then he looked at his soldiers below the broken Stair.

"One cart," he agreed. "Yara commands security."

Korra slapped the release pin. Sarn guards opened their ring. Vaun riggers pulled the first cart free.

Hollen drew his sword. "That matériel remains requisitioned."

Beroch did not face him. "It remains under my control."

"You are facilitating mutineers."

"I am recovering imperial troops and patients your brace stranded."

The cart reached the gap. Sava and three riggers unfolded two shedstone ribs while Sarn pikers planted a defensive line around them. Korra measured the new span with her eye. Five paces across, lower landing moving independently, thirty-eight breaths between pulses.

"Single rib footbridge," she said. "No deck. Hand ropes only. We need the second rib as counterbrace."

"Litters cannot cross a rib," Yara said.

"They can if we hang them under it."

Korra sent lines over the gap with weighted bolts. Soldiers below anchored them to the turn-six rail. Sava seated the upper rib. The next pulse arrived before they set the counterbrace.

"Clear hands!"

The broken edges moved toward each other. The rib bowed. Its upper pin jumped halfway out. Korra struck it down while Sava controlled the drum. When the edges separated, the rib recovered with a crack from its western socket.

"Lost one layer," Sava said.

"Still carries?"

"One hundred crossings if they crawl. Twenty litter transfers, perhaps."

"We need seventeen."

They rigged the first litter beneath the rib on two loops. Bearers crossed above while hauling it under them. The crushed-chest patient traveled level over the

open break. At the upper edge, Thalen received her and checked her breath.

The number slate began moving again.

1,938.

1,939.

The crown gallery resumed its hum.

Meris stood between the operator chairs and Venn. "The Stair failure demonstrates directional plate interference. If you transmit again, the brace will increase shear."

Venn pointed to the turning sky beyond Harth. "Kharad is rotating east. We must hold it before the upper districts lose foundations."

"You are driving asymmetrical load into the turn."

"Then correct the plate."

"I need the third joint open."

Hollen heard. "No disassembly during civil attack."

Meris looked toward Korra again. This time she raised her shortened right hand and closed it around an imaginary pin.

Kivik touched the counter-hammer under their coat. "She wants it removed."

"Can you interrupt contact from here?"

"Not without cracking the support ribs under everyone."

"Then get to the joint."

"The ward line notices goblins with hammers."

Korra took off her blue route coat and put it over Kivik's shoulders. "Now they see evacuation command."

"Your coat does not improve my face."

"It improves who has to explain stopping you."

They joined a team carrying a toolbox toward the crown. Korra returned to the bridge gap.

The clinic transfer reached nineteen. Two patients had joined from below who were not in the original forty-two; Pela marked them as injuries inside the existing population count, not additional evacuees. The last of the original litters cleared. Children began crossing on hands and knees.

At 2,003, wardens tried to close the upper gate.

Hollen's lieutenant advanced with shields, citing the arrest order and the danger of sabotage. Vaun workers met them with bridge poles held crosswise. No blades. Korra put herself between the two lines.

"Every fight in this yard loads the broken Stair," she said. "If you push us, people below lose their bridge."

"Surrender the stolen records."

"The records describe the machinery currently breaking your pass."

"The Regent classified them."

"Stone failed to observe the classification."

The lieutenant ordered shields forward.

Beroch's pikes lowered across their path.

For one instant Korra thought he had changed sides. Then he spoke to the ward line.

"No armed formation enters my recovery ground."

Hollen came behind them. "Commander Sarn, remove your pikes."

"After the trapped detachment clears."

"The detachment can remain below. Stop the civilians."

Beroch turned slowly. "My soldiers remain on unstable stone because your operator moved before my requested delay. I will not abandon them to improve your arrest."

"This is direct refusal."

"This is sequence. Recovery, then enforcement."

Exact language held the yard another few minutes.

Korra used them. Children crossed in groups of four. At the lower approach, Pela moved completed households away from the landing so no crowd built beneath the bridge. Harth sent down the last seventy foundation workers carrying only hand tools, route food, and the kiln arch keys negotiated the night before.

Kivik reached the crown's outer support.

Meris dropped a wrench. It skidded under the third joint. When she knelt to retrieve it, she pulled the locking clip halfway free and left its ring exposed.

A ward engineer saw her. "Engineer Tal, secure that clip."

"The joint has climbed." She pointed at the bright wear. "I need a second hand."

Kivik came beside her in Korra's coat. "Evacuation maintenance."

"You are under arrest," Hollen called.

"Then arrest me after I keep your crown from splitting," Kivik said.

Meris passed them the wrench.

They set the counter-hammer's shedstone head against the lower wedge. The tool's copper layers had separated inside the throat chamber, leaving its high counter-tone unreliable. Kivik rotated it, listening through the handle.

"On the next transmission," Meris said quietly. "Not before. Load traps the wedge. You break the frequency, I pull."

Korra could not hear the words, but she saw their hands.

Hollen saw them too.

"Take the crown platform," he ordered.

Wardens broke from the shield line. Beroch's pikers shifted to block them, then hesitated. Protecting a recovery ground did not clearly cover sabotage of imperial machinery.

Beroch looked at Korra across the yard.

"How many?" he called.

She checked the slate. "2,071."

"Thirty-nine?"

"Thirty-nine."

A command courier ran from Hollen to Beroch with a red-sealed strip. Beroch opened it. Whatever he read erased the last hesitation from his face.

He raised his sword.

"Sarn line," he called. "Clear the crown platform. Arrest saboteurs. Hold the gate."

His pikes swung away from the wardens and toward Korra's workers.

The battle changed.

Sarn troops advanced in measured ranks across the yard. Vaun crews had bridge poles, mallets, rope hooks, and no room to retreat without crushing the final cohort. Korra ordered two lines: one to protect the bridge gap, one to delay the pikes. Workers hooked shafts aside and stepped back rather than trying to break the Sarn formation. The first collision knocked six people down. No one could stay down safely.

Korra caught a pike under her route staff and pushed the point toward empty sky. The trooper holding it recognized her.

"Move," he said through his teeth.

"After thirty-nine."

"My commander ordered the gate."

"Then make him pay for each pace."

He did, but with the flat of the shaft.

Yara's cavalry moved down the outer road to secure the eastern landing. Their horses could not charge on the tilted turns, so riders dismounted and formed a second barrier below the footbridge. The last foundation workers found themselves trapped between Sarn lines.

Pela shoved the evacuation slate into her coat and climbed onto a supply box. "These people have already been counted for passage. If you return them uphill, your clerks create missing labor rolls."

Yara almost smiled. "You learned Beroch's language."

"I learned what he hides behind."

"Move twenty through. Hold nineteen."

"Thirty-nine."

"Twenty-five."

A pulse entered the crown.

Kivik struck.

The counter-hammer rang against the brace wedge. The imperial command broke into two competing beats. Operators cried out. Meris seized the exposed clip and pulled. It moved one finger-width, stopped under load, then came free with a spray of metal filings.

The direction plate dropped on one side.

Kharad convulsed.

The Sable Stair's upper retaining tower began to fall.

Its shadow crossed the yard. Sava shouted for everyone to clear, but the only open ground held the final civilians. Korra saw the tower's route before it moved: east face down, tension line snapping, debris crossing the footbridge, lower landing torn away.

"Counterbrace the tower!" she shouted.

Sava looked at the remaining drum. "No anchor left."

The crown's central contact stood open after an operator tore his mineralizing hand free. Meris had removed the direction plate, but the brace channel still connected to Kharad's throat-nail.

Korra understood the machinery only as a bridge. Contact, continuous stone, load, response. One pulse could force Kharad's shoulder to hold beneath the tower. The act would drive pain into the wound they had found.

Meris saw where she looked. "Do not touch it."

"Can it brace this section?"

"For seconds. It will conduct through you."

"Which contact?"

Meris pointed despite herself. "Left plate, single strike. Follow the return. If you repeat it, the line may lock."

Korra ran.

A Sarn trooper tried to stop her. Beroch knocked his pike aside, whether to preserve the crown or the people she could not tell.

The tower tilted farther.

Korra put her left hand on the live plate.

Cold seized her fingertips. The crown transmitted every irregular beat from the

throat chamber: pain around iron, pressure toward the east, the failed brace scattering through stone. She did not hear Kharad speak. She found only load and resistance, enough for a pathwright to know where a structure could bear one more moment.

She struck the shedstone plate with her right palm in the rhythm Meris called.

One direct pulse entered the nail.

Agony climbed through Korra's left hand. Her nails turned gray at the edges. The contact held her skin as though the stone had grown around it.

Kharad's shoulder braced.

The tower paused in its fall.

"Now!" Korra screamed.

Sava released the western tension line. Instead of tearing across the Stair, the tower rotated away from the bridge and collapsed into the empty crown-side wall. Dust swallowed the yard. The footbridge jumped but remained seated.

Meris struck the emergency release. The contact lifted from Korra's hand. She fell backward, clutching fingers that no longer felt the ground.

Thalen reached her first. He wiped dust from her skin. Gray tracery ran beneath the nails of all four left fingertips and across the pad of her thumb.

"Can you move them?"

Korra tried. The fingers bent slowly, cold as winter tools.

"Enough." She stood. "What count?"

"2,071," Thalen said.

"Then we are not done."

The crown platform had partially collapsed. Kivik and Meris remained beside the open joint. Hollen's wardens dragged at the counter-hammer. Kivik held the strap with both hands while Meris wedged herself between the wardens and the exposed hub.

"This crown cannot take another transmission," she shouted. "The direction plate has separated."

Hollen climbed onto the platform. Blood ran from his forehead. "Reseat it."

"Not under load."

"Reseat it or face military judgment."

"I am looking at the judgment." Meris pointed toward the injured operators. Two had gray hands. One lay unconscious with a healer checking his pulse.

Hollen grabbed the removable pin from the floor.

Kivik hit his wrist with the counter-hammer's wooden handle. He dropped the pin. Wardens drew swords.

Beroch's command carried through the dust. "Stop."

Both lines held.

He stood at the upper gate with Hollen's red order in one hand. "The Regent directs me to clear Sable Stair by force before Kharad completes its turn. Civilian obstruction may be treated as armed resistance."

Korra's workers tightened around the final cohort. Several held tools bloodied from the pike fight. Hollen had found the wording that could turn them into an enemy.

Beroch tore the order once down its center.

"This ground cannot support a charge," he said. "Cavalry withdraws east. Pikes recover our lower detachment. Ward forces may remain if Commander Hollen accepts the terrain."

"You are refusing the Regent," Hollen said.

"I am refusing to massacre civilians on a collapsing stair and call it route clearance."

"You will lose the charter."

"Then write that you spent it here."

Beroch signaled Yara.

The Sarn lower line opened.

Pela sent the last thirty-nine workers forward. They crossed the narrow rib one at a time, tools tied to their backs. Sarn soldiers came after them from below, giving the footbridge to civilians first. Beroch's upper pikes withdrew in ranks, facing the wardens until their comrades reached stable ground.

Hollen tried to close the gate with his own people. Imperial shields blocked the last nine residents on the upper side.

Korra could not grip her route staff with her left hand. She shifted it right and advanced beside Sava. Vaun bridge workers spread across the gate. Thalen brought clinic porters. Pela's grain crews came uphill empty-handed, which gave them both speed and numbers.

Meris left the crown platform.

She carried the removable pin in her shortened right hand.

"Ward captain," she called, "your brace authority depends on an operational crown. This crown has failed. Emergency route command returns to local evacuation officers under the foundation code."

Hollen pointed his sword at her. "You sabotaged it."

"I prevented a locked direction failure. Arrest me after you read the test slate."

"You no longer hold engineering authority."

"Then you have no engineer willing to certify this gate."

Ward officers looked toward the fallen tower, the broken Stair, and Kharad's moving skyline. Institutional courage often ended at uncertified stone.

The shields parted.

Eight foundation workers crossed. The last evacuee had remained behind to carry the public route slate, a fifteen-year-old kiln apprentice named Mett who had refused a child place the previous day because his younger sisters needed their mother. He held the slate above his head while crawling over the rib.

At the eastern landing, Pela read his name aloud. The ward clerk confirmed it. Sava drove the final blue pin.

"2,110," she called.

The number moved through the pass, repeated by route captains and families until it became a roar.

Korra cut the footbridge's upper release. Sava freed the lower rope. Sarn soldiers caught the shedstone rib as it swung east, saving the kit from the collapsing gap.

Then Kharad rose.

No command came from the crown. Its broken arcs lay silent among injured operators. The throat-nail still bound living stone, but the direction plate hung loose and Kivik's counter-tone had interrupted the imperial rhythm.

The western shoulder lifted beneath Harth. Houses, orchards, walls, and roads climbed into the sky together. Foundation lines groaned. Flexible bridges bent. Rigid imperial arches cracked at their crowns. People threw themselves onto marked brace grounds and held rescue ropes rather than trying to stand.

Sable Stair fell away from Kharad's side.

For centuries, maps had drawn the pass as part of one mountain. Korra watched a gulf open between the moving eastern shoulder and the fixed lower ridge. The last Vaun bridge rib swung across empty air, safely in Sarn hands on the far side.

Kharad placed immense weight onto a forelimb hidden beneath leagues of stone and soil. The footfall rolled outward. Upper Harth dropped, recovered, and continued east.

The city moved with it.

Korra counted because awe could kill as efficiently as panic. Starting residents: 12,480. Confirmed dead from the first waking: fifty-four. Pre-Stair evacuation: 2,110. Remaining aboard: 10,316.

She shouted the number to Sava. Route bells carried it across Harth.

Ten thousand three hundred sixteen people still needed water, flexible crossings, shelter away from rigid walls, and a route across a moving country.

At the widening gulf, Beroch stood on fixed ground with Yara and the Sarn cavalry. Hollen's wardens clustered behind them. The commander had saved the

bridge rib and refused the massacre, yet imperial banners still flew over his line.

Korra raised her right hand to him. Not thanks. Witness.

Beroch touched two fingers to the blue clay on his tusks, acknowledging the same.

Meris had seconds to choose. The crown engineer stood near Kharad's moving edge while the imperial platform remained behind. Hollen shouted for soldiers to seize her. Kivik extended a rope from the last flexible crossing.

Meris looked once at the broken crown, then at the operator whose gray hand Thalen had wrapped. She threw the removable pin across the gulf toward Hollen.

It struck stone short of his boots.

She caught Kivik's rope with her left hand. Her shortened right hand closed around a knot. Vaun riggers hauled her onto Kharad as the gap widened beyond any jump.

"You understand," she said to Korra, breathless, "that I built most of what nearly killed you."

Korra looked at her numb left fingertips. "I understand you know where it breaks."

"That does not balance it."

"No."

Behind them, Thalen secured the raw pulse sheet inside Pela's grain strongbox. Kivik checked the counter-hammer; one copper layer had split, but the shedstone head remained seated. Sava began assigning crews to every rigid crossing in Harth. No one had time to turn defection into absolution.

Kharad completed the turn.

The east lay beyond a long descending wilderness of old cuts, dry stream beds, abandoned roadstones, and routes erased from imperial maintenance. Nothing there promised safety. It offered space.

Korra pressed her right palm to the moving road. A pulse traveled beneath it, strained and pained, followed by deliberate weight placed toward the open horizon. Her left fingertips remained cold against her chest.

"Blue crews to the upper terraces," she ordered. "Red crews inspect every foundation arch. Yellow takes clinics and water. Mark anything that cannot flex."

Harth's bells answered from a mountain no longer fixed to the pass.

Meris joined Kivik at the first broken street, carrying a tool case instead of an imperial seal. Thalen went toward the injured operators who had crossed with them. Sava shouted for rope. Pela demanded district counts before anyone moved grain.

Under all of it, Kharad took another eastward step.

Part II

Chapter 8 — East Upon Kharad

Meris climbed the maintenance tower while the horizon moved behind her.

Each iron rung had been set for a structure that never changed its angle. Kharad's gait tipped the tower seven degrees east, returned it through level, then carried it four degrees south as weight passed beneath Harth. Meris climbed during the return and locked both elbows when the next lean arrived.

Below, the city traveled.

Orchards rippled along Kharad's shoulder. Roof lines rose and fell over distances large enough to disguise motion until a far ridge slid across the sky. Behind them, Sable Stair had diminished to a pale scar on fixed ground. Ahead stretched broken highland and the faint paired cuts of imperial roads.

Meris reached the survey platform and found three bolts missing from the eastern rail.

She marked them in red chalk, clipped her harness to the central mast, and set a plumb frame against the floor. The instrument's pendulum traced Kharad's gait across smoked glass. First step after the pass: twenty-one centimeters of lateral shear through the tower base. Second: nineteen. The motion had begun to settle into a pattern, but Harth's foundations had never been built to follow it.

A bell rang below. Two short, one long: street break in a settled district.

Meris folded the smoked glass into its case and descended.

Her right hand slipped once where the missing fingertips could not close fully around a rung. She caught herself with her left and continued. No imperial safety code had imagined inspectors climbing a tower mounted on a walking body. Codes tended to describe yesterday with confidence.

Korra waited at the base with her left hand wrapped in gray wool. She held the route slate in her right.

"Glass quarter," she said. "Two streets pulling apart. Sava wants your shear numbers."

"Twenty-one centimeters at this tower. Could be twice that across a rigid block."

"You sound pleased."

"I prefer a measured failure to an unmeasured one."

"People hear the first word."

They walked downhill. Meris had defected across the widening gulf less than a day earlier. Harth's residents knew her as the engineer who arrived with the crown. Some saw the imperial coat she no longer wore. Others saw the broken machine

and assumed betrayal made her clean. Korra allowed neither simplification.

At every crossing, blue route workers had tied white warning cloth beside gray stone creep markers. Korra's fingertips matched the markers too closely. She kept the hand near her chest when crowds pressed, then used it openly while inspecting ropes. Concealment could invite panic when the truth emerged.

The glass quarter had split along a drainage seam. One side of Tern Street stood nearly a pace higher than the other. A grain cart had lost its front wheel in the gap. The horse hung in traces with its hindquarters downhill. Pela Orr knelt by the bridle, talking to the animal while workers unloaded sacks.

Sava stood on the lower street with two shedstone ribs and a coil of cable. "Engineer. Tell me how far this opens next time."

Meris put her thumb knuckle against the exposed seam. Fresh mortar had broken cleanly. Older foundation stone below showed polished faces that had been sliding past each other for centuries in movements too small for survey records.

"I can tell you what happened at the tower," she said. "I cannot promise this block matches it."

"Good. A promise would waste time." Sava pointed at the ribs. "Flexible hinge or suspended tread?"

"Neither, if you anchor to both street slabs. Their motion will tear the join."

Korra studied the gap. "Anchor one side. Let the far end slide."

Meris looked at her. "A loose seat with lateral guards."

"That approval?"

"A description."

"Better."

They built two parallel ribs from the higher street, each seated in a deep socket and resting on bronze rollers at the lower end. Rope rails carried no structural load. When the next pulse came, the streets shifted apart. The ribs slid across their rollers instead of breaking.

Residents cheered.

Meris raised her voice over them. "Do not mistake survival of one pulse for certification. Inspect the rollers after every step. No loaded carts until the gap stabilizes."

Pela finished unloading the grain cart. "Then how does food cross?"

"Smaller loads."

"We have six districts waiting."

"Six districts receive food slowly or none receives it after the bridge fails."

Pela nodded once. She reorganized sacks into hand sledges and assigned teams to return with empty ones. The change doubled labor. It also kept grain moving

without gambling the bridge on one cart.

Sava sent the design to every route crew under a new name: sliding street, unproven, inspect each step. Meris noticed she had omitted its designer.

“Good,” Meris said.

Sava glanced at her. “You expected offense?”

“I expected my name to function as authority.”

“Does it?”

“No.”

“Then we agree.”

At midday Korra called a council in the kiln yard. No building offered enough level floor, so they sat beneath awnings tied to independent root posts. Present were Sava, Pela, Thalen, Kivik, six district route captains, two Green Mantle worker representatives, and Meris. The population slate still read 10,316 aboard. No one had left Kharad since the Stair.

Korra placed the Kharad command gauge beside Meris’s copied linkage rubbings. “Explain what came across with you.”

Meris unrolled the sheets. Graphite had blurred inside her measuring-square handle, but the main lines remained.

“The modular crown began as an evacuation tool,” she said. “Portable arcs, replaceable joints, one core hub. Existing throat systems differ, so I designed sections that could adapt without rebuilding an entire gallery.”

Kivik leaned over the third joint. “And this?”

“A removable brace wedge. I added it after learning about the direction plate. Pulling the pin separates direction load from the hub.”

“You added a sabotage point.”

“I called it maintenance access so fabrication would approve it.”

Korra tapped the three linked surveys. “Names.”

“Kharad. Volda. Orun.”

Thalen’s mantle tightened slightly. “The same names on the service gauge rack.”

“Volda supplies amplification through its fortress gallery,” Meris said. “Orun supplies a stable return through the capital foundations. Kharad provided the live test because it moved first.”

“What can three linked nails do?” Korra asked.

“Reinforce simple commands over greater distance. Brace, halt, turn, strike. They cannot give detailed instructions. Conflicting returns will fracture crowns and bodies.”

“Whose bodies?” Pela asked.

"Operators first. Stone creep starts at contact points. The command also injures the pulse channels."

"You knew that before Sable Stair?"

"I knew after the first live test. Ivara knew earlier."

"Did you stop the convoy?"

"No."

Meris made herself leave the answer bare.

A route captain named Dor Pell pushed the rubbings away. "Why should we build from your maps?"

"You should not trust them without checking."

"We have days, not seven years."

"Then use them as warnings. Every crown point marks an anchor relay. Imperial roads near those relays can carry command vibration and troops. Old roads without continuous foundation stone reduce both."

Korra folded her wrapped left fingers. "You knew enough to hide a weakness. Why wait until the battle?"

"I kept trying to make the system safe."

"It had already hurt an operator."

"Yes."

"It had already hurt Kharad."

"Yes."

"Then what changed?"

Meris looked toward Tern Street, where workers carried grain by hand over the sliding ribs. "The failure left my calculations and reached people I could see."

"That is not admirable."

"No."

Korra took the copied sheets. "These belong on the public route board. Every district sees the link points and uncertainty notes. You do not certify anything alone."

"What authority do I hold?"

"Tool authority while your hand is on a tool. Advice while people keep listening. Nothing else."

The terms felt smaller than imperial office and more difficult to satisfy.

"I accept."

Kivik touched the outline of the removable wedge. "The field crown behind us lost its joint. Future crowns may use permanent rivets."

"The next modular crown left fabrication three days ago," Meris said. "Its field

pattern includes the same access because the revised drawing went into standard work."

"Your deceit became specification."

"For now."

After the council, Meris went to the orchard clinic where three former crown operators had crossed with Kharad. One slept under warming blankets. Another sat with both hands immersed in bowls, one flesh-colored and flexible, the other veined gray from wrist to thumb. The third, a young foundation listener named Resh, paced beside the treatment beds because his stone creep had begun in two toes and standing let him pretend they still answered.

Thalen moved Meris to the washing table before he let her speak to them. "Scrub the crown oil from your hands."

"I have not touched a live plate since yesterday."

"Their bodies will recognize residue before your conscience does."

She washed with ash soap. Her missing right fingertips tingled in the hot water, an old injury mocking the new ones she helped cause.

The operator with the gray hand, Leto Marr, watched her. "You told the gallery master to rotate us."

"Yes."

"He held contact anyway."

"Yes."

"Did rotation make it safe?"

"No."

Thalen dried Leto's hand and tested each joint with a strip of warm copper. Sensation stopped below the first thumb knuckle. "No cold response beyond yesterday's line. That means progression has slowed, not ended."

Leto looked at Meris. "What did I command?"

"A brace."

"What did it do?"

"It increased shear at Sable Stair because a direction plate carried unequal load."

"So my hand paid for a machine that did the opposite."

"The command still forced Kharad to hold against movement. The local structure failed under conflicting forces."

Leto pulled his arm away from Thalen. "Engineers can put a clean edge on any answer."

Meris sat on the floor rather than taking the healer's stool. "Your hand paid for command. My plate made the damage less predictable. Both belong in the record."

Resh stopped pacing. "What record? The field slate fell behind."

"I copied its test marks before departure. Korra will post them."

"Under our names?"

"If you consent."

"Post mine," Leto said. "Post what I was paid and the words in the injury clause."

The sleeping operator's sister refused on his behalf until he woke. Resh wanted his name withheld from family reports because his mother depended on an imperial stipend. Different choices complicated the public account. Meris recorded each one without forcing courage into a uniform.

Thalen handed her a packet of gray-stained dressings. "The route board needs symptoms too. Numbness, cold, reduced movement. People touched command hardware during the collapse without knowing it."

Meris added contact locations and immediate isolation steps. No cure existed. She wrote that plainly. At the bottom, she listed herself as designer of the modular contacts and certifier of the original hazard table.

When she carried the sheet to the kiln yard, residents gathered before anyone posted a route announcement. Korra read the entire record aloud, including Meris's responsibility and the operators' chosen names. No officer summarized it into acceptable loss. People heard where hands had touched machinery and what those hands could no longer feel.

A mason threw a lump of dried mortar at Meris. It struck her shoulder. Route guards did not arrest him. Pela asked his name and added his demand for compensation to the same public board.

Public responsibility offered no clean ritual. Meris stood until questions ended, then went back to work.

That afternoon Harth's northern cistern cracked along a rigid aqueduct. Water spilled across three orchard levels. Meris joined Sava's crews at the break. They could not save the stone channel, so they broke it deliberately at two more points and fed the flow into leather skins hung between root posts. Residents protested while workers took mallets to an aqueduct their grandparents had repaired.

"Break the next arch before the pulse," Meris called.

An imperial mason refused. "That section is sound."

"It is attached to two sections moving differently."

"We can brace it."

"With what?"

He pointed to a stack of iron anchor spikes.

Meris knocked one from his hand. "No fresh pin enters Kharad."

"It goes into foundation fill."

"You cannot know where fill ends while the street shears."

Korra stepped between them before the argument became a fight. "Rope and shedstone only. If it cannot flex, remove it."

The mason looked around at the city he had spent thirty years making rigid. "You are asking us to dismantle Harth."

"Only the parts that try to tear people apart."

"Every wall depends on another."

"Then we learn which walls can let go."

Crews opened the aqueduct. Water dropped into the skins. When Kharad's next step moved the orchard roots, the suspended channels swayed and held. One old arch remained standing alone, useful only as a marker of where the fixed line had run.

At dusk, Kivik intercepted a message through an imperial road relay on Kharad's eastern shoulder. The anchor chain still connected intermittently to fixed ground whenever a lower plate pressed against the old cut. Each contact delivered fragments of coded pulse.

Meris listened through a shedstone fork while Kivik varied pressure. The signal arrived as numbers, not speech. She recognized the crown preparation code first. Then the location mark.

Volda.

A second sequence named Orun as reserve return. The final line ordered approach pressure along the imperial east road: cavalry stations reinforced, culverts blocked, route villages required to report Kharad's direction.

"Can they command Kharad through this relay?" Korra asked.

"Not with the Sable crown broken," Meris said. "They can track contact and prepare another gallery ahead."

Thalen examined the map. "What lies on the official road?"

"Stone relays every twelve kilometers. Fortified wells. Three narrow cuts where a small force can hold thousands."

"And the other line?" Pela pointed to a faded survey branch east of the orchards.

Meris knew it from pre-imperial drainage maps. "Old corridor. Mostly erased from current charts. Wider ground, fewer bridges, no maintained relay after the first two stations."

"Why abandoned?" Sava asked.

"Too expensive to patrol. River changes cut the south approach. Imperial freight moved to the paved road."

Korra studied the gradients. "Can Kharad fit?"

The question exposed every absurd limit of Meris's expertise. Maps treated

Kharad as terrain, not a traveler moving across terrain. The old corridor measured several kilometers wide at its narrowest. Kharad spanned many times that across the settled shoulder, yet lower slopes could pass over open ground if cliffs did not trap its gait.

"I can map obstacle height and fracture," she said. "I cannot steer Kharad."

"Neither can I," Korra replied.

"You sent a brace through the crown."

"One pulse, into pain, to save a failing Stair. I will not call that a route." Her left fingers remained wrapped. "We clear choices on the ground. We watch what Kharad does."

District captains argued until full dark. The imperial road offered wells, known bridges, and military opposition. The old corridor offered uncertain water, wide ground, and no guarantee Kharad would approach it. Pela required enough stored water for three days before any turn. Sava needed every route crew on flexible crossings. Thalen wanted listening beds at both approaches. Kivik demanded scouts test the abandoned culverts for sealed anchor relays.

Meris produced the original road survey from her copied case. A small note beside the imperial cut listed load assumptions. Every bridge there had been calculated for carts and cavalry. Kharad's moving edge would erase them before the city could use their wells.

"The known infrastructure does not serve this scale," she said. "It only gives the empire places to wait for us."

Korra put two markers on the route board: one for the paved road, one for the old corridor. "Scouts inspect both. No decision hidden in an engineer's room."

They worked through Day 6.

Blue crews turned rigid alleys into rope walks. Red crews cut sacrificial joints into foundation walls. Yellow teams moved clinics to root-supported terraces. Meris walked every district with local masons, writing tolerances in chalk where anyone could challenge them. Twice residents rejected demolition and chose to reinforce for another step. One house held. The other cracked, but its family had moved outside before the pulse.

Scouts returned near evening. Imperial cavalry occupied the paved road's first cut. Relay crews had sunk fresh stakes along both sides. The old corridor's south approach held a washed ravine, but Vaun bridge teams could lay three temporary crossings without touching living stone. Beyond it lay open highland marked by old roadstones.

Korra assembled the district captains on a moving terrace. This time Meris stood among tool leaders, not at the center.

"The official road offers water under guns," Korra said. "The old line offers dry ground and room. Pela's stores cover three days. Sava can cross the ravine if we

salvage the sliding-street ribs after the districts pass.”

A root owner objected. “You would dismantle our streets to build roads ahead.”

“Yes,” Sava said. “Stone can serve twice.”

“Who decides which district loses first?”

“Each district names what can release. Public board. No seizure by route crews.”

The choice carried hardship whichever line they marked. Yet people could see it, refuse parts, and argue before movement closed the option.

They chose the old east corridor.

Meris climbed the maintenance tower once more before sunset. Harth’s new flexible crossings moved below like narrow threads between stone blocks. Far east, imperial watch fires lined the paved cut. South of them, Vaun scouts marked the ravine with blue lamps.

Kharad’s next step placed its eastern slope nearer those lamps.

Meris recorded the shift on smoked glass without naming it obedience. Then she descended to publish the measurement and help dismantle the first sliding street for the road ahead.

Chapter 9 — The Drumholds of the Open Road

Korra set her palm on the Vaun roadstone while three delegations argued over who owned the river.

The marker stood at the edge of a wind-cut plateau, half buried in grass. Old route lines crossed its shedstone face and separated around a carved hollow. None carried a crown mark. Behind Korra, Kharad's forward slope filled the western sky, moving so slowly that distance disguised each step until loose stones jumped underfoot.

Ahead, the plateau ended in an open fracture.

The split ran north to south for at least twelve kilometers. Its western lip had dropped during an old quake, leaving a steep trench full of broken pillars and hot mineral vapor. Kharad's current eastward line pointed directly toward it.

Davi Rusk of the River Rauk planted a ferry pole beside the roadstone. "Our boats control the lower crossing. Scouts, work crews, and any residents who leave Kharad use River water under River toll."

Sava folded her arms. "Your boats carry twenty people. Kharad carries 10,316."

"Then Kharad does not need our water."

"The crews clearing its route do."

"And those crews will pay."

Nesh Aru sat on the grass between the two women, gray Cinder Cloister cords tied around both wrists. They were eighteen, slight even by Rauk measure, and carried no weapon. Their drum lay on its side, used as a writing table for route testimony.

"The gathering has not established which waterline remains safe," Nesh said. "Control before diagnosis invites a toll on a dead ferry."

Davi's broken canine showed when she smiled. "Cinder Cloister always discovers principle after someone else builds the landing."

"We discovered the north landing rests on a sliding shelf."

"That shelf held through winter."

"Kharad did not approach during winter."

Korra lifted her hand from the roadstone. Listening had given her fracture noise, distant pulse, and pressure moving east. No words. No useful instruction about whether Kharad could cross a trench wider than Harth.

Her left fingertips remained numb beneath wool wraps. Thalen had checked the gray tracery that morning. It had not advanced past the nail beds. She used the hand when work required it and refused when pride did.

"We need two decisions," Korra said. "How scouts and workers cross the river

cut. How we clear ground north of the fracture. River authority can govern the first without commanding the second.”

Davi shook her head. “Route crews depend on our ferries. That gives us a place in the route decision.”

“A place, yes. Control, no.”

“Vaun captains have controlled this gathering since before my grandmother.”

“Vaun pathwrights kept the stones. We did not own the roads carved on them.”

Sava glanced at Korra. Eighteen years earlier, Korra would have defended Vaun expertise as authority. Kestrel Cut had taught her where that road ended.

Nesh turned the drum and showed the testimony already inscribed on its skin: Vaun observations of the fracture, River depth marks, Cinder listening intervals, Harth’s population and water needs. “No party signs below a supreme route command.”

Davi objected. “Without command, who keeps the work line from turning into a military road?”

“You do,” Korra said, “by keeping control of your ferries. Cinder witnesses keep route testimony out of military custody. Vaun crews clear ground. Harth districts decide whether anyone disembarks. Separate refusals.”

“Slow.”

“Yes.”

Kharad’s next pulse traveled through the plateau. Grass flattened around the roadstone. A fracture pillar collapsed in the distance, its fall reaching them as a dull delayed roar.

No one called slowness a minor inconvenience after that.

Meris arrived from the forward survey camp with Kivik and two district masons. She carried maps rolled inside oilcloth. Residents at the gathering made room without welcoming her.

“The trench deepens south,” she said. “North of marker eleven, its western lip narrows into broken ground. Three kilometers of basalt fins block a turn, but the underlying slope can carry distributed weight if cleared.”

“Can Kharad turn?” Davi asked.

“It turned after Sable Stair.”

“Can you make it?”

“No.”

Korra heard murmurs. Meris’s refusal to overclaim mattered more than a confident plan.

Kivik set a brass funnel against the roadstone. “The fracture returns heat and void. North strip returns solid ground interrupted by six shallow cuts. We can mark

the cuts. We cannot ask Kharad to read paint."

"Ground contact," Nesh said. "Old testimony says travelers answer prepared width."

Davi snorted. "Old testimony calls hills ancestors."

"It records direction changes after route clearing. You can reject the faith and test the observation."

A horn sounded from the western path.

Four Sarn riders approached under a white witness pennant. Yara led them. Her blue-black coat carried dust from two days of hard travel around Kharad's northern edge. The Sarn had found roads through fixed ground while the city moved.

Korra stepped away from the stone. "Where is Beroch?"

"Holding the eastern detachments under imperial command," Yara said. "I carry his terms."

"Then speak them where everyone hears."

Yara looked at Meris. "Cendar offers protected passage along the paved road. Harth route crews may access imperial wells. River ferries retain current toll charters. Cinder witnesses receive safe conduct. In exchange, Engineer Meris Tal surrenders for military judgment, along with stolen crown plans."

Davi whistled softly. The offer preserved exactly what each delegation feared losing, aside from Meris.

Korra addressed Meris. "Do you claim protection under Harth evacuation authority?"

"I claim responsibility for the crown and the right to public judgment by those it harmed," Meris said. "I do not accept return to a sealed military gallery."

Yara dismounted. "Beroch expected that wording."

"Did he expect mine?" Korra asked. "No surrender."

"Safe passage can save labor and lives."

"So can the fracture route if we clear it."

"You do not know Kharad will take it."

"No."

"The imperial road has supplies."

"And a crown being prepared ahead."

Yara's eyes moved to Meris. She had not known Korra possessed that message.

"The road also has soldiers under orders not to attack residents," Yara said.

"Until they define residents as obstruction."

Beroch's refusal at Sable Stair stood between them, useful and incomplete. He had rejected a massacre without rejecting the power that ordered it.

Yara untied a small charter copy from her belt. "Commander Sarn added a clause. If Meris surrenders, no Harth resident may be detained for route testimony or service desertion."

Pela, who had arrived with the water slate, spoke from the edge. "And if she does not?"

"The offer expires."

"Then those detentions remain part of the plan, not a response to her refusal."

Yara did not argue.

Nesh wrote the exchange onto the drumskin. "Cinder Cloister will witness the offer. We will not carry military terms as route command."

"Beroch requested your drumhold communicate the response."

"I will carry testimony. He can hear refusal within it."

Davi leaned on her ferry pole. "River Rauk accept no imperial road decision without guaranteed landing rights."

"You are negotiating with an offer already refused," Sava said.

"I am naming what they tried to buy."

The gathering continued until midday. No unity emerged. River ferrymakers accepted worker crossings at reduced emergency toll but retained boat authority. Cinder Cloister refused armed escorts on testimony ferries. Vaun crews received permission to cut brush on communal north ground but not to remove memorial stones. Harth route captains committed four hundred workers for one day, after which the city council would review water use.

Korra put every term on the public drumskin.

Work began on the north strip.

Before any pillar moved, Korra divided the ground into release zones. White rope marked areas crews must abandon at a pulse bell. Blue marked safe tool caches. Red marked stone no one touched until Kivik listened. Imperial work gangs often rewarded the person who stayed longest under danger. Korra put authority in the opposite act: any worker could sound retreat, and no captain could cancel it until the ground settled.

The rule faced its first test within an hour. A basalt fin leaned across the planned strip with a narrow crack at its base. Meris judged that two rope teams could pull it west. Kivik listened from three sides and found a hollow beneath the eastern foot.

"Void opens toward the fracture," they said. "Pull west and the root may roll east first."

A Vaun foreman disagreed. "The weight sits west of center."

"Above ground."

"We lose half a day going around."

Korra gave him the listening funnel. "Test it."

The foreman pressed brass to stone. A pulse rolled under the plateau. The fin answered with a long empty note. He took the funnel away. "We go around."

Changing route required moving a memorial cluster placed by three River households. Davi refused removal until descendants arrived. Instead of treating the stones as obstacles, Sava laid the working line in a wide curve and used the memorials as the inner boundary. The detour consumed more rope and one hour. It also left people willing to defend the route rather than resent it.

At the first shallow cut, crews tried Meris's sliding-rib design on fixed ground. The western sockets held. The eastern ends rested on gravel beds instead of bronze rollers, allowing the ribs to travel as soil shifted. Harth masons questioned every tolerance. Meris wrote corrections directly onto the shedstone with washable chalk, leaving no sealed engineer's copy.

A brush hauler slipped beyond the white rope when the fracture released vapor. Korra heard the retreat bell and saw him on his knees, tangled in a dragging net. Two workers started back.

"No," she called. "Anchor from blue."

They threw a hooked line from the safe zone. The first missed. Hot air flattened grass along the cut. The second caught the net. Six people hauled the brush worker across the marker as a shelf collapsed where rescuers would have run.

He came out with a burned calf and no crush injury. Thalen's field apprentices cooled the burn while the route clerk recorded why the retreat rule held. No captain received praise for bravery. The worker who rang the bell signed first.

By midday, even skeptical crews had learned the pattern: listen, mark, clear, withdraw. The work looked slower than a military road until one counted the collapses nobody stood beneath.

The basalt fins stood like broken teeth across the plateau. Crews could not move the largest without fresh blasting, which risked expanding the fracture. Meris mapped a path between them. Kivik listened for hidden voids. Vaun riggers used shedstone wedges and rope teams to topple only loose pillars.

A route hamlet of sixty-three people occupied the chosen strip. Their houses sat on low sled foundations, a practice older than imperial fixed roads. The headwoman, Tera Oss, refused Korra's first request to move them.

"We shifted twice for Vaun seasonal circuits," Tera said. "Each time your people promised the route would remain common. Each time merchants fenced the cleared ground after you left."

"This route may not remain ground."

"All the more reason not to lose our houses for another drumhold's emergency."

Korra looked toward Kharad's advancing slope. The hamlet had perhaps six hours before the forward plates reached the western field.

“What do you require?”

“New sites chosen by each household, ferry transport for the north group, bridge labor for the south group, and written return rights if the ground survives.”

Davi agreed to ferry transport only if Vaun paid half the emergency toll. Sava objected that the route served everyone. Pela offered grain credit from Harth, provided the hamlet accepted displaced city families at its new sites later. Tera refused that condition until families could approve it individually.

No one had time, yet coercion would merely move the cost onto people with smaller numbers.

They wrote household terms at the roadstone. Forty chose the north bank with ferry transport. Twenty-three moved south with bridge crews. Twelve households agreed to later shelter obligations in exchange for grain; the rest retained the right to negotiate separately. Work stopped for two pulse intervals while names and sled teams were assigned.

Meris watched the delay. “The north strip needs another kilometer cleared.”

“Yes,” Korra said.

“If Kharad does not turn before sunset, the forward slope reaches the hamlet fields.”

“Yes.”

“You could order relocation under immediate danger.”

“I could.”

“Why not?”

“Because I know how useful command feels when time proves you right.”

Meris accepted that. She went to help fit sled runners.

By late afternoon, the strip had become visible from a height. Workers laid safely shed plates at shallow cuts, not as a paved road but as broad contact markers. They removed carts, fences, and iron tools. Brush fires were forbidden; smoke might hide the fracture edge. Ferry crews carried the last northbound households. Harth grain teams established water points beyond the route so people would not gather in the path.

The open fracture remained untouched. No barrier disguised it. Cinder witnesses marked both lips with tall white poles and recorded every collapse.

Korra climbed a basalt fin with Nesh as Kharad approached.

From there, the scale defeated ordinary route sense. Kharad’s forward plates spread across kilometers of ground, layered ridges moving under soil and orchard. Harth rode far back on the shoulder, its towers tiny against the living stone. The fracture cut across the direct line like a dark river with no bottom.

“Do your traditions say what happens now?” Korra asked.

“They say a First Traveler chooses where no bridle speaks.”

"That is belief."

"Yes." Nesh adjusted the writing drum. "The observations say cleared ground preceded seven recorded turns. Two travelers ignored it. One crossed the obstacle and lost plate."

"Better."

"You prefer uncertainty when numbered."

"I prefer knowing where it lives."

Kharad's pulse shortened.

Loose stone poured from the advancing slope. The leading plate reached the first white fracture pole and crushed it beneath an edge wider than a street. Heat rose from the trench. A second plate shifted forward, then stopped.

Pain traveled through Korra's roadstone studs. Her left fingertips throbbed inside their wrap, reacting to the same frequency that had mineralized them. She kept both hands away from the ground. Listening now might tempt her to mistake familiarity for permission.

No crown stood on the plateau. Kivik's counter-hammer remained sheathed. Meris held no command contact. Every witness could see that.

Kharad placed weight toward the fracture.

The western lip collapsed under the pressure. A section of living plate recoiled. The pulse scattered, then gathered along the northern side.

Slowly, the forward slope changed angle.

It moved toward the cleared strip.

Workers fled beyond their marked safety line. Basalt fins shook as Kharad's outer plates passed between them. The broad route carried no wall, no chain, and no command frequency. Kharad's weight followed the open ground north around the fracture.

Nesh wrote without looking down. "First contact at sunset. Fracture refusal after lip collapse. Northward change followed cleared width. No bridle present."

"Do not write refusal," Korra said. "We cannot know intent."

Nesh struck the word and replaced it. "Withdrawal."

The distinction mattered. So did the turn.

Davi climbed the fin behind them, breathing hard. "My south landing would have gone under the direct line."

"Your shelf warning kept ferries north," Nesh said.

Davi watched Kharad pass toward the cleared ground. "River authority remains at the water."

"Yes," Korra said. "And route testimony remains with witnesses."

"Vaun command?"

“No supreme command.”

The phrase frightened Korra less when spoken over work that had succeeded without one.

At the roadstone gathering that night, seven witnesses copied the observation. Meris added survey angles. Kivik added void readings. Tera Oss added every household relocation term and noted that no route crew had seized a house. Davi recorded ferry authority and reduced toll. Separate truths occupied the same document without merging into one ruler’s account.

Korra brought out the unedited pulse record from Pela’s strongbox. It could not remain only on Kharad. If imperial forces captured the moving city or destroyed one archive, evidence needed another route.

“Nesh Aru,” she said, “will you carry this to Split River?”

Nesh did not reach for it immediately. “Under whose command?”

“None. Under witness terms. You deliver copies to the river communes, Cinder keepers, and any clinic that will preserve the readings. You do not surrender the original to an army, including mine.”

“You do not have an army.”

“Keep reminding people.”

Nesh accepted the packet. Thalen had sealed it against water and included a diagnostic key. Meris added the crown-link points she could verify. Korra tied no Vaun ownership cord around it. Cinder gray marked custody.

Yara approached before departure. Her Sarn riders had camped beyond the gathering under witness protection.

“Beroch will ask whether you chose war,” she said.

“I chose no surrender.”

“He will hear the difference and prepare for both.”

“Tell him Kharad turned from the open fracture without a command.”

“He may call that chance.”

“Bring him the measurements.”

Yara looked at the moving dark mass to the north. “If a cleared road can turn it, the imperial road can too.”

“Only if kept open.”

“And whoever controls the road controls the turn.”

Korra shook her head. “That returns us to a bridle made of soldiers. A free route requires choices no one force can close.”

She had not solved how to build such a thing. Today they had managed one strip through divided authority, ferry rights, household terms, and witnessed refusal. It took longer than command. Kharad still turned.

At dawn on Day 8, Nesh boarded Davi's north ferry with the record secured beneath their gray cords. No armed escort joined them. River crews poled into the current while Cinder witnesses beat one low departure note on the bank.

Korra stood beside the old Vaun roadstone. Kharad moved east-northeast beyond the cleared strip, carrying Harth and 10,316 residents. Meris worked openly among the survey crews. Thalen checked Korra's left fingertips; the gray line had not passed the nails.

She marked the new direction on the roadstone beside the divided paths. One line recorded the fracture. Another recorded cleared ground. Neither claimed a command.

Then Korra sent the work crews ahead to find the next place wide enough for Kharad to choose.

Chapter 10 — The White Canopy Refuses

Thalen held the listening dish against the root wall while an orchard moved past the clinic window.

Pear trunks traveled sideways against a pale morning, their crowns roped together so Kharad's gait would not tear them from the Green Mantle terraces. Every forty breaths, the floor lifted beneath Thalen's knees. Water climbed the copper lip of the dish, trembled, then settled into a pattern too quick for sleep and too regular for collapse.

Orinel Thyr's face occupied the lichen mirror above it. Distance frayed her image into green sparks, but her cultivated veil remained immaculate. Behind her rose White Canopy's stationary arches, grown over Orun's northern shoulder and protected from any moving horizon.

"Four trays of blue cup," Thalen said. "Two of fever lace. Clean binding moss enough for sixty dressings. We have twelve resonance burns and root rot in the third orchard. Send the cultures to the eastern drop before noon."

"You have become economical with courtesy," Orinel replied.

A clinic hand tightened a bridge strap outside. The wall groaned as the terrace leaned. Thalen steadied the dish with both palms.

"Courtesy does not divide into sixty dressings."

"White Canopy has terms."

He had expected a delay, a demand for sealed case notes, perhaps a lecture on inheritance. The plural chilled him more than refusal.

Orinel lifted one finger. "Meris Tal will be delivered to an imperial escort at the Chalk Ford. The original pulse record will accompany her. Once receipt reaches me, your shipment leaves Orun."

"There is no escort at Chalk Ford. Kharad turned from the imperial road two days ago."

"Then persuade your pathwright to turn back."

Thalen looked through the window. Workers moved beneath the pears with padded poles, adjusting each brace to match the next long rise of Kharad's shoulder. They had lost two irrigation channels overnight. None of them could afford the White Canopy's patience.

"The record belongs with those injured by what it proves," he said.

"Records belong with physicians qualified to interpret them. Meris belongs before the Regent. You have until the next consultation pulse."

A young keeper entered carrying a cedar medicine chest. Its bottom had split. Gray glass tubes rolled against one another inside, several empty, two furred with black contamination. Nemi had spent the night salvaging cultures from the west

clinic and had bark embedded beneath both palms.

Thalen turned the dish so Orinel could see.

"That chest supplied three terraces," he said. "Look at it."

"I see property removed without a transfer seal."

Nemi gave a harsh laugh. Thalen raised a hand too late to protect either of them from the sound.

Orinel's gaze shifted. "Who stands with you?"

"A keeper doing the work your contracts pretend to fund."

"Name yourself," Orinel said.

Nemi set the broken chest on the floor. "Nemi Sar. Lower drains, fifth root tier. My name appears on every cleaning roster and no ownership table."

The mirror's green light sharpened along Orinel's cheek. "Leave the consultation."

"No," Thalen said.

That single answer opened the room. Nemi pushed the outer door wide. Patients waiting under the awning could hear now: orchard cutters with lichen burns stippling their wrists, two human terrace hands bruised by a failed brace, an Ilaith child whose mantle had flushed yellow around one ear. Beyond them, keepers leaned from the moving root walks.

Orinel understood the changed acoustics. "Do you intend a spectacle?"

"I intend a diagnosis with witnesses. White Canopy refuses medicine to a moving clinic unless we surrender a woman and a record. Correct me if any word lacks precision."

"We refuse uncontrolled distribution during an imperial emergency. You know what false panic does to a canopy."

Thalen felt the old defense fit itself around his thoughts. Panic harmed patients. Unverified claims caused migrations, shortages, failed dormancies. Twenty-two years earlier, those reasons had sounded like care when Orinel first placed a correction stylus in his hand.

Someone outside asked, "What record?"

He could still narrow the answer. He could say an anomalous sheet, a disputed classification, a document requiring review. The habits of office offered him a dozen sterile shelters.

Thalen moved the dish from the root wall and carried it to the threshold. Orinel's image spread across the water, visible to everyone crowded on the walk.

"For twenty-two years," he said, "I altered the public readings from Kharad's principal pulse channel. I called pain harmless settling. I lowered peaks, lengthened intervals, and signed the classifications with my office seal."

Nobody spoke. Kharad's next step rolled under them, lifting the far end of the walk until ropes creaked above the silence.

Nemi looked at his hands rather than his face. "How many readings?"

"Three hundred and eight formal sheets. More weekly summaries than I counted."

"Why?"

"Because White Canopy said disclosure would empty the orchards and end the medicine exchange. Because Green Mantle's root owners said workers would riot. Because I believed keeping the clinic open excused what I concealed."

A woman with a burned wrist pushed past the awning post. "My father died in a foundation split six years ago. Your sheet called that settling."

Thalen knew the case. Terrace Seven, two deaths, one hand crushed. He had softened the pulse peak after midnight.

"Yes," he said.

Her uninjured hand struck his mouth. The dish tipped. Nemi caught it before the water spilled, and Orinel's face broke into rings.

No one restrained the woman. Thalen tasted blood and remained where she had left him.

From the disturbed mirror, Orinel said, "Your confession proves you cannot hold a medical office. Green Mantle must appoint a custodian at once."

"Agreed."

The speed of his answer unsettled her. It also unsettled the root owners arriving from the upper tier, three elders in layered living cloth with emergency hooks fastened at their waists. Elder Var had already brought two terrace guards.

"Physician Iri," Var said, "give me your seal."

Thalen unclasped the bronze root from his collar. His mantle had grown around its upper prong over decades. Pulling it loose tore three pale strands and sent a bright sting across his shoulder. He placed the seal in Var's palm.

"Confine him in the west nursery," the elder ordered.

Nemi blocked the narrow walk with the broken medicine chest. "After he shows us which cultures remain clean."

"You have no standing here."

"Then your drains can stop standing too. See how long the canopy remains above Kharad."

Other workers came onto the walk. Soil carriers. Irrigation tenders. Graft keepers. Human rope crews from Harth. They carried no weapons, only hooks, pruning blades, chalk slates, and the accumulated knowledge of what would fail if they folded their hands.

Var's guards watched the clinic supports sway. Neither advanced.

Orinel spoke from the dish. "Custodian Var, lock the culture rooms. White Canopy recognizes your authority pending review."

Nemi bent, lifted the chest, and rammed its broken corner against the clinic's inner latch. Cedar gave before iron. The door opened on six shelves of sealed diagnostic trays.

Chaos did not follow. That surprised the root owners more than force would have. Nemi assigned two workers to every shelf, ordered an inventory slate hung outside, and forbade anyone to remove a culture without a patient name and two witnesses. The burned woman took the first chalk. A human drain tender took the second.

"We need treatment cultures, not another court," Thalen said.

Nemi rounded on him. "You do not get to tell us what we need today."

"No. I don't."

Her anger paused, finding no resistance to brace against.

The workers formed their council beside the open culture room while Kharad carried them east. Five seats went to clinic labor, drains, orchards, Harth patients, and dormancy keepers. They left a sixth chair empty for the root tiers after Var refused it. Nemi made every rule provisional until an assembly could meet at dusk.

Their first dispute concerned the child with yellow mantle around one ear. A root owner named his family and claimed a hereditary place ahead of two human cutters. The child's mother crossed out her own patronymic on the intake slate.

"His fever does not outrank a burn because his grandfather owned pears," she said. "Read the tissues."

Thalen examined all three under the workers' eyes. The child's flush came from strain but had not reached the dangerous violet margin. One cutter had a blistered pulse line climbing toward her elbow. The other could wait until morning if the damaged skin stayed wet.

Nemi assigned one blue-cup dressing to the climbing burn, half a cooling wrap to the child, and a watch rotation for the second cutter. She made Thalen state each reason aloud, then required a keeper to repeat it without title or court language. By the fourth patient, everyone near the board could understand why one body went first. The procedure slowed the queue. It also denied any hidden hand the power to reorder it.

"Keep doing that after I leave," Thalen said.

The child's mother met his gaze. "We kept doing the work while you stayed."

Thalen sat on the floor beneath the patient board and tested contaminated tubes. Office had once allowed him to call such work beneath his training. Shame gave the task its proper size.

By afternoon, they had twenty-seven viable diagnostic cultures, nine fever-lace starts, and enough blue cup for eighteen full burn dressings. It would not serve sixty. It would keep the worst cases alive until the next settlement.

A crate from the lowest shelf carried no clinic code. Kivik's chalk notation marked its lid from an earlier inventory: three short lines beside a hollow circle. Thalen ran his thumb across the waxed shipping strip.

The first stamp belonged to White Canopy propagation. A second recorded transfer through the imperial medical exchange. Beneath both, almost hidden by resin, a black hammer enclosed a red oval.

Meris entered as Nemi finished reading the shelf totals aloud. Dust striped the engineer's coat, and a rolled route plan pressed beneath her arm.

"That mark," Thalen said. "Do you know it?"

She crouched without touching the crate. Her missing fingertips hovered over the black hammer. "Red Hollow casting authority. Restricted coreworks."

"Why would a throat-nail forge receive diagnostic cultures?"

"Operators need pain suppressants. Casting crews need resonance masks." Meris examined the transfer numbers. "This lot didn't come here from White Canopy. It passed through here on its way east, then six tubes were diverted to your clinic."

Nemi checked the inventory leaf lodged under the lid. "Forty trays shipped. Six received."

Thalen read the date. It preceded Kharad's first step by four months.

Orinel had not reacted to an emergency. White Canopy had provisioned its concealed work in advance.

"Red Hollow," he said. The name felt dry against his split lip.

Meris unrolled her route plan across the floor. "Two days southeast if Kharad keeps this line. Less for three people using the ventilation approach, if Kivik's old guild maps remain true."

Var stepped forward at last. "This proves nothing about the Speaker. Supply clerks redirect cultures every season."

Nemi held up the leaf. "Then supply clerks can answer in public."

"You cannot publish court inventory."

"We can carry our own copy."

Thalen expected the workers to send him under guard or keep him as a convenient interpreter. Instead, the council withdrew to the awning and argued while patients moved through the clinic. Their decision took an hour.

At dusk Nemi returned with three written mandates. One gave the clinic stock to the worker council. Another demanded White Canopy restore medicine without conditions. The third authorized Thalen to accompany Meris and Kivik to Red

Hollow, identify the cultures, and return with copies of every related ledger he could reach.

"This does not restore your office," Nemi said.

"It should not."

"You speak for no patient except one who asks you directly. You carry no Green Mantle seal. If you find proof, it belongs first to the workers named in it."

Thalen folded the mandate and placed it where the bronze root had hung. Torn mantle strands tingled at his collar.

Across the terraces, lamps moved toward the dusk assembly. Var's guards had lowered their hooks. The root owners kept their distance, counting which workers had left which posts and discovering that the orchards still stood.

The lichen dish brightened once more. Orinel had resumed the connection.

"Thalen," she said, her voice thin across the crowded clinic, "if you go to that forge, White Canopy will strike your name from every court register."

He looked at the patients receiving the eighteen dressings, each allocation written in chalk where anyone could challenge it. Nemi waited beside the open shelves. Meris had already marked the ventilation route.

"Record the refusal first," Thalen said. "Medicine withheld pending surrender. Put your seal beneath it."

Orinel ended the pulse.

Before dawn, Thalen packed two clean cultures, Senri's copied notes, and the worker mandate. He left the clinic by its lowest root stair without escort. Above him, the council inventory remained lit for the night shift; ahead, Meris and Kivik waited beside a roadstone pointing toward Red Hollow.

Chapter 11 — Beroch Sarn's Charter

Beroch put his hand on the lead mare's bridle before the imperial quartermaster could mark her flank.

Blue clay streaked his knuckles when he drew them across the animal's black cheek. The mare stamped once, offended by the six supply carts crowding the Sarn remount yard. Behind her, forty-three winter mares pressed against a basalt rail, their breath pale in the highland morning.

Quartermaster Helve held the requisition brush above a pot of white pitch. "Commander, I have a regent's seal."

"You have a supply seal." Beroch pointed to the copper disk hanging from Helve's neck. "A regent's seal carries nine cuts. Yours carries five."

The quartermaster covered it with his thumb. "The western army needs mounts."

"These mares do not carry cavalry. They carry next spring's herd."

"Animals breed in imperial pasture as readily as here."

Sarn riders lined the yard without drawing weapons. Their blue-clayed tusks and clean tack made a wall more orderly than the quartermaster's infantry. Beroch had chosen twelve witnesses, including two human stable hands and old Rutha, who kept the Sarn breeding ledger and distrusted every uniform equally.

He unrolled a skin copy of the charter on the rail. "Article Four. Winter pasture remains under Sarn custody from first frost through thaw. Breeding stock cannot be requisitioned unless an invasion enters the named valleys. Kharad is moving east. No hostile force has entered this valley."

Helve glanced toward the ridge. Beyond it, Kharad's distant back crossed the horizon, a country of terraces traveling where a mountain had stood. "That appears invasion enough."

"Then write that the Regent considers a mountain's departure an invading army. Put your name beneath the sentence."

One of Beroch's captains coughed to hide satisfaction. Helve heard it and reddened.

The quartermaster lowered his brush. "I can seize twenty geldings under the transport article."

"Eighteen. Two have cracked hooves. You may inspect them in front of Rutha."

"Twenty."

"Nineteen, with grain for their return if your army releases them before spring."

Helve agreed because another hour would bring more witnesses. Beroch allowed him to mark nineteen bay geldings. The loss would shorten Sarn patrol range, but

the mares stayed behind the basalt rail. Law had done what a drawn blade could not: forced the empire to count the price in public.

Rutha waited until the carts departed. "You made surrender look tidy."

"Nineteen instead of forty-three."

"Still nineteen."

"Put every name in the ledger."

She had already begun.

A field courier arrived before noon with a route cylinder bound in red leather. Beroch broke its wax in the charter tent, where maps covered a table weighted by horseshoes. His captains stood around him: Torga of the remounts, quiet Hask from the southern camps, and Ven Sarn, Beroch's sister's son, young enough to resent any victory won with ink.

The first sheet appointed Beroch auxiliary field commander under Deren Cend. The second ordered three cavalry columns east. A survey plate lay beneath them, etched with Volda's proposed waking route.

Hask bent over the line. "That crosses the old road."

Beroch had seen it. The route cut through a hooked valley marked as empty on the imperial survey. Sarn maps carried thirty-seven roadstones there, each set where families had turned from a flood, a famine, a feud, or a campaign. His father's marker stood among them. So did the flat black stone for the ninety riders killed at Bel's Ford before the charter.

"The burial roads extend from Olt Ridge to the twin wells," he said. "Why does this plate show unused ground?"

The courier, a narrow human officer named Sevet, consulted her orders. "Imperial surveys record permanent structures. Memorials can be relocated."

Ven's chair struck the ground as he rose. "Relocate your own dead."

Beroch did not raise his voice. "Sit."

His nephew obeyed, jaw rigid.

Sevet set a smaller paper beside the route. "Field Marshal Cend anticipates customary concerns. The treasury will compensate registered custodians for disturbance. Skilled crews will move recognized stones."

"Recognized by whom?"

"The Office of Frontier Works."

Torga laughed once. Frontier Works had denied half the roadstones existed when it fenced the northern grazing lanes.

Beroch read the route again. Volda would wake under a bridle and move west. The line passed within two valleys of Sarn's largest winter camp. He had not received a command schedule, only transport orders and a promise that stone markers could change ground without changing meaning.

"I require a reroute south of Olt Ridge," he said.

"The grade there exceeds the engineering allowance."

"Then Volda remains on its present ground."

Sevet's expression barely changed. "That decision lies above my commission."

"Your commission brought me the plate. It can carry my answer back."

He dictated an objection citing the charter's burial protection and winter pasture limits. Sevet wrote quickly, pausing only when he required the word inviolate. Beroch made all three captains sign as witnesses.

Outside, a cluster of civilians waited beside the tether lines. Sarn parents rarely came to his command tent together unless blood compensation had failed. There were eight of them, carrying folded school letters bound with the yellow cord of Avenor's Frontier Academy.

Beroch dismissed his captains except Hask and invited the parents inside. No one sat.

A potter named Dava placed her letter on the route plate. "My daughter has started writing in weather."

He did not understand until she showed him the page. Every harmless sentence about arithmetic or dormitory meals began with a small description of the sky. Clear meant supervised. Rain meant a teacher had left the room. Frost meant the child had heard soldiers discussing Sarn.

Rain touched the north windows yesterday. We practice the capital salute each morning now. The schoolchildren from river families have moved to the lower dormitory. Frost came before supper, though the season remains warm. Please tell Grandmother I still know the old road names.

The signature belonged to Lera Dava, age twelve.

Other letters used different codes. A boy described missing buttons whenever mail had been opened. Two sisters wrote the same sentence about excellent soup in hands so unlike that one had copied under watch. One page held only an official notice: student correspondence suspended during frontier instability.

"They are hostages," Ven said from the tent opening. He had ignored Beroch's dismissal.

Dava looked at him. "They are also learning. My daughter can calculate a bridge load now. She reads three scripts. Do not make this simple because simplicity feels brave."

Beroch respected her for the rebuke. The academy guarantee had persuaded many Sarn families to accept the charter. Before it, imperial guilds barred Rauk children from survey schools, and rival drumholds could close winter teaching camps without consequence. Avenor gave them instruction, meals, contacts, and a locked gate.

"How many Sarn students remain there?" he asked.

"Seventy-six in the academy," Dava said. "Another nineteen apprenticed in city works."

Ninety-five young lives, each one both beneficiary and pledge.

Before answering the parents, Beroch rode to the northern edge of winter pasture with Dava and Hask. He needed to see what the imperial line called empty. Frost silvered the bunchgrass between black shelves of basalt. Sarn mares grazed in the lee of the ridge, each band kept apart by low rope instead of fences that could trap them during a ground slip.

The first roadstone stood no higher than Beroch's knee. Wind had worn its carved route nearly smooth, but blue clay remained pressed into the turn mark. Dava touched two fingers to it.

"My mother's mother set this after the ash winter," she said. "They came south with fourteen children and arrived with twelve. The marker records where they chose water over shelter."

Hask walked ahead, counting. The stones did not form graves in the imperial sense. Most held no bodies. They preserved decisions, each marker placed where a drumhold or family had changed its route at irreversible cost. Moving one to a tidy field elsewhere would sever it from the ground that gave the choice meaning.

Farther down the road, Beroch found his father's broad marker leaning beneath thorn scrub. He cleared ice from the shallow cup at its center. Jor Sarn had turned seventy riders back from Bel's Ford after scouts found imperial prisoners tied across the crossing. The retreat cost Sarn the battle and saved thirty captives from being trampled by their own rescuers. Beroch had been twenty-two and furious. Years later, he understood the choice better than he loved it.

Survey stakes ran past the marker at ten-pace intervals. White paint put Volda's center line directly over the old road.

Dava crouched beside one stake. "A field clerk knew enough to measure this place."

"Knowing does not create authority," Hask said.

"It creates guilt when authority uses the measurement."

Hoofbeats approached from the eastern rise. Four imperial surveyors came under a cavalry escort, carrying rods and a wheeled grade frame. Their officer saluted Beroch without dismounting.

"We have orders to complete obstruction notation."

Beroch pointed at the nearest roadstone. "Name that obstruction."

The officer consulted his slate. "Surface feature, movable, category four."

"Name its witness."

"No witness appears in the works table."

Dava stood. "I am standing in front of you."

The exchange nearly became an arrest when a surveyor tried to paint the stone. Hask caught the brush hand while Beroch placed the charter copy over the wet stake. He did not threaten the escort. He required the officer to read the burial protection aloud, then dictated every marker and living custodian into the works table. Thirty-seven entries delayed the survey until sunset.

At the last stone, the officer said, "The route will not change because you improved the nouns."

"No," Beroch replied. "But now an order to cross must admit what it crosses."

They returned to the command tent after dark with blue clay on their fingers and a copy of the amended survey. The parents still waited. Beroch gave Dava the works table beside her daughter's letter. Neither document released a child or shifted Volda by a single pace, yet together they fixed the people and places the empire preferred to call movable.

Hask read Lera's line about frost. "What did she hear?"

"We don't know. That's why we came."

Beroch turned to Courier Sevet. "When does the academy recess?"

"Frontier students remain through emergency term. Travel presents a greater danger."

"Who ordered the emergency term?"

"The city prefect, under regency authority."

"Write a request for their immediate return under Article Seven."

Sevet hesitated. "Article Seven guarantees schooling. It does not require release during military emergency."

"Write the request."

She wrote. Beroch signed, then gave Dava a copy rather than promising an answer. Parents understood the worth of paper that had not yet moved anyone.

The Regent's offer arrived that evening through the same lichen mirror used for field conferences. Ivara Cend appeared seated in a plain stone room. Beroch recognized deliberate austerity when he saw it. A ruler with a palace behind her had chosen a soldier's wall.

"Commander Sarn," she said. "Quartermaster Helve reports that you preserved the breeding herd."

"The charter preserved it."

"You applied the charter. Tools require hands."

He let the praise pass.

Ivara asked everyone but Sevet to leave. Beroch kept Hask as a charter witness. The Regent noticed and did not object.

"Meris Tal is traveling with the saboteur Kivik Noll," Ivara said. "They intend an attack on Red Hollow. Tal possesses military designs. Noll possesses a counter-resonance tool stolen from a maintenance shaft. Capture them alive."

"My current order protects Volda's field route."

"I am expanding it. Three Sarn columns under your direct authority, reinforced by eight hundred imperial foot. In return, the eastern winter pasture enters your charter at thaw."

Hask's eyes moved to the map. Eastern pasture had watered ground in poor years and a defensible basalt rim. River Rauk claimed its lower ford; accepting the offer could start a fight before any imperial enemy arrived.

"In return for two prisoners," Beroch said.

"In return for preventing a forge disaster. Without new throat-nails, controlled waking fails. Then every city on living ground faces Kharad's chaos."

Beroch thought of the 2,110 civilians Korra had pushed through Sable Stair. He also remembered the bridge kits she tried to take under threat. Her cause did not purify her methods. Meris had built the crown before objecting to its use. Kivik had struck imperial equipment and could destroy more.

"The pasture language must include River access," he said. "No exclusive Sarn claim below the third marker."

Ivara tilted her head. "You decline an advantage over your rivals?"

"I decline a guaranteed skirmish that would consume the advantage."

"Accepted."

"The burial route shifts south."

"Engineering says it cannot."

"Then protection crews move every roadstone under Sarn witness before Volda crosses. Custodians receive replacement ground, not coin alone."

Silence lengthened across the mirror. Ivara had expected bargaining over pasture, perhaps over rank. The dead complicated schedules without increasing cavalry strength.

"I will authorize protected removal where feasible," she said.

"Feasible belongs to whoever holds the measuring rod. Name the witness."

Sevet kept her face still.

Ivara's iron-gray braid rested over one shoulder. "Commander, six western springs are failing. Two grain cities face rationing by winter. Every delay protects one valley by endangering ten."

"Then ten valleys can witness what necessity costs this one."

Hask's fingers touched the charter copy. Beroch understood that the Regent could end the conference and order another force across Sarn land. Exact terms

only mattered while both sides still found advantage in them.

He chose his next demand carefully. "Add an evacuation clause to my field commission. No commanded route crosses an occupied camp, school convoy, burial crew, or marked civilian column until a named officer certifies clearance. My cavalry may halt supporting movement to enforce it."

Ivara's gaze hardened. "You ask authority to interrupt the march."

"I ask authority to keep imperial wheels from grinding the people who make them useful."

"And if Tal reaches Red Hollow while you count tents?"

"Then your eight hundred foot can explain why they abandoned civilians to chase an engineer."

Sevet looked down, hiding either alarm or approval.

The mirror dimmed as distance disturbed the pulse. When Ivara's image steadied, fatigue showed around her eyes. "Draft the clause. Field Marshal Cend may revise operational wording."

"He may add protection. He may not remove named groups."

"Draft it."

Beroch worked through the night with Hask and Sevet. Every noun created a battlefield. Camp required three occupied shelters so scouts could not delay an army with one empty tent. Marked civilian column required a visible blue-and-white route cloth and two witnesses. Burial crews gained six hours to clear a line after notice. School convoys received first bridge passage unless an active attack made the bridge itself unsafe.

Ven argued that exceptions swallowed protection. Dava, summoned from the parent camp, argued that no clause survived contact with war unless someone on the field had power to stop a column. Beroch added that power to his own commission and to any Sarn captain acting within sight of a protected group.

At dawn, Sevet pressed her five-cut supply seal beneath the draft.

"Insufficient," Beroch said.

"The Regent authorized me to execute field appendices."

"Yesterday you said your commission could not alter routes. Today you claim it can alter commands. Choose one weakness."

Her mouth tightened. She opened the red route cylinder and removed a second seal wrapped in wool. Nine cuts marked its edge.

Hask murmured, "You carried that all day."

"I carried authority for an agreement the Regent expected to reach."

Beroch almost admired the preparation. "Read the evacuation clause aloud."

Sevet read it before the captains, parents, Rutha, and two imperial stable hands.

Then she pressed the regent's field seal into black wax. Beroch signed beneath it. Dava copied the text in her own hand while Rutha made two further copies for riders taking separate roads.

No paper could stop a Worldback's foot. A paper could place a living officer between that foot and a camp, backed by witnesses who would know whether the officer chose obedience or law.

The cavalry formed after sunrise. Nineteen remount leads stood empty. Three hundred and sixty Sarn riders carried six days of grain, bridge cord, winter blankets, and no certainty that Red Hollow still stood. Eight hundred imperial infantry would meet them beyond Olt Ridge. Beroch assigned Ven to the rear company, where impatience had fewer chances to become policy.

Dava approached his horse before departure. "If the city refuses the return request?"

"I will send another under my field seal."

"And if paper keeps failing?"

He could have offered confidence. She had brought him evidence because she did not need comfort.

"Then I will know the charter has lost one of its bargains," he said. "I will count what remains before I choose."

Her expression said that parents already knew which bargain mattered most.

Beroch mounted. The eastern road passed the burial valley before climbing toward Volda's fortress terraces. For now the colossus remained still beyond two ranges, its outline fixed against cloud. He gave Hask custody of the sealed appendix and kept only a copy inside his coat.

At the fork, one rider turned toward the parent camp, another toward Sarn's southern council, and a third toward the burial custodians. Beroch led the main column east. Every recipient would carry the same words before any imperial wheel reached the old road.

Chapter 12 — A Regent Counts Her Cities

Ivara tipped the measuring jar until the last cup of springwater struck the brass basin.

The sound barely reached the citizens packed inside Avenor's Hall of Measures. Once, water from the Western Stair spring had filled that basin in four breaths. On Day 12 of the emergency, a clerk had waited eleven minutes to collect one jar.

"Again," said the delegate from Pellin.

Chief Measurer Olt looked toward the Regent.

"Again," Ivara ordered.

They emptied the basin, checked the jar's etched line, and sent a runner down three flights to the spring chamber. The hall waited. Quarry factors stood beside hospital stewards. Two mayors wore traveling dust on their formal coats. Low Lichen drain workers occupied the rear benches because the front had been reserved for guilds that owned pipes.

Avenor did not panic well. Its people translated fear into petitions, precedence, and accusations about valves. Ivara trusted that noise more than silence.

The runner returned with water below the etched line.

Mayor Pellin gripped the witness rail. "Your measurer has narrowed the feed."

"I watched the seal broken this morning," Olt said.

"Then Orun's quarry pumps are stealing pressure."

A quarry factor objected. Hospital Steward Mara called both of them cowards. Voices climbed until Ivara struck the rim of the basin with the empty jar.

"Western Stair has lost sixty-one parts in a hundred since first thaw," she said. "The quarry draw accounts for seven. Closing it gains Pellin four days and leaves six thousand cutters without wages or washwater. Continue accusing one another if you have a way to turn accusation into rain. Otherwise we will assign the remaining flow."

The two threatened cities lay west of Avenor: Pellin, where thirty-two thousand people milled winter grain, and Sova, whose copperworks made pump fittings for half the empire. Both faced ration failure before frost. Saving either by cart would consume transport needed for the frontier army.

Ivara moved carved counters on the city board. Forty blue stones to Pellin. Twenty-six to Sova. A black counter for every day before cisterns reached the sanitary floor.

"Pellin receives western canal priority for fourteen days," she decided. "Sova closes two smelters and sends their pump crews to restore the Karst line. Capital granaries release twelve thousand sacks to both cities against spring debt, not purchase price. Quarry pumps reduce by one quarter. Hospitals retain full

allotment."

Mara nodded once. The quarry factors began calculating their losses before Ivara finished.

Mayor Sova stared at the board. "Two smelters means eight hundred workers dismissed."

"Reassign them to the Karst crews."

"They are furnacers, not ditch hands."

"Then pair each four with a surveyor and pay all five from relief funds."

"That fund is committed to Lorn survivors."

The name entered Ivara through her damaged left ear as a pressure rather than a sound.

She looked up at the hall's north bell. Its bronze had come from Lorn's collapsed council house, recast with the names of seven hundred and six dead around the lower rim. A clerk rang it at every spring census. The note reached her right ear cleanly and broke against the old injury on the left.

Forty years earlier, she had lain beneath a table while a street folded.

Memory did not give her a wide view. It gave her a floorboard against her teeth, dust packed behind one eyelid, and her youngest brother Lio's hand opening twice beside a fallen chair. He had been eight. Their mother shouted from the stair until stone cut the sound short. The ground rose again. Walls met overhead. Ivara crawled toward daylight through a pantry no longer attached to its house.

No operator had commanded Lorn's foundation. No prepared corridor existed. Engineers had argued for three years over whether the tremors justified relocation, and every delay had protected property values for one more season. When the old ridge shifted, twelve thousand people tried to use one southern road.

Ivara had watched a flour cart overturn across it.

Her brothers never reached that road. Her mother never left the stair.

The official memorial taught a cleaner lesson: uncontrolled stone killed; imperial order rebuilt. What it omitted had also remained true. Officials concealed early surveys. Landowners opposed evacuation. Soldiers closed a second gate to prevent looting and trapped two neighborhoods behind it. Command did not arrive innocent after chaos. It helped prepare the casualties it later counted.

Ivara knew this. She kept choosing command.

"The Lorn fund remains intact," she told Mayor Sova. "Use emergency works credit. My office will guarantee wages for twenty days. After that, show me water or show me why another city should surrender it."

The hearing continued until the sunlight crossed all twelve floor marks. At its end, Olt did not hand her the continental census. He asked her to follow him beneath the hall.

They descended through the public spring chamber, past copper pipes engraved with donor houses, into service passages too low for Ivara's guards to stand upright. Heat gathered under the stone. Condensation darkened her braid. Three Low Lichen workers waited beside a junction where the Western Stair feed divided between hospital, quarry, and court districts.

Their mantles grew in practical strips along scalp and spine, cut short around shoulders so drainage harnesses would not catch. The oldest, a woman named Issen, held a cracked valve in both hands.

"Your hearing counted flow at the basin," Issen said. "It did not count what fails before water reaches the basin."

Mineral rot had eaten the valve from within. Ivara pressed a nail against its orange edge and watched metal flake away.

"How many?"

"Seven junction valves below their safe thickness. Four can be replaced from stores. The other three require Sova copper."

Mayor Sova had just been ordered to close two smelters. Every decision returned wearing another person's work clothes.

Olt opened a service ledger. Drain crews had reported the thinning for eleven months. Pipe owners delayed replacement because the Western Stair spring still exceeded contracted minimums then. By the time flow fell, emergency copper cost six times its ordinary price.

"Who rejected the first request?" Ivara asked.

Issen named a court water commissioner related to one of the front-bench guild factors. The man had signed three speeches that morning demanding discipline from western towns.

"Remove him," Ivara told Olt. "Seize the pipe reserve attached to his house."

Issen shook her head. "That reserve uses ornamental gauge. Melt it and half becomes waste. Give us Sova sheet."

"Sova needs sheet for the Karst line."

"Then choose which repair fails. Do not send us noble copper and call it generosity."

Ivara crouched beside the junction. Running water once made these pipes sing against the wall. Now she could hear individual drops. A child's chalk drawing covered one dry section: a blue city under nine dark humps, every roof smoking as if evening meals waited inside.

"Which three valves protect the most people?" she asked.

Issen marked hospital south, Low Lichen drains, and Old Grain kitchens. Court baths came fourth.

"Close the baths," Ivara said. "Move their existing valve to the Karst staging

cistern. Sova sheet replaces these three first."

Olt noted the order.

"Inspection access too," Issen added. "Pipe owners lock us out until failure."

The request had no grandeur, only hinges and keys. Ivara granted service crews entry under dual witness. Issen accepted without gratitude and gave her the broken valve as evidence.

On the climb back, they passed a dormitory cut into Orun's foundation plate. Twenty drain families lived there between tool racks and warm stone. A little boy slept with one hand against the wall, feeling the slow pulse that adults had taught him to ignore.

Ivara stopped outside the doorway.

If Orun rose before those chambers flexed, the carved ceiling would shear along the old quarry seam. Evacuation planners classified the residents as service labor and placed them behind government households. She knew that without opening a slate.

"Put this dormitory into the north flex survey," she told Olt.

"The survey already exceeds its crew allotment."

"Then remove the ceremonial archive. Paper can be carried upstairs."

The change might save two hundred people. It did nothing for Pellin's thirty-two thousand. Sovereignty often worked at that scale: one corrected valve visible beneath a continent-sized failure.

Back in the emptied hall, Olt finally handed her the continental spring census in a locked gray case.

Six western springs had entered terminal decline. Esseth's northern channel no longer fed the Reed Plain. Morra's old basin had dropped below root depth. Galn, Tirava, Osk, and Bel each showed pressure changes matching the first stage of Kharad's waking. Orun remained stable beneath Avenor, though deep gauges had begun to warm.

Pellin and Sova faced famine risk. Three smaller towns could follow within a year. Keeping the Worldbacks fixed no longer kept the empire stable.

Ivara carried the case through the government quarter herself. Guards opened the nine-lock map room beneath the regency tower. Inside, an oval table held the continent in fitted stone plates. Mountain chains rose in dark relief. Cities gleamed as copper studs. Officially the model depicted watersheds and roads.

Engineers waiting around it knew better.

Deren Cend stood near Volda's plate in a field marshal's red coat. Meris Tal's former deputy, Yana Peor, kept both hands wrapped against early stone creep. Orinel Thyr attended by lichen mirror, pale green light filling a silver dish at Orun's end of the table. Three ministers, two operators, and Chief Measurer Olt completed

the council.

Ivara unlocked the central drawer. Nine fresh-corestone splinters lay in separate lead cradles. Thin copper threads ran from each cradle toward a three-part crown diagram.

"Kharad has proved that waking cannot be postponed," she said. "The spring census proves fixed sleep cannot continue. We therefore proceed with the Ninefold March."

Minister Sale touched the edge of the table. "That title appears nowhere in the civil authorization."

"It appears now."

She placed the first splinter over Volda, the second over Kharad, the third over Orun. Copper threads connected them. Six more lines spread west and south.

Meris had designed a modular bridle crown to wake one Deep Patient slowly enough for evacuation. Her linkage calculations allowed three crowns to share load. Ivara's operators had extended the geometry. Volda would provide directed force. Orun's older pulse channels would amplify reach. Kharad, once recaptured, would close the western side of the circuit. Together they could send a waking command through the dormant network to Esseth, Morra, Galn, Tirava, Osk, and Bel.

All nine would move.

Not blindly, Ivara told herself. Surveyed routes led toward selected spring regions. Armies would clear settlements. Bridle corrections would separate the lines. Once the western aquifers recovered, controlled intervals could replace the single emergency march.

Yana Peor flexed wrapped fingers. Gray showed beneath the cloth at her middle joints. "We have never linked more than two test channels."

"The two-channel test held for seven minutes."

"At one-thirtieth field load."

Deren leaned over Volda's route. "Field movement does not require full link at first. Wake Volda, establish gait, then take Kharad's crown after Red Hollow replaces the damaged brace."

"And Orun?" asked Sale.

Ivara looked at Avenor's copper stud. Forty-one thousand residents lived above the oldest throat-nail. Hospitals occupied flex chambers near the north quarry, but most districts had forgotten that their streets rested on anything except ground.

"Orun remains still until the capital evacuation plan reaches readiness," she said.

Olt's face made clear that readiness had no present date.

Orinel's image stirred above the silver dish. "White Canopy requires assurances

before we supply additional cultures. Our propagation houses cannot absorb unlimited operator sickness."

Yana looked at her wrapped hands. "You mean the sickness your cultures hide."

"Pain masking allows a damaged operator to withdraw without shock. Misuse belongs to command, not medicine."

"Your last tray kept Pell Station working until two operators lost finger movement."

Orinel did not turn toward the deputy. "Regent, our conditions remain medical priority for White Canopy households, protected dormancy transport, and independent custody of our low-temperature stores."

"Include Green Mantle?" Ivara asked.

"Green Mantle has repudiated lawful office. Its workers seized court cultures."

"Then your request covers White Canopy only."

A pause crossed Orinel's face. She had expected the Regent to enlarge the bargain out of decorum. Ivara preferred terms that admitted their boundaries.

"White Canopy and registered propagation labor," Orinel said.

"Define registered."

"Workers entered in the root rolls before this emergency."

That would omit casual drain hands and recent refugees. It would also secure the trained cultivators required to make more cultures. Ivara directed Sale to write the category exactly.

Yana said, "We should reduce operator exposure, not provision it. Meris built a removable brace joint into the crown. If Red Hollow copies her early geometry, we can relieve load between commands."

Deren looked at her. "Tal used that joint to break the field crown at Sable Stair."

"Because you used it for military direction."

"We are using the entire system for military direction."

No one mistook the admission.

Ivara moved a black counter onto Kharad's eastern line. "Red Hollow will correct the weakness."

"Fresh casting requires months," Yana said.

"It has five days."

"Then workers will die."

"Workers are already dying in failing spring towns. Give me a plan with no bodies beneath it and I will sign yours instead."

Yana's gaze dropped to the wrapped hands. Ivara regretted the cruelty but not the demand. Government received every death as an argument for a different

death.

Chief Measurer Olt opened the census case. "If all nine move on commanded lines, their routes converge here." He pointed east of the capital, beyond the immediate map. "Our old mineral surveys show broad salt deposits, but no crown model includes close-body interference at that scale."

"They will not arrive together," Deren said. "The march staggers by gait."

"We do not know six of those gaits."

Ivara placed time rods along each route. Weeks separated the projected arrivals. Some estimates came from imperial foundation records. Others relied on Rauk roadstones confiscated during corridor surveys. Uncertainty widened toward the east.

"Then widen the intervals," she said. "The first three establish control. The remaining six wake in sequence after field confirmation."

Sale cleared his throat. "Public authorization?"

"Spring restoration and controlled evacuation. Do not publish the linked mechanism until Volda stands."

"That conceals material risk from the cities asked to clear routes."

"It prevents nine simultaneous flight panics before we possess one functioning road."

The minister signed because refusal would remove him from the room, and absence would not stop the order.

Deren requested Day 16 for Volda's waking. Red Hollow needed the bridle plates tested under cold load. Cavalry had not yet cleared Olt Ridge. Beroch's appendix complicated the western approach.

Ivara considered the calendar. Every lost day lowered Pellin's cistern. Every rushed hour increased operator damage and the chance Volda would step into an occupied valley.

"Day 17," she said. "First command at dawn. Beroch clears the burial line under his own clause. Your crews honor it where movement permits."

Deren heard the qualification. "He will hear only the clause."

"Then do not give him a reason to read it against us."

The council broke near midnight. Orinel left with a signed priority compact. Deren carried the waking schedule and route authority. Sale took the language for public rationing notices. Yana remained beside the crown diagram after everyone else moved away.

"Meris left a report," the deputy said. "Before Sable Stair. She wrote that a listening response had altered Kharad's direction without command."

"Kharad also destroyed roads and killed citizens."

"A bridle command made its pulse stutter."

"I read the operator record."

"Then you know direction can come from something other than us."

Ivara covered the nine splinters with their lead lid. "Direction without schedule killed Lorn."

"People killed at Lorn had schedules. They lacked an open road."

For an instant the map room narrowed to flour dust, a fallen chair, and a small hand opening beside it. Ivara made herself look at Yana.

"Prepare your operators for Day 17. No one with creep beyond the second joint enters the gallery."

"That leaves eleven qualified."

"Train more."

When Ivara returned to the Hall of Measures, cleaners had emptied the brass basin. Petitions remained stacked at her chair. One came from Lorn survivors objecting to diversion of emergency credit. Another listed the names of Sova's eight hundred furnacers. A third requested that Low Lichen drains receive direct water allotments rather than whatever White Canopy released downward.

She amended the water order to include those drains. She denied the Lorn objection and attached a repayment schedule. She required Sova to keep every reassigned furnacer on the wage roll.

Then she wrote the Red Hollow command herself.

Double throat-nail output. Suspend peacetime exposure limits for five days. Record every worker assigned, every injury, and every death. Deliver Volda brace plates before Day 17.

Recording did not redeem the order. It did ensure that a clerk could not later reduce the dead to damaged inventory, and that choice mattered to claims she might never control. Ivara signed anyway.

Dawn paled the high windows. Beneath the floor, Orun's deep pulse traveled through the capital, too slow for most citizens to notice. The water in the measuring jar trembled once. Ivara set nine counters in a line, closed the census case, and sent the sealed forge command east.

Chapter 13 — The Forge of Throat-Nails

Meris crawled beneath a fan that had not stopped turning in three centuries.

Its shedstone blades passed a handspan above her back, each one pushing furnace heat west through the old Noll ventilation shaft. According to Kivik's contract map, the blades should have pulled cool air inward. Red Hollow's doubled casting load had reversed the pressure and turned the entry route into an oven.

Kivik lay ahead of her with one brass funnel pressed against the floor. Their other funnel hung unused at the right side of their head, tied back so it would not strike stone. Thalen followed behind, dragging a lichen-wrapped medicine case through red dust.

"Three blades have chipped roots," Kivik said. "We stop the fan or become educational stains."

Meris measured the gap by thumb knuckle. A maintenance latch revolved beyond the blade hub. "The brake sits on the forge side."

"Naturally. Maintenance exists to teach the dead what management forgot."

They had entered through a collapsed condensation drain two hours before dawn. Above them, Red Hollow occupied a volcanic cut between two ridges, far enough from any sleeping Worldback that residents had once believed its industry harmless. The empire shipped fresh corestone there under wet felt, cast it around command rods, and sent throat-nail components east. The main gate held a hundred soldiers. The Noll shafts held old contracts, bad air, and Kivik's memory.

Another vibration traveled through the floor. Meris counted six rapid impacts, a pause, then two more.

"Casting hammer," she whispered.

Kivik shook their head. "Distress knock. Six, pause, two means trapped beyond a hot door."

"Could be bait."

"Could be a worker."

They struck the floor with a knuckle: two, pause, six. An answer came immediately.

Stealth narrowed around a choice. The trapped person lay east, away from the ledger room and main casting bed. Rescue would announce that someone controlled the vents. Meris looked at Kivik's shaved head, shining with sweat.

"Show me the branch," she said.

They backed into a junction barely wide enough to turn. Kivik removed three corroded pins from a wall grille, keeping each one in a pocket rather than letting it ring on stone. Thalen pushed the grille inward. Heat struck them with the smell of scorched cloth.

A young goblin hung by one arm from a service ladder above a red-lit drop. His other sleeve had caught in a closing damper. Blood ran from his wrist to his chin. Below him, furnace exhaust pulsed through a vertical throat.

Meris looped a cord around the ladder and braced her boots. Kivik crawled onto the first rung.

"Name," they called.

"Pesh Noll. Third-air shift."

"Contract holder?"

"Revoked yesterday. They kept my shift."

Kivik's mouth flattened. They climbed until the damper heat smoked their glove, then set the counter-hammer against its hinge. The tool looked too small for the work: a shedstone head, two copper collars, a wrapped grip. Kivik tapped once, listening through the handle, and struck a second time at a different angle.

The hinge released its stored vibration. The damper jumped open.

Pesh fell. Meris took his weight through the cord, her two missing fingertips slipping on the wet knot. Thalen caught his legs and dragged him into the branch while Kivik kicked the damper brace into place.

Pesh's forearm carried parallel red lines from command exposure. No gray tracery showed yet.

"Can you walk?" Thalen asked.

"If walking points outward."

"It does after you tell us the shift pattern," Meris said.

Pesh looked from her imperial-cut coat to the old contract marks on Kivik's tools. "You're here to break the forge."

"We are here to stop throat-nail production and remove evidence. Workers leave first."

"Management locked the north housing gate at curfew. My mother sleeps there."

Meris had mapped structural loads, not families. "How many in housing?"

"Two hundred fourteen on night allotment. More in the day sheds."

Kivik tore a blank margin from the contract map. "Name every occupied section."

Pesh did. Housing north. Sorting benches west. Quench crews below the casting floor. Forty workers in the wet corestone vault. Twelve cleaners inside the flue court. Injured laborers kept in an infirmary beside the White Canopy store because sending them home would create compensation records.

Every name changed the sabotage geometry.

Meris had planned to fracture three casting supports and let the roof settle into

the bed. With two hundred people behind the north line, that collapse would close their exit. The corestone vault could not absorb a shock without transmitting it through the command rods.

"We need the old west exhaust open," she said. "And the casting bed must fail inward, not north."

Kivik studied her. "Can your hidden joint do that?"

"If they copied it."

"Management copies every cheap defect and calls maintenance original. We may live."

Thalen bound Pesh's wrist with clean moss. The rescued worker led them through a bypass around the fan brake. They emerged one by one into a tool recess overlooking the casting floor.

Red Hollow descended in seven industrial terraces. On the lowest, a molten salt channel circled an oval bed forty paces long. Fresh corestone lay in fitted slabs within it, dark red veins moving beneath wet surfaces. Workers in reflective aprons guided a suspended command spine over the slabs. Each time the spine descended, the corestone contracted as if trying to pull away.

Meris had seen plans for the process. Plans had not included motion.

The casting hammer struck. Vibration punched through her teeth. Two workers staggered. An overseer gestured for the next blow before they regained balance.

Above the bed, modular brace plates formed a segmented ring. Meris recognized her seven-year-old geometry, including the removable joint she had hidden to permit load relief. Red Hollow had enlarged every dimension and removed the safety spacing. Four joints now connected the casting frame to the bridle plate being made for Volda.

"Five days," she murmured. "They're compressing a three-month cooling sequence into five days."

Pesh pointed toward a glass-fronted gallery. "Night master keeps the output book there. Guild ledgers below. Soldiers took both after the last death claim."

Kivik did not ask how many deaths. They already carried a number inherited from rumors and closed contracts.

Thalen watched the workers near the bed. "Their mantles are too pale. White Canopy cultures have suppressed inflammation."

Crates beneath the gallery bore the black hammer and green propagation seal. Proof sat in public view because authority often mistook visibility for innocence.

Meris traced routes across the terraces. One stair to the gallery. Two bridges over the salt channel. North hoists serving housing. West exhaust controls behind the quench tanks. Imperial guards stood at every vertical exit, twenty-four visible, with more in the gate barracks.

"We cannot organize two hundred people from a recess," she said.

Pesh nodded toward a copper speaking tube. "Shift call reaches every bench."

"And management hears it."

"Management hears everything except a contract."

Kivik took the tube cap off. "Then we begin with a contract."

They spoke their guild name, work lineage, and revocation status into the tube. Conversations died across the forge.

"I am Kivik Noll, void-listener of the South Channels, party to Maintenance Compact Six before management burned its witness copy. I bring notice of lethal concealed resonance, unlawful confinement, and an active exit obstruction. Under revocation right, any worker may leave a tool safe and withdraw. Under memorial right, any worker may demand the death ledger before further hazardous work. I demand it now."

The night master's voice burst through another tube. "Unauthorized use. Arrest team to Vent Three."

Workers did not move. A woman at the quench station set down her hook with deliberate care.

The casting hammer operator raised both hands from the controls.

An overseer shoved him back. Across the west benches, tools began striking stone in the contract rhythm: one for witness, two for refusal. Not rebellion yet. A count.

Guards climbed toward the recess.

"Gallery first," Meris said.

Pesh led them through a narrow cable trench. Thalen remained at the tube to direct injured workers toward the old exhaust route. Kivik moved beside Meris, counter-hammer wrapped against accidental contact.

They reached the gallery from below. Meris pushed her shoulder against a floor hatch while Kivik worked its pins. The metal resisted until her right hand cramped around the short grip. She shifted to her left, cursed the old quarry machine that had taken two fingertips years ago, and drove upward.

The hatch opened beneath a clerk's stool. The clerk fell backward. Kivik caught the man's head before it hit a cabinet.

"Stay down," they said.

Night Master Carron reached for an alarm lever. Meris threw the floor pin. It struck his wrist, not hard enough to break it, hard enough to turn his hand aside. Pesh barred the gallery door as soldiers reached the outer landing.

Glass surrounded them on three sides. Workers below could see every movement.

Kivik went to the locked guild cabinet. Carron laughed through his pain. "The

key left with the day master."

"Keys are apologies for hinges."

One counter-hammer tap found the cabinet's resonant seam. A second opened it without splintering the shelves.

Ledgers filled four levels. The top book listed current shifts. Lower volumes carried sealed accident claims, contract revocations, and medical removals. Kivik chose the oldest unopened claim book and laid it on the output desk.

Names filled the first page. Noll names, human names, two Ilaith names from ventilation cultivation crews. Beside each one, a clerk had written fever, joint failure, fall, or voluntary departure. A hidden exposure column recorded command resonance above fatal limits.

Kivik turned pages slowly.

"Read them," Pesh said.

Soldiers hammered the gallery door.

Kivik read every name into the speaking tube. The forge heard the dead return as contract holders, parents, apprentices, debtors, singers, bad cooks, careful joiners, and people whose tools had passed to relatives without compensation. Workers answered each name with one strike.

Thirty-eight.

Thirty-nine.

Forty.

The final page had been pasted to the back cover. Kivik slid a thin blade beneath it and freed the paper.

"Mera Noll," they said. Their voice roughened. "Second-air master. My mother's elder sister. Cause entered as departure. Exposure column records heart mineralization."

The count was forty-one.

A third impact bowed the door inward. Meris overturned the output desk against it.

Thalen's voice came through the tube. "Workers ask whether the west exhaust is safe."

"Not yet," Meris answered. "Quench crews must reverse Channel Two and drain Channel Four into the empty slag pit. Do not touch Channel Three."

A quench forewoman below looked up. "Channel Two feeds the bed."

"Exactly. Cool the south braces before the north. We need the frame to turn inward."

"That cracks the current casting."

"It ends every casting."

Night Master Carron pushed himself upright. "You will rupture the vault. Half this settlement sits over the hot channel."

"Only if your emergency alterations tied the vault to the bed."

His eyes flicked toward the lower plan drawer.

Meris opened it. Beneath production schedules lay a black stone plate incised with nine linked channels. Three central marks corresponded to Volda, Kharad, and Orun. Six branches spread beyond them. Load figures had been updated in Yana Peor's hand, then overridden under the Regent's seal.

The full Ninefold plate weighed more than a child. Meris could not carry it and climb quickly.

Pesh pulled a hanging chain through its holes. "Two people carry."

Another drawer held White Canopy receipts: fever lace, blue cup, dormant nerve moss, all shipped under operator care exemptions. Worker allotments had been charged against wages. The pain-masking cultures did not reduce exposure. They kept people on shift after their bodies would otherwise force them down.

Thalen arrived through the hatch, blood staining one sleeve that did not belong to him. "The infirmary has thirty-six patients. Nine cannot walk."

"North hoists?" Meris asked.

"Guards hold them."

Workers below had begun the channel reversal. Steam rolled over the southern half of the bed. The suspended command spine twisted a finger's width.

Kivik tore pages from no ledger. They passed whole books through the hatch to workers in the cable trench, assigning each to a named witness. "One copy route to Split River. One to Cinder Cloister. One stays with the bereaved. White Canopy receipts go with Thalen. Death ledger stays with me."

"We need hands at the hoists," Pesh said.

Meris looked through the gallery floor. Thirty workers stood back from their benches, waiting for a plan that accounted for where they slept.

She took the speaking tube.

"My name is Meris Tal. I designed the brace geometry above the bed. The empire removed its safety spacing and used it to cast command plates. I am going to release the south joints. When that begins, the frame will rotate toward the empty slag pit. If any north joint releases first, housing collapses. I need four teams, each under a forge worker who knows the local bolts better than I do. No one follows my instruction without checking it against the frame in front of them."

A man near Brace One raised a scarred arm. "I take south inner."

The quench forewoman claimed south outer. Pesh named two maintenance hands for the center locks. Thalen organized stretcher lines toward the west exhaust. Workers made choices quickly because they had spent years imagining

which failures would kill them.

The gallery door burst inward.

Imperial soldiers came over the desk in pairs. Meris ducked a spear shaft, caught it under her arm, and used the attacker's momentum to drive him into the cabinet. Pesh swung a clerk's stool at the second soldier's knees. Kivik did not use the counter-hammer on flesh. They struck the gallery frame instead.

The glass wall released from its lower seating and dropped outward in one sheet. It shattered on an empty inspection platform. A new exit opened onto the hoist cable.

Workers below threw hooks upward. Meris sent the ledgers first. Thalen slid down after them with the White Canopy receipts inside his shirt. Pesh and Kivik lowered the Ninefold plate on its chain.

Carron grabbed the speaking tube. "Main gate, seal all housing. Any worker leaving station forfeits family ration."

His threat changed hesitation into motion. Quench crews opened Channel Two. Sorters pushed ore carts across the guards' stair. Hoist operators reversed the north lifts, bringing families down from locked housing while armed crews climbed toward them.

Meris descended the cable hand over hand. The missing fingertips on her right hand forced more load into her wrist. A guard cut the line above her. Fibers snapped one by one.

She swung toward the brace ring and landed hard on its outer walk. The severed cable fell across the salt channel.

Below, the corestone slabs moved under the command spine. Meris felt their contraction through her boots. Fresh material had been cut from living pulse channels somewhere far from Red Hollow, transported wet, and forced into a new instrument of pain. Destroying the forge could not return it.

Brace One's worker team had removed three bolts. The fourth had fused under heat.

"Cold wedge!" Meris called.

The forewoman sent a wet iron shim sliding along the rail. Meris caught it, seated it at the joint, and struck with a maintenance maul. Steam blinded her. The fused bolt split.

South inner released.

The frame dipped toward the slag pit by half a degree. North braces screamed under the transferred load.

"Hold there," she ordered. "No second release until housing clears the upper span."

A runner crossed the floor. "Thirty-two still above. Hoist Two jammed."

Kivik appeared on the brace walk, carrying the counter-hammer and the death ledger in a chest strap. "I can clear the hoist resonance."

"You need the tool for the bed."

"A tool can do two jobs if management never designed either."

They ran north. Meris stayed at the joint, watching the frame's strain marks creep toward failure. Soldiers occupied the east stair but could not cross the ore carts. Their captain ordered archers onto the gallery ruin.

Workers pulled reflective aprons overhead as arrows came down. One shaft struck the quench forewoman's thigh. She sat against a pipe, snapped the shaft short, and kept calling valve positions.

Thalen reached her with a dressing. "You leave now."

"After Channel Four opens."

"Someone else has hands."

A younger worker took the valve wheel. Thalen and two stretcher carriers moved the forewoman west.

From the north hoist came a deep counterstroke. Kivik had found the jam. The platform descended carrying children, sleeping elders, and workers still in shift aprons. A second load followed.

"Housing clear!" Pesh shouted.

Meris signaled the center teams. They withdrew pins in sequence, inside before outside. The frame rotated another degree. Molten salt spilled over the bed lip into the empty slag pit. Corestone cracked along her removable geometry.

The sound arrived below hearing, a force that compressed her chest.

Kivik returned at a run. Blood showed beneath the brass funnel over their right ear.

"You're hurt," Meris said.

"Later. Where?"

She pointed to the command spine's root coupling. "One counterstroke there when I release south outer. Too early sends load north. Too late leaves the plate intact. Watch my hand."

They knelt on opposite sides of the joint. Around them, workers abandoned the last benches. Thalen's stretcher line passed through the west exhaust. Imperial guards climbed over the ore carts. The casting hammer operator had removed its control pins and thrown them into the salt channel.

Meris raised three fingers on her left hand.

Two.

One.

She drove the release bar down.

Kivik struck.

Counter-resonance ran through the command spine and met the frame's stored load. Every brace plate lifted. For a breath, the entire casting array hung without support.

Then the southern bed folded into the slag pit.

The throat-nail casting split lengthwise. Hot corestone slid under its own weight, burying molds, hammer guides, and cooling rails. The roof supports held north and failed south exactly as Meris had calculated, dropping stone into the empty work terraces. A red wave of dust crossed the floor.

The second pulse came from the vault.

Meris felt it through her knees. "Channel Three!"

Someone had opened it despite her warning, or a broken pipe had done the work. Cooling water struck stored corestone. Pressure climbed behind the vault doors.

A rupture would send command fragments through every connected foundation in Red Hollow.

Workers were still inside the west exhaust.

Meris ran toward the vault. Pesh caught her coat. "No entry."

"The relief stack needs manual opening."

"Control sits above the wet core."

"I know. I drew the revision."

Kivik seized the old contract map. "There is a bypass from First Air."

"Collapsed," Pesh said.

"Collapsed is not filled."

They led Meris into a side shaft while the floor bucked. The passage narrowed around fallen brick. Kivik listened with their left funnel now, head tilted awkwardly. Blood ran down the right side of their neck.

"Void above," they said too loudly. "Two arm lengths."

Meris and Pesh pulled bricks until their nails tore. Thalen arrived without being summoned and worked beside them. Behind him, the last stretcher disappeared into the exhaust.

They broke into the relief stack chamber. Its wheel had warped from heat. Four people leaned on it. Nothing moved.

Meris examined the hub. "It turns clockwise."

Pesh spat dust. "Every vent wheel turns left."

"Imperial revision. So an evacuating worker would close it by instinct."

Kivik looked back toward the collapsing forge. "Management originality."

They reversed pressure. The wheel shifted. Once, twice, then through a full quarter turn.

Steam erupted above Red Hollow with a roar that flattened everyone in the chamber. The vault pressure fell. Fresh corestone remained buried and ruined, but the foundation channels did not rupture.

When Meris regained her knees, Kivik sat against the wall pressing both hands over their ears.

"Can you hear me?" she asked.

"Left."

She moved to their left side. "And right?"

Kivik removed the blood-slick funnel. "A bell under water. No words."

Thalen examined the canal with a light culture, his face tightening as its color spread. "The membrane has torn. I can close the bleeding. I cannot promise hearing."

"Do not promise what you cannot measure," Kivik said. Their own voice remained too loud.

Pesh returned from the exhaust entrance. "All named sections report clear. Three guards came out with the infirmary carriers. The others retreated to the main gate."

"Casualties?" Meris asked.

"One worker crushed at the ore stair. Two soldiers under the gallery. More injured than I can count yet."

The success acquired bodies at once. Meris made him repeat the locations so no one disappeared beneath a general word.

They left through First Air as Red Hollow settled behind them. The forge roof collapsed in stages, each fall contained south of the housing line. Dawn showed a column of red steam above the ridge.

On the outer slope, workers gathered by contract groups rather than waiting for Meris. Some chose the Split River road with copied ledgers. Others turned toward Noll guild settlements to find families of the dead. A mixed crew remained to count injuries, free prisoners from the main gate cells, and prevent imperial stores from burning into the town.

Kivik sat on a stone while Thalen bound their right ear. The counter-hammer lay across their knees. They would not surrender it.

Meris and Pesh carried the Ninefold plate between them on the gallery chain. Nine channels caught the dawn in shallow cuts. She could read enough to know the first linkage ran through Volda, Kharad, and Orun. The rest required study away from the smoke.

Thalen sealed the White Canopy receipts inside oilcloth. The death ledger

remained against Kivik's chest, forty-one names protected from ash.

"Did we stop Volda?" Pesh asked.

Meris looked east. Nothing in the forge collapse could reach an installed throat-nail. Volda's bridle already had its command spine, its operator gallery, and plates enough for a first waking.

"No," she said. "We stopped the next replacement and the one after it. Volda can still be driven."

Pesh considered the ruined roof. "Then make this evidence travel faster than a mountain."

Workers divided the records among three routes. Before anyone departed, Kivik called for a slate and made Pesh begin a new ledger on the roadside. They entered the crushed worker as Ovan Pell, hook tender, thirty-four, survived by a husband in north housing. The two dead soldiers received names from a captured muster rather than a common mark. Thalen listed nineteen major injuries requiring transport and fifty-two lesser burns, cuts, or hearing complaints. Seven workers could not yet account for relatives because day-shift housing had scattered during the alarm.

No one agreed on who would pay the claims. Kivik wrote liability disputed, evidence held by witnesses and named five custodians from different shifts. Meris added her own signature beneath the structural sequence. The admission could place her before an imperial court if Cendar survived in recognizable form. It also prevented her from later calling the collapse an engineering success without its dead.

Only after the copies had separate carriers did the groups move. Meris took one end of the stone plate. Kivik rose unsteadily with the counter-hammer in one hand and refused every offered arm. They turned east toward the moving country, leaving Red Hollow unable to cast another throat-nail before Day 17.

Chapter 14 — Stone Rain over Harth

Korra saw the first artillery stone skip across Kharad's shoulder and knew the second would reach the city.

The black shot struck an abandoned orchard wall, burst through two terrace ribs, and vanished over the moving edge. Three heartbeats later, vibration reached her boots. The interval told her where the battery stood: north ground, beyond the shallow ridge, firing uphill at a target forty kilometers long.

"Down!" she shouted.

Workers on the bridge store dropped behind shedstone racks. Another shot crossed the morning, low enough for its wake to flatten winter grass rooted along Kharad's upper plate. It hit near the east water tower. The tower leaned, held, then shed half its clay tanks into the street.

Imperial gunners were not trying to kill Kharad. Nothing they could throw would do that. They meant to hurt one side until the colossus turned away from the old corridor.

Korra put two numb left fingertips to the road. The pulse beneath the worked surface accelerated, each beat carrying a rough edge from the northern impacts. She heard no words, only pain location and motion. Kharad's gait shortened on the struck side.

"Harth signal," she told the bridge crew. "Stone rain protocol. Flex shelters, not foundation vaults. Cut every rigid street join."

A drummer repeated the order downslope. Three beats for overhead hazard. Five for structural release. Harth answered from district towers as Korra ran.

The city traveled in pieces now. Streets once paved as proud continuous avenues had been cut into floating sections, linked by rope and fitted shedstone tongues. Orchard bridges rose and fell between terraces. Houses leaned within padded frames. Nothing looked orderly to an imperial surveyor. That disorder kept walls from tearing apart every time Kharad took a step.

The third shot struck a ridge above Harth.

A shelf of weathered stone lifted into the air. For one suspended instant, Korra saw roof-sized slabs turning against the sky. Then stone rain came down.

She reached the first market as people fled across it. A slab crushed three empty grain stalls. Fist-sized fragments tore through awnings and bounced along the paving. Sava Vaun stood on a cistern cart directing families toward a rope-hung cellar beneath the dye houses.

"West arch is full," Sava called. "Upper orchard shelter lost its stair."

"Open the drainage walk."

"Too narrow for litters."

Korra looked at the market slope. The drainage walk ran under a flexible culvert, protected from falling stone but steep enough to pitch anyone with poor footing. "Rope both sides. Walking wounded there. Litters to the dye cellar."

Pela Orr arrived with six grain hands and a slate tied to her belt. Dust coated one side of her face.

"Two hundred eighty places below the dye houses," Pela said. "We have four hundred coming."

"What stores can move?"

"People first. Grain stays."

Korra nodded. Months earlier, she might have ordered every sack carried because supply arithmetic had no bruises. Pela had taught her that food guarded at the cost of its eaters became an offering to empty walls.

A fourth shot landed beyond the Green Mantle terraces. Orchard roots jumped. Harth's north face released a long grinding sound.

Korra climbed the cistern cart. "Everyone from upper market, listen. Red cords go to dye cellar. White cords use the drainage walk. If you cannot see a cord, stand still and raise one hand. Runners will come to you. Do not follow a crowd without a route color."

Three imperfect routes formed instead of one efficient crush.

She left Sava with the market and took the upper stair two steps at a time. Her left fingertips would not close fully around the rail. Gray lines remained faint beneath the nails, no farther than they had reached at Sable Stair. She gripped with her right hand and kept moving.

At the artillery terrace, an imperial defector named Cal Rusk had assembled forty former wardens around salvaged bolt throwers. He pointed north toward flashes beyond the ridge.

"We can answer if your bridge crews raise a firing platform," he said. "Need sixty laborers, maybe eighty."

"From where?"

"The lower shelters."

"No."

"They sit protected while gunners strip this city."

"They live here. That does not make them your artillery crew."

Rusk gestured at the next flash. "If we don't suppress those engines, shelters become graves."

Korra studied the angle. Kharad's movement carried them east by several paces every breath. A fixed platform would lose alignment before the crews loaded twice. Exposed civilians would build a target that could not do its promised work.

"Strip two empty roof frames," she said. "Use trained wardens and bridge

volunteers. No shelter levy. Mount on sled runners so the platform moves with the shoulder grade."

"That gives me twenty people."

"Then fire one engine well instead of three badly."

Rusk swore but began naming volunteers. Korra sent four pathwrights to calculate runners. Consent under shelling did not become pure because she asked; she required each volunteer to name who would replace their shelter duty before climbing.

A runner found her at the next impact. "Bridge stores under cavalry attack. South approach."

Beroch.

His Sarn riders had followed faster than expected. The artillery forced Korra to protect Harth. The raid aimed at the flexible spans that let districts survive Kharad's gait. Lose those kits and every fracture ahead became a siege.

She left Rusk the firing solution and descended toward the store yards with thirty-two Vaun bridge hands.

Sarn cavalry had crossed by portable basalt ramps. They struck in narrow files, not a broad charge, because Kharad's skin rose and fell under their horses. Riders cut supply traces and hooked bridge-rib sleds for towing. Imperial infantry fired from the ground beyond the moving edge, trying to keep defenders away from the south approach.

Korra saw Beroch beside the central store. Blue clay marked his tusks. He directed two teams toward rope drums and one toward fitted stone tongues, taking components that would matter rather than burning everything.

"Leave the bridge stores!" Korra shouted.

He turned in the saddle. "Surrender Tal and Noll. The stores remain."

"Red Hollow is already gone."

The news reached him as a blow carefully hidden. "Then you have destroyed the next safe waking."

"There was nothing safe in that forge."

A shell struck the terrace above them.

The impact opened a line across the store yard. Horses screamed. Korra fell to one knee as stacked bridge ribs jumped from their cradles. A roof panel slid downhill and struck a rope cart, spilling burning pitch from a signal pot.

Fire raced along the treated cords.

Beyond it, eighteen civilians huddled under a loading canopy: store clerks, three children, and an old man on a wheeled litter. Their north exit had collapsed. The fire cut them off from Korra.

A Vaun worker ran for the burning rope. Korra caught his shoulder. "It will take

your legs."

"My daughters are there."

Before she could find another route, Beroch wheeled his horse toward the canopy.

"Third file, blankets wet!" he ordered. "Second file, open the slope gate."

His riders abandoned two hooked sleds. Six galloped through smoke with soaked saddle blankets held along their horses' flanks. Others ripped the south fence apart and laid a basalt ramp over the burning cord. Imperial infantry shouted for them to resume the raid.

Beroch ignored the call. He dismounted beside the wheeled litter, put his shoulder to its lower bar, and pushed it up the ramp while Sarn riders carried the children between horses. A shot from the ground struck one rescuer below the ribs. She stayed mounted until the last clerk crossed, then slid into another rider's arms.

Korra's bridge hands pulled survivors behind the stone racks. The store worker found both daughters and counted their faces before touching them.

Beroch remounted. Smoke blackened his ceremonial clay.

"Your gunners did that," Korra said.

"Not my battery."

"Your banner."

"As much as Red Hollow belonged to every worker inside it?"

The comparison angered her because it required an answer longer than battle allowed. "You had a choice at the fire. Make another."

"Release the people I was ordered to capture."

"No."

Beroch signaled withdrawal. His cavalry took four rope drums and eleven fitted tongues, less than a quarter of the stores they had hooked. They carried their wounded rescuer and left the bridge-rib sleds where they stood.

Korra did not order pursuit across the unstable approach. Killing riders who had just pulled children through fire would not restore the stolen equipment. It would also expose her people to infantry shot.

"Count every missing piece," she told the store master. "Then send the rescue witnesses to the casualty board. Both acts go down."

The artillery continued until afternoon. Rusk's single mobile thrower disabled one imperial engine by breaking its winding arm. Kharad's eastward motion carried Harth beyond the cleanest firing arc, but the northern ridge curved with them. More shots landed on the upper plates.

Near sunset, the ground under Korra changed rhythm.

Kharad set the right forelimb wide. The movement tilted Harth south, away from

the impacts, then raised the northern shoulder into a steeper shield. Roof frames groaned. Flexible streets extended to their cord limits. The turn did not match any bridle pulse Korra had felt at Sable Stair.

A deep crack opened above the abandoned orchard.

Korra reached it with Sava, Pela, and two pathwrights after the shelling slowed. A plate the size of a district had split along a natural shedding seam. Warm air rose from below, carrying mineral damp. Within the broken shell lay dozens of rounded stones nested in soft gray tissue.

They ranged from thumb-sized beads to ovals larger than a human torso. Fine veins pulsed inside their dark surfaces. None resembled throat-nail corestone. The surrounding tissue cradled each one without a cut.

Pela crouched at the edge. "Eggs?"

"Don't name what we haven't measured," Korra said, hearing Meris in the caution.

Sava pressed a listening wedge to safely detached rubble beside the seam. "Small pulses. Separate from Kharad's main rhythm."

The largest oval shifted when another shell struck far north. Kharad's shoulder rose higher. Loose shedstone slid over the opening, not enough to crush the contents, enough to make a sloped roof above them.

"Seed-stones," said an old Cinder Cloister keeper behind them.

Korra turned. The keeper had arrived with Nesh's westbound messenger group, carrying a roadstone staff and a packet sealed in forge wax.

"You know them?"

"Only from route cuts older than the empire. First Travelers carried young stone east. The markers show them sheltered from hail and heat."

Listening offered no explanation. Kharad had changed gait around the opened plate and placed its own body between the contents and artillery. That behavior answered one question without granting Korra command over the answer.

She marked a wide exclusion line. "No one enters the tissue. Roof the observation walk with detached plate only. Two witnesses at every shift. If a stone moves, record direction and pulse. Nobody takes a sample."

Pela looked toward Harth. "People need shelter too."

"Yes. Seed watch gets material after occupied shelters, not before."

The distinction held through the night. Crews rebuilt awnings over three districts. They pulled twelve injured people from damaged houses and recovered six bodies: two market traders, one Green Mantle keeper, two wardens, and the Sarn rider shot during the rescue, whom her companions had been forced to leave when she died. A seventh civilian died before dawn from head injuries. These deaths stayed separate from the locked first-waking count.

Thirty-seven residents remained unaccounted for when the first shelter rolls came together. Rusk wanted to assume they had crossed between districts before the attack. Pela refused to balance a slate with assumptions. She divided the missing names by last known workplace and found that eleven belonged to a laundry crew beneath the north retaining wall.

Korra took a four-person search team along the wall's outer seam. The artillery had pushed one street section over another, sealing the laundry stair under a tilted slab. Voices reached them through a drain no wider than a wrist.

"Water rising," someone called.

A broken cistern fed the chamber. Cutting the upper slab would release the street load onto the people below. Korra crawled under the overlapping edge and found two tension pins carrying most of its weight. Her numb fingertips could not judge the smaller pin's vibration, so she made a young apprentice named Essel put their uninjured hand to it.

"Tell me what moves," she said.

Essel swallowed. "Fast tremor on the left. Slow on the right."

"Which one changes when Kharad steps?"

They waited through the lift and fall. "Right."

Korra placed a jack beneath the left pin, then ordered the bridge team to lace a rope cradle across three roof frames. None of the frames could carry the slab alone. Shared tension spread the weight over buildings already evacuated.

Rusk arrived with eight wardens. "Battery flashes again. We need these people on the firing platform once they're out."

A laundry worker heard him through the drain. "Get us out before you hire us."

Korra handed Rusk a jack lever. "Today you work for them."

They lifted on Kharad's next rising step. Essel called changes at the pin. The slab moved a finger's width, then two. Pela's grain hands cut through the wooden laundry door from below while water climbed to their waists. One by one, eleven workers squeezed through the opening. The last carried a baby who had not appeared on the shelter roster because the family arrived from a route farm that morning.

Pela added the child before anyone could turn that omission into blame.

Other searches found nine missing residents in Green Mantle shelters, eight helping at the water tower, and six who had joined relatives without reporting. Two names belonged to people who had left Harth three days earlier. One man remained missing near the upper orchard, where another fall made recovery impossible until morning.

By dawn the board held one unresolved name instead of thirty-seven. Rusk had recruited four laundry workers after offering wages, shelter replacements, and the right to leave the platform after one firing cycle. The others refused without

penalty. The process cost the wardens an hour and gave them a crew that understood wet rope better than soldiers did.

At the casualty board, Korra wrote names rather than adding them to 54. Sarn witnesses gave the rider's name as Jorla Fen and requested blue clay over her grave marker. Korra granted the clay from Beroch's abandoned supply pouch, not from any claim of friendship.

Harth could survive another pass of artillery. It could not keep all residents aboard through every pass, every fracture, and whatever answered from the east. The route council met beneath the dye houses before dawn.

Pela presented stores. Sava presented shelter capacity. Black Saddle lay ahead, a high basalt notch where several old corridors met. Ground settlements south of it had offered temporary camps if evacuees brought their own bridge labor and accepted commune ration rules.

"No forced list," Korra said. "Districts choose delegates. Families choose whether to go. Essential work gets replacement terms, not a ban on departure."

Rusk objected that Harth needed every able hand. Nemi Sar, arriving with Green Mantle's medicine slate, asked who defined able. The argument lasted two hours and improved the plan.

Seven hundred twenty people joined the first route convoy. They included families from the most damaged upper market, injured residents needing still-ground clinics, orchard workers whose root plots had sheared away, and people who simply refused another day under artillery. Sixty bridge workers volunteered for the convoy; Harth replaced them from trained apprentices. Pela allotted twenty-one days of grain and recorded the debt against all districts, not the evacuees alone.

At noon on Day 16, the convoy descended by a flexible ramp to still ground. Korra stood at the upper anchor as each group crossed. She did not call their leaving abandonment or salvation. Black Saddle could refuse them. Imperial patrols could close the road. Staying carried other dangers.

The last cart belonged to the dye-house families who had sheltered strangers during the attack. Once it reached ground, crews released the ramp and Kharad walked beyond it. The carried count fell from 10,316 to 9,596. Route departures toward the locked 3,900 total had begun with 720 names.

Nesh's messenger opened the Red Hollow packet that evening before representatives from Vaun, Green Mantle workers, Cinder Cloister, and Harth. Copies of the death ledger named forty-one workers. White Canopy receipts carried dates and propagation seals. The Ninefold plate itself traveled with Meris and Kivik, but rubbings already moved toward every drumhold.

Korra watched messengers take separate paths so no capture could stop the proof. One rode toward River Rauk ferries. Another went south for the Cinder Cloister. A third carried a copy toward Sarn camps, though Beroch might seize it

before reading.

The east answered before sunset.

A pulse came through Kharad's road, hard enough to rattle every loose cup in Harth. Korra dropped to one knee and touched the stone with her right hand. The vibration carried a forced regularity she remembered from the field crown: direction pressed through pain, repeated until resistance blurred.

It came from beyond Black Saddle.

Volda had begun to wake.

Kharad shortened one step. Beneath the broken plate, the seed-stones quickened in separate faint rhythms. Korra ordered the observation walk cleared, the east bridges doubled, and every civilian convoy warned off the northern gorge.

Part III

Chapter 15 — The Road Every Map Forgot

Thalen poured warm water into Kivik's right ear and watched none of it tremble.

Beside the left ear, a listening dish shivered with every footfall on Kharad. The difference required no court instrument. One membrane still received the moving world's pulse. The other held blood, swelling, and a muffled pressure Kivik described as a bell beneath deep water.

"Say that again," Kivik said.

Thalen moved to their left side. "No fracture along the outer canal. The membrane tore. I can keep it clean. I cannot restore what it no longer conducts."

"Better. Your lips lie when you stand on the wrong side."

They sat beneath an abandoned roadstone at the eastern edge of Kharad's shoulder. Harth moved behind them in damaged terraces. Ahead, the colossus's descending back met a plain of thorn scrub, old fences, and imperial drainage cuts. No road on Meris's map crossed it.

Kharad's current line would enter a basalt ravine within half a day. Volda's forced pulse came through that ravine at shortening intervals.

Thalen packed blue cup around Kivik's ear without covering the canal. "No counter-hammer work for two days."

"Volda has declined your schedule."

"Then use your left ear and another person's hand."

"That sounds almost like management."

"Management would charge you for the dressing."

Kivik accepted the point with a tilt of their head. The counter-hammer remained across their knees.

A faint secondary vibration traveled through the roadstone behind them. Thalen first mistook it for Kharad's step. The pattern repeated after the main pulse, too soft and too closely spaced. He set the dish against the marker's base.

The stone carried three angled knocks, a pause, then one long drag.

"Cinder route notation," said Nesh Aru.

The young courier had returned from their first evidence circuit with dust whitening their sleeves. They knelt across from Thalen and traced the marker's eroded face. Imperial masons had chiseled away most of its turn marks. A shallow hook remained under lichen near the ground.

"Three choices witnessed," Nesh said. "One route closed by harm. The drag means continue along the line of least breakage."

Meris unfolded the military survey. "This entire plain carries no road classification."

"That does not mean no route," Kivik said. "It means no tax station."

Thalen searched Senri's copied notes. His sister had drawn a similar hooked line beside an entry from twenty-five years earlier. He had treated it as a diagnostic flourish, an impatient underline made during her descent.

The page described mineral traces found in a dry pulse chamber: pale crystals under a living membrane, flow direction east-northeast, response stronger after contact. Below that, Senri had written three short strokes and a trailing curve.

"She copied a road mark," he said.

Nesh examined the page without touching it. "Or made one. Cinder signs record witnessed choice, not membership."

For years Thalen had read Senri's notes only for evidence of the injury that killed her. Every line became a step toward her death. He had missed that she also worked, doubted, compared, and left useful errors.

"She marked east-northeast," he said. "Not a diagnosis. A bearing."

Meris put her thumb knuckle against the survey scale. "That line reaches Split River if it holds past the ravine."

"No line holds because ink wishes it," Nesh replied.

Korra arrived with six pathwrights and demanded something they could test. Thalen showed her the roadstone pulse. She listened through a shedstone wedge, careful to use her right hand. The gray tracery beneath her left nails had not advanced, though the fingers remained stiff.

"The marker could preserve old impacts," she said. "Cart traffic. Herd movement."

"Or a migration corridor," Thalen answered.

"What makes you willing to call it that now?"

The question carried no cruelty. She had learned to distrust his certainty.

"Three sources align," he said. "Senri's chamber bearing. Cinder marks. Kharad's turn away from the open fracture. None proves intent. Together they justify clearing ground and observing response."

Korra looked over the plain. Fences divided scrub into abandoned imperial allotments. A straight drainage wall crossed the likely bearing, built from quarried stone too rigid to flex under a Worldback's approach.

"Observation costs labor," she said. "And if we are wrong, the ravine closes while we cut fences."

"If we follow the mapped road, we enter Volda's line."

"That also costs labor."

She sent two scouts along Senri's bearing and one toward the ravine. Nobody called the decision revelation.

The first buried marker appeared beneath a boundary mound. Nesh found it by the black moss Cinder keepers once cultivated only on chosen-route stones. Workers dismantled the mound by hand. Underneath, a broad arrow curved around a carved crack.

A second marker stood half a kilometer east, built into an imperial sheep wall with its face turned inward. The wall's owners had used old testimony as convenient masonry. Korra's crews photographed its position on wax sheets before freeing it.

Inside the wall they found a boundary box sealed in lead. The farm family who held the nearest allotment brought its key, inherited with the land despite never having seen what the box contained. Imperial survey leaves filled it, each generation of clerks copying the same property edge.

Meris spread the oldest leaf beside the newest. On the first, a pale band crossed the allotment under the words traditional passage, no permanent obstruction. Thirty years later, a clerk narrowed that band and labeled it seasonal stock drift. Another survey reduced it to a drainage easement. The latest map erased it entirely and granted the center to a wool factor in Avenor.

"No decree closed the route," Thalen said.

"It died one copying at a time," Meris replied.

The younger farmer, Teli, read the wool factor's name. "We pay him for grazing we clear ourselves."

Korra asked whether the family wanted the boundary box kept as evidence or sent ahead with Nesh. Teli's father wanted it buried again. A document carried toward war could be seized; a document in known ground could outlast an army. Teli disagreed. Without the leaves, any future court would call the open corridor trespass.

They settled on divided custody. Nesh copied every line onto cloth. Meris took wax impressions of seals. The family reburied the originals under a new stone placed twenty paces from Kharad's expected foot line. Three witnesses marked the location on separate route sheets.

Opening the pasture required more than cutting wire. Two hundred sheep grazed between the corridor marks. Their owner had fled west with the factor's agents, leaving Teli's family to tend them without pay. Korra could drive the animals south quickly and ruin the farm's winter fodder, or wait while neighbors moved them in smaller flocks.

"How long?" she asked.

"Four hours if the eastern gate opens," Teli said. "Six if the lambs scatter."

Volda's pulse sounded through the ground before anyone answered, hard and

regular.

Korra gave them four hours and twenty bridge hands. Nesh walked the first flock through the cut while children from both farms shook grain tins along the safe line. Thalen helped carry lambs over a collapsed drainage lip. He had spent much of his long life regarding field labor as an interruption to clinical duty. Here, moving animals cleared a living patient's route more honestly than any sheet he had signed.

The last flock passed as Kharad's shadow reached the western fence. Teli removed the gate from its hinges instead of merely opening it, widening the gap enough that no post would tear against moving stone. Her father set the old stock-drift leaf's copied phrase on the new witness marker.

By dusk, the markers described a lane almost two kilometers wide. It did not resemble a human road. It crossed shallow streams at multiple points, avoided narrow cuts, and left broad islands around villages. Later fences and canals had fragmented it until the continuous space vanished from official sight.

"Wide enough for a First Traveler," Nesh said.

"If the eastern bridge clears," Meris replied.

A stone aqueduct stood across the line, carrying water toward an imperial estate now abandoned. Demolishing it carelessly would drop blocks into the route and flood two lower farms. Korra gathered residents from both farms before choosing where to break it.

The older farmer refused. "That channel holds our late-season water."

"Kharad will destroy it if it remains," Korra said.

"Then Kharad destroys it. You don't get to call your hammer mercy."

Thalen watched Korra absorb the rebuke. She walked the aqueduct with the farmers, found two settling arches, and changed the work. Crews dismantled only the central span. They diverted water through a flexible clay channel around the route, leaving the farms a smaller but usable flow.

The delay consumed most of Day 17.

Near midnight, Volda's pulse struck the plain. This time the forced rhythm came with a second vibration: a huge impact followed by sliding earth. Kivik turned their left ear toward it.

"First step," they said.

No one cheered the success of their diagnosis.

At dawn, Kharad approached the cleared aqueduct gap. Korra kept every listening tool silent. Meris disconnected a portable bridle sensor so no accidental return pulse could resemble a direction command. Thalen stood beside the roadstone with his palms away from it.

The colossus reached the last fence line.

Its right forelimb descended beyond Harth's horizon. Soil rose in a long wave. The city tilted, settled, and moved forward. Kharad's central line pointed toward the basalt ravine.

Then the exposed roadstones began to answer one another.

Not speech. Each marker received the footfall and released its own stored resonance along the broad old route. The effect resembled rain traveling across leaves, a sequence of local contacts rather than one amplified order.

Kharad slowed.

Minutes passed between the beginning of the shift and anything a human could call a turn. The left side lengthened its next step. The right side shortened. Harth rotated against the distant ridge by a fraction.

Korra checked the survey stakes. "East-northeast."

The bearing matched Senri's mark.

Thalen pressed a culture strip into damp ground uncovered beneath the aqueduct. Pale crystals formed around its edge. Their taste held bitter minerals absent from the nearby farm soil. Similar traces appeared along the old lane, faint but continuous.

"It follows something," Meris said.

"Open ground," Korra replied.

"Mineral trace," Thalen added.

Nesh planted no new roadstone. "One witnessed turn does not finish the testimony."

Thalen looked at Kharad's broken northern plate, where the seed-stones remained sheltered, then at the crystals gathering on his strip. Pain could explain a turn away from artillery. Room could explain avoidance of a fracture. These mineral traces introduced another possibility.

"Hunger or command," he said. "We have spent three centuries treating those as the same question."

Kivik touched the counter-hammer but did not lift it. "Hunger follows what it needs. Command follows whoever hurts it correctly."

"We do not yet know what it needs."

"Then keep opening road until it tells us by going or refusing."

The scouts returned before noon. Senri's bearing continued through two more buried markers, crossed a broad dry shelf, and reached the western approaches of Split River. From there, old route cuts climbed toward Black Saddle. The river communes controlled flexible crossings and enough low ground to stage the remaining Harth departures.

The northern ravine scout arrived last with a dead horse and a burn across one shoulder. Volda had risen behind the ridge. Imperial columns moved along its lower

fortress terraces. Its planned western line intersected the rediscovered corridor less than a day's march from Split River.

Korra spread both scout reports on a detached plate. "If we continue testing here, Volda closes the river before our civilians reach it."

"If we rush east, we may turn this route into another military road," Nesh said.

"Then the communes decide how we enter. Send terms, not orders."

Meris marked the likely crossing. "We need their floodgates intact. They can flex a bridge better than imperial engineers think."

"You built those engineers," Korra said.

"I can apologize after I keep their siege tables from working."

Thalen repacked Kivik's dressing. The right ear had stopped bleeding. Hearing had not returned. Kivik accepted a signal cord tied to their left shoulder so workers would approach from the side they could hear.

Before they left, Nesh and the two farm families reset the freed roadstones in their original ground. No one claimed ownership of the route. Crews opened three more fence gaps and laid bright cloth along the drainage cuts so Kharad could see continuous clear earth through contact.

On Day 18, Harth turned toward Split River. Far across the plain, Volda's bridled outline rose above the western gorge, fortress towers moving on its back. Each forced step struck the old migration corridor from the opposite direction.

Korra ordered advance messengers to the communes. Meris carried the Ninefold plate under guard. Kivik walked with their good ear toward the road. Thalen folded Senri's bearing into his coat and followed the line she had recorded without pretending she had known where it ended.

Chapter 16 — Volda Wakes in Chains

Beroch stood behind the operator chairs when Volda took its first commanded step.

The gallery windows faced west across fortress terraces cut into the colossus's upper neck. Nothing outside seemed to move at first. The horizon held steady. Signal towers remained aligned. Then every hanging plumb line leaned east, and the floor rose beneath Beroch with the immense patience of a tide.

Six operators gripped the copper rails of the bridle crown. Gray tracery marked three sets of fingers. One man's left thumb had already stiffened straight. Lichen pads from White Canopy covered their wrists, muting pain without changing the mineral lines beneath.

Deren Cend stood at the direction table. The field marshal wore no operator loops. He gave orders to a crown master, who translated each into a simple resonant pattern.

"West," Deren said. "Hold the southern brace. One step."

The crown master lowered a corestone lever.

Vibration passed through the gallery. Beroch felt it in his tusks, his old lip scar, and the roots of every tooth. The operators arched against their chairs. Beyond the windows, a ridge that had always stood below Volda's western face began sliding toward them.

No rider could have mistaken the motion for willing gait. Volda's first pulse pushed north. The bridle forced west. The disagreement shuddered through the floor in alternating directions.

Operator Yana Peor gasped, "Release between beats."

The crown master looked at Deren.

"Complete the step," he said.

"Load exceeds the brace table."

"Complete it."

Yana pulled her wrapped hands from the rail. Skin remained stuck to one copper contact. Another operator took her load before the rhythm broke.

Beroch stepped forward. "Your own table says release."

Deren did not turn. "Your charter gives you cavalry command, not crown command."

"My evacuation clause gives me power to halt supporting movement at occupied lines."

"Volda does not answer to a Sarn appendix."

The sentence should have sounded absurd. Instead, every person in the gallery

accepted its practical truth.

The first step ended with a crash beyond the western observation deck. A retaining tower folded under changed load. Soldiers on its roof had evacuated minutes earlier, but storage sheds below split open and spilled grain down Volda's side. The colossus's next uncommanded pulse traveled north again.

Deren ordered a west correction.

Beroch caught the crown master's sleeve. "How many corrections before hands fail?"

The man looked to Deren for permission to answer.

"How many?" Beroch repeated.

"At current load, four operators reach second-joint creep before dusk. Replacement shift carries less exposure."

Yana bound her torn palm herself. "Replacement shift trained for six days."

Deren finally faced Beroch. He resembled Ivvara around the eyes, though ambition kept his posture more rigid than hers. "Red Hollow no longer supplies us. If we do not establish westward gait now, the existing plate may crack before reinforcement arrives."

"Then stop."

"Kharad moves toward Split River. If it reaches the western gorge, the frontier controls the only pass broad enough for a military corridor."

"A corridor for what?"

"For every city whose springs depend on this operation."

The larger plan hid behind that answer. Beroch knew Volda carried more than a local route command, but not how many sleeping mountains the crown intended to touch.

A signal officer entered with a route slate. "Burial clearance reports from Olt Ridge. Twenty-nine markers removed. Eight remain in place. Custodian crews request six more hours."

Beroch held out his hand. The slate listed his father's roadstone among those removed. It said nothing about whether Sarn witnesses had supervised the work.

"We wait six hours," he said.

Deren moved a time rod on the direction table. "Kharad gains eleven kilometers in six hours."

"My signed clause grants burial crews that period after notice."

"Notice went out yesterday."

"The custodians received it at dawn."

"Then your riders delivered slowly."

Beroch placed his copy beside Deren's route rods. "The seal does not change

meaning because your messenger chose a shorter clock."

Volda pulsed beneath them. One operator cried out. A gray line crossed the base of her index finger while Beroch watched.

Deren dismissed everyone except the two of them. The operators could not leave, which made the privacy false.

"My aunt accepted your appendix to keep Sarn cavalry in the field," he said quietly. "She expected you to interpret it within military necessity."

"I am."

"No. You interpret it as a separate sovereignty."

"A charter with no power to interrupt anyone is decoration."

Deren tapped the western gorge. "If Korra Vaun takes Split River, she controls evacuation and supply for half this front. River Rauk will charge every imperial village for passage. Kharad carries saboteurs who destroyed our replacement forge. Your pasture survives one more winter while two grain cities begin to starve. Is that the sovereignty you purchased?"

Beroch knew every fact had been selected to make refusal look provincial. He also knew those cities existed. Ivara's order had preserved Sarn schools and land for years while rival leaders offered unity speeches and no winter grass.

"Four hours," he said. "My riders finish the removal. You rest the most injured operators and begin the next command after the burial line clears."

Deren studied him. "Three hours."

"Four."

"Three, with your cavalry on the road now."

Beroch took the compromise because eight markers might still be saved.

He left the gallery by the western descent. Moving across an awakened Worldback broke every cavalry instinct. Stairs changed grade between one stride and the next. Fortress roads designed around a fixed summit now leaned toward open air. His horse, Tar, spread all four hooves and refused the mounting block.

"Good judgment," Beroch told him.

He led the animal to the lower stable ramp and mounted on level shedstone. Three hundred and sixty Sarn riders waited in companies, along with imperial infantry assembling from the fortress barracks. Volda's total field force numbered 7,200 at waking, though many had never trained on moving ground.

Beroch sent Hask ahead with fresh horses and took the fastest file toward Olt Ridge.

The burial road no longer occupied a valley below them. Volda carried its fortress toward it. From the observation ledge, Beroch saw roadstones scattered across the ground ahead like dark teeth. Custodian crews worked around eight remaining markers with sledges and padded hoists.

His father's stone stood on a wagon near the southern edge. Relief lasted only until he saw it lying flat among six unrelated markers, each witness cup emptied of its native soil.

Dava met him beside the wagon. "They cut the base."

A clean saw line crossed Jor Sarn's route mark. The stone had not been lifted from its setting. A works crew severed it at ground level to save time.

"Who authorized cutting?"

Dava pointed to an imperial engineer mounted on a gray mule. "He calls the lower half foundation waste."

Beroch rode over and read the man's field badge. "Engineer Pall, dismount."

Pall looked at the advancing shadow of Volda. "Commander, we have less than an hour."

"Dismount and name what you cut."

"A registered memorial under emergency removal."

"You left half in the road."

"The visible inscription remains intact. Compensation covers restoration."

Beroch pulled him from the saddle.

Sarn riders moved closer. Imperial workers lowered their saws. For a dangerous breath, the entire alliance narrowed to Pall's collar in Beroch's hand.

Dava said, "The stone first."

She did not ask for blood. Beroch released the engineer and ordered every available horse put to the eight remaining sledges. Riders wrapped stones in winter blankets. Custodians packed native soil into labeled pots, work the survey plan had omitted.

Volda's shadow reached the east markers.

A bridle command hit.

The colossus tried to set its next forelimb north. The crown dragged the motion west. Ground folded ahead of the foot in a moving ridge. Three empty roadstone pits vanished under broken earth.

"Clear!" Beroch shouted.

Teams pulled six markers beyond the projected pressure line. The seventh sled lost a wheel. Riders carried the stone between four spear shafts while the custodian ran beside them with its soil pot.

The eighth marker belonged to the ninety dead of Bel's Ford. It had been cut from a basalt outcrop rather than set upon the ground. No team could move it in minutes.

Hask looked at Beroch. "We can split the inscription face."

The same crime in Sarn hands did not become care.

"Copy every name," Beroch said. "Take witness clay and get out."

Dava and two custodians pressed cloth over the carving, rubbing blue clay into the letters. They finished the final line as the earth ridge reached the outcrop.

Volda's foot descended beyond sight.

The burial road jumped. Bel's Ford stone broke into three slabs. One flipped face down. The hooked paths between markers disappeared under a trough of pulverized ground. Volda moved on, carrying an imperial fortress over the route protected by nine-cut wax.

Custodians returned after the pressure ridge passed. They did not try to stand the broken slabs upright. Dava stopped workers from dragging the inscription face out by chain because abrasion would erase the last names. Instead, riders dug around each fragment with hand tools while imperial engineers waited for the road to reopen.

"We have a march behind us," Pall said. His collar still carried the crease from Beroch's fist.

"Then the march can learn to wait behind the dead," Dava replied.

The burial roads served more than mourning. Every marker established legal memory of where Sarn families had accepted risk, surrendered a claim, or turned from violence. Without their ground, later councils could argue that no protected crossing or pasture promise existed. The empire had crushed a map of obligations while calling the damage sentimental.

Beroch ordered twenty cavalry assigned to recovery. Hask objected in a low voice. "Deren gave us three hours. We spent them."

"Write twenty riders absent by my order."

"I will. I'm asking whether you intend to arrive with a command or a collection of witnesses."

"Both, if I can keep both."

They recovered fragments from five markers. Three remained under compacted earth beyond any safe digging time. Dava filled witness pots from the last exposed ground and sealed each with blue clay. A young custodian named Cor took coordinates using the imperial survey stakes, repurposing the same measurements that guided Volda across them.

Beroch required Engineer Pall to sign every pot label. Pall resisted the first.

"I did not witness the original placement."

"You witnessed the destruction and the recovery ground. Sign what you saw."

The engineer signed.

At Bel's Ford, the largest slab required eight horses. Beroch's riders laid spear shafts beneath it and built a rolling bed from the cut fence posts. The work consumed another hour. Imperial columns passed on both sides, soldiers watching

Sarn cavalry struggle with stone while Volda moved farther west.

Ven rode up from the rear company. "Leave it. We can carve the names again."

Beroch looked at his nephew. "Your grandfather turned on this ground. Carve it elsewhere and you record a different choice."

"He would not sacrifice riders during a campaign for his own marker."

"Correct. We recover it for the ninety names above his, not for him alone."

Ven dismounted and took a lever.

When the slab finally reached the wagon, Dava tied the academy letters beside the soil pots. Schooling, pasture, and memory had occupied separate charter articles. On the wagon they traveled as one record of what imperial necessity touched first.

Beroch stayed until the dust thinned. He entered Pall's name, Deren's timetable, the actual notice hour, and every destroyed marker on Hask's copy. Compensation could buy stone. It could not recreate where a choice had occurred.

A courier found him before the companies reformed. The yellow cord on her dispatch bag belonged to Avenor's Frontier Academy.

Beroch opened the packet with Dava watching.

The city prefect acknowledged his return request and denied it under emergency-term authority. All seventy-six Sarn academy pupils remained housed within Avenor. Nineteen apprentices remained assigned to city works. The letter assured him that schoolchildren received full meals, instruction, and guard protection. A second sealed line requested continued Sarn compliance to preserve those arrangements.

"They finally wrote the hostage sentence plainly," Dava said.

"Plain enough for us. Not for a court."

"Will you keep riding for them?"

Beroch looked toward Volda. Its second step had begun. Imperial banners moved above the dust. If he withdrew now, Deren could arrest Sarn youths as enemy dependents. River rivals might seize eastern pasture under emergency decree. His 360 riders could save their honor and lose every person the charter held within reach.

"For now," he said.

Dava's disappointment required no argument.

He sent three copies of the academy letter by different routes: one to Sarn council, one to the parents, and one toward Nesh Aru's Cinder witnesses. Then he remounted and joined Volda's western column.

The next breach came at dusk.

A pasture camp lay two kilometers south of the planned military descent, outside Volda's direct foot line but inside the supply column's shortcut. Two

hundred sixty Sarn residents wintered there with sheep, remount foals, and three mobile schools. Deren's schedule sent eight hundred infantry and sixty heavy wagons straight through the camp's water lanes.

Beroch's evacuation clause required clearance. The column commander had received a different page.

"We march through," said Colonel Venn. "Civilians move aside."

"They need four hours to strike shelters and herd animals."

"I have orders to reach the western staging terrace by midnight."

"I have authority to halt supporting movement at an occupied camp."

Venn showed his route paper. Deren's red seal overrode local delay where Volda's gait created a closing supply window.

Beroch showed the nine-cut appendix. "Mine carries the Regent."

"Then ask her which seal she meant."

No mirror connection would hold during Volda's step. Deren had placed contradictory authority on the ground and let urgency choose the winner.

Beroch deployed his cavalry across the supply road.

Imperial infantry lowered pikes. Sarn riders did not draw sabers. Behind them, camp families tore down felt roofs and loaded school slates onto carts. Children drove sheep toward the south gully.

Colonel Venn rode within speaking distance. "If you delay us, Kharad reaches Split River first."

"Then your soldiers can use the ridge road."

"Heavy wagons cannot make that grade."

"Unload them. Two mule loads per wagon."

"That loses six hours."

"It saves the camp."

Venn ordered his first rank forward. Beroch had no desire to start a civil battle beneath a chained colossus. He shifted tactics.

"Hask, take second and third companies to the ridge. Every Sarn packhorse carries an imperial load. First company stays until the last shelter clears."

His riders would do the labor that imperial planning omitted. It preserved the column while refusing the shortcut, and it exhausted horses needed for later combat.

Venn accepted because movement mattered more than pride. Soldiers unloaded bolts, grain, medical chests, and crown equipment. Sarn cavalry carried them over the ridge while the heavy wagons waited for the camp road to clear.

Beroch worked beside the families. He lifted school chests, pulled fence posts, and assigned riders to the remount foals. No one thanked him for enforcing terms

already owed.

The final shelter cart entered the south gully after moonrise. Camp head Leth Sarn placed her route cloth in Beroch's hand.

"We go toward Split River," she said. "Not your field camp."

"Imperial troops are moving there."

"So is everyone else. At least the river communes ask before assigning our children beds."

He could order her under military protection. The appendix did not grant him ownership of the evacuation it enabled.

"Take the lower road," he said. "Volda's column uses the gorge."

Leth departed with 260 people. They did not count against Kharad's population ledger; they had lived on still ground. Beroch marked them as an independent refugee column and sent a Sarn escort only after Leth named the number she would accept.

At midnight, Deren summoned him back to the operator gallery.

Volda had completed three westward steps. Two operators could no longer bend their index fingers. Yana Peor had left active duty after the skin of her palm hardened around a split. The fortress terraces held, though one barracks remained evacuated.

Deren read Beroch's delay report. "You cost the timetable five hours."

"The camp cleared. Your supplies reached the staging terrace by packhorse."

"You taught every commander that orders can be renegotiated in the road."

"Your seals taught them first."

Deren looked toward the dark west. "If Kharad takes Split River, I will not permit another delay."

Beroch set the academy denial and burial-road record on the direction table. "If another order crosses my clause, you will sign the breach before I move."

"Or what?"

A week earlier, Beroch might have answered with the charter. Now the cut roadstones traveled on Sarn wagons. Parents held the academy letter. Cinder witnesses held copies. His cavalry had carried imperial supplies over a ridge and proved the army needed them more than its seals admitted.

"Or you will discover which part of this march moves because I allow it," he said.

Deren did not arrest him. That fact carried more weight than agreement.

The crown master called the next command. Beroch left the gallery before the operators gripped their rails. From Volda's western deck, he watched the lower refugee road wind toward Split River and ordered Hask to keep one scout within sight of Leth's last cart.

Volda stepped after them in chains. Beroch rode with the imperial column, carrying every broken term in duplicate.

Chapter 17 — The Siege of Split River

Meris measured the bridge's sag while a river councillor threatened to cut it down beneath her.

"Three fingerwidths unloaded," Meris said, kneeling beside the west anchor. "Nine under the first refugee column. If it reaches twelve, release the outer pins in pairs."

Councillor Aru Fen held an ax across both hands. "If Kharad steps into the floodplain, I release every pin and let the bridge go."

"That saves your bridge from Kharad by destroying your bridge."

"It saves the eastern bank from becoming an imperial road."

Below them, Split River divided around gravel islands and willow-grown dikes. The communes had built five linked crossings rather than one grand span. Each used timber decks on shedstone ribs, with rope anchors that could lengthen during spring floods. Imperial engineers called the arrangement temporary. It had survived eighty-six flood seasons.

Kharad's upper ridges darkened the western horizon. Volda stood behind the gorge farther west, not yet visible, though each forced pulse rattled the anchor gauges.

Meris moved her thumb knuckle along the load scale. "Kharad will not step onto this bridge. People will. One thousand four hundred eighty from the carried districts, plus your west-bank households and the Sarn pasture camp. The colossus crosses north of town where the channel splits into shallows."

"Your map puts its left foot through our barley fields."

"Korra moved the line after your farmers marked buried drains."

"And if Kharad changes direction?"

"Then you cut the bridge. I am telling you when cutting becomes structurally necessary, not asking you to surrender the ax."

Aru Fen lowered the blade a fraction. Commune authority did not fit Meris's old command diagrams. River engineers owned no bridge alone. Every anchor had a household keeper, and any three keepers could suspend crossing. It slowed decisions. It also meant no captured tower gave an army the whole river.

Kivik climbed from beneath the west abutment with mud to their shoulders. They approached Meris on her left, forcing her to shift so her voice reached their undamaged ear.

"The lower rib has a hidden splice," they said. "Old repair, good work, omitted from your imperial survey."

"How much does it change tolerance?"

"Enough to embarrass your numbers, not enough to kill anyone if you recalculate."

Meris redrew the load table. Two missing fingertips made charcoal awkward, so Aru Fen's bridge keeper, Lio Mar, held the ruler while she marked revised release points.

A horn sounded from the western dike.

Three long calls. Imperial infantry in formation.

The siege began before they finished the arithmetic.

Meris climbed the watch platform. Columns emerged from the western gorge road in disciplined blocks, shields covered against river glare. Banners identified Deren Cend's field force. Scouts counted 5,960 troops after desertion, injury, and losses during Volda's wakening approach. Cavalry moved on the northern flank under Sarn colors.

Beroch still rode beneath the imperial banner.

His units did not lead the attack. Infantry engineers came first, carrying fascines for the flood ditches and hooked ladders for the dikes. Their objectives showed in their equipment: seize the west anchors, close the refugee lanes, and take the floodgate house before the communes could change water levels.

Meris looked down at the incomplete bridge table. "No mass crossing until we know whether the west anchor holds under impact."

Aru Fen pointed to the road behind them. Families already approached with carts.

"They cannot wait in range," the councillor said.

"Then stagger them. Four carts per deck section, twenty paces between groups. No iron-rimmed wagons on the repaired rib."

"You tell a frightened column to keep twenty paces."

"Give each group a rope that length. They hold it or they stop."

Commune runners cut measuring ropes while horns called defense crews to the dikes. Meris descended to the floodgate house with Kivik.

Six gate wheels controlled channels feeding the western marsh. Opening them together would send a wall of water toward three downstream farms. Keeping them closed let imperial engineers cross dry ditches within an hour.

Kivik pressed their left brass funnel to the central conduit. "Gate Three sticks halfway. Four leaks around the axle."

Gate keeper Senn, a broad human woman with both arms tattooed in flood dates, folded them across her chest. "We know."

"Your annual ledger calls Three sound."

"Imperial tax assessors read annual ledgers. Our winter chalk calls it stubborn."

Kivik smiled. "A contract after my heart."

Meris studied the channels. "Release Five for four minutes. Close it. Open Two and Four after the first water reaches Willow Cut. Three stays at half."

Senn's expression hardened. "Open Five first and you flood the low bean field."

"Only if the north sluice remains shut."

"The north sluice feeds Korren Farm."

Meris had treated the sluice as empty overflow because the imperial survey omitted its user. Another household rendered her clean solution dirty.

"How much water can Korren absorb?"

"At this season? Six minutes before the root trench overtops."

Kivik drew the channels in mud. They marked gate times with pebbles, then shifted two to account for the sticking wheel. The final sequence sent shallow water across three imperial approaches, deepened the ditch below the west anchors, and limited the downstream rise to half a cubit. It required eight gate changes over nineteen minutes.

"One missed signal floods someone," Meris said.

Senn picked up her wheel key. "Then we don't miss. My keepers turn. You two watch pressure."

The first arrows struck the dike roof.

Commune shields covered the gate team. Senn opened Five. Water entered the low channel with a brown rush. Meris counted by pulse, watching a reed marker bend at Willow Cut. Kivik listened at the conduit and relayed pressure with hand signs because battle noise blurred voices.

At the fourth minute, Gate Five resisted closure.

Two keepers leaned on the wheel. It did not move.

Meris saw the failure mode: downstream pressure had seated the warped plate against its own frame. More force at the wheel would shear the stem.

"Open another quarter first," she said.

Senn stared at her. "That sends more water."

"It releases the seat. Open, then reverse."

The bean field vanished under a thin sheet. A second push freed the plate. Keepers spun Five shut and opened Two.

Imperial engineers reached the first ditch as water filled it. Their front rank sank to the thigh. Fascines floated apart before weight settled them. Archers on the dike forced the soldiers to raise shields instead of recovering bundles.

North of the gate house, Sarn cavalry stopped short of the flooded ground. Beroch could have ordered horses into it. He turned his first company toward higher ground, preserving mounts and leaving infantry exposed.

Meris could not tell whether caution or disobedience drove him.

The refugee crossing started behind the dikes. Split River households came first from the west islands, carrying only what commune allotments allowed. Each four-cart group held a twenty-pace rope. Children wore cork belts. Livestock used the shallow south ford under separate keepers.

The 260-person Sarn pasture camp arrived with imperial scouts close behind. Leth Sarn refused to merge her people into a commune column until she received a written camp allotment on the east bank. Aru Fen signed for three nights of ground and shared wells, conditional on camp labor at the willow dikes.

"We decide after three nights whether we stay," Leth said.

"We decide whether to offer four," Aru Fen replied.

They clasped wrists and sent the first school cart onto the bridge.

Kharad's carried evacuees descended from a temporary ramp north of town. Pela Orr kept their roster. Seven hundred twenty had already left near Harth; these 1,480 brought the route total to 2,200. The people crossing now came from districts damaged by artillery, clinics requiring still foundations, and households choosing ground before the gorge became a battlefield.

No one called the transfer orderly. A wheel broke on the second span. A frightened horse backed into a rope group. One household tried to bring a stone stove that exceeded the marked load. Bridge keepers stopped the entire lane until the family abandoned it.

A mortar stone struck the west approach.

The repaired rib dropped from nine fingerwidths of sag to eleven. Meris ran onto the anchor platform as refugees crouched under carts.

"Outer pins, first pair!"

Lio Mar pulled one. The second jammed. Meris used her right hand, could not grip the ring with missing fingertips, and switched to a hooked wrench. The pin released. Rope anchors lengthened, lowering the deck rather than snapping it.

"Move the four carts on the center section," she shouted. "Everyone else stays."

A mother tried to run forward with two children. Aru Fen caught the group's measuring rope and held it. Ten people behind her stopped because their hands shared the same line.

The center carts cleared. Sag returned to ten.

Imperial troops reached the west anchor stairs before the next group moved. Commune defenders fought for the platform with boat hooks and short spears. Meris had no field rank here. She joined Lio at the release frame and kept the bridge alive while others defended it.

A soldier climbed over the rail. Kivik struck a vertical rib with the counter-hammer, releasing a sharp vibration through the wet deck. The soldier's

feet slipped. A commune defender pulled him down and took his weapon rather than killing him.

"One use," Thalen had ordered Kivik.

They grimaced toward their right ear. Fresh blood had not appeared. "One."

The flood sequence reached Gate Four. Water cut the imperial approach behind the attackers. Their stair team found itself isolated between the river and a deepening ditch. Beroch's cavalry remained on high ground. No rescue charge came.

The soldiers surrendered after their captain fell from the platform with a broken leg.

By sunset on Day 20, the first civilian columns held the east bank. Kharad's carried count had fallen to 8,116. The local and Sarn refugees did not enter that arithmetic. Pela posted both ledgers side by side so later histories could not turn every displaced person into one convenient mass.

Night did not pause the crossing work. Bridge keepers hung hooded lamps beneath the decks and inspected every wet joint by touch. Meris crawled with them along the repaired rib, marking new splinters in yellow chalk. Imperial mortar crews could see any light above the rail, so children on the east bank carried shutter signals from one anchor to the next.

At the ferry hall, Thalen sorted wounded by airway, bleeding, and resonance exposure rather than uniform. Commune guards objected when he placed an imperial engineer ahead of a local defender with a broken wrist.

"The engineer cannot breathe," Thalen said. "Your defender can insult me in complete sentences. That determines order."

The defender proved his condition by offering a detailed insult. Guards let the engineer pass.

Meris recognized the prisoner as Lieutenant Solm, one of Deren's route staff. A rib fracture had punctured his lung. While Thalen inserted a reed drain, Solm clutched Meris's sleeve.

"Volda cannot stop in the gorge," he whispered.

"Cannot or will not?"

"Crown heat. They command each time the north pulse returns. If they release too long, it turns."

"Toward what?"

Solm shook his head, short of breath. "North. Always north since waking. Deren needs west."

Listening did not reveal why Volda chose north, but the conflict gave Meris a timing limit. Every forced correction injured operators and tightened gait. Deren would attack before the gallery lost enough hands.

After treatment, Aru Fen convened an emergency commune vote in the ferry hall, wounded bodies still lining the walls. Some households wanted the western bridges cut immediately. Others had relatives on the far bank and demanded another daylight crossing. Leth Sarn requested protected passage for late pasture carts but refused any vote that treated her camp as commune property.

Meris presented structural facts and no recommendation. Four crossings could last another day under controlled loads. Two mortar hits at the main west anchor would change that. Floodgates could slow infantry twice more before farm damage became severe.

A miller asked, "What would an imperial engineer do?"

"Close the bridge to preserve military use."

"What do you advise now?"

Meris looked at the families waiting under tarps. "Keep one civilian lane until noon. Prepare to sever west access section by section, not all together. Let each island finish its own roster."

The vote passed by three household marks. Aru Fen assigned Meris no command; the councillor required her to stand at the west gauge and report when tolerance changed. Meris accepted the narrower power.

Prisoners contributed knowledge under witnessed terms, not threat. Lieutenant Solm identified mortar ranges in exchange for written assurance that wounded engineers would not be returned before they could walk. Commune defenders moved two shelter lines outside those ranges. In return, they permitted imperial stretcher teams to recover bodies from the first ditch at dawn.

Kivik slept for one hour with their damaged ear elevated. On waking, they found a bridge child had painted a white half-circle on every tool handle so workers would approach from their left. They complained that the mark resembled a bad moon and kept it anyway.

The imperial siege shifted north before midnight. Deren's engineers built firing mounds above the flood reach. Beroch's riders seized two outer wells but left their civilian keepers in place under Sarn guard. Volda's pulses grew louder through the gorge.

On Day 21, Nesh Aru arrived at Meris's work shelter carrying a packet inside their coat.

"The original pulse record?" she asked.

Nesh opened the waxed wrap enough to show Thalen's first unedited sheet. "Copies reached Cinder Cloister, two River Rauk councils, and three Sarn camps. This one must pass east."

"The siege line closes the eastern road."

"The river does not."

Nesh planned to use a reed boat through the lower channels, then cross behind

imperial pickets where old fishing paths climbed the bank. Pacifism had not made them harmless. It constrained what harm they would carry.

Meris gave them a captured dispatch map. Inside its case she found a second plan bearing Avenor's government seal. The sheet outlined capital evacuation routes from six outward gates: North Quarry, Lichen, River, Glass, Old Grain, and Dawn Gate.

Each gate had a capacity estimate. Each also had an inward-defense lock designed to contain riots.

"Why carry this at Split River?" Nesh asked.

"Volda's field staff expects the capital to evacuate," Meris said. "Or expects to control who does."

She copied the gate names and hinge types onto waterproof cloth. Dawn Gate held the broadest military road. North Quarry opened through cut-stone switchbacks she had inspected as a junior engineer. The plans might one day matter more than the siege in front of them, but only if someone survived to use them.

Nesh took one copy and left before moonrise. Commune fishers guided the boat without joining the war. At the lower bend, imperial scouts spotted them. Arrows struck reeds. Nesh slid into waist-deep water, dragged the packet inside an oilskin bladder, and disappeared beneath a willow shelf. They emerged downstream and walked through the farm channels the flood plan had spared.

The unedited pulse record passed the siege line.

Day 22 opened with an imperial assault on all five crossings. Mortars targeted anchors. Infantry entered the shallows behind shield screens. Deren had learned the gate timing and waited until low water before committing.

Meris and Senn changed the sequence.

They opened no western gate. Instead, farm crews broke three temporary irrigation berms upstream. Water arrived slowly, hidden by willow islands, and spread beneath the imperial formation after it entered the channel. The rise reached only a soldier's calf, but current pulled at shield lines and exposed the buried gravel bars commune defenders knew.

Kivik marked safe counterstrokes on bridge ribs. They let local teams strike, protecting their damaged ear from direct tools. Meris moved between anchors, releasing load as mortar impacts changed deck angles. One crossing broke at its west stair after every civilian had cleared. Keepers cut the final ropes and let the deck swing downstream, blocking an imperial ford.

Beroch's cavalry received an order to force the northern shallow. Meris saw his banners form, halt, then divide. One company advanced against commune defenders. Two rode south to recover isolated infantry instead of completing the crossing. He still fought for the empire, but Deren no longer controlled the exact

shape of every obedience.

At dusk, the imperial horns called withdrawal beyond bow range.

Split River held four usable crossings, both main flood controls, and every east-bank shelter. Downstream farms had wet fields and damaged berms, not drowned houses. Commune dead numbered twenty-three; imperial bodies recovered from the channels numbered forty-one. Wounded from both sides filled the ferry hall under separate guards.

Meris stood at the west anchor as Lio reset its outer pins. Her revised table, smudged with river water, had become commune property by use.

A low concussion rolled out of the gorge.

Willows shook without wind. On the horizon, fortress towers rose above the western cliffs. Volda entered the gorge carrying Deren's remaining army, every forced step narrowing the distance to Kharad.

Aru Fen rested the ax against the anchor frame. "Does your calculation cover two mountains?"

"No bridge does."

Meris ordered the captured Avenor plans copied again, the west approaches abandoned beyond the flood line, and every remaining civilian cart moved toward Black Saddle before Volda's next step.

Chapter 18 — Ivara Cend's Smallest Order

Ivara scraped ninety-five names from the evacuation slate with the edge of a kitchen knife.

The proper correction blade had snapped before midnight. Its ivory handle lay beside three cups of cold tea, two shelter ledgers, and a report from Split River stamped with Deren's field seal. Gray wax dust covered the table.

She worked by hand because the copying clerks had gone to sleep on benches outside the census room. Every formal category on the slate carried a capacity number. Every number now exceeded the chambers assigned to it.

Government households: 1,840.

Operator households and medical dependents: 2,106.

Frontier academy pupils and apprentices: 612.

White Canopy registered families and propagation labor: 1,274.

Low Lichen drain and service households: 986.

Hostage families under crown protection: 741.

The categories overlapped. An operator's wife might work a drain shift. A Sarn apprentice might sleep in academy housing but report to city works. White Canopy's root rolls omitted seasonal laborers who lived in its lower galleries. Clerks had counted bodies according to which office might complain, not where those bodies could shelter.

The flex chambers beneath North Quarry held 6,300 if the unfinished rooms passed load tests. Current protected claims exceeded eight thousand. Avenor's ordinary population of 41,000 had not yet received an evacuation order. Most citizens expected their streets to remain ground.

Ivara drew a line through frontier academy pupils and apprentices and wrote secondary relocation, east district in the margin.

The east district possessed two school halls, a grain warehouse, and foundation walls never tested under waking load. Calling it relocation did not make it protection.

She restored the category.

Outside, a bell marked the second hour before dawn. A copying clerk shifted in sleep and knocked over a stool. Ivara read Deren's report again.

Split River held. Commune floodgates had broken two assaults. Twenty-three defenders and forty-one imperial troops lay dead. Beroch Sarn had diverted cavalry to recover isolated infantry rather than force the northern ford. Before that, he had delayed the field march at a pasture camp. Before that, he had spent hours recovering burial stones after Volda crossed them.

Each act fit his sealed clause if read by a lawyer who did not need a military road. Together they had allowed Kharad's civilians to cross the river.

Ivara moved the academy category below operator households.

That change still protected the Sarn schoolchildren, only later.

She knew what later meant when ground began moving.

Chief Measurer Olt entered without waiting for a summons. His collar hung open, and he carried the broken valve from the Western Stair service chamber.

"You asked for independent shelter capacity," he said. "North Quarry lost two hundred spaces after the west seam test."

Ivara looked at the total. "Why?"

"The ceremonial archive ceiling carries more load than the survey assumed. Moving the paper does not move the stone shelves."

"Break the shelves."

"They brace the upper floor."

Another subtraction. She revised 6,300 to 6,100.

"Hospitals?"

"South flex rooms accept 740 litters if corridors remain one-way. Nine hundred twelve patients cannot walk."

"Move those with stable fractures to surface tents before any waking order."

"In winter rain?"

"Under insulated awnings."

"We do not have enough."

"Take campaign cloth from the east barracks."

Olt noted it. He neither praised the solution nor called it cruel. Good administrators spared rulers the comfort of either.

Ivara asked, "How many Low Lichen households maintain the flex drains?"

"Two hundred nineteen."

"Inside the 986?"

"Mostly. Root rolls recognize sixty-three. City service rolls recognize another eighty. The rest work through daily counters or family contracts."

If she protected only registered propagation labor under Orinel's compact, the chambers could lose the people who kept waste channels open. If she protected every lower-canopy worker, White Canopy's allocation grew beyond its bargain.

"Bring Issen," Ivara said. "And wake the academy prefect."

They met at North Quarry before dawn.

The unfinished flex chambers occupied old extraction galleries carved into Orun's upper plate. Meris Tal had designed sliding wall joints and rope-suspended

ceilings there seven years earlier, before the bridle crown consumed her office. Crews now widened sleeping bays while quarry dust drifted through lamp smoke.

Issen stood beside a drain trench with three workers. The oldest wore the same practical mantle strips Ivara remembered from the spring chamber. A human man named Ko had a service counter hanging from his belt instead of a formal guild seal. The third, Ilaith girl barely out of adolescence, kept a list of every pipe junction in her memory because White Canopy charged workers for copies.

"Show me what fails at full shelter," Ivara said.

Issen pointed to the trench. "Waste rise. Six thousand bodies fill that channel in four hours if the lower drop stays open. Orun shifts one fingerwidth, the old clay throat closes, and this room becomes unlivable before anyone suffocates."

"Can you brace it?"

"With forty workers per shift and access to the propagation pumps."

"White Canopy owns those pumps."

"White Canopy owns the seals. We maintain the pumps."

The academy prefect arrived in a fur-lined coat over sleeping clothes. Prefect Soll had brought student rolls and no students.

"How quickly can the frontier dormitories move here?" Ivara asked.

"The pupils can march in two hours. Apprentices require release from city works."

"How many need medical accommodation?"

"Seventeen. Three sleepwalk during tremors. One Sarn girl has fever."

Ivara knew the girl from the letters Beroch had attached to his return petition: Lera Dava, twelve, talented in bridge arithmetic, prone to writing about weather when watched.

"Do parents know their location?"

Soll hesitated. "Correspondence remains suspended."

"That was not my question."

"No."

The pupils served as leverage only if the empire controlled both their bodies and information about them. Beroch understood this. His delays tested how much the Regent would tolerate before using the leverage plainly.

Ivara walked deeper into the chamber. A quarry crew broke shelves from the ceremonial archive under Olt's emergency order. Each impact traveled through Orun's stone and returned as a slow pulse too faint for ordinary hearing. Dust shivered from the ceiling.

"Stop," Ivara said.

Workers froze.

Another pulse arrived. It had warmed since yesterday.

Orun remained asleep, but the linked crown preparations were reaching the eldest Worldback. Avenor possessed less time than its citizens knew.

Ivara ordered everyone out of the chamber except Olt. "Final tested capacity?"

"Six thousand one hundred. Perhaps the original 6,300 if Meris's wall tolerances hold."

"Do not count perhaps."

"Then 6,100."

"Government households drop by four hundred. Ministers shelter with their district rolls."

Olt blinked. "That will create opposition."

"It creates room."

"For whom?"

She should have answered the academy. Six hundred twelve pupils and apprentices did not fit into four hundred spaces, but the cut would reduce the shortage. Yet Deren needed Beroch's cavalry at the western gorge. A priority guarantee removed pressure from the only instrument she held in Avenor.

"Operators and immediate dependents first," she said. "Drain crews essential to chamber function next. Hospitals. Registered White Canopy propagation workers. Government command staff, not households."

"Frontier students?"

"East-district relocation until field compliance stabilizes."

Olt stared at her. "That is not a shelter category."

"It is temporary logistics."

"Temporary until what?"

"Until Commander Sarn follows Deren's timetable."

The blunt answer sounded uglier outside the census room. Ivara kept it.

Lera's fever-bright face returned to her, along with the girl's calm correction that the east halls should not shelter anyone if Orun moved. Ivara imagined that fact arriving in a letter to Beroch: your pupil lost tested stone because you delayed an army. The image did not alter the order. Its persistence removed the last defense of ignorance; she chose with the child's face present.

Olt closed his ledger. "Do you want the dependency stated on the order?"

"No. State capacity reassignment."

"Then no clerk will know when to restore it."

"I will know."

He had served her long enough to recognize the danger of a condition held in

one ruler's mind.

Ivara did not return directly to the census room. She made Prefect Soll take her through the frontier academy and across to the east-district halls she had just designated.

Students filled the dormitory court for morning count. Rauk pupils stood beside human river children, goblin apprentices, and six Ilaith survey students sent from provincial courts. Their uniforms shared yellow cord but no common cut; the academy had learned that standardized collars fit almost nobody well.

A teacher called names while guards checked them against a movement slate. The process looked like attendance. Four armed exits changed its meaning.

Lera Dava answered from the third row. Fever had flushed the mineral calluses along her jaw. She held herself straight until the count ended, then sat on a bench before permission reached her.

Soll hurried forward. "She should be in the infirmary."

"The infirmary moved stable cases last night," the teacher said. "Her temperature rose after dawn."

Ivara crouched in front of the girl. "You are Lera Dava."

"Yes, Regent."

"Your bridge calculations received distinction."

Wariness crossed Lera's face. "My mother tells people."

"Your mother writes often?"

"When letters arrive."

The answer stayed within academy rules and accused them anyway.

Ivara asked what Lera understood about the shelter drill. The girl explained that academy pupils would march to North Quarry in six columns, apprentices first to help carry medical litters. She knew the route, rest stations, and assigned chamber bay. Nobody had told her that the bay no longer belonged to her category.

"Suppose your route changes to east district," Ivara said. "How would you organize it?"

Lera considered the problem as schoolwork. "East Grain Street narrows at the glass market. We would need three columns, not six. The apprentices should take the handcarts around Cooper Lane. Fever cases need the covered way because rain cools a lichen mantle too fast."

"The east halls lack flex ceilings."

"Then we should not shelter there if Orun moves."

No court speech improved upon that conclusion.

A guard approached with a sealed academy notice. It reported another delay in family correspondence. Ivara read the list of reasons: insecure roads, coded

political content, insufficient censors. Lera watched the paper.

"Does it say when we can write?" she asked.

"No."

Ivara could have ordered the letters released. Messages to Sarn parents might reduce panic, or reveal that their children remained useful and carefully held. Either effect would alter Beroch's decisions. She returned the notice without changing it.

At the east-district warehouse, grain dust lay thick over floor planks. Iron posts supported a roof designed for snow, not movement beneath its foundation. Two school halls nearby held fixed masonry partitions. A clinic occupied four rooms over a bakery and had twelve beds.

Soll stopped in the warehouse center. "You cannot put 612 pupils here."

"Only the Sarn contingent moves to secondary holding."

"Ninety-five."

"Correct."

"Because their commander delayed your army."

Ivara examined a roof post. Old cracks carried fresh chalk marks from an inspector. "Because protected capacity has fallen."

"Capacity fell for everyone. You selected one group."

The prefect had spent twelve years enforcing emergency terms and censoring letters. His objection did not make him innocent. It made the line visible even to someone who maintained it.

"Can this building survive ordinary tremors?" she asked.

"Ordinary, yes. Not waking."

"Prepare it for temporary occupancy. Add rain awnings between the halls. Move twelve clinic cots here."

"And if Orun reaches waking threshold before we transfer them?"

"My office will issue a new priority."

Soll looked back toward the academy. "Your office may be under stone by then."

Ivara wrote his objection on the inspection margin and signed beneath it. She ordered carpenters to brace roof posts, though no timber brace could turn fixed warehouse walls into a flex chamber. She assigned two medical workers and one city clerk to the relocation. These measures could reduce ordinary harm. They could not make the category honest.

On the walk back, academy pupils began a shelter drill. Yellow cords moved through the streets in measured groups. Lera traveled in the covered fever cart, still giving route advice to a teacher walking beside her. The column turned toward North Quarry under the plan Ivara intended to revise before noon.

Back at the census room, Ivvara made the change. She did not remove every frontier pupil. River families, quarry apprentices, and children attached to loyal auxiliary commands remained on the first slate. She moved the 76 Sarn academy pupils and 19 Sarn apprentices to east-district holding. Their names remained in the city. Their protection moved onto paper without tested stone beneath it.

Ninety-five lines required a single category mark.

The knife scrape took less than a minute.

Orinel Thyr requested a mirror conference at sunrise. Her image appeared above a silver bowl fed by cultivated lichen. White Canopy's Speaker had dressed formally despite the hour, layers of green veil falling over her shoulders.

"Your revised slate reduces our protected allotment by three hundred twelve," Orinel said without greeting.

"Unregistered workers do not fall under the compact you signed."

"Propagation houses depend on lower-canopy labor."

"You defined registered labor."

"During a medicine bargain, not an evacuation."

Ivvara turned the priority sheet so Orinel could see. "We are discussing one capacity. If your compact expands, another category leaves."

Orinel read the page. Her eyes passed over the Sarn demotion without pause and stopped at the lower-canopy lines.

In the nine-lock map room, Orinel had bought White Canopy priority with cultures for the March, and Ivvara had insisted on an exact definition of registered labor. Here that exactness produced a ledger in which Ko's unregistered hands could keep six thousand people alive yet counted for less than a ceremonial household. The bargain had reached its promised destination.

"You have removed drain tenders, soil carriers, and nursery hands."

"I protected 143 essential flex-drain workers under city service authority."

"White Canopy requires 418 laborers to move the culture stores."

"Then leave some ceremonial households behind."

Color deepened beneath Orinel's pale mantle. "Those households carry lineages we cannot replace."

"Neither can the workers."

"Lineage is not a count of bodies."

"Today shelter is."

Orinel threatened to suspend culture shipments to Volda. Ivvara knew the threat lacked time. Red Hollow lay destroyed, operators already carried White Canopy stores, and withholding new shipments would endanger the system Orinel relied upon for priority.

"You may choose 275 additional lower-canopy workers," Ivara said. "Named individually by function. Each one replaces a White Canopy household place."

"That violates our compact."

"Your compact promised registered labor, not every root family."

"And the frontier students?"

The question came only as Orinel searched for categories to trade.

"Their relocation remains separate."

"White Canopy takes no position on military hostages."

The words clarified her protest. Orinel would fracture over workers necessary to her court. She would not spend leverage on Sarn children outside it.

"Send your 275 names before midday," Ivara said. "Afterward the slate closes."

She ended the mirror connection.

Copying clerks returned to their tables as the capital woke. Ivara gave them three versions. The public shelter notice listed functions without names. White Canopy received its allocation and substitution procedure. Field command received a short appendix placing frontier dependents under compliance review.

Junior clerk Pel copied the Sarn amendment. His pen paused at Lera Dava's name.

"Problem?" Ivara asked.

"The academy medical list marks her fever."

"East district has a clinic."

"No flex ceiling."

"Then medical staff move her if Orun enters waking threshold."

Pel wrote the instruction in the margin. "Who declares threshold?"

"My office."

His face remained properly blank.

A field mirror brightened before noon. Deren appeared from Volda's gallery, the image shaking with each commanded step. His left cheek carried a cut. Behind him, operators changed shift around empty chairs.

"Split River remains open east," he said. "Kharad's columns move toward the high junction. Beroch refuses a direct pursuit until his pasture refugees clear."

Ivara spread the route map. The main refugee corridor ran from Split River toward the highland saddle, wide enough for camps and Kharad's approach. Driving Volda into it would force civilian columns aside and place the bridled colossus across Kharad's free line.

"Take Volda through the refugee corridor," she said.

Deren looked away from the mirror, perhaps toward Beroch or a route officer.

"The ground carries noncombat columns."

"Issue clearing notice."

"They cannot clear before our next step."

"Then slow the first support column and use cavalry to open lateral routes. Volda continues."

"Beroch will invoke his appendix."

Ivara slid the compliance amendment beneath her hand, though Deren could not see it through the mirror. "Tell him the academy remains under review."

"That may hold him for one order."

"One order reaches the junction."

Deren did not salute. "And if Volda strikes the refugees?"

"Do not let it."

The command compressed impossibility into a subordinate's duty. Ivara heard herself do it and proceeded.

After the mirror dimmed, Pel brought three clean copies for seal. One listed the 95 Sarn names in an appendix. Another concealed them under a category total. The third, intended for field command, stated only that priority depended on compliance.

Ivara sealed all three.

"Destroy working scrap," she told him.

Pel gathered the wax curls and scraped leaves. Among them lay the first slate, where restored lines and fresh cuts showed the sequence of her choices.

"This too?" he asked.

She considered keeping it in the regency archive. Drafts invited interpretations that final orders prevented.

"Destroy it."

Pel carried the bundle toward the furnace room.

Ivara returned to the measuring basin. Western Stair water arrived below yesterday's line. Far beneath Avenor, Orun pulsed again. The surface trembled around the jar.

On Day 23, Red Hollow lay broken, Split River still held, and Volda moved under a bridle toward civilians who had escaped its army. Ivara corrected the public slate by three hundred twelve places, signed the east-district clinic order, and sent Deren the shortest version of what she had done.

In the furnace room, Pel burned the wax curls. He folded the first scraped slate beneath his coat instead of feeding it to the flame.

Chapter 19 — Three Drumholds at Black Saddle

Korra drove the first copper pin into Black Saddle before sunrise and felt Volda through the hammer haft.

The answer came up from the ground as a thick double tremor. Loose shale skipped around her boots. Thirty paces below, Vaun crews hauling a bridge rib froze in place until she raised one hand. Their silence lasted only long enough to distinguish the pulse from Kharad's steadier beat beneath the western slope.

"Keep the rib moving," she called. "Volda has distance yet."

No one asked how much. The Saddle concealed the eastern approach behind two black ridges, and echoes made liars of minutes. Korra set a second pin and sighted the three lanes she had marked through the pass. Red cords led to the civilian terraces. White chalk marked the supply traverse. Blue flags followed a dry streambed broad enough for cavalry, though Beroch had not agreed to place a single Sarn rider there.

A younger Vaun pathwright named Daska crouched beside the pin. "Three entrances give us three arguments."

"One entrance gives whoever holds it a prison."

Daska glanced toward the council shelter. "They have been arguing since moonset."

"Then they are awake." Korra handed her the hammer. "Set the next pin where River Rauk can see it from their ferry wagons. If they think we hid a turning, they leave."

The last route convoy crawled up from Kharad's northern shoulder while daylight spread across the pass. Carts moved first, each axle bound in wet rope against the vibration. Walkers followed in groups of forty. Pela Orr stood where the red cords divided, counting every person who stepped from living stone onto the Saddle's fixed basalt. Sava worked behind her with two bridge companies, loosening the temporary stair after each section cleared.

Kharad had carried them east for twenty-four days. Its back now rose against the western sky, a country tilted beneath Harth's broken towers and Green Mantle terraces. Every waking pulse tightened the ropes. Yet the Worldback held its pace, choosing the cleared strip through low ground rather than the cliff road the empire had left open like a blade.

Korra pressed her mineral-stiff fingertips against her palm. They closed slowly. Cold tracery had reached the first joints and no farther. She had learned to tie with her right hand leading, to sleep while pain ticked through the left, to stop people from watching when the fingers failed on a small buckle.

A horn sounded from the southern shelf. Not an alarm: three short calls, Sarn formality announcing a commander under truce.

Beroch rode into Black Saddle beneath no imperial banner. Forty basalt cavalry followed at a walk, blue clay freshly laid on their tusks. Their horses carried empty lance sockets and full saddlebags. A folded white cloth hung from Beroch's saddle bow, too clean for surrender and too plain for rank.

Korra met him between the blue flags. "You brought witnesses."

"I brought people who can repeat what they see without improving it." His scarred lip drew tighter. "Are the routes yours?"

"The work crews answer to their own parties. The marks belong to anyone who can read them."

Beroch dismounted. Dust coated his boots to the knee, and one sleeve carried a dark line of old blood. "That sounds prepared."

"It has had practice."

He pulled a paper from inside his riding coat. The regent's seal remained unbroken at its lower edge, but the fold bore finger dents. "Read this before someone asks me for an oath."

Korra did not reach for it. "Say it."

"Schooling households assigned under the Sarn charter have been removed from Avenor's first evacuation allotment. Their places go to crown operators and households essential to continuity." Each word emerged level. "I delayed Volda by thirty-seven minutes to clear a pasture camp. Regent Cend calls the removal temporary leverage."

The children had lived in Avenor as pupils, hostages, or both depending on who described the same locked dormitory. Korra knew eight names from the letters Sarn parents had carried to Split River. She thought of those names instead of Beroch's imperial raids, because keeping both truths present required effort.

"You believed exact terms could hold her," she said.

"I believed breaking them would cost her more than keeping them."

"And now?"

"Now I have evidence that I priced her shame too high." He offered the order. "Do not mistake that for submission to you."

Korra took the paper. "I wouldn't know what to do with it."

That almost drew a smile. Beroch tied his horse beside her copper pin, a deliberate claim to the negotiating ground rather than any marked lane.

The council shelter occupied a quarry cut open to the north. No table stood at its center. Seven low map frames formed a rough circle, one for each party, with enough space between them for a person to walk out without stepping over another's tools. Korra had insisted on that arrangement. Beroch noticed it and said nothing.

Nesh Aru sat for the Cinder Cloister with the unedited pulse record wrapped in

oilcloth across their knees. River Rauk sent Fara Den, a ferrymaster whose gray braids carried tiny iron depth weights. Thalen represented the Green Mantle worker council only until its elected root-tenders arrived from Kharad, a limitation he announced before sitting. Kivik Noll came with three guild witnesses and a brass ear funnel hanging against their damaged right ear. Split River's communes had sent baker Jori Pell and floodkeeper Tamas Ro. Korra stood for Vaun. Beroch placed Ivara's paper on the Sarn frame.

"These are the seven parties present," Nesh said for the witness roll. "Vaun drumhold. Sarn drumhold. Cinder Cloister. River Rauk league. Green Mantle worker council. Noll maintenance guild. Split River communes. White Canopy has sent no delegate. Cendar has sent an army."

"An army remains a negotiating position," Beroch said.

Fara Den tapped a depth weight on her map. "So does leaving. River wagons can clear north before sunset."

Tamas answered, "Your wagons cross our repaired bank to do it."

"They paid for the bank."

"They paid for stone. Split River buried people under it."

Korra let the dispute run long enough to reveal its load. Fara wanted authority over every wet crossing. Tamas wanted downstream farms protected from military floodwork. Kivik required public maintenance ledgers and guild refusal rights where corestone appeared. Thalen demanded clinical authority independent from command. Nesh would carry terms but direct no fighters. Beroch wanted a military schedule capable of surviving contact with Volda. Vaun crews would not build another closed route.

Seven parties meant seven legitimate ways to stop the coalition by leaving. That fragility frightened every trained commander in the shelter. Korra trusted it more than obedience.

Beroch unrolled an imperial field map. "Volda enters the east defile by tomorrow's second light. Five thousand nine hundred sixty troops remain with it. Some will desert if offered a witnessed road. Others will hold because their families remain under Ivara. My cavalry can take the lower operator gallery if River Rauk secures the ravine and Noll crews open its ventilation cut."

Kivik angled their good ear toward him. "Can take, or can attempt?"

"Can reach. The gallery may collapse before we hold it."

"Better." Kivik made a notation. "Contracts built on honest verbs kill fewer people."

Jori Pell pushed a ration slate onto the central floor. "Your fighters eat tomorrow. Our communes need three days' grain in reserve if the refugee column turns back. Who owns the wagons during battle?"

"No one owns them," Fara said. "Drivers retain them."

"Then who directs them?"

"The drivers."

Beroch's knuckles touched his map frame. "Eighteen thousand fighters cannot move by private preference once contact begins."

"Neither can six thousand support workers become your baggage train," Korra said.

His gaze found hers. "Then name a command."

"Name an objective."

"Prevent Volda from entering the refugee corridor."

"Good. Sarn chooses how Sarn fights toward it. Vaun chooses how our bridge crews serve it. River Rauk can refuse any crossing that destroys their bank. Civilians answer to route wardens elected by the communities moving through each lane."

"And when two routes require the same bridge?"

"The civilian lane takes precedence."

"Always?"

"While people remain on it."

"Then an enemy can pin us by driving civilians ahead."

Tamas leaned over his frame. "People aren't pins."

"On a battlefield, a cruel commander uses whatever stops you." Beroch did not soften the statement. "Ivara has already ordered Volda through a refugee corridor."

The paper on his frame made the claim heavier than accusation. Korra looked around the circle. Everyone had a reason to fear his discipline. Everyone also needed the hours his cavalry could buy.

She took the old copper roadstone stud from her right temple and set it beside Ivara's order. "At Kestrel Cut, I held sole route command. Imperial troops wanted the bridge before Harrow Camp cleared. I calculated that delaying them would strand two supply companies in floodwater. So I opened on schedule."

No one moved. Thalen had heard pieces, not the whole admission. Beroch knew the campaign from the opposite side of an imperial archive.

"The troops crossed," Korra continued. "They reached the camp before the civilian route opened. I spent eighteen years saying I had built a bridge, not given an order. That distinction kept my hands clean in my own telling. It did nothing for the dead."

Nesh lowered their eyes to the stud. Cinder practice granted silence to an irreversible choice. Korra had no wish for ritual, but she accepted the pause.

"I will not take supreme route command," she said. "I will sign a task that can be

withdrawn. I will accept removal by Vaun witnesses. I will report every closed road to all seven frames. If someone wants a cleaner promise, choose another pathwright."

Beroch read her face with the care he usually gave charter clauses. "I will not place Sarn under Vaun authority."

"Don't."

"I will coordinate the military objective with one delegate from each fighting party. Orders apply only to forces whose delegates accept them."

Fara clicked her depth weight again. "River accepts defense of crossings, no pursuit east of our last marked well."

Kivik said, "Noll accepts severance access. No command to extract fresh corestone, even to save the operation."

Thalen added, "Clinical triage cannot be overruled for rank."

The terms began as refusals. Korra watched them become a structure.

At midday, Volda tested it.

A pulse struck Black Saddle hard enough to spill chalk from every frame. The quarry wall gave a dry crack. Outside, horses screamed and bridge crews dropped flat. A runner burst into the shelter shouting that the east defile had opened.

Beroch reached the blue lane before anyone else. Korra followed with Kivik and found a brown cloud lifting beyond the ridge. Three signalers on the high shelf reported movement beneath it. One swore Volda had turned north. Another read a direct approach. The third had lost sight of the ground.

"Cavalry to the east shelf," Beroch ordered.

Korra caught his bridle before he mounted. "That shelf crosses the last civilian descent."

"Volda may be six hours early."

"May be. The convoy needs nineteen minutes."

His horse danced under the continuing tremor. "If the report is true, nineteen minutes closes the military lane."

"Then Sarn takes the dry streambed. Vaun drops the upper pylon after the convoy. You still reach the shelf by the quarry turn."

"That costs twelve minutes."

"It costs your riders twelve. The people walking downhill keep their road."

Behind them, the council parties gathered without waiting for summons. Fara sent two scouts to the north seep. Tamas ordered the red-lane wardens to widen intervals. Kivik put listeners against fixed basalt and called for silence.

Their first reading came with blood from Kivik's right ear. They wiped it away, shifted the funnel left, and listened again.

"Plate fall," they said. "Large. Volda struck the east wall, but no step followed. Echo crossed the defile twice."

Beroch kept one hand on the saddle. "Certain?"

"No. Certain enough to spend twelve minutes rather than nineteen lives."

He sent his riders through the streambed.

The decision passed through seven authorities in less than four minutes. No supreme voice had improved it. The convoy continued down the red cords, and Pela called each number at the transfer line.

By late afternoon the last cart stood on fixed ground. A woman from Green Mantle crossed behind it carrying three dormant lichen trays against her chest. Sava pulled the release rope. The temporary stair folded in six sections, its shedstone ribs settling onto Kharad for reuse.

Pela checked her slate against two witnesses, then checked it again. "Route departures total three thousand nine hundred. Initial dead remain fifty-four, listed separately. Pre-Stair evacuation remains two thousand one hundred ten."

Korra knew the answer, yet made Pela speak it.

"How many aboard?"

"6,416."

Across the gap, Harth clung to Kharad's back under evening dust. Lights appeared along flexible streets. Those who remained had chosen under pressure, history, family, fear, and limited alternatives. A ledger could preserve their number. It could not simplify their reasons.

Pela did not close the slate. She carried it to the council shelter and laid it beside the ration schedule. "Six thousand four hundred sixteen bodies require water whether we win or lose. Kharad's shoulder cistern cracked during the last turn. We have two days at marching issue."

Jori examined the columns. "Split River can supply eight hundred barrels."

"Your barrels sit north of Volda's approach," Fara said. "Moving them now exposes the ferry wagons."

Sava entered with bridge dust whitening her hair. "Then don't move barrels. We hang skins beneath the western runoff and take what the night gives us."

"No rain forecast," Beroch said.

"Worldbacks shed heat after hard travel. Heat meets Saddle air. I have watched clouds form over Kharad for twenty-four years."

Thalen touched a lichen strip to the wind and watched its margins darken. "Moisture will condense before dawn. Not enough for full issue, perhaps enough to spare the barrels."

The argument shifted from ownership to measurement. Green Mantle workers offered collection cloth. Noll crews had ventilation skins that could be washed free

of forge soot. River Rauk would lend wagon frames if civilian wardens held the traces. Sarn supplied horses without claiming the cargo. Korra listened as a water system assembled from assets no party would have surrendered to a supreme quartermaster.

She walked the proposed catch line with Sava before dusk. They fixed the first cloth between a basalt tooth and a portable pylon, keeping every knot capable of release if Kharad shifted. Below, children who had left the moving country watched droplets gather along the fabric's edge.

A boy held out a cup too early. Sava tipped the cloth with one finger, giving him three drops.

"That proves nothing," Korra said.

"It proves the cup works."

They set thirty-two more lines. By the time the eastern sky darkened around Volda's dust, moisture silvered every sheet. The catch would not solve tomorrow. It would carry one more choice into it.

Night brought signatures.

Nesh wrote the headings on seven separate sheets so no single page could be seized and called the whole pact. Civilian route councils held authority over evacuation lanes. Military delegates coordinated named objectives but could not requisition people, medicine, or bridges without the relevant party's consent. Every party retained withdrawal rights after public notice, except while abandoning a route would strand civilians already admitted under its mark. Disputes required three witnesses from parties not involved. No command passed through ancestry, imperial rank, or control of a Worldback.

Beroch signed SARN in hard square strokes. "A pact made to be revoked."

"A bridge made to release," Korra said. "Both fail less violently."

He pressed his seal beside the word peer. "Do not grow fond of the comparison."

Fara signed for River Rauk after adding a flood clause. Tamas and Jori signed for Split River. Thalen's worker mandate arrived by runner, carrying seventy-three thumbmarks and root-dye prints; he placed his name under them rather than above. Kivik's three witnesses stamped an open square for the Noll guild. Nesh marked the Cinder road sign without accepting military office. Korra replaced her temple stud and signed last for Vaun.

Outside the shelter, muster fires climbed the Saddle in distinct rows. Sarn blue lamps held the southern shelf. Vaun copper baskets lined the bridge yards. River Rauk kept low green flames beside the water carts. No banner covered the others.

The count reached 18,000 fighters, with six thousand noncombat support and evacuation workers entered on separate rolls. Korra ordered the numbers copied onto every frame. An army could lose people inside a total. A coalition needed to

remember who could say no.

Near midnight, Volda cleared the eastern ridge.

Its fortress towers leaned against a red sky. Command pulses flashed pale through seams along its throat, each one followed by a shudder that sent avalanches down the defile. The Worldback's front plates struck the first black slope, stopped, then ground forward under another imposed beat.

Kharad answered beneath Korra's boots. Its pulse traveled through three marked lanes and every released bridge joint in the Saddle.

Beroch mounted at the blue flags. "My lower-gallery force moves on the next long interval."

"Vaun keeps the civilian terraces open," Korra said.

"River holds the ravine," Fara called from her wagon.

One by one, the other parties named what they would do. No one named a ruler.

Korra lifted the copper hammer. Along the Saddle, eighteen thousand fighters moved toward their separate tasks while the red cords behind them remained open.

Chapter 20 — The War Between Mountains

Thalen tied the clinic floor to Kharad with living roots because ordinary stakes tore free at the first conflicting pulse.

He worked on his knees beneath a canvas roof while Green Mantle tenders passed wet root cords through holes in the shedstone platform. Each cord ended in a clay basin of soil carried from the terrace nurseries. The roots tightened when Kharad moved and loosened between steps, a slow grip that spared the platform from cracking. Beyond the clinic, Black Saddle shook under two separate rhythms.

Volda's beat arrived sharp and regular through the eastern ridge. Command drove every interval toward sameness. Kharad answered from below with an uneven pulse that shortened near broken ground and lengthened beneath the seed-stone terraces. The interference made jars creep across tables. It made patients vomit. It made Thalen's lichen mantle lift along his collarbones as if seeking distance from his skin.

"Third cot has gray tracery," a root-tender called.

Thalen crossed the swaying platform. A Sarn signaler lay with both hands clenched. Mineral lines had spread from the copper throat disk he wore against his chest, though he had never touched a crown. Thalen removed the disk with wooden tongs and dropped it into a sand jar.

"Relay exposure," he said. "Warm wraps. No deepcraft. Mark the hand joints every quarter hour."

The signaler stared at him. "Can I ride?"

"You can choose to lose the use of your fingers today or preserve what remains."

"My section moves at first horn."

"Then teach another person your calls." Thalen held his gaze. "I will not call damage readiness."

Outside, eighteen thousand fighters moved among separate flags. The coalition had no central camp. Sarn cavalry occupied the southern shelf. Vaun bridge crews worked the high cuts. River Rauk skirmishers guarded the ravine, Noll teams marked ventilation faults, and Split River companies held the refugee approach. Six thousand support workers kept water, food, litters, animals, and road signals moving behind them. Their divisions looked inefficient from a crown tower. From the clinic, they looked harder to destroy with one order.

Korra came through the entrance carrying a coil of red cord over her right shoulder. Dust had turned her close-cropped hair gray. "Volda changed gait."

Thalen touched two fingers to the platform. A violent beat crossed his skin, then a softer answer rolled from Kharad's interior. "The imposed interval shortened."

"Can you tell direction?"

"Pain increased. Direction requires eyes."

"Good."

"You sound pleased."

"I am tired of people hearing what they want." She opened her left hand for inspection.

The tracery still occupied her fingertips, but the skin had cooled farther into the palm. Thalen pressed each nail bed. The third finger returned color slowly.

"Do not conduct today," he said.

"I may need one correction."

"Then decide now which part of your hand you can afford."

Her expression hardened. "There are 6,416 people on Kharad. I can't afford their part."

"You are not dividing one body against six thousand." He wrapped her palm in a lichen strip tuned to show fresh mineral spread. "Your hand belongs in the casualty count before you spend it."

Korra flexed against the wrap. "Keep the strip visible."

A runner summoned them to the high observation cut. Thalen brought a pulse frame, six diagnostic cultures, and the shameful memory of every chart he had altered to make pain look harmless. On the climb, the ground pitched east. Loose stones rolled toward Volda before reversing under Kharad's next step.

The two Worldbacks came into view across the Saddle.

Kharad filled the western approach, its broad front plates split by old roads and new flexible bridges. Harth's remaining towers rose far behind the leading ridge of its back. Along one shoulder, workers had roofed the seed-stone beds with layered shedstone and soil. Kharad angled north around the central basalt tooth, following the widest cleared ground.

Volda advanced from the east under a fortress built for war. Black walls straddled its neck. Artillery galleries occupied both shoulders. Pale command light pulsed beneath a crown tower, then traveled down through the throat-nail in a straight wound. At each flash, Volda planted a forelimb where the imposed route demanded. Its natural weight pulled south. The bridle forced west.

Between them lay six kilometers of narrowing pass, refugee terraces on the north side, and enough loose basalt to bury a town.

Beroch stood over three field maps with Fara Den and Kivik. "We keep them from meeting in the central throat," he said. "River teams clear the north ravine. Vaun holds the suspension ways on Kharad. Sarn reaches Volda's lower gallery through this ventilation seam."

Kivik tapped the seam with a brass compass. "The passage fits one file. If Volda

rolls its shoulder, your first twenty riders become a stopper for everyone behind."

"Then we go on foot after the first shelf."

"Better. Leave armor that catches."

Beroch looked offended by the suggestion and began unbuckling his shoulder plates.

Korra studied the central basalt tooth. "If Kharad keeps north, Volda's forced line clips its front quarter. Collision still happens."

"Can Kharad turn?" Fara asked.

"If we open ground, perhaps. There isn't time to move the tooth."

Kivik pointed toward a fracture channel beneath it. "No need. Break the western footing. The tooth falls east and forces Volda to climb. That buys Kharad space."

"It also sends stone over the north ravine," Fara said.

"Unless your water teams flood the cut before the fall. Mud catches fragments."

"My people can release two gates. The lower farms take silt."

Tamas Ro answered from behind her. "Split River accepts silt. We don't accept a dam break."

They argued quantities, not ownership. Thalen placed cultures on the map corners and watched their colors. Volda's pulse turned the first strip white. Kharad's answer darkened another to green-black. When both arrived together, the center culture blistered.

"The collision begins before their bodies touch," he said. "Conflicting resonance crosses continuous stone. Break contact paths around the refugee terraces. Lift every fixed bridge onto rope or timber."

Korra looked toward the north camps. "That severs their water carts."

"Use separate skins until passage."

Beroch folded the map. "First objective: protect the carried population and refugee terraces from pulse transfer. Second: divert their bodies. Third: sever Volda's westward command. No pursuit."

Each delegate repeated the objective to their own force. No one gave a universal order.

The battle opened with work crews.

Before any charge, the north terraces had to move sideways. Their shelters could not descend while Kharad blocked the western slope, and Volda's approach closed the east. Korra divided the occupied ledges into six release groups. Nobody moved by household rank. People nearest fixed stone crossed first because resonance would reach them hardest.

Thalen joined the third ledge with a basket of diagnostic leaves. A Split River elder named Mares had tied himself to a millstone trough and refused the litter

assigned to him.

"My daughters are at the floodgate," he said. "They know where I am."

"The fixed trough conducts both pulses." Thalen laid a leaf on its rim. White veins spread through green tissue at once. "When the rhythms meet, this stone may fracture under you."

"I cannot walk."

"You can choose the root raft, a rope seat, or staying after seeing this reading. I will not call the last choice safe."

Mares inspected the leaf. "Does the raft go with my grain chest?"

"People before property."

"That chest holds the winter seed for three communes. It is not property in the way your coat is property."

Thalen felt the old institutional answer rise in him: classification first, life made to fit it. He looked at the chest. Four people could carry it. Those same four could move two injured children.

"Separate the seed sacks," he said. "Six carriers take one sack apiece. The chest stays."

Mares cut his own tether. "Rope seat, then."

Across the ledge, choices multiplied. A Green Mantle family refused to abandon dormant orchard grafts until root-tenders distributed them among twenty packs. Two imperial deserters carried the mill seed under commune witness. Sarn horses pulled clinic platforms but wore civilian route marks over military tack. A Vaun rigger opened a fence to free goats rather than spend thirty workers driving them through a choke point.

Volda's next pulse hit while Mares hung above the ravine. The rope seat swung into the cliff. Thalen caught the guide line with both hands, taking the old man's weight through his shoulders. Three others braced behind him. Below, River Rauk had stretched a catch net woven for ferry cargo. The net turned a fatal drop into bruises if the line failed, which it did not.

"Your clinic has poor chairs," Mares said when they landed.

"File the complaint after survival."

"Already dictated."

By the time the sixth group reached suspended ground, the terraces held only marked property caches and fixed shelters. Civilian wardens painted each empty entrance with lime. Military scouts could now distinguish abandoned cover from occupied refuge. That distinction changed where archers placed themselves and where Noll crews permitted charges.

Korra found Thalen checking a pregnant quarry worker whose pulse had accelerated with Kharad's. "North ledges clear," she said. "Thirty-one people chose

flex shelters under the basalt lip. They have two medics, water, and release ropes."

"You allowed them to remain?"

"They heard the risk. The shelters may outlast the open route if artillery cuts across it."

Thalen nodded. Choice could produce a result he disliked without becoming false. He marked the shelter count on his clinic slate and sent copies to the three nearest route wardens.

The evacuation consumed forty-two minutes. A centralized command might have saved ten by stripping seed, separating families, and dragging Mares without explanation. Those minutes now existed inside distributed packs, witnessed shelter rolls, and people who still knew where their kin had gone. When the first imperial gun elevated, no commander had to guess which terraces held bodies.

Vaun teams hammered wedges under fixed bridge feet while families crossed to suspended platforms. Green Mantle workers lifted clinic beds onto root rafts. River Rauk opened the upper floodgate in measured turns, sending water through the fracture channel without stripping the downstream bank. Noll sappers crawled under the basalt tooth with charges made from quarry powder and tuned shedstone cups.

Imperial artillery fired before the crews cleared.

The first stone struck Kharad's leading plate and shattered into roof-sized pieces. Kharad flinched. A street on its shoulder rose three meters, throwing carts against their ropes. Thalen's clinic platform swung but the roots held. The second shot fell into the north ravine, killing four water workers and punching through a grain wagon.

Thalen ran downhill with two tenders. He reached the wagon as another pulse forced Volda forward. A ferrymaker lay beneath the rear axle with a crushed thigh. Beside her, a child had driven a splinter through his cheek. Fighters passed toward the east without taking either litter; their objective did not grant them custody of the civilian lane.

"Lift on the long beat," Thalen said.

The tenders set a jack. Kharad's pulse rose under them. They lifted with it, using the ground's motion rather than resisting. The axle cleared long enough to drag the ferrymaker free. Blood filled the trouser leg in two quick surges.

Thalen packed the wound with clot lichen and marked a tourniquet time on her forehead. "Clinic north. Do not cross fixed stone."

"I have the gate count," she said through clenched teeth.

"Give it."

"Upper release at three turns. Lower held."

A runner carried the count. The ferrymaker kept her leg because her number

moved faster than her body.

On Volda, blue Sarn lamps appeared along the lower flank. Beroch's force had reached the ventilation shelf. Imperial defenders fired downward from loopholes, but the angle favored no one on a body that rolled with each step. Figures slid across Volda's plates, catching ropes or falling into dust.

Deren Cend watched from the crown gallery above them. Thalen knew him only by a silver command mantle and the straight posture of someone who had spent his life being visible. The gallery flashed. Volda's head lowered, driving toward the central throat.

"Now," Korra called from the observation line.

Kivik struck the quarry signal. Noll charges broke the western footing beneath the basalt tooth. River water had softened the fracture into black mud. The huge pillar leaned, paused, and fell east in three pieces. Mud swallowed the smaller fragments. The largest lodged against Volda's route like a step built for a god.

Volda struck it.

The impact flattened tents on the eastern shelf. Fortress walls cracked along two vertical lines. Volda's leading body rose against the obstacle, while the bridle continued ordering west. Its limbs sought footing south. Command dragged its throat north. Thalen's cultures burst one after another.

Kharad turned away from the collision point.

No human pulse directed the choice. Open ground waited along the northern cut, and the Worldback found it slowly, protecting the covered seed beds behind its shoulder. Its turn pulled Harth sideways across the horizon. Bridge crews released joints in sequence, letting streets bend rather than tear.

A crown trumpet sounded from Volda: one long imperial command call.

Then a second signal overrode it, sharper and repeated. Beroch's field listeners translated the flag that followed.

"Order from Ivara," a Sarn runner shouted. "Drive through the north terraces. Crush the refugee column to clear Volda's turn."

Thalen saw the route at once. The command would use bodies as softer ground between the Worldbacks, placing Kharad's people under Volda's advancing plates. Six thousand support workers and the last route evacuees occupied those terraces.

The crown gallery lit but no answering pulse descended.

Deren stood at its open face with one hand raised. An officer seized his arm. Deren struck him away and pulled the westward direction lever back to brace. His refusal traveled through machinery rather than speech: gallery shutters opened, release lamps flared, and Volda's imposed step faltered.

For a breath, the Worldback chose south.

Conflicting orders met inside the crown.

The tower split below Deren's feet. White resonance flashed through every brace. Operators dropped where they stood, hands and faces turning gray. A whole side of the gallery folded inward. Deren caught the railing, lost it, and disappeared with the floor into the throat shaft.

Thalen felt his death as a cessation of one frantic human relay amid Volda's much larger pain. He would not pretend the Worldback had judged him. A damaged structure had killed a man after one refusal, and that refusal had spared the refugee line for several minutes.

"Gallery fracture," Kivik said. Blood ran again from their right ear. "Lower command may still carry."

Beroch's blue lamps vanished into the ventilation seam.

The military line advanced while clinics withdrew. Sarn infantry crossed Volda's rolling flank by pairs. River archers covered the outer ports. Noll sappers cut three grilles, losing one worker when a plate closed over her rope. No unit moved under Korra's voice, yet every accepted task brought them toward the same lower gallery.

Thalen returned to the clinic because battle plans could not set broken bones.

Patients arrived faster than cots. Two Vaun riggers carried a child with spinal pain after a street lift. Seven imperial deserters came across the ravine under a white maintenance cloth, three showing command burns. A Sarn officer surrendered his litter place to the Noll worker crushed at the grille. Thalen cut boots away, marked circulation, refused rank, and sent every person capable of walking to carry water.

Orinel's pain-masking cultures appeared in an imperial medicine chest taken from Volda. A junior physician held one vial up. "This could keep the operators moving."

"It could keep them from knowing their organs are mineralizing."

"They may be the only people able to stop the crown."

"Then show them the damage and let them choose with accurate sight." Thalen placed a revealing culture beside the vial. "No concealment."

Three former operators chose to return as guides after seeing the gray spread under their skin. Four refused. Both groups received treatment.

Near sunset, Beroch took the lower gallery.

His signal reached them through two blue lamps hung upside down. Coalition flags rose over a doorway cracked across Volda's throat. Beroch himself emerged carrying an imperial operator by the harness. One side of his face ran with blood. Behind him, Kivik's crews exposed the active throat-nail housing.

Korra, Thalen, and Meris crossed from Kharad on a suspension line rigged between passing plates. The gap widened and narrowed with every stride. Meris went first, her shortened right hand locked around a pulley brake. Thalen followed

with diagnostic roots strapped to his chest. Korra came last, looking down only to judge distance.

Inside Volda, heat pressed through the walls. The lower gallery had lost half its floor. Dead operators remained buckled into copper frames. Living ones lay where Sarn medics worked without stripping their insignia or weapons until each person could witness the inventory.

Beroch pointed to the throat housing. "Can we pull it?"

Meris measured the fracture with her thumb knuckle. "Not while any crown relay remains active. The pulse channel will tear."

"Deren's gallery collapsed."

"Manual plates continue below. See that blue return?"

Light moved through a seam beside the nail. Volda convulsed around them. Thalen placed a root against the wall and received heat, pressure, salt-starved contraction, and an urgent southward lean. No words came. Nothing absolved their intrusion.

"The westward command remains," he said. "We can interrupt it, not remove the nail."

Beroch's jaw tightened. "We fought onto a living wound to leave the blade in."

"We leave it until removal does less harm than patience."

A crash rolled through the gallery. Kharad's northern turn had reached its limit. Volda climbed the fallen basalt, bringing their front quarters within two kilometers. Resonance joined them through the Saddle floor.

Meris opened the brace panel. "A counter-hammer at the lower joint can break one command interval. Kivik must set it from here."

"Kivik has the tool," Korra said. "I can carry the answering interval through Kharad."

Thalen looked at her bandaged left hand. The diagnostic strip had darkened from pale green to iron gray along the palm. "You have already begun conducting through contact."

"I know."

"You will lose the wrist."

"If the bodies collide, people lose more."

Beroch heard them. "Name another method."

Meris searched the panel, then shook her head. "Not in the time we have."

Korra did not ask permission. She crossed back on the suspension line while Kivik descended to the brace joint. Thalen stayed on Volda to call pulse intervals. Meris kept the fractured panel open. Beroch moved every unnecessary body out of the gallery.

They prepared without a shared command channel. Red lamps marked Kharad's natural beat. Blue lamps showed Volda's forced interval. Kivik hung a white lamp over the counter-hammer. Thalen stood between them with both hands on separate diagnostic roots, never joining the circuits.

"Natural interval in six," he called. "Forced strike in four."

Volda's wall contracted under his right palm. Kharad's answer rose through the left root.

"Three. Two. Hold."

The command pulse flashed.

Kivik drove the counter-hammer into Meris's brace joint. The tool gave a flat note that canceled one narrow frequency. Volda's westward order broke mid-beat. On Kharad, Korra pressed her left palm to a Vaun roadstone and sent no direction, only the opposing resonance that kept the broken command from finding Kharad's throat-nail.

Gray mineral light ran from her fingers to her left wrist.

Kharad planted both front limbs around the seed-stone terraces. Its body braced in a curve, not against Volda, but around the fragile chambers on its own shoulder. The motion opened another strip of north ground.

Freed from one command interval, Volda tried to turn south.

Its injured forelimb met the fallen basalt. The joint folded. Forty kilometers of living stone descended onto one knee.

The Saddle rolled like water. Thalen struck the gallery floor hard enough to bite his tongue. Walls opened. Beroch caught him by the back of his mantle before the crack took his arm. Outside, fortress towers fell from Volda's shoulder in slow ruin. One artillery wall collapsed away from the refugee terraces because the Worldback's southward lean carried it clear.

The throat-nail housing screamed through stone. Kivik released the hammer before the return pulse shattered it. Meris closed the brace panel with a locking wedge.

"Command line?" Beroch shouted.

Thalen pressed the diagnostic root to the wall. Volda's pain remained immense. Its pulse wandered, seeking a stable rhythm. The straight westward drive did not return.

"Interrupted," he said. "Not severed. It is no longer advancing west."

Beroch closed his eyes once. "Then get everyone out."

Night revealed the battle's shape more honestly than banners. Kharad stood north of the central throat, bruised but upright. Volda knelt east of the fallen basalt, its fortress broken and its living body still breathing in pulses. The refugee terraces remained open. Fires marked crushed clinics, shattered guns, and places

where people searched rubble by hand.

At the ravine, the catch nets held roof stone, three horses, and eleven people who would otherwise have fallen beyond reach. Fara ordered every rope inspected before anyone claimed victory. Tamas sent a written silt estimate downstream with the first uninjured rider. Vaun crews replaced two released bridge feet with timber cradles, preserving the distinction between a crossing and a command path. The coalition had won ground through small structures that still required tending. No surviving route could be taken for granted tomorrow.

Thalen moved among casualties until dawn. Deren's body came out of the crown shaft with nine operators, all dead. Beroch ordered his nephew's imperial mantle recorded and returned with the body, not displayed as a trophy. Coalition dead received names by party. Imperial dead received names where records survived. No subtraction touched the locked 6,416 aboard Kharad; battle deaths occupied a separate ledger.

Korra sat on a water crate while Thalen unwrapped her hand. Mineral tracery covered every finger and crossed the palm into her left wrist. The joint bent less than half its prior range.

"Say it plainly," she told him.

"The stone creep has reached your left wrist. It will not reverse. Further command resonance may stiffen the whole hand or travel beyond it."

She looked toward Kharad's dark bulk. "The people aboard?"

"Counted. Shelters damaged, no mass breach. Sava reports every seed bed intact."

Only then did Korra allow him to splint the wrist.

A basin on the clinic floor rippled before he finished. No one had touched it. The water formed three close rings, paused, and formed another from much farther away.

Meris crouched beside it. Her face changed before she spoke. "That interval belongs to Orun's old survey record."

Thalen laid a diagnostic leaf on the water. The tissue darkened at its center under a waking pulse traveling from the east.

"Avenor," Beroch said from the doorway.

Behind him, Volda remained on one knee. Kharad held the open northern ground. The coalition had prevented one collision and broken one westward command, but the eldest Worldback now stirred beneath a city of 41,000.

Thalen closed the clinic ledger on Black Saddle and opened a clean page for the road to Avenor.

Chapter 21 — Down into the Underheart

Meris tested the descent cage by dropping a barrel of water into Kharad's throat and watching half of it return as steam.

The cage held. Its shedstone ribs flexed against three guide ropes, and the brake teeth seated where she had cut them. The barrel did not. Heat split the staves eighty meters below, marking the first vent with a brief white cloud.

Kivik leaned over the shaft lip with their good ear turned down. "Vent opens every fourth pulse. Sometimes the fifth."

"Sometimes?" Korra asked.

"Kharad has survived a war. Bodies lose regularity."

Meris checked the right-hand brake with the stumps of her two missing fingertips tucked away from the ratchet. "We descend after the vent closes. If the interval shortens, cut the clay seal. Water floods the lower skin and buys us one breath."

Thalen touched a diagnostic root to the cage floor. "One breath for what?"

"To decide which bad design kills us least."

Kivik showed a flash of teeth. "She has learned honest specifications."

Black Saddle lay behind them under burial fires and repair lamps. Volda remained on one knee. Kharad had moved two careful lengths north, enough to settle its damaged plates without crushing the covered seed beds. Avenor waited east under Orun's accelerating pulse. Before the coalition approached a city of 41,000, Meris needed to understand what the crown plans treated as machinery.

The four of them entered the cage. Korra wore a splint from left palm to forearm. Thalen carried Senri's old notes in an oilskin case. Kivik held the counter-hammer across their knees. Meris released the first brake.

Warm darkness swallowed them.

Kharad's maintenance shaft had once carried Noll crews to the throat-nail housing. Below that work, imperial drawings turned blank. The cage descended past drilled walls into stone that had never received a tool. Mineral veins glowed dull red under translucent membranes. Each pulse tightened the shaft, narrowing it by the width of a hand, then released.

Meris counted intervals against her thumb knuckle. "Vent in two."

A deep valve opened below. Heat struck upward. The guide ropes sang. Thalen's mantle flattened against his neck while Kivik clapped a palm over their right ear.

"Brake," Meris said.

Korra drove the left lever with her right hand. Meris took the other. Teeth caught. The cage swung inside the hot current, close enough to the wall for a

membrane to brush Kivik's boot.

They did not recoil. They placed the counter-hammer head gently against the cage floor and listened through its shaft.

"Three voids," they said when the vent closed. "Separate corridors. One carries fluid east. One rises toward the seed beds. The third descends."

"Which reaches the underheart?" Thalen asked.

"The descending one reaches somewhere hotter. Name it after we survive."

At the next landing, the shaft divided around a pillar of mineral tissue. No single passage fit the cage. Meris locked it to the wall and rigged four waist lines. The eastern corridor breathed wet salt. The rising branch carried a cool pulse toward Kharad's shoulder. Heat bent the air in the descending cut.

Senri's notes described a fork marked with three crescents, but no tool marks appeared on the living walls. Thalen studied the drawing. "She may have mistaken natural folds for maintenance signs."

"Or the tissue changed in twenty-five years," Meris said.

"She wrote that the downward chamber contracted against intrusion."

Korra looked at him. "Did she write how she died?"

"No. Orinel sealed the final sheet. I spent years pretending the omission protected a patient rather than an institution."

They chose the hot corridor because its pulse led inward, not because any record promised safety.

The passage forced them into single file. Kivik went first with chalk made from shedstone powder. They marked the wall only where a gray scar showed dead surface, never across translucent tissue. Meris followed, measuring every turn. Korra came behind her. Thalen carried the rear diagnostic line.

After six hundred paces, Kharad shifted above them.

The corridor split along its floor. Meris jumped the opening. Korra caught the waist line with her right hand, but her left wrist struck the wall. Pain folded her to one knee.

"Do not use that hand," Thalen said.

"I have noticed." Korra pushed upright with her shoulder. Gray tracery showed through the splint.

A contraction closed the gap between Meris and Kivik. The wall swelled until the passage permitted no return. Behind it, Korra and Thalen vanished from sight.

Meris gripped the rope linking their waists. It ran into living stone and held without movement.

"Korra?"

Her answer came muffled. "Breathing. Find another joining."

Meris's training urged her to cut the wall, shore the opening, force a route where plans demanded one. She took out a measuring pin, then put it away. Fresh corestone glowed beneath the membrane. Any cut would wound Kharad and might trigger another contraction.

"Separate corridors," Kivik said. "We follow this one until they meet by their own shape."

"That could be kilometers."

"Then shouting will not shorten it."

Meris tied three knots in the waist rope, their agreed signal for independent continuation, and cut it at her end. Korra tugged once in acknowledgment before the severed length disappeared.

Kivik led downward. Their corridor narrowed around a flow of hot brine moving under a clear mineral skin. Small dark bodies drifted in it like seeds with folded fins. Meris first took them for debris. Then one opened along a seam and sent white root threads into the wall.

"Living channel," she whispered.

"Everything here qualifies."

Her crown drawings had reduced such passages to transfer lines. The linkage plan required three Worldbacks to drive one pulse through matching geometry. Here no geometry matched. The channel curved, branched, healed, and chose pressure around blockages. Meris had designed against variation because variation made command unreliable.

A metallic note traveled from behind them. Counter-hammer resonance returned from the corridor walls in three staggered echoes.

Kivik stopped. "Someone is driving Volda's damaged relay."

"At this distance?"

"Continuous ground. Weak signal." They set the hammer against a dead scar and rotated its tuning collar. "I can map what Kharad rejects."

"Listening only."

"Listening with an expensive piece of stolen harm."

The first test note disappeared into the brine channel. The second returned sharply enough to make Meris's teeth ache. Kivik adjusted lower. On the third, the wall answered with two slow pulses and a long absence.

Their right ear began to bleed.

Meris caught the hammer before it slipped. "Stop."

"I have the sequence."

"You have blood down your neck."

"The left ear still hears you complaining."

Kivik sat because Meris pressed them down. She packed the damaged ear with Thalen's soft diagnostic moss, careful not to seal it. "Tell me the sequence without striking again."

"Natural beat. Pause through the contraction. Counter on the command return, never on the living pulse. Three releases must answer from separate stone paths."

"Three?"

"Kharad, Volda, Orun if the crown links them first. The other six receive amplification later."

Meris saw the failure field. If one counterpulse dominated, it would become another command. Separate returns could cancel the crown while leaving the bodies distinct.

A light appeared ahead, green rather than mineral red. Thalen crawled through a side opening with Korra behind him. Dust coated them both. Korra had looped her left arm against her chest.

"Our corridor rose into a seed channel," Thalen said. "It joins here."

Kivik pointed at his case. "Did Senri know?"

Thalen opened the notes. A final diagram, stained and incomplete, showed branching cups around a broad chamber. "She recorded repeated salt crystals on tissue. Orinel classified them as contamination from maintenance crews."

Meris crouched by the brine. Its mineral content glittered under the green light. "Maintenance crews did not carry this volume."

They followed the joining current downward. The heat increased until breath hurt. Thalen painted cooling lichen onto their necks and inner wrists. Korra refused any strip over the gray tracery; she needed to see whether the mineral spread.

The corridor opened abruptly.

Kharad's underheart chamber extended beyond their lamps. It did not resemble a furnace, engine, or cavern. Great layered sacs filled the depth, some swollen with dark fluid, others collapsed around crystalline ribs. Pulse channels entered from every direction. Seed bodies clustered in protected folds above pools gone nearly dry.

Thalen descended to a salt shelf and touched a diagnostic root to its edge. Color left the root in seconds.

"Starvation," he said. "Not simple thirst. The tissue lacks a compound carried in these crystals."

Korra watched one collapsed sac contract. "Can we bring salt here?"

"Not enough. This body spans more than forty kilometers. The chamber expects replenishment on a scale only a landscape provides."

Meris opened an imperial route plate on the floor. It showed nine lines converging before the eastern basin, compressed into one military approach. "The

crown plan drives them together here.”

She placed Senri's seed-channel diagram over it. Each Worldback needed room to lower its body, expose damaged plates, circulate basin salts, and release seed-stones into different beds. The Ninefold geometry denied every requirement. Even without fortresses on their backs, nine bodies entering one commanded line would crush channels against channels.

Kivik used chalk to mark nine lengths around the chamber rim. “Separate corridors into the basin. Separate beds after arrival. No shared neck.”

“Could one arrive after another?” Korra asked.

Thalen examined the contraction intervals. “Possibly over years. I cannot derive timing from one patient. Commanding a schedule would repeat the error.”

A seed body opened in the pool below. Fine mineral threads drifted toward the salt shelf and found none. Kharad's pulse tightened around it.

Korra rested her right palm on dead shedstone. “At Harth, Kharad turned to shield these.”

“White Canopy calls a Worldback in long care a Deep Patient,” Thalen said. “Your road histories call one carrying seed a First Traveler. We spent three centuries treating those as separate questions because one name served a clinic and the other served a road. The body before us contains both.”

He watched the seed body's mineral threads search the empty shelf. “That response may preserve reproduction. We can observe protection. We cannot assign a human intention beyond it.”

Meris looked at the crown plate she had helped make. “Ivara thinks the Basin restores springs because the Worldbacks carry water east. She has the direction backward. They replenish there, then seed springs along later routes.”

“Do we know that?” Korra asked.

“We know the channels carry seed bodies outward. We know old spring records follow historical return corridors. The rest remains interpretation.”

“Then say exactly that in Avenor.”

The chamber shook under a distant pulse. Orun's interval arrived through the deep ground, faster than before. One collapsed sac flexed in sympathy. Kharad's throat-nail relay tried to answer, producing a thin command whine.

Kivik lifted the counter-hammer.

“Once,” Thalen warned.

They placed it on dead mineral and waited through Kharad's natural beat. The command return came late. Kivik struck between them.

The whine vanished. A separate pulse continued through each channel. Blood soaked the moss at their right ear, and they sagged against Meris.

“Sequence confirmed,” they said too loudly. “Hearing worsened. Record it

honestly.”

Meris wrote the injury on the back of her crown plate. “Right ear, further loss after underheart mapping. Left ear functional.”

“Good.” Kivik held out the counter-hammer. “Take it.”

She did not. “You built the sequence.”

“I can no longer hear the high return reliably. You can read Meris Tal's brace joint because you designed it. Custody transfers now, witnessed by three people and one patient.”

Korra said, “Witnessed.”

Thalen added his name.

Meris accepted the tool. Its handle carried Kivik's sweat and forge soot. The head had a hairline fracture from Black Saddle, but its tuning collar still moved. “I hold it through severance or documented transfer.”

“Do not turn it into a crown,” Kivik said.

“I won't.”

They rested before climbing. Thalen took samples only from shed crystals already detached. Korra sketched the branching routes with her right hand. Meris revised the plan around absences: no central operator, no single release line, no forced direction.

Their severance sequence required three conditions. City anchors had to release so Orun could feel open ground. Migration corridors had to remain materially clear, offering each Worldback a distinct route. Crown relays needed simultaneous counter-resonance at established brace joints, timed between natural pulses. A throat-nail could be isolated only after command ceased. Pulling one during active linkage risked tearing the living channel.

“Not another command,” Korra said.

“A removal of command,” Meris answered. “The difference depends on whether we leave choice after the crown goes silent.”

Before leaving the chamber, Thalen found a cluster of pale crystals lodged under a shed plate. He reached toward them, stopped, and asked Korra for the thin bronze mirror in her kit. With reflected light he examined the tissue without contact.

“Detached?” Meris asked.

“Three crystals lie free. Two remain connected by living filaments.”

Kivik crouched on his hearing side. “The empire would take the cluster and call the torn filaments acceptable loss.”

“White Canopy would take none, publish no finding, and preserve its monopoly on ignorance,” Thalen said. “I have practiced that form of care.”

He used wooden forceps to lift only the three loose crystals into separate clay

cups. Each cup received its exact location, temperature, and pulse interval. Korra added a route note describing how they had reached the site. Meris signed that no wall had been cut. Kivik stamped the Noll open square under the custody line.

The ceremony took fifteen minutes while Orun's distant pulses accelerated. Meris felt every minute as pressure behind her eyes.

"If we arrive late," she said, "this record will look precious in a ruined city."

"If we arrive with evidence obtained by repeating the injury, our plan has already failed," Thalen replied.

Korra closed the sample case. "We spend the time and record the cost."

On the first upward corridor, that choice paid unexpectedly. The living filaments attached to the remaining crystals brightened when Kharad contracted. Their light revealed a lateral passage absent from every drawing. Kivik tested it with a shedstone chip and found cool airflow. The route bypassed the vent that had destroyed their water barrel.

They entered one at a time. Meris took the lead now that Kivik could not hear high fractures on the right. The side passage rose across ribbed mineral plates slick with condensation. Every twenty paces, she seated a removable rope loop around a naturally shed spur. Korra climbed using her right hand and shoulder. Thalen pushed from below only when asked.

Halfway up, the spur above Meris broke free.

Her line dropped thirty centimeters. The counter-hammer swung from its harness and struck the wall. A thin command note rang through the passage. Kharad's tissue tightened around them.

"Cover the head," Kivik shouted.

Meris trapped the hammer inside her coat. Korra drove her boot into a rib and held the shared safety rope. The contraction squeezed air from Thalen's lungs and pinned his mantle against stone. Heat rose quickly.

No one struck back. Meris waited through the natural pulse, counting by pressure against her ribs. When the tissue released, she moved the hammer into its padded case and unhooked the broken spur.

"Tool custody includes preventing accidental command," she said when she could breathe.

Kivik answered from below. "Put that in your public tolerances."

The route narrowed again. They passed packs upward, then bodies. Korra reached a ledge and anchored with her right arm while Meris hauled Kivik's equipment. The uselessness of Korra's left wrist appeared in every slow transfer. Nobody called the workaround recovery.

At a cool pocket, they encountered old maintenance remains: a brass buckle, a ventilation knife, and three finger bones mineralized together. Noll guild marks on the buckle matched the Red Hollow ledger period.

Kivik sat beside the bones. "No name here."

"Could this belong to one of the forty-one?" Meris asked.

"Could. The ledger listed deaths, not retrieval." They wrapped the remains in plain cloth. "Record as unknown Noll worker until evidence says more."

Thalen wrote the location. Senri had passed this fork twenty-five years earlier; whether she had seen the worker remained beyond proof. The underheart contained no convenient testimony, only materials that narrowed lies.

They rested before climbing.

Kivik heard little on their right side by the time they reached the cage. Thalen spoke from their left and made them repeat treatment instructions. Korra's wrist had not advanced beyond its Black Saddle line, though swelling tightened the splint.

Near the upper shaft, the cage caught on a distorted guide rail. Meris could have driven a fresh spike into the wall and hauled past it. Instead, they unloaded the cage, climbed the last distance by separate ropes, and abandoned the frame where Kharad could close around it without injury.

Dawn reached them at the throat opening. Sava waited with water. Beroch stood beside an Avenor map spread across a supply crate. Six outward gates had been circled in charcoal.

"Orun pulsed eleven times in the last hour," he said. "Ivara is moving crown operators below the government quarter."

Meris laid the counter-hammer across the map. "Then we do not begin with the crown. We begin with open ground."

She marked separate corridors through North Quarry, Lichen, River, Glass, Old Grain, and Dawn Gate. Beyond the city, she drew three lines that never converged.

Behind them, Kharad's underheart beat through salt-starved chambers. Ahead, Orun carried 41,000 people and a crown designed to mistake obedience for rescue.

Meris closed her hand around the transferred hammer and set the road crews moving toward Avenor.

Part IV

Chapter 22 — The Eldest Beneath Avenor

Korra counted Avenor's outer quarry lifts by the ropes that had already snapped.

Three hung empty against the white escarpment. Two carried stonecutters upward in cages meant for blocks, not bodies. The sixth had jammed halfway between Orun's flank and North Quarry Gate, leaving nineteen people suspended over a slope that rose and fell with the eldest Worldback's waking breath.

"Lower the counterweight by hand," Korra told the quarry crew. "No fixed winch. Orun's next pulse will shear the teeth."

A foreman in an imperial red coat stared at her splinted left wrist. "That cage carries crown surveyors."

"It carries nineteen people."

"They have route priority."

"Show me a route that recognizes coats."

Another pulse traveled beneath the quarry. White walls flexed. The jammed cage dropped half a meter and stopped on its safety knots. Workers abandoned the powered drum and took the counterweight line by hand. Korra joined with her right arm, setting her boots against a shedstone curb. Forty bodies lowered the weight while the cage rose. When its floor reached the gate, two surveyors stepped out first and began demanding escorts.

The quarry workers brought the injured lift tender out before anyone answered them.

Beyond North Quarry, Avenor covered Orun's back in terraces of pale stone. Government towers crowned the central ridge. Hospitals occupied the cooler northern folds. Grain vaults formed low domes beside Old Grain Gate. Lichen roofs spread around the White Canopy estates. Far east, Dawn Gate opened toward a road too narrow for the population gathered behind it.

41,000 people lived above a waking body.

Korra carried that number on a slate copied by six witnesses. It included imperial households, quarry laborers, foreign merchants, Sarn schoolchildren, low-canopy workers, prisoners, patients, soldiers' families, and people missing from every respectable census until gate wardens added them. It did not tell her who could walk, who had carts, who needed medicine kept cool, or who would refuse to leave the only street they knew.

Meris met her beneath a cracked loading arch. "Anchor teams ready at Quarry Seven. I can release four spikes for the test."

"Crown operators?"

"None attached. Ivara pulled them into the government quarter."

"Good. We show the quarry workers before the city council."

Meris raised an eyebrow. "The council claims authority over foundation changes."

"The quarry workers know what holds the foundation."

They crossed toward the test cut while Orun's pulse lifted dust from every sill. Korra's left fingers had stiffened inside the splint during the ride from Black Saddle. Thalen had loosened the binding twice. She could grip nothing with that hand, but she kept it visible. A city asked to trust release should see its cost before hearing promises.

At Quarry Seven, Noll crews had exposed four anchor spikes around an abandoned storehouse. Each spike penetrated shed plate laid over living tissue. Unlike a throat-nail, it could not direct Orun. In linked rows, however, thousands of anchors fixed streets and towers against the motions of sleep.

Meris showed the assembly a model made from rope, clay, and four boot knives. "Pull one without slackening the neighboring foundations and the load transfers there. Release a ring in sequence, and the district floats on flexible beds."

A hospital steward named Cera Mond pushed through the listeners. "Floats where? My lower wards have three hundred patients who cannot survive a quarry road."

"Then they use Lichen Gate," Korra said.

"White Canopy sealed it."

Thalen arrived carrying a bundle of priority sheets. "White Canopy sealed it for those not listed here."

Orinel walked ten paces behind him with six mantle keepers and no ceremonial escort. Her pale lichen layers had been cut short around one temple, exposing age-darkened skin.

Thalen spread the sheets on an ore cart. Names filled the first pages by household. Crown officers. Senior canopy families. Licensed physicians. Grain factors with continuity seals. Lower pages reduced workers to quantities.

"Low-canopy drainage crews receive three hundred places," he said. "Their census holds two thousand one hundred forty people. Root owners receive all listed household members, attendants included."

A worker in green-stained gloves tore one page from the cart. "You signed these."

Orinel did not retreat. "I negotiated them before Ivara struck lower-canopy workers from even that allotment."

"So you objected when your lesser theft stopped paying."

"Yes," Orinel said. The answer quieted the cut more than denial. "I will open the

medicine stores. I do not ask you to call that restitution."

Thalen watched his former teacher without rescuing her. "Store keys transfer to elected clinic stewards. Diagnostic cultures travel through Lichen Gate under public count."

The mantle keepers looked to Orinel. After a pause, she removed a root-shaped key from her belt and placed it on the ore cart.

The worker in stained gloves took it. "My name is Ilse Vey. I hold this for the drain council until its meeting."

"Witnessed," Korra said.

Choice moved outward from the key. Low-canopy crews reopened drain tunnels beneath Lichen Gate. Hospital stewards began sorting patients by treatment need rather than rank. Quarry teams offered block sledges for beds. None of it solved the gates. It turned a sealed system into work.

The first city assembly convened in a roofless counting court. Merchants demanded protection for vault contracts. Quarry masters warned that abandoned cuts would flood. Three neighborhood speakers accused the coalition of inventing danger to seize Avenor. An imperial clerk read Ivara's broadcast promising controlled waking under the crown.

Korra let Meris explain anchor release in six sentences. On the seventh, a grain factor interrupted.

"You ask us to abandon fixed warehouses because your engineer says movement can be safe."

"I say fixed warehouses cannot remain fixed," Meris replied. "Safety depends on how many release before Orun moves."

"Regent Cend offers direction."

"She offers force through the throat."

A woman from Glass Ward raised a shardworker's bandaged hand. "If we leave, who owns our furnaces?"

"No one here can preserve every furnace," Korra said.

"Convenient for people who live in tents."

Korra felt the insult find its target. Vaun routes gave her skills for leaving. They did not make departure cheap. "My home remains on Kharad. Some of it fell. Some people chose fixed ground at Black Saddle. I cannot promise your furnace, and I will not call the loss small."

The woman held up her damaged hand. "Then what do you promise?"

"Six outward gates, not one selected road. Public counts. Shelter work for people who stay. No cavalry seizure of carts. No medical priority by title. A route you may refuse after hearing its risk."

A councilor laughed without humor. "You promise administration."

“Administration keeps a child from vanishing inside the word evacuation.”

Beroch's officers brought the Sarn school roll into the court. Names excluded by Ivara entered the public count. Parents' letters were read by Nesh Aru, who offered no argument beyond each stated request: keep siblings together, preserve one blue medicine case, tell a grandmother where her grandson went.

Resistance did not end. It became specific.

Beroch took Korra to the school quarter before returning to his gate force. The dormitory stood behind an iron garden fence, its doors open now that three teachers had broken the imperial seals. One hundred twelve Sarn children and adolescents waited in the courtyard with bedrolls arranged by household road. Their blue school coats made them look like a military unit until Korra noticed the patched cuffs, unfinished sums, and clay horses lined along a windowsill.

A girl of fourteen approached Beroch without saluting. “Commander, did our parents trade for us?”

“No,” he said.

“Did you?”

“I served the charter that placed you here. I believed its schooling clause protected you. Regent Cend removed your households from evacuation priority after I delayed her march.”

The girl absorbed this without granting him relief. “So your delay did this?”

“My service gave her the leverage. My delay exposed how she meant to use it.”

“What happens now?”

“You choose a listed gate with your teachers. Sarn riders can escort, but they do not take custody unless you consent.”

Another student called from the steps, “Our youngest sleep through alarms.”

Korra entered the dormitory. The upper room held thirty small beds and two wheeled chairs. Its only stair turned too sharply for either chair. A rear laundry chute descended toward River Ward, but iron bars crossed the outlet.

“Remove the bars,” she told the building keeper.

“Imperial child-security code.”

“Then preserve the bars on a receipt.”

Kivik's Noll crew cut the frame from surrounding mortar rather than sawing living shedstone. Vaun riggers widened the chute with a removable timber cradle. Sarn students tested cloth seats using sacks equal to the youngest children's weight. By the third trial, one student could lower another while two controlled speed below.

The fourteen-year-old watched Beroch carry the first bundle of blankets. “You could order us through Dawn Gate.”

“I could try.”

"Would we have to obey?"

"Under the corridor pact, no."

She looked at Korra. "Under the empire?"

"Yes," Korra said. "That difference matters only if enough people defend your refusal."

The students chose River Gate because several had kin among the ferry communes. Twenty-three older pupils volunteered to remain until the younger children moved. Beroch wrote the choice into the gate ledger and signed beneath the teacher, not above her.

From the school quarter, Korra went to the flex-shelter works under Central Archive. Some people could not leave Avenor before Orun rose. Others would not. Meris's crews had cut six chambers along natural joints, lining each with suspended floors and soft water bladders. A pulse could deform the walls while the inner platforms stayed level.

A prisoner named Radek inspected rope beds beside a magistrate whose court had sentenced him. Neither wore a chain. Radek had spent eleven years maintaining quarry drains; he understood moving water better than the three appointed engineers.

"This wall drains into the archive cellar," he told Korra. "When Orun lifts, the cellar becomes the low point. Your bladders float unless you vent there."

The magistrate objected. "Opening archive storage risks state records."

"Drowning six hundred people risks people," Radek said.

Korra followed the drain. Radek's reading held. She authorized a channel through the archive threshold, but required clerks to inventory every moved box so nobody could blame prisoners for later losses. The magistrate signed after two shelter residents watched him refuse twice.

One elderly glassworker chose a shelter because travel would separate her from a kiln-dependent breathing apparatus. A quarry family stayed to tend three relatives with advanced fever. Forty archive clerks volunteered for document salvage; Korra cut their request to twelve after engineers calculated air volume. Every choice entered the roll with its material need and exit path.

"People will accuse you of encouraging them to stay," Meris said while they inspected a ceiling sling.

"People accused me of forcing them out this morning."

"Both can be true if information differs by district."

"Then we publish the same load limits at every gate." Korra tested the sling with her shoulder. "No promise that these chambers cannot fail. No language calling death voluntary because someone stayed."

Meris added the sentence to her tolerance sheet.

By night, shelter wardens had a rule the crown plans lacked: each chamber retained a surface liaison who could order its doors opened without waiting for palace approval. The arrangement threatened security. It also prevented a command center from sealing 6,300 people underground for convenience, though the final shelter count remained days away.

Quarry masters agreed to release workers if pumps continued for two days. Glass Ward demanded sand wagons on the River route. The hospital required six hundred litter teams and cold lichen stores. Old Grain factors wanted receipts protecting community claims after movement. People from the prison terraces demanded inclusion without transfer into military custody. Korra assigned no answer alone. She sent each problem to the gate party whose resources touched it and required the decision returned publicly.

On Day 31, they performed the anchor test.

Quarry Seven had been cleared except for six observers, two Noll crews, Meris, and Korra. The abandoned storehouse rested on a flexible raft placed beneath its foundation beams. Four anchor heads protruded around it. Beyond the cut, hundreds watched from rope-marked distance.

Meris held the counter-hammer but did not use it. "No command signal present. We release mechanically."

Korra checked the open ground east of the quarry. Crews had removed two stone fences and laid loose gravel across a shallow cut. The path offered Orun's limb room to shift without meeting a wall.

"Route open," she said.

First spike turned one quarter. The storehouse creaked. Second spike released after the neighboring rope bed took load. Dust rose from the roof. Third came free under six workers pulling a long wooden key. With the fourth, the building settled three finger widths east.

Orun pulsed.

The sensation differed from crown resonance. No white flash crossed the rock. No operator frame answered. A slow wave rose through Quarry Seven, reached the loosened foundation, and continued into open ground. The eldest Worldback shifted one plate beneath the storehouse. Flexible beds moved with it.

Nothing collapsed.

Meris placed a diagnostic strip on the nearest worker's hand. No gray tracery appeared. Across the cut, people who had expected disaster began talking over one another.

Korra kept her eyes on the route. Orun's movement stopped at the next anchored block. The proof remained bounded.

"One free pulse," she called. "One released ring. It does not prove a whole city safe. It proves command isn't required for this step."

Observers crossed the rope only after Meris declared the ring stable. Ilse brought three low-canopy drain workers to inspect the underside. A crown surveyor who had escaped the lift lowered himself beside them and admitted his office had never modeled a free pulse. They measured the shifted beams together, obtaining a spread of less than two fingers across the storehouse length. The result went onto six copies, one posted at each gate before the next pulse arrived.

An old quarry mason pressed his cheek to the loosened curb. "No return signal," he said. "The old manuals claim a mountain waits for direction after release."

"Manuals written by people who installed the direction," Kivik replied.

The mason stood and handed his fixed-spike key to a younger worker. "Then teach me the rope beds. My hands can still hold tension."

A quarry master climbed down to inspect the raft. "Release the next store row and we can float the pump house."

"After load drawings."

"We know the loads."

"Then put your name on them."

He did.

By evening, anchor crews formed across the outer districts. Noll teams paired with local foundation workers so no outside force controlled release. Each ring required a clear route, a casualty station, a public load sheet, and two neighboring districts warned before movement. Progress slowed under the rules. Trust increased enough to keep crews at work.

Ivara answered from the government quarter by closing Glass and Dawn approaches with imperial troops.

Her broadcast bells sounded across Avenor. "Remain in assigned districts. Unauthorized anchor interference threatens every household. The crown will preserve controlled stability while lawful evacuation proceeds."

At North Quarry, people looked from the bell towers to the storehouse that had moved without injury.

Ilse Vey unlocked the White Canopy medicine vault. Workers formed a count line down the street. Orinel stood beside it recording every vial her court had withheld.

Thalen joined Korra at the gate map. "Some lower-canopy workers want to remain and protect the root beds."

"Can the beds flex?"

"Parts can. Other portions will tear when Orun rises."

"Tell them which. Then shelter crews take their requests."

"You do not intend to force them out."

"I intend to make staying a choice with engineering, not a punishment for missing a list."

They found Meris beneath the gatehouse marking six routes. North Quarry could take sledges and heavy carts. Lichen handled clinics and cold stores. River served foot traffic and ferry wagons. Glass required heatproof lanes for furnace crews. Old Grain carried food and livestock. Dawn offered the shortest eastern exit and the greatest military risk.

"Six outward gates," Meris said. "If opened together, they divide the count. If one remains closed, its neighboring routes overload within an hour."

"Who holds each?" Korra asked.

"Not us alone." Meris assigned Noll engineers to Quarry, worker clinics to Lichen, River Rauk to River, shardworkers and deserters to Glass, grain councils to Old Grain. Her finger stopped at Dawn. "Beroch wants this."

"He gets a peer objective, not the city."

"He knows."

Below the map room, a new pulse lifted the gate doors against their hinges. Orun had found the released quarry ring and pressed gently into the available space. The movement traveled under Avenor without crown light.

Then a sharper signal struck from the government quarter. White resonance ran along central streets. Operators had begun linking the crown.

Korra's left wrist ached in answer. She tucked the splinted arm against her ribs and used her right hand to turn every route marker outward.

"Open teams begin before dawn," she said. "Anyone who waits for the crown will wake inside its choice."

Across Avenor, quarry hammers took up the work of release, one witnessed anchor at a time.

Chapter 23 — Every Gate Opens Outward

Beroch broke North Quarry Gate's imperial lock with the butt of a cavalry lance and handed the splintered seal to its keeper.

"Record who broke it," he said.

The keeper stared at the blue clay on his tusks, then at two hundred Sarn riders filling the quarry road. "Under whose authority?"

"Mine, for the damage. The quarry council's, for the gate."

Stone rose under their boots. Orun's pulse pulled the gate towers apart by a finger width and let them settle. Beyond the doors, the road descended through switchbacks broad enough for block sledges. Inside, six thousand people waited among carts, litters, animals, and bundles marked for three different exits.

An imperial captain held the inner stair with eighty soldiers. "Commander Sarn, Regent Cend orders all traffic to Dawn Gate."

Beroch showed him Ivara's exclusion order. "She also ordered children out of the count. Which command do you ask me to honor?"

The captain's face tightened. "I ask you to preserve the city."

"Then open its road."

No charge followed. Quarry workers climbed the walls through lift shafts they had built, reached the capstans, and released both bars from above. The soldiers found themselves defending an open space. Twenty-seven joined the gate wardens. The captain withdrew toward the government quarter with the rest.

Beroch did not pursue. Dawn Gate still lay closed. Lichen crews reported resistance. Every mounted fighter spent hunting the captain would leave a civilian lane thinner.

"First sledges out," he ordered. "Cavalry rides beside the route, never through it."

The quarry council corrected him. "Heavy pumps first. Sledges carrying households follow."

Beroch inclined his head. "Your route."

North Quarry began to empty.

His peer force operated through six sets of signals. White flags showed an open gate. Red marked obstruction. Black requested military support. Green called medical need. No color gave Beroch command over another party. He had spent thirty years reducing uncertainty through rank. Now each report required consent, explanation, and the chance that someone would refuse him.

At Lichen Gate, refusal had bodies behind it.

White Canopy guards barred the arch while low-canopy workers packed the

street. Ilse Vey stood on a medicine cart holding the store key. Orinel faced her own household guard from outside their line.

"By mantle inheritance, these cultures remain court property," the guard captain said.

Orinel removed the silver clasp of her office. "By my recorded custody, I supplied cultures that concealed injury. Property claims enter the hearing. People leave now."

The captain looked past her to Beroch. "Will Sarn enforce an Ilaith internal order?"

"No."

"Then why are you here?"

"Because your closed gate blocks clinic litters whose patients did not choose your inheritance."

Ilse raised the root key. Drain workers opened three under-gate sluices. Noll crews crawled through and loosened the bar housing from below. White Canopy guards could hold the arch or prevent the mechanism from leaving the wall, not both. They chose the arch.

Orinel walked alone to their line. "Anyone who stands aside remains a witness in later Ilaith proceedings. Anyone who strikes a patient answers by name."

Four guards lowered spears. Two more followed. The captain kept his upright until the bar dropped behind him, then stepped away without surrendering it.

Lichen Gate opened onto a shaded road lined with wet cloth. Hospital litters moved first, followed by cold-store carts and low-canopy households. Orinel joined a carrying team. Nobody returned her clasp.

River Gate sent white before noon. Fara Den's ferry wagons passed through in paired lines, carrying the Sarn students and prison-terrace families under separate custody rolls. The fourteen-year-old who had questioned Beroch rode on a wagon step beside her teacher. She saw him and held up the blue medicine case named in a parent's letter.

Beroch touched two fingers to his tusk clay. She did not salute. The gesture felt more honest returned unfinished.

River Gate's apparent success concealed a jam beyond the arch. Ferry wagons had met hospital carts on a road narrowed by a fallen customs house. Two route authorities each held written priority. Neither could reverse without backing thousands of people into the city.

Beroch arrived to find riders trying to clear the center by command. "Sarn off the road," he said.

His lieutenant frowned. "We can pull the rubble in ten minutes."

"Your horses occupy the space needed to turn the capstan. Off."

Fara Den climbed onto the customs ruin with a sounding pole. Ilse's clinic wardens held their litter line. The dispute sharpened around a cold-store wagon whose lichen would spoil in direct sun.

"River traffic has the posted slot," Fara said.

"Those cultures treat four gates," Ilse replied. "Spoil them and your route loses medicine by night."

Beroch could have chosen. His rank expected that habit so strongly his body leaned toward the decision. Instead, he asked, "How long can the cultures hold?"

"Twenty-two minutes under wet cover."

"How far to the next shade?"

"Seventy paces."

Fara measured the road with her pole. "We move six ferry wagons into the drainage court. Litters pass to the shade. Then our empty carts take hospital stores while the full wagons regain the lane."

A prison-terrace speaker objected from the fourth cart. "The drainage court has one gate. We will not enter another enclosure under guard."

"Then your wagon remains on the outer edge with its team facing out," Fara said. "Five turn."

The maneuver used nineteen minutes. Patients reached shade. No prisoner passed beneath a locked arch. Ferry cargo traveled on a mixed train with public custody marks. Beroch's cavalry contributed only rope and two teams after route wardens requested them.

At the end, his lieutenant said, "One command would have been faster."

"One command would have chosen what to forget."

"Battles do not wait for councils."

"Neither do consequences." Beroch sent him to inspect the shelter liaison routes, a task requiring more judgment than obedience.

A second obstruction formed near the riverside school transfer. Three teachers discovered eleven names absent from the duplicate roll. The missing students had worked night shift in an imperial laundry and slept in a separate attic. Their dormitory group had already passed the gate.

Beroch closed one ferry wagon to cargo and sent it back with the fourteen-year-old pupil, two teachers, and a River witness. Imperial sentries at the laundry refused entry until the pupil threw Ivara's exclusion copy through their window. Workers inside opened the attic stair. Eleven students emerged carrying wet uniforms and no packs.

The recovery delayed a hundred wagons. Nobody proposed leaving the students as an acceptable discrepancy once their names had been spoken publicly.

Near noon, Orun shifted at the released quarry ring. River road tilted toward the

bank. A cart wheel broke. One horse went down between shafts, pulling the cart sideways across a litter line. Beroch dismounted, cut the traces, and helped six workers roll the load off the animal. The horse's foreleg had snapped high. Its driver put it down after clearing the road, then sat beside the harness until another person took the reins.

No song would preserve that cost. The gate ledger did: one horse killed, one medicine cart damaged, no patients lost, traffic delayed thirteen minutes. Material truth resisted triumph as stubbornly as grief.

Glass Gate remained red.

A crown artillery company had placed two light engines across its approach. Behind them, furnace families waited with heatproof wagons. Shutting the kilns too quickly could crack vessels of caustic dye and send poison through the ward. Shardworkers needed three hours. Ivvara's commander gave them one if they moved to Dawn Gate.

Beroch met Meris in a tile yard overlooking the barricade. "I can take the engines."

"At what cost?"

"Perhaps forty fighters. More if they fire into the glass roofs."

Meris measured the gatehouse lean. "The artillery platforms share an anchor ring. Release the south pair and Orun's next pulse tilts both engines away from the street."

"Can you time it?"

"No. Quarry workers can release. Orun chooses when to shift."

Beroch sent the proposal to the shardworkers. Their answer returned with conditions: no explosive shot near the dye vaults, furnace crews control the shutdown, captured artillery horses transfer to evacuation use, and imperial gunners receive a surrender lane.

"Accepted for Sarn," Beroch said. River Rauk and Vaun delegates added their marks.

Quarry workers turned the first anchor. Meris released the second mechanically, keeping the counter-hammer cased. The gun commander saw the platform settle and ordered fire before the tilt worsened.

His first stone crossed high. The second struck a glass roof. Colored panes fell into the yard, cutting six people. Beroch's riders advanced behind quarry sledges covered in wet hides. They did not charge the narrow street. Sappers reached the platform base as Orun pulsed.

The released ring moved. Both engines leaned south. One threw its loaded stone into an empty wall. The other lost a wheel. Imperial gunners abandoned the braces and found the surrender lane marked in white lime.

Glass Gate opened after two hours and forty minutes. Shardworkers shut the

last dye vessel themselves. Their wagons joined a western road carrying furnaces small enough to rebuild and receipts for those left behind.

Old Grain presented no battle. Its factors had locked the vaults and demanded crown guarantees against confiscation. Jori Pell arrived with Split River bakers and six blank ledgers.

"Community grain travels by measured allotment," she told them. "Private claims get copied. Nobody eats a seal."

A factor named Hollis barred the scale room. "These stores secure debts across Cendar."

Beroch dismounted outside. "Then carry the debt books if someone has room."

"You cannot void law with cavalry."

"I am not voiding it. I am declining to guard grain while people wait behind a closed gate."

The workers inside opened a side hatch. Sack by sack, they passed food to communal wagons. Hollis kept the scale room locked until his own clerks left through the hatch. At last he emerged with one iron cashbox, saw no rider waiting to seize it, and gave Jori the vault key.

Old Grain's doors swung outward before sunset.

Five gates showed white. Dawn remained red beneath the government ridge.

Ivara had concentrated loyal troops there, turning the shortest eastern road into a funnel. Thirty thousand people already outside Avenor spread across quarry camps, river flats, orchard terraces, and grain fields. Thousands remained inside. Flex-shelter wardens reported their chambers filling by informed choice or necessity. The count changed each hour, but it changed on copied slates.

Beroch assembled the military delegates under a broken aqueduct. Korra attended for Vaun route crews. Fara represented River. Ilse spoke for Lichen wardens. Meris held engineering custody. Noll, Split River, and Cinder witnesses completed the circle.

"We can encircle Dawn," Beroch said. "Ivara has two thousand troops in the approaches. A direct assault closes the civilian road during fighting."

Korra pointed to an old grain drain beneath the southern wall. "Open the gate from inside. No army through the drain. Twelve people."

"Who commands them?"

"Each other. Vaun supplies two riggers. Noll supplies four sappers. Sarn can send guides who know imperial calls. Gate workers choose the rest."

Beroch wanted a captain he could punish if they failed. Instead, he sent two Sarn soldiers who had family among the excluded pupils and made their authority expire at the inner bar.

The team entered after dark.

While they crawled, Beroch staged cavalry on the north approach to draw imperial attention. He displayed his old field standard but no imperial banner. Crown officers recognized it and sent an envoy.

"Regent Cend offers you emergency governorship of Avenor," the envoy said. "Open one gate under controlled schedule, restore the Sarn children's priority, and place frontier forces under city law."

Beroch read the offer twice. Governorship would give him the pasture guarantees he had sought, schools no regent could revoke, and a capital army capable of crushing rival claims. It would also turn the corridor pact into a temporary ladder beneath his feet.

"Where is the crown key?" he asked.

"With the regent."

"Then your offer controls nothing she cannot withdraw."

"The throne endures beyond one regent."

"So does the road where your throne buries people." Beroch folded the paper and gave it back. "Tell Ivara I will meet her as Sarn commander, not her replacement."

The envoy looked almost disappointed. "You choose seven disputing parties over a city."

"I choose not to own their disagreement."

A white lamp appeared inside Dawn Gate.

The infiltration team had reached the bar. Imperial troops saw the signal and turned inward. Beroch advanced his cavalry just far enough to hold them between threats, then halted outside bow range. River slingers struck tower lamps. Vaun crews dragged mobile shields toward the arch. Nobody entered the civilian lane.

The first bar rose one handspan. A defender cut its rope. Noll sappers caught it on a counterweight. Gate workers turned the western capstan while Sarn guides called false maintenance alarms through the inner court.

Orun pulsed beneath them.

Dawn Gate's fixed hinges twisted. Meris's released anchor strip allowed the left tower to settle outward. The doors opened unevenly, one scraping stone, the other swinging free.

Civilians came through before fighters went in.

Avenor residents filled the road carrying packs, children, account books, caged birds, sacred roots, broken tools, and nothing. Beroch's riders faced outward toward imperial troops. When a loyal company tried to close the gap, Glass Ward deserters blocked them with the disabled artillery horses and surrendered gun carriages.

By dawn on Day 35, all six gates stood open.

Opening did not finish the work. Beroch spent the morning riding against the flow, checking that every door remained outward when fear encouraged wardens to narrow passage. At North Quarry, a rumor of imperial cavalry sent a gate crew reaching for the bar. He made them post scouts instead. At Lichen, medicine thieves cut a cart loose; low-canopy workers caught them and recovered every sealed case without closing the arch. Old Grain lost a wagon on a steep turn and rebuilt its axle in the road while people passed on both sides.

Dawn Gate carried the most dangerous crowding. Families who had waited for crown instructions arrived beside government clerks fleeing those same offices. One clerk demanded protection for a copper archive chest.

"What does it contain?" Beroch asked.

"Land grants, tax succession, hereditary office records."

"How many carriers?"

"Eight."

Beroch pointed to a shelter wagon missing four hands. "You may carry the chest after that wagon clears the slope. Your eight become its team until then."

The clerk protested that records would be lost. A prison-terrace woman beside him laughed. "Some of us might survive long enough to dispute them."

He joined the wagon. The chest waited under a witnessed tarp and reached the outer camp later, its ownership unresolved rather than erased.

Shelter liaisons sent their last admission rolls near midday. Beroch visited Central Archive to confirm that staying had not become quiet abandonment. Flex floors hung level over the opened drain. Radek, the prisoner engineer, demonstrated the release valves to three surface messengers. The magistrate recorded his instruction under Radek's name.

"You could leave now," Beroch told him.

"I could," Radek said. "My sister refuses to move our father. I know these drains. So I stay until the first step, then decide again."

"Your sentence?"

"Can wait for a court that has a floor."

Beroch assigned no guard. The shelter council retained custody and emergency release. Such arrangements would trouble every law officer left in Cendar. Orun moved before law could make itself comfortable.

Counting required another full day. Gate ledgers came to the aqueduct in bundles. Nesh and forty clerks compared duplicate marks, removed people counted at transfers, and added shelter admissions. No estimate entered the final slate without two route witnesses.

34,700 had evacuated through North Quarry, Lichen, River, Glass, Old Grain, and Dawn Gate.

Another 6,300 remained in flex shelters. Some could not travel. Some tended patients or water systems. Some refused exile from Avenor after receiving structural risk reports. Their chambers had food, air lines, independent liaisons, and routes to the surface where terrain allowed.

Together, the numbers accounted for 41,000.

Beroch read the slate aloud beside Dawn Gate. He did not call the operation bloodless. Twenty-three people had died during gate fighting and structural failures. Those deaths received a separate ledger, never hidden inside the evacuation arithmetic.

A messenger arrived from the government quarter carrying news that Ivara had withdrawn to Orun's crown gallery. She still held the crown key. White command light now crossed the central ridge at every third pulse.

Korra found Beroch looking up at the emptied throne tower. "You could take it," she said.

"I was offered it."

"Tempted?"

"Yes." His honesty surprised neither of them. "A Sarn ruler in Avenor could enforce the charter."

"Until the road changes under the paper."

"Or until the ruler decides exact terms obstruct necessity." He mounted and tightened his clean tack. "The crown key matters. The throne does not."

He assigned peer forces to hold every outward gate and turned his own riders toward the government ridge. Behind him, Dawn Gate remained open to civilians. Ahead, Ivara carried the only object capable of linking Orun's throat to all nine.

Beroch rode past the vacant palace steps without placing one boot on them.

Chapter 24 — The Capital Marches

Ivara hooked both arms through the crown-gallery rail as Orun lifted the government quarter.

The first rise came without the clean vertical force promised by Meris Tal's old calculations. Floor slabs shoved east. The operator benches slid west on their anchor bolts, dragging six harnessed bodies until leather cut their shoulders. Across the gallery, the imperial map split through Avenor and dropped its western half into the relay trench.

"Loose the bench locks," Ivara ordered. "Let them travel with the floor."

Deputy Peor struck the release lever with a wrapped fist. Five benches rolled on their runners. The sixth caught against a warped stop, pitching its operator forward. Blood sprang from his bitten tongue. Two attendants pulled him upright while the white command light beneath his palms brightened.

Above them, masonry tore loose from the evacuated ministries. Ivara watched a council dome descend past the gallery windows in sections, blue tiles turning through smoke. No clerks occupied those offices now. No petitioners stood beneath the painted vault. The arithmetic of the gates had bought her that absence: 34,700 beyond the walls, 6,300 sheltered in chambers built to flex. It had also left the heart of government empty enough to become a machine room.

Orun rose again.

The gallery's copper crown hung from twelve gimbals around a fresh-corestone hub. Nine radial plates waited under shuttered lamps. Three carried active lines: Volda pulsed unevenly from the west, Kharad answered from farther north, while Orun hammered beneath Ivara's boots. Six dim plates bore the old names Esseth, Morra, Galn, Tirava, Osk, and Bel.

Yana Peor checked the operators one by one. Gray tracery had passed the knuckles on four hands. A fifth operator could no longer straighten two fingers. White Canopy lichen lay around their wrists in damp green bands, dulling pain without stopping the cold advance beneath the skin.

"Load remains beyond field tolerance," Yana said.

"We need one complete pulse."

"One may take their hands."

Ivara looked through the south windows. Dawn Gate stood open below the ridge, its twisted leaves braced outward with quarry beams. Beyond it, six roads spread through camps and fields toward the pale eastern basin. A city could move through those roads if someone held a schedule against panic. A continent required more.

"Ask them," she said.

Yana's mouth hardened. "You have already ordered it."

“Ask them by name.”

Each operator heard the stated exposure: loss of movement, circulation failure, possible death if resonance reached the chest. Three withdrew. One tried to rise and found his knees would not obey him. Attendants carried all four toward the western service stair. Five remained, including Yana.

Ivara entered the vacant sixth station herself.

The harness smelled of old sweat and medicinal rot. She set the crown key into the brass throat of the hub but did not turn it. Beside her left hand, a narrow slate held the manual command plate, a field duplicate cut from the full array. It could drive one simple direction through a live crown. It could not coordinate nine responses. For that, she needed the gallery.

“Natural interval,” Yana called.

Everyone placed bare skin against the shedstone contacts. Listening pressure climbed through Ivara's palms: pulse, mass, fractures opening under foundations, motion leaning toward ground beyond the eastern wall. No words waited in the stone. Orun's next contraction arrived as a force too immense to comprehend beyond its immediate effects. The gallery lifted a handspan and dropped crooked.

Ivara turned the crown key.

White light crossed the three live plates. Volda's line returned first, ragged after the damage at Black Saddle. Kharad produced a broader beat that refused the imposed frequency, slipping around it like weight finding a weaker floor. Orun struck last. Their combined return entered the crown hub and drove outward along the buried throat-nail network.

“Ninefold pulse,” Ivara said. “Send.”

Yana brought down the relay lever.

Resonance hit Ivara from fingers to jaw. Her damaged left ear filled with the pressure of Lorn collapsing, though the gallery carried no such sound. She held contact while the hub forced the three pulses into one narrow beat. Copper threads glowed. Fresh corestone darkened as if bruising.

The first distant lamp opened over Esseth.

Its return barely moved the gauge, a long dormant pressure broken by a new contraction. Morra answered with two short shifts. Galn's plate warmed slowly enough that Ivara thought the buried relay had failed, then its needle crossed the waking mark. Tirava returned through a fractured line. Osk shook dust from the ceiling. Bel arrived last in a deep lateral movement that knocked an attendant against the trench rail.

Nine lamps burned around the crown.

All nine had begun to wake.

Relief came to Ivara as a reduction in unknowns. Fixed sleep had ended before dead springs ended cities. Every Worldback now possessed a measurable interval.

Surveyors could mark pace. Roads could clear. Water might return west before Pellin emptied its final cistern.

Then the operator to her right screamed.

Stone creep crossed his wrist in a visible gray branching. His fingers clenched against the contact and stayed there. An attendant cut the straps, but mineralized joints held his palm flat. Yana used a wooden wedge to pry him loose. Skin remained on the warm shedstone.

"Close his line," Ivara said.

"They share load now," Yana replied. Sweat ran into the lichen at her temple. "Close one under return and it tears through the other stations."

Orun drove a shoulder or flank against the released foundation rings. Avenor's ridge changed pitch. The open Dawn Gate moved several paces east, towers walking on the back of the eldest creature beneath them. Beyond the walls, route flags snapped as wardens redirected traffic away from a quarry seam.

Ivara saw choice in none of it. She saw force without liability, power that could crush a shelter and never stand before names. Her operators had names. Their consent sheets had witnesses. The dead at Lorn had possessed neither.

"Hold through the broadcast," she said.

The public horns came alive from every gate tower still connected to crown wire. Ivara had written the address during the evacuation, cutting six pages to one. Now her own voice traveled through the shifting capital and outward to the camps.

"Citizens of Cendar and the frontier corridors, the age of fixed mountains has ended. Six western springs approach failure. Three carried cities have already moved. Today the crown has woken every Founding Mountain under one measured sequence. The Ninefold March will guide them toward replenishment while keeping their routes apart. Avenor moves east under control. Remain on posted roads. Obey local evacuation marks. This action preserves the cities that can be preserved."

She avoided promises that all would survive. Only frauds promised that.

At the fifth horn tower, her voice broke beneath another sound: operators crying out as Orun resisted the directional plate. The crown demanded east by the imperial road. The body below leaned southeast toward a salt trace passing under the river flats. Conflicting force twisted the relay trench. One copper thread snapped and lashed sparks across the gallery.

The public wire carried Yana shouting for wet cloth. It carried the trapped operator begging someone to cut off his hand. Ivara reached for the horn switch, then stopped. Concealment would not restore control. Let the camps hear its price and judge whether dead springs offered a gentler choice.

"Direction plate again," she ordered.

Yana stared at her. "The southeast ground already leads toward Dawn Basin."

"It leads through the River camps."

"Their wardens can clear it."

"In how many minutes?"

Nobody answered. Orun accelerated below one minute between pulses.

Ivara turned the east command ring. The contact chilled her right hand. Pressure crossed both arms, sharp enough to lock breath beneath her ribs, and the crown pressed a simple order through the throat-nail: east.

Orun's reply cracked every remaining ministry window.

The eldritch scale of the motion offered no grandeur from inside it. Benches struck stops. Lamps burst. A falling beam killed an attendant before he could turn his head. Yet the ground outside changed direction. Dawn Gate aligned with the prepared eastern avenue. The nearest River camp gained time to break its kitchens and move south.

"There," Ivara said through numb lips. "That spared them."

Yana pulled off her gloves. Gray had reached the base of her fingers. "For this pulse."

Boots sounded on the upper service bridge.

Ivara's loyal guard formed between the crown and the gallery doors. Thirty remained from the government companies, most with plaster whitening their armor. Their captain reported Sarn riders inside the outer works. Vaun riggers climbed the collapsed north arcade. Beroch had not attacked through Dawn Gate; he had approached along the empty palace terraces, keeping his force out of the civilian road.

Orinel Thyr entered from the clinic stair before the guards sealed it.

The White Canopy speaker no longer wore her silver clasp. Torn working cloth covered her mantle, and dried blood marked one sleeve. Six Ilaith cultivators followed with medicine frames on their backs.

"Your operators need withdrawal," Orinel said.

"They need two more direction pulses."

"Four cannot receive one." She went to the man pinned by his own hand. "This lichen conceals symptoms. It does not interrupt mineralization."

"You sold it to me as operator support."

"I sold pain because it bought White Canopy passage. Call the act what it purchased." Orinel cut the green band from the man's wrist. Blackened root threads clung beneath it. "No cultivator under my remaining authority will maintain these stations."

"Your authority did not survive Lichen Gate."

"Then regard this as six individual refusals."

One by one, the cultivators named themselves and stepped away from the medicine benches. Yana ordered attendants to begin releasing operator harnesses. Ivara countermanded her. Two attendants obeyed Yana anyway.

The gallery lost more than medicine. White Canopy frames had damped reflected resonance between stations. As cultivators lifted them, the crown whine sharpened. A crack traveled through the eastern gimbal.

Ivara drew the manual plate from its slate and buckled it beneath her coat.

"You planned an escape," Orinel said.

"I planned redundancy."

"For yourself."

"For the command."

A ram struck the upper doors. The loyal guards leveled spears as the bronze hinges bowed inward. Beroch's voice carried through the gap.

"Ivara Cend. Open the gallery. We take the crown key into witnessed custody."

She signaled the guard captain to hold. "On whose sovereign authority?"

"Sarn authority reaches my riders. The corridor pact reaches its signatories. Your key reaches into living throats none of us owns."

"Your charter reached into imperial schools when you wanted our walls around Sarn children."

Silence followed. Ivara knew she had struck accurately. Beroch had used the empire until its terms cut him, as every frontier lord did.

His answer came quieter. "Ninety-five pupils and apprentices came out through River Gate under their teachers. They carried the exclusion order you signed. I served you after Volda broke our burial roads because I believed exact words restrained power. You taught me whose children disappear when words become inconvenient."

"They did not disappear. They left alive."

"Because people you called disordered opened six roads."

The ram struck again.

Orun pulsed at the same instant. The cracked eastern gimbal tore free. Half the crown dropped toward the operator trench, held by one copper bundle. Ivara threw herself against the key housing as the floor pitched. Guards, cultivators, and attendants slid together. The upper doors burst inward over two fallen soldiers.

Beroch crossed the threshold behind a shedstone shield. He wore no imperial mantle. Blue clay remained on his tusks, chipped from the gate fighting. His riders spread only far enough to contain the guards and leave the clinic stair open.

Ivara drew her short sword. "Take the crown offline and you lose the waking sequence."

"Meris says the key can hold release until the field joints stand ready."

"Meris designed the failure now hanging above you."

"She admits it." Beroch stepped around a broken bench. "That places her one admission ahead."

The crown bundle began to part strand by strand. If it broke under load, all nine returns would recoil into their throat-nails. Ivara dropped the sword and seized the key with both hands. Beroch reached the housing from the other side.

"Quarter turn left," she said. "Hold at the black score."

He looked once at Yana. The engineer nodded.

Together they turned. Resistance climbed until Ivara's shoulders shook. The linked lamps narrowed from white to amber. The hanging crown section went dark, but the remaining plates kept a low return. No waking body received a fresh direction. No line tore.

The floor split between them.

Beroch's boots found the broader slab. Ivara fell against the housing, losing her right-hand grip. He rotated the key through the final finger width and pulled it free.

"Crown key in Sarn custody," he called. "Witnessed by Peor, Thyr, and every person still breathing here."

Ivara snatched up her sword with her left hand. The loyal captain drove between them with six guards, making a wall of bodies around her.

"West clinic stair is cut," he said. "East roof descent remains."

Beroch did not order his riders to rush. Wounded operators lay across the direct line, and he would not trample them for speed. Ivara used that restraint. Her guards pushed through a map-room door as Sarn fighters lowered weapons to lift a broken bench from an Ilaith cultivator.

The eastern roof had become a sloping field of copper tiles. Ivara descended by a maintenance cable with twelve loyal soldiers. Behind them, the regency tower folded at its center and carried the gallery out of sight. She did not know whether Beroch survived the fall. She knew the crown key remained behind.

At the lower carriage court, field horses waited beside three supply wagons. The captain asked whether they should ride north and recover troops from Glass Ward.

"East," Ivara said.

"Dawn Gate belongs to Sarn."

"Then use the aqueduct breach."

Her manual command plate pressed cold against her ribs. It lacked the reach to wake distant bodies, yet Orun's throat-nail remained live. Field relays waited along the basin ridge. A single direction, applied at the right ground, could still keep three approaching giants from crushing one another. Without the key, she could not coordinate the full array. She would work with the authority left in her hands.

The aqueduct court had split into three terraces. Soldiers led the horses down by halters while masons lowered wagon wheels on ropes. Ivara took the rear of the first descent because a regent who demanded haste could at least occupy its most exposed place. Orun's next step raised the broken water channel behind them. A thousand-year arch leaned, paused, and fell across the route they had just cleared.

At the wall breach they met people traveling in the opposite direction. Twenty shelter liaisons climbed toward Avenor with water skins, splints, lamp oil, and copied lists of those who remained below. A gray-haired woman in a quarry coat recognized Ivara and stopped so abruptly that the carrier behind her struck her pack.

"Our north air shaft closed," the woman said. "Your troops took the lifting mules."

The loyal captain reached for her shoulder. Ivara waved him back.

"How much can your teams carry?"

"Not six cast-iron blowers."

Two supply wagons held gallery tools and officer tents. Ivara ordered both emptied. The soldiers left the tents in the rubble and stacked delicate gauges beside them. Shelter workers turned the wagons uphill. Four of Ivara's horses went with the blower teams.

"Write the transfer," Ivara told the captain.

The quarry woman gave a bitter laugh. "Will the receipt breathe for us?"

"No. It will stop the next officer calling you a thief."

That answer did not earn thanks. It made the woman take the slate, sign her name, and hurry toward the moving city. Ivara watched the wagons climb until dust hid them. The exchange reduced her provisions and left her column slower. It might keep one flex shelter alive. Decisions still mattered after their author lost the key.

Outside the walls, her broadcast repeated from a cracked horn on the Dawn road. The recorded voice promised measured sequence while the ridge heaved beneath listeners' feet. Evacuees paused in their work to stare at her passing column. Some spat. Others asked soldiers whether their ward would return with Orun. Nobody cheered the waking of Esseth or Morra. Distant survival could not compete with a roof vanishing over the wall.

Near an abandoned way station, Ivara saw three routes diverge around a salt marsh. Each carried separate flags. River carts followed blue poles along firm ground. Lichen clinics used the shaded southern bank. Quarry families hauled pumps on a longer northern grade. No mounted overseer combined them. Wardens traded crossing times at one narrow culvert and separated again.

The arrangement appeared wasteful. It also continued after Orun's step destroyed the central road.

Ivara wanted to call that luck. The route crews rebuilt before the word settled.

They rode through a rent in the eastern wall while Orun carried Avenor after them. Flex shelters moved below the ruined streets. Dawn Gate marched on the eldest Worldback's forward slope, open doors lashed wide as its towers swayed. Far to the northwest, Kharad approached beneath a weather front. Volda advanced more slowly from the west, damaged and uneven. The other six answered only through long tremors beneath distant country.

By nightfall on Day 37, the capital had cleared its old foundations. Empty palaces, shelter chambers, broken quarries, and the open gate traveled together toward Dawn Basin.

Ivara did not look back for a throne. She rode ahead to recover command.

Chapter 25 — What Thalen Cut from His Own Flesh

Thalen pressed a wooden spoon between Yana Peor's teeth before the spasm could break them.

Her shoulders lifted from the clinic table. Gray mineral tracery climbed both wrists and disappeared beneath sleeves wet from the crown gallery. Two Green Mantle workers held her elbows without forcing the joints. Each command pulse from Orun tightened her hands. Between pulses, the fingers loosened by less than a grain's width.

"Do not straighten them," Thalen told the workers. "Pad the shape she has."

Yana bit the spoon until the wood creaked. "The return line still carries."

"You no longer carry it."

"My hands disagree."

Thalen cut away the lichen bands wrapped around her forearms. Black roots had grown into the moist dressing from below, fed by resonance while she remained against the crown contact. The cultures had hidden pain long enough for mineralization to cross two joints. He dropped them into a glazed isolation bowl and covered it with sand.

Orun stepped. Every water cup in the field clinic jumped east. The hide walls strained against their ropes. Outside, carriers shouted as a litter slid down the newly tilted ground.

Forty-three patients occupied a shelter built for twelve. Former crown operators lay nearest the open side, where nobody would mistake clean air for a cure. Civilians from the aqueduct breach filled the center: broken ankles, stone cuts, smoke lungs. At the rear, Sarn riders and imperial deserters shared a row because neither had yielded custody of weapons. Thalen's clinical markers granted no faction better blood.

"Pulse interval, forty-seven breaths," called Ilse Vey from the door.

"Write it beside Yana's spasm."

He eased the spoon from the engineer's mouth. A red groove marked her lower lip. "Sensation?"

"Cold. Pressure. No pain."

"The absence of pain comes from the culture, not improvement."

Thalen made Ilse record that too. He had spent twenty-two years teaching institutions how to transform missing pain into evidence of health. In this clinic, every silence required a cause.

Orinel arrived carrying six propagation frames from the ruined gallery. Her mantle had dried to ash green around the edges. She set the frames beside Thalen without asking where a former White Canopy speaker belonged.

"These strains remain viable," she said. "The indigo cups damp command shock. Amber root slows vascular closure."

Thalen lifted one frame toward the light. "Indigo also masks spread."

"Label it. Use it with consent."

"On patients whose hands cannot hold a consent mark?"

"Witness speech."

Yana turned her head. "No indigo."

Orinel knelt beside her. "Without it, the next pulse may dislocate your shoulders."

"Then bind my shoulders. I want to know whether the creep reaches my elbows."

Thalen met Orinel's eyes. "There is your answer."

Not every operator refused. Two chose pain masking after hearing that it changed sensation but not progression. Their choices received two witnesses and a time limit. Three accepted amber cultures only. One asked for sleep tincture after dictating a message to his husband. Treatment continued without pretending one honest rule produced one honest preference.

Near sunset, a messenger brought a contact strip from the forward relay camp. Purple diagnostic lichen covered one end. Its color had faded along a narrow branching pattern.

"Meris wants to know whether the field line still joins Orun's crown," he said.

Thalen held his hand above the strip. "Was this detached before collection?"

"The relay crew cut the copper."

"Copper does not carry the living branch alone. Did anyone test the stone path?"

The messenger glanced toward the sealed bowl. "They heard a pulse after cutting."

"Listening?"

"A command return. One worker's fingertips grayed."

Thalen ordered the strip isolated. He should have sent a diagnostic crew with dry tools. Instead, field reports placed Ivara half a day ahead, and every delay let her manual plate reach another relay. The coalition needed to distinguish active paths from dead copper before the battle lines closed.

He prepared a contact table outside the clinic. A shedstone slab rested on wooden trestles, separated from Orun's carried stone by hide pads. Ilse arranged clean amber culture along its edge. Thalen used bone forceps to lift one purple root from the captured strip.

"No skin contact," Orinel said.

"I know."

The root stretched farther than expected. Its underside had grown through a crack in the strip and caught around the forceps hinge. When Thalen twisted to free it, Orun pulsed.

White force flashed through the root.

The bone forceps split. A wet filament struck the lichen mantle at Thalen's left wrist and adhered before he could shake it loose. Cold traveled under his symbiotic growth, racing toward the shoulder along cultivated channels meant to carry medicine through his body.

Ilse cut the filament with a glass blade. Orinel tore the contaminated cuff away. Neither action stopped the gray-green darkening that had already crossed Thalen's forearm.

"Isolation cloth," he said.

His own voice sounded far away. Tinnitus tightened around one high note. Listening fatigue he knew. This brought no impression of fracture or motion. The active command return had entered living culture and now followed the same mantle roots that sustained his long dormancy.

Orinel wrapped his arm above the elbow. "We can flood the mantle with indigo."

"It will hide the border."

"It may slow contraction."

"May?"

She did not answer.

Thalen watched color change beneath his skin. Healthy mantle held layered greens: pale tips, blue-shadowed cups, brown anchoring threads. The infected channel flattened those distinctions into metallic gray. It reached his left shoulder while they watched. A second branch climbed his neck toward the scalp bed.

He knew the anatomy too well to bargain with it. The mantle joined his circulation at thousands of hair-thin grafts. Once the resonance crossed the crown of his scalp, it could enter the right side, then the deep dormant tissues around heart and lungs. No medicine reversed stone creep. Removing contaminated lichen could reduce transmission only while a clean boundary remained.

"Prepare the cutting frame," he said.

Ilse stared at him. "How much?"

"Left mantle. Wrist to scalp, including the shoulder bed."

Orinel gripped the table. "That is forty years of growth."

"One hundred thirteen."

"Your present mantle began after juvenile shedding."

"My body began before your accounting." Thalen traced the advancing edge

with chalk. His fingers shook once. "Cut beyond this line."

The clinic workers carried him into the clean tent. Orun's motion made a fixed surgical table dangerous, so they slung a woven frame from four independent ropes. It remained level while the ground leaned. Ilse boiled glass knives. Yana, unable to use her hands, dictated the witness record from her nearby litter.

Thalen stated his name, age, diagnosis, and available choices. "Pain masking with uncertain delay. Partial removal with high risk of retained infection. Full removal of the left mantle from scalp, neck, shoulder, and arm. I choose full removal."

Yana asked, "Expected consequence?"

He had given this prognosis to Bare-Bough patients who cut ceremonial growth, never to someone losing half a functional mantle under contamination.

"Reduced dormancy. Poor heat regulation. Higher infection risk. Shortened life."

"Estimated degree?"

"Unknown. Decades are plausible."

Orinel said, "You may not survive the excision."

"Record that."

"Thalen." Her use of his name carried the old teacher's warning, intimate and authoritative. "Let me place indigo above the scalp line. We can preserve more."

"You preserved institutions by making damage quiet."

Pain crossed her face without asking him to relieve it.

He softened his tone, not the decision. "You may cut, if you can follow the chalk."

Orinel washed her hands.

They began at the wrist. Amber tincture dulled the surface but left deep sensation intact enough for Thalen to report heat, pressure, and the direction of each pull. Ilse lifted lichen with blunt forks. Orinel slid glass beneath the anchoring roots. Blood welled where symbiotic vessels separated from skin.

No clean sheet of mantle came away. They removed it in pieces, each carrying years of cultivated color and medicinal memory. The wrist section held root patterns he had trained to read fever. The shoulder cups had propagated Green Mantle burn salves. Near his collarbone, Orinel found a gray strand beyond the chalk and widened the cut by two fingers.

Thalen clenched a rolled cloth between his right hand and ribs. He refused indigo when the pain sharpened. Refusal granted no moral purity; it kept the infection boundary visible.

At his scalp, nausea overcame him. He vomited into a basin and nearly rolled out of the sling. Ilse tightened the side ropes. Orinel waited through Orun's next step, then removed the last infected web from behind his left ear.

“Natural skin,” she said.

For the first time since childhood, cold air touched half his scalp.

They inspected under white light. No gray roots remained at the margin. Orinel covered the raw bed with sterile mesh grown from safely detached culture. It would protect skin, not become a new mantle. Regrowth required a stable canopy cycle and years he might no longer possess.

When Thalen woke, night had moved the clinic three miles east.

His left side felt skinned by winter. The missing weight changed how he held his head. Fever warmed his face while the exposed shoulder shook beneath blankets. Ilse offered water. He took the cup in his right hand and spilled half because his body expected the mantle to regulate the tremor.

An orderly changed the mesh while he counted breaths. Clean blood stippled the dressing; no metallic gray crossed the cut margin. That result meant the surgery had interrupted transmission. It did not restore what the knives removed. Thalen asked her to write both findings where every later physician would see them.

Yana's witness slate lay beside him. Beneath the surgical record, Thalen added his own line in uneven script: Loss accepted with full knowledge that it shortens expected life. No claim of cure. Monitor the clean margin at every pulse.

Orinel sat outside the lamp circle sorting sealed packets.

“You should sleep,” he said.

“You should not be awake.”

“The White Canopy evidence.”

She indicated two iron cases. Forge shipment copies, operator contracts, priority rolls, propagation notes, and her signed bargains filled them. Ilse and three Green Mantle workers checked each inventory against the records taken at Lichen Gate.

Thalen asked the witnesses to bring both cases close. “Custody leaves Orinel and me now. One case goes to the worker council. One travels with Nesh for the public hearing. Every copy names the cultures used to conceal injury.”

Orinel placed her palm beneath the final seal. “Record my transfer without immunity or settlement.”

Ilse did so.

Before dawn on Day 39, Thalen returned to the contact table against every instruction he would have given a patient. He did not touch it. Workers fixed shedstone sample tiles on separate wooden frames. Each tile held a narrow line of living diagnostic culture fed with saltwater and shielded from direct body contact.

The experiment used the property White Canopy had exploited for years. Pain-masking strains paled around command resonance, allowing operators to ignore exposure. Untreated diagnostic strains changed color instead: violet near an active throat-nail return, rust red near a bridle relay, clear green over natural

pulse.

Meris supplied six recovered field plates. Kivik marked their brace geometry. Workers set each plate beneath a culture tile, then brought the plates one at a time near continuous stone paths leading toward Dawn Basin.

Color opened across the cultures.

One rust branch ran east toward Ivara's advance camp. Two followed Orun's carried relays. A faint violet line reached west to Volda. Kharad's route showed broad green interrupted by a narrow imposed thread. Dead copper produced no change. The living cups revealed command lines without carrying an order or translating any pulse into speech.

Thalen dictated distances while Ilse painted matching marks on the field map. Each observation came from workers who could withdraw their tile by a rope and discard it in sand. Nobody placed skin against an active path.

At sunrise Meris arrived to inspect the map. Her right hand, short by two fingertips, hovered over the rust branches.

"This gives Kivik the relay approaches," she said. "It gives me the live brace joint."

"It also tells you which routes carry natural return. Do not strike those."

Meris looked at the bandage covering half his head and shoulder. "Can you read the cultures in the field?"

"From a separated frame."

"Can you touch a line?"

Thalen felt the cold edge beneath his dressing. His shortened life had become an entry on a slate, which made it no less difficult to inhabit.

"No," he said. "If I operate one, the remaining mantle may carry resonance into my chest. Build your plan around my eyes, not my hands."

Meris accepted the limit without praise. She rolled the marked map and summoned the severance crews.

Behind them, the revealing cultures continued to color each active path toward the basin. Thalen watched from beyond reach and named every line he could see.

Chapter 26 — The Battle of the Dawn Basin

Korra moved the North Quarry route two hundred paces uphill while its bridge still carried wagons.

“Keep them crossing,” she told the riggers. “Shift one pylon at a time.”

Below, salt water spread over the old road in a bright sheet. Kharad's approach had depressed the basin rim during the night, squeezing buried water through cracked clay. The flooded ground looked shallow. A sounding pole sank past its painted head.

Six hundred evacuees waited on the western bank with pump carts and dismantled roofs. Beyond them came the supply column for Dawn Gate. If Korra closed the bridge, both lines would knot against Kharad's forward route. If she held it where it stood, the next pulse could drop every wagon into salt mud.

Vaun riggers paid out the northern cable. Quarry crews dragged the free pylon along a plank bed. The bridge slewed upstream under live traffic, shedstone ribs creaking as teams crossed sideways. Korra gripped the tension drum with her right hand and pressed her stiffening left wrist against its brace.

“One cart per rib,” she called. “No bunching because the road moved.”

A driver asked where the route ended now.

“Yellow flags on the ridge. After that, the quarry wardens decide.”

She would once have named every turn to the final camp. Kestrel Cut had also possessed one engineer, one clean line, and soldiers waiting at its far end. Here North Quarry climbed. Lichen followed damp shade along the southern terrace. River used reed mats across the western flats. Glass crossed the dry black slope where no cart could carry open flame. Old Grain circled behind Kharad with the heavy food trains. Dawn ran straight through the gate on Orun's moving back.

Six imperfect routes left no single road for Ivara to close.

The last pump cart reached firm ground. Riggers seated the shifted pylon and tightened the bridge into its new curve. A pulse traveled under Korra's boots, broad and uneven. Kharad filled the northwestern horizon, carrying Harth's broken terraces and 6,416 residents. Far west, damaged Volda dragged one flank through a chalk pass. Orun approached from the southwest with Avenor and Dawn Gate tilting across its forward ridge.

None held the same vector. All three converged on the basin.

Nesh Aru waited beside the yellow flags with the coalition slate. “Eighteen thousand fighters accounted for,” they said. “Six thousand support workers remain under civilian route authority. Avenor sends 4,200 from its combat garrison.”

“Separate command?”

“Their assembly insisted.”

“Good.”

Korra read the deployments. Vaun held the northern bridges. River Rauk protected the water routes. Cinder witnesses staffed signals and casualty ledgers. Green Mantle workers operated clinics. Noll crews had divided among nine relay cuts. Split River companies guarded the camps. Beroch's Sarn force held Dawn Gate as a peer wing. Nobody possessed authority over all of them.

The arrangement required questions in places where an army expected obedience. It also meant Ivara could not break the whole field by taking one commander.

At sunrise, red command light appeared on the basin's central ridge.

Three portable relay towers rose from salt hummocks around an old imperial survey station. Ivara's loyal companies had spent the night digging firing steps and seating fresh-corestone plates into continuous rock. The manual command plate hung beneath a white awning at the highest tower. Lines from that position ran west toward Volda and southwest toward Orun. A thinner buried branch reached Kharad through the damaged old network.

Thalen's cultures showed them before any lamp brightened. Workers lifted separated frames along the coalition ridge. Rust color branched east to the survey station. Violet gathered near active throat-nail returns. Clear green spread across natural pulse paths and had to remain untouched.

Thalen stood behind a hide screen with half his scalp and left shoulder bandaged. He used a long pointer in his right hand.

“Relay path below the white salt seam,” he told Kivik. “Natural return lies three paces north. Mark both.”

Kivik repeated the instruction toward their good left ear and chalked a double line. “Three paces will become one when artillery starts.”

“Then widen your safety margin.”

“An Ilaith admitting margins improve outcomes. I should have brought a second ledger.”

Their dry humor failed to hide how carefully they turned the damaged right side of their head away from the relay hum.

Meris knelt over the severance plan. The counter-hammer rested in a padded case beside her left knee. Her right hand, missing two fingertips, measured intervals against the knuckle of her thumb. Nine Noll crews would break the field relays at brace joints copied from her own design. Quarry teams aboard Orun had already released local anchor rings. On Kharad, Sava's bridge crews cleared the northern corridor around seed terraces. Beroch's captured lower gallery had opened Volda's southern approach but left the active nail untouched.

Everything depended on timing between natural beats.

“Wait through the body's pulse,” Meris said. “Counter the command return. Key

turns only after all three local releases answer. If one crew is late, nobody improvises a pull."

Korra looked toward the separate approaches. "And if Ivara commands a strike before the returns?"

"Routes bend. People move. We do not replace her command with ours."

Horns sounded from Dawn Gate.

Ivara's first assault hit the open doors from both sides. Loyal infantry climbed Orun's government slope behind overturned archive carts. A mounted company attacked uphill from the basin, trying to seize the gate mouth before Beroch's garrison could join the coalition field. The gate itself moved with Orun, turning every fixed firing line obsolete after a few breaths.

Beroch planted the Sarn standard outside the civilian lane. He had four ranks of shield fighters across the northern leaf and cavalry dismounted behind them. Avenor's 4,200 entered through the southern opening under their own blue quarry flags, then wheeled east against the mounted loyalists.

"Dawn route remains open," his horn called.

Evacuation workers kept moving between the fighting lines. They carried water east and wounded west, using white-marked lanes beside the gate towers. Beroch's soldiers faced outward. Avenor companies formed movable walls. Neither closed the arch.

Korra sent no fighters to command them. She sent six Vaun bridge screens because arrows had begun falling into the carrier lane.

The screens reached Dawn Gate as Orun stepped down into the basin. Its forward slope rose sharply. Carts rolled backward. Route workers dropped chocks behind wheels while archers braced knees against paving stones that had once lain level through the capital.

Ivara's mounted company charged into the change of grade. Horses lost speed. Avenor shield crews struck their flank, capturing riders who could not turn between abandoned ministries. Beroch's line advanced three paces, enough to keep loyal infantry from the northern hinge, then halted rather than leave the lane exposed.

Artillery opened from the central ridge.

The first stone hit Lichen route's shade frames. Cloth, wood, and cultivated trays scattered over the terrace. Clinic workers switched to their lower road without waiting for military permission. A second shot crossed Dawn Gate and broke an Orun shelter vent. Black signal flags rose from Avenor's carried ridge: trapped air crew, twelve people needed.

Korra redirected two quarry pump teams from North route. "Their council retains the machines. Shelter liaison requests use, not custody."

The foreman nodded and made her repeat it for the witness slate before he moved.

Such exactness cost half a minute. It prevented emergency loan from becoming seizure after the battle, if there remained an after.

A white flare rose over Volda.

Command resonance traveled through the ridge plates. Korra felt it enter the old stone beneath her left palm before pain arrived. Volda's damaged body shuddered west of the basin and altered direction toward Orun. Its kneeling injury forced an uneven gait, each step throwing soldiers from the fortress terraces. The southern corridor lay open before it. Ivara's command pulled it northeast instead.

Thalen's nearest frame turned violet.

"Active line four," he called. "Rust branch under the artillery stair."

Kivik sent two Noll crews forward behind River shields. They carried wedges, rope, and compact hammers, none resonant enough to interrupt the network alone. Their objective lay at the removable brace housings between relay plates. Open those joints, and Meris could drive counter-resonance through a weaker structure.

Loyal archers shifted fire toward them. River slingers answered from reed trenches. Salt crust broke under one Noll crew, dropping three workers waist-deep in bitter mud. Their companions laid ladders flat and crawled out while the second crew continued. No captain ordered the trapped abandoned.

Korra ran toward Dawn route. A stone had opened a crater beside its supply lane. Wagons backed against the gate, reducing six choices toward the single choke point she had promised to prevent.

"Old Grain takes all food carts from marker seventeen," she told the lane wardens. "Glass takes empty wagons and southbound wounded. Dawn keeps hand carriers only."

"Glass has artillery fall," one objected.

"Their dry-slope branch remains open below the black flags."

"Adds four miles."

"Adds four miles people can walk."

Wardens relayed the change. Grain carts peeled north before reaching the knot. Wounded teams moved south. Dawn Gate emptied enough for Beroch's reserve to cross without entering civilian traffic.

He found Korra below the southern tower. Blood darkened one side of his blue tusk clay, and his left shoulder plate hung from a cut strap.

"Key transfer," he said.

From beneath his armor he drew the crown key wrapped in the Sarn exclusion order. The brass shaft bore fresh scoring from the gallery breach.

Korra did not take it at once. "Witnesses?"

Nesh stepped from behind a bridge screen. An Avenor gate captain joined them.

Kivik, listening through their left funnel from twenty paces away, raised a chalked hand.

“Beroch Sarn transfers the crown key for the severance interval only,” Beroch said. “Korra Vaun holds no command over Sarn forces by receiving it. If she survives, it enters public evidence.”

“Accepted under those terms,” Korra said.

The key weighed less than a bridge pin. Her mineralized left fingers could not close around it, so Nesh bound it across her palm with clean cord. Its metal touched the gray tracery at her wrist.

Beroch inspected the knot. “You built better bindings at Sable Stair.”

“I had two working hands and fewer opinions.”

“You have accumulated both costs.”

He returned to Dawn Gate before she found an answer.

The battle widened across the basin. Eighteen thousand coalition fighters did not move as one mass. Split River infantry seized the lower survey trenches. River boats crossed a spring channel that had not existed the previous morning. Cinder teams carried no weapons but kept signal masts upright under fire. Vaun riders opened a path for the first Noll crew to reach relay four. Avenor's 4,200 divided by ward, with no company taken into Sarn rank.

Ivara answered difference with one repeated command.

East.

Orun's throat-nail drove it through the carried city. Volda received the same imposed beat and lurched northeast. The thin line into Kharad tightened across old buried relays. All three nearby Worldbacks angled toward the central salt bed.

People on Kharad's terraces cut their temporary moorings. Six routes beyond Dawn Gate cleared toward different ridges. The bodies below still bore nails, yet the ground ahead offered visible alternatives through continuous stone.

Meris raised a green flag: first brace joint open.

Kivik's crews reached the second tower by climbing beneath its firing shelf. They drove ordinary wedges into the housing seam. Loyal defenders poured sand and lamp oil down the wall. Wet hides turned the first spill. A torch caught the second. One worker rolled burning into the salt mud while the others pulled the brace pin with a rope.

Red flag: casualty. Green followed: joint open.

At the third relay, imperial operators locked their own access door and remained harnessed to the plate. Meris sent a speaking horn forward.

“This structure will break,” she told them. “Release your contacts and leave by the south stair.”

An operator answered, “If we leave, Volda collides with Orun.”

"Your command turns Volda toward Orun."

"The regent has the intervals."

"Look west."

Volda's damaged front limb struck a basin ridge. The colossus slowed, but the imposed pulse kept driving through it. Plates shed from its flank and smashed the imperial camp below.

Two operators emerged. A third stayed harnessed. Loyal guards held the stair behind him. Kivik changed the crew's approach, cutting through an empty ventilation skin rather than storming the door. The delay carried into every signal line.

Korra reached the crown-release frame at the basin roadstone.

The Cinder Cloister had set the old marker generations before imperial surveyors buried it. Its shedstone face showed nine routes spreading from the Ember Cradle, weathered almost smooth. Meris had built a mechanical housing around it without drilling into the marker. Three receiver bars touched continuous paths toward Kharad, Volda, and Orun. The key socket stood at their center.

"Local release from Kharad," Sava signaled on the north mast.

No answer came from Volda.

Orun's quarry crews raised green, lowered it, then raised red as loyal artillery hit their anchor team. Korra waited. Every instinct demanded she choose the available bodies, save two, repair the third later. Pulling early would tear a live pulse channel.

"Keep the routes moving," she said.

Ivara saw their delay.

The manual plate on the central tower flashed hard white. An order entered Orun beneath Dawn Gate, stronger than the prior directions. Strike, stripped of target or meaning beyond forced motion.

Orun's forward body lifted.

The capital rose above the basin. Flex shelters swung inside released foundation rings. One air shaft collapsed despite the pump crews. Dawn Gate climbed until its open leaves framed only sky. Beroch's soldiers and Avenor companies slid down the government slope among stone and broken carts.

Korra's six routes changed elevation at once. North Quarry lost its lower bridge. River water surged over reed mats. Glass became the only easy grade from the gate camps.

She refused the easy grade.

"North uses the shifted bridge above the flood. River divides at the double poles. Lichen carries shelter wounded south. Old Grain opens its empty-cart lane to foot traffic. Dawn closes only below the moving arch, not at the outer marker."

Orders traveled through route authorities, each free to adapt. The camp population spread instead of pouring toward Glass. When an artillery shot landed on that slope, it killed people in one lane, not everyone trapped behind them.

Orun brought its lifted body down against the salt ridge.

The impact threw Korra across the roadstone frame. Bound brass crushed into her left palm. White pain climbed the mineral tracery to her elbow. She smelled hot copper and skin.

Meris pulled her upright. "Can you hold the key?"

"It is tied."

"That does not answer me."

Korra tried to bend her fingers. Thumb moved. Forefinger shivered. The other three remained fixed around empty air.

"I can turn from the shoulder."

Volda's mast changed to green.

Beroch had reached the captured lower gallery with a Sarn crew and Volda deserters. They released the remaining local anchors mechanically, never touching the active nail. Orun's signal also turned green. Quarry workers had lost seven people but finished opening the ring.

Three local releases stood ready. Three distinct routes lay open across the ground.

Meris lifted the counter-hammer.

Kivik's final crew broke through the ventilation skin. Green flags rose above relay three. The operator who had remained chose to cut his own harness when the brace housing opened beneath him. Loyal guards withdrew toward Ivara's tower.

"Natural beat coming," Thalen called from the culture line.

The clear green cups darkened in sequence: Kharad, Volda, Orun.

Meris waited through the last pulse. She placed the counter-hammer against her removable brace joint at the roadstone housing. Kivik relayed each return from the field crews. Thalen watched colors, separated from every active path.

Command light turned rust.

"Now," Meris said.

She struck.

The counter-hammer sent an opposing frequency through the opened relay joints. It did not tell any Worldback where to go. It carved a silence between imposed beats. For one interval, Ivara's command return failed to close through the crown network.

Korra drove the key left with her shoulder.

Resistance caught at the black score. The cord cut deeper into her palm. She leaned until the stone creep in her wrist felt fused to the metal. Around the basin, nine relay crews pulled their mechanical releases. Orun's quarry anchors opened fully. Volda's lower gallery dropped its clamps. Kharad's route teams loosed the last carried crown braces.

Ivara forced the manual plate again.

White light reached the roadstone frame and entered Korra's left hand.

Her fingers locked. The wrist stiffened. Mineral cold crossed the joint and stopped midway along the forearm, where living muscle fought to keep blood moving. She could have released the key by cutting the cord. Instead she turned from hips and shoulder through the final quarter.

The crown network opened.

Meris's brace joint split under reflected force. She struck again to hold the counter-frequency through the release. The hammer head cracked. On the third blow, its tuned shedstone face burst into black fragments. The handle spun from her hand and vanished into the trench.

Every command lamp went dark.

Silence did not follow. Stone broke across the ridge. Operators shouted. Water surged through new cracks. Three immense pulse patterns continued beneath the basin, unlinked and uneven.

Korra fell beside the roadstone. Her left hand retained the shape it had held around the key, though Nesh cut the binding and lifted the brass free. She tried once to flatten her palm. Nothing below the thumb obeyed.

"Do not force it," Thalen said, reaching her with his bandaged side guarded from the stone. He checked color at her nails and pulse above the wrist. "Circulation remains. Flexibility does not."

"Permanent?"

His answer came without disguise. "Yes."

Across the field, Ivara's tower continued flashing from a private lamp. Her manual plate retained local power, but no crown path accepted it. Orun paused with Dawn Gate high on its slope. Volda's forced northeast turn slowed. Kharad reached the northern salt shelf.

Nobody gave them another direction.

Kharad moved first. Its broad body turned along the cleared northern corridor, away from the central bed. Harth's terraces leaned but held. The colossus entered a basin hollow where dark salt water welled around its damaged plates.

Volda remained still through two natural pulses. Then its injured gait carried it south, following the open grade Beroch's crews had cleared from the lower gallery. It settled against a chalk shelf far from Kharad's flank.

Orun lowered its forward body. Instead of taking Ivara's east line, it followed the salt trace southeast beneath the River camps after their wardens cleared the crossings. Avenor traveled with it, open Dawn Gate facing backward toward the field.

Kharad, Volda, and Orun chose separate basin beds.

No voice held their direction. Their paths appeared through motion, refusal, and the ground left open before them.

Fighting continued after the network broke. Loyal companies on the central ridge tried to withdraw with Ivara. Beroch held Dawn Gate, then sent surrender terms rather than cavalry up the narrow survey stair. Avenor troops secured the lower trenches under their own captains. Split River companies blocked the eastern ford without closing it to clinic traffic.

Ivara reached the last relay tower with thirty guards. She held the manual plate against a dead contact and ordered Orun east until her voice failed. When coalition fighters climbed into view, she drew a short sword.

Beroch stopped below the platform. "Alive," he told the mixed line. "She answers where the people she counted can hear."

The loyal captain looked from his twelve remaining soldiers to the dark command lamps. He laid down his weapon. Six followed. Three tried the eastern ladder and found River wardens above it. The others closed around Ivara without attacking either side.

Korra climbed the stair with her left arm splinted against her body. Each step jarred the locked hand. Nesh carried the crown key in an evidence bag. Meris came without the destroyed counter-hammer, soot blackening her face.

Ivara saw the empty tool case. "You have broken the only control that kept them apart."

Korra pointed north, south, and southeast with her working hand. "Look."

Three distinct bodies occupied three distinct hollows. Roads between them remained open. No collision followed the absence of command.

"For one morning," Ivara said.

"For this choice. Tomorrow requires another."

Ivara's sword lowered a finger width. Beroch approached in view of Sarn, River, Avenor, and Cinder witnesses. He took the manual plate only after she released it. An Avenor captain removed the sword. River wardens bound her wrists with cloth over skin already reddened by command contact.

Ivara Cend entered joint civilian custody alive.

Custody took work after the declaration. The River wardens searched Ivara's coat while an Avenor clerk inventoried each object: two seal rings, a field schedule, one cracked ear guard, six blank command chits. Beroch placed the manual plate on a shield rather than carry it under his armor. Nesh set the bagged crown key

beside it, and Meris identified both without touching their contact faces. Sarn soldiers formed an outer square. Avenor wardens occupied the inner one. Neither party could remove the prisoner or evidence without crossing the other in public view.

Korra sent no victory horn. Red casualty flags still moved along the routes. At the lower survey trench, Green Mantle workers cooled an imperial operator whose arm had mineralized to the elbow. Fifty paces away, an Avenor shield bearer held pressure on a loyal soldier's thigh because the clinic markers admitted both. Kivik sat with their good ear against silence, vomiting after the last relay note. They refused a litter until every Noll crew answered its roll.

Meris found only fragments of the counter-hammer. She used wooden tongs to lift three pieces into separate sand boxes. None retained a continuous tuned face; no blow could be struck from them again. The handle remained beneath the collapsed brace trench. On her evidence slate she wrote destroyed during severance, then asked a Noll witness and an Avenor engineer to sign.

Only after the routes reported passable did Beroch move Ivara downhill. She walked, guarded and visible, past operators her commands had injured. No one struck her. Two people tried, and other evacuees held them back for the hearing they had been promised.

The count occupied the rest of Day 41.

Crews searched collapsed shelters, route craters, the relay trenches, and Orun's carried streets. They distinguished people killed after the final battle began from the twenty-three lost during the gate operation. They did not subtract either group from the closed evacuation arithmetic. The 34,700 who had left Avenor and the 6,300 assigned to flex shelters still accounted for the original 41,000 at evacuation close.

Exactly 286 Avenor deaths occurred in the battle across shelters and evacuation routes. Their names entered a separate book. The number did not describe coalition field losses, loyalist dead, or people from other settlements. Those received their own ledgers.

Likewise, the 4,200 Avenor garrison figure recorded direct-combat strength at entry, not survivors and not civilians. Nesh forced three exhausted officers to correct a slate that had mixed those quantities.

At dusk, Korra returned to the shifted North Quarry bridge. Its curve had held. Pump wagons crossed toward Orun's new bed, carrying air equipment back to the 6,300 shelter residents. On the far bank, clinic lamps marked Lichen route. Grain traffic moved north. Dawn Gate remained open on a slope that no longer pointed east.

Thalen had strapped Korra's left hand into a padded resting frame. The fingers would never close around rope again. She tested the bridge rail with her right palm and felt Kharad's distant natural pulse pass through safely shed stone.

No order rode upon it.

“Move the yellow flags to tomorrow's ground,” she told the route crew.

Chapter 27 — When No Voice Held the Bridle

Meris stopped a quarry crew from lifting the dead relay plate with iron hooks.

“Set those down,” she said. “The lamp has gone dark. The corestone has not gone dead.”

Three workers froze around the salt-crusted slab. One hook already touched its copper rim. Nobody had bare skin near it, but rainwater pooled between the metal and the continuous rock below.

Meris knelt beyond reach and measured the gap with her thumb knuckle. Orun's natural pulse arrived through the basin floor. The plate gave a weak white twitch in answer, too small to light its shattered gauge.

“Residual return,” she said. “Wooden levers under the corners. Hide cradle beneath. Break contact before you raise weight.”

The foreman looked toward the camps where kettles had begun boiling. “I thought the war ended.”

“It did. This can still take your hand.”

Workers fetched seasoned beams. Meris had them build a fulcrum from dry shedstone chips, then slide waxed hide between the plate and wet ground one finger width at a time. Once separated, the corestone stopped twitching. They carried it to an isolation trench marked with nine red posts.

Day 42 began with such corrections. Celebration could wait for the basin to stop killing people through abandoned equipment.

Meris divided the field into squares. Noll crews mapped live fragments. Quarry engineers tested slopes beneath Orun's new bed. River wardens marked salt springs that had opened under shallow crust. Vaun riggers inspected bridges altered during battle. Every square required one technical witness and one route witness from a different party before anyone declared it safe.

Kivik supervised the old brace trench from a stool. Their right ear wore a fresh packing wrap; the brass funnel on that side rested in an evidence bag. Whenever somebody approached from the damaged side, they turned too late and hid the mistake by demanding another measurement.

“Hammer fragments?” Meris asked.

“Three boxed. Head core discontinuous in every piece. Handle inaccessible without shifting the wall.”

“Then the counter-hammer remains destroyed. We do not excavate beneath an unstable brace to make the record prettier.”

Kivik scratched the conclusion onto a public slate. “You understand that guild memorial standards prefer recovered tools.”

“Guild memorial standards may argue with gravity under their own name.”

"They often do."

No smile followed. Forty-one older names waited in the ledgers Kivik had carried from Red Hollow, and new Noll dead lay under yesterday's signal flags.

At the crown-release roadstone, Meris found Korra directing work with her left arm strapped across her ribs. Four fingers held the fixed half-curve imposed by the key. Thalen had padded each gap to keep nails from cutting the palm.

"You should be in the clinic," Meris said.

"The clinic sent me out because I rearranged its litter route."

"Did the route need it?"

"Yes."

"That does not answer the physician."

Korra used her right hand to point at the release housing. "Your receiver bars remain on a public roadstone."

Meris had built the frame quickly, assuming crews would dismantle it after severance. The key socket, three contact bars, and broken brace could still serve as the center of a smaller command device if someone fitted fresh corestone. She saw how little separated emergency apparatus from permanent authority: bolts left in place, tolerances kept private, a useful machine waiting for the next crisis.

"I will strip it before the hearing," she said.

"In front of witnesses."

"That usually makes stripping bolts slower."

"You will endure history's cruelty."

Korra's bluntness carried enough warmth to count as trust. Meris accepted it without turning the exchange sentimental.

They began with the casualty squares.

Green Mantle clinics posted three boards: identified dead, unidentified dead, missing. No name moved from one to another on clothing alone. Teeth, work marks, witness recognition, and carried records each received separate columns. Cinder clerks compared the lists against route rolls. Sarn officers opened their field books to River witnesses. Avenor companies corrected the earlier mistake that had treated their 4,200 combat entry as a surviving headcount.

The 286 Avenor battle deaths remained in their own ledger, separate from the twenty-three gate-operation deaths and from all evacuation totals. Other books recorded coalition fighters, Ivara's loyal troops, support workers, residents of Kharad, and people not yet identified. No single number made the losses clean.

Thalen moved between the stone-creep cots with a wool hood covering the absent left side of his mantle. Heat flushed the exposed half of his face. He examined mineralized limbs, marked the limits, and told each patient what would not return. Some cursed him for refusing hope. Others asked him to repeat the

prognosis to family witnesses.

Yana Peor sat upright with both hands splinted open. She dictated the crown-gallery operator roll. Seven people had entered the Ninefold pulse by recorded consent after risk disclosure. Consent had not transformed the command into a harmless act. It established who had been told what, and who had lied before the telling.

Near noon, Kivik opened the Red Hollow memorial ledger.

The book lay on a table made from the forge's recovered counting door. Imperial clerks had listed dead workers by shift marks in the expense columns, then charged replacement gloves to their contracts. Noll families and guild witnesses had restored names from duplicate rolls.

Kivik read all forty-one aloud.

"Avi Pell. Beren Noll. Chessa Vey. Daro Kett. Evin Marr. Fara Noll. Gessi Ul. Harek Vonn. Isti Pell. Jaro Vey. Kessa Noll. Luri Tamm. Merek Ul. Niva Rell. Odo Kett. Parsi Vonn. Quen Marr. Ressi Pell. Saro Noll. Tavi Ul. Uren Vey. Vessi Kett. Waro Tamm. Xeri Noll. Yara Rell. Zerine Vonn. Asha Marr. Brek Pell. Ciri Ul. Dessi Noll. Erro Vey. Fenn Kett. Garo Rell. Hessi Tamm. Iven Noll. Jessa Marr. Karo Vonn. Leto Pell. Miri Ul. Naro Vey. Ossi Noll."

After each name, one guild member struck a cold brass pin against the counting door. The taps produced no tuned frequency and touched no living stone. Memorial sound carried through air, not command.

The unidentified remains found in Kharad's underheart did not acquire a name through convenience. Their bone tool marks matched Noll work, but none of the forty-one records proved which worker had descended there. Kivik entered the remains beneath a separate unknown mark and left the question open.

Families received copies of the forge exposure sheets. The original ledger went into joint Noll and Split River custody. Meris signed beside the line recording that her crown specifications had increased Red Hollow output demands seven years after she began the design.

"You did not order those shifts," a former forge worker told her.

"My tolerances made the casting possible."

"That is not the same act."

"No. Record both acts."

The public hearing convened under Dawn Gate's southern leaf because no intact hall could hold the crowd. Orun had settled with the gate facing back toward the battlefield. Its hinges hung open over a sloped plaza. Workers laid level plank aisles and reserved the broad center for witnesses, not rank.

Ivara sat without chains inside a square held jointly by Avenor wardens and River civilians. Cloth wraps covered command burns on both palms. Beroch's Sarn guards formed the outer perimeter but held no key to her enclosure. An advocate

chosen from the evacuated court clerks sat beside her. Nobody called the gathering a trial. Evidence remained incomplete, defense witnesses had not assembled, and the seven pact parties possessed no shared criminal code.

Nesh opened the preliminary public hearing by stating its limited purpose: confirm identity, preserve charges and artifacts, establish humane custody, hear urgent evidence at risk of loss, then set a later tribunal whose authority could be disputed before judgment.

The charges read without titles. Forced command through living throat-nails. Concealed material risk. Use of Volda against refugee routes. Punitive removal of Sarn schoolchildren from evacuation priority. Exposure of operators and workers beyond declared limits. Attempted forced convergence at Dawn Basin.

Ivara stood when asked her name. "Ivara Cend, Regent of Cendar."

An Avenor quarry delegate said, "Regency authority has no functioning council confirmation."

Her advocate touched her sleeve. Ivara continued, "Record the claimed office and the objection."

Meris recognized the habit. Compress dispute into a sentence. Keep moving while others remained caught in the edges.

The manual plate entered evidence first. Beroch described taking it after surrender. Nesh produced the bagged crown key and recited its transfers from Ivara to Beroch, Beroch to Korra, then Korra to shared evidence custody. Meris identified the plate geometry and explained how the broken network had rendered its commands unable to reach the three nearby throat-nails.

"Could the same device be rebuilt?" asked a River delegate.

"Yes," Meris said.

Murmurs crossed the plaza.

"With fresh corestone, a live throat-nail, and my tolerances or equivalent measurements. That is why every plate must be dismantled and every specification must become public. Secrecy gives the designer private control. Publication lets route councils recognize forbidden construction."

Ivara's advocate asked, "You designed the crown under imperial contract?"

"For seven years, yes."

"You accepted payment and authority for seven years?"

"I did."

"Then Regent Cend acted through a system you presented as safe."

"I presented one-body gradual waking as conditionally survivable. I hid a brace joint when I learned she had added military plates. I should have stopped before hiding became my substitute for public refusal."

The answer harmed Ivara's defense and Meris together. That made it closer to

complete.

When Ivara spoke, she did not deny ordering the march. She described the six dying western springs. She named Pellin and Sova. At her advocate's request, she described Lorn forty years earlier: the blocked southern road, officials concealing tremor surveys, her mother and two younger brothers dying in the collapse.

"I had seen what unmanaged waking did to a city," she said. "I possessed a mechanism that could impose intervals. Refusing to use it would also have assigned deaths."

Nesh asked, "Who concealed Lorn's surveys?"

"Imperial officials and landowners."

"Who closed its second gate?"

"Imperial soldiers."

"What lesson did you take from failures committed under command?"

Ivara looked toward Orun's moved horizon. "That command needed better information."

No shout answered her. The quiet held sharper judgment.

Korra testified from the route benches. Six open choices had prevented a single choke-point massacre. They had not prevented 286 Avenor deaths. She named the limits of the success before anyone could make it pure.

The hearing ordered Ivara held alive under rotating Avenor, River, and Sarn observation, with counsel, medical care, public visits, and no access to continuous living stone. A later tribunal would hear claims from frontier communities, operator families, Worldback-carried settlements, and imperial cities. Her grief entered the record as context. It reduced no charge.

Orinel approached next without waiting for a summons. She placed her White Canopy clasp and signed culture compact on the evidence table.

"I request transfer to Ilaith proceedings under worker witness," she said.

Ilse Vey answered from the Green Mantle bench. "You request no immunity from common claims?"

"None."

"No hereditary court custody?"

"No."

Low-canopy workers formed her escort. Orinel walked with them toward the clinic camp, neither acquitted nor displayed as a trophy.

Beroch removed his sword before taking the witness space. He admitted Sarn enforcement at Sable Stair, seizure of bridge stores, raids on Kharad's routes, detention under imperial labor rolls, and violence used to protect charter pasture. He named officers where records supported command. For disputed acts, he named the dispute rather than burying it beneath collective guilt.

"The charter gave our children schools and held rival claims off winter ground," he said. "Those benefits remain facts. So do the people we harmed to keep them. Sarn will answer claims as a signatory, not dissolve itself into Cendar or Vaun to escape them."

Korra did not forgive him from the benches. River delegates filed three immediate claims. Beroch accepted service of each and retained command.

After the hearing recessed, Meris dismantled the release frame.

She worked under six lamps with witnesses surrounding the roadstone. First came the key socket. Next, receiver bars. Then the broken brace joint, each bolt tagged to its plate. She used no resonant blows. Wooden screws drew contacts apart. Dry hide isolated any piece that retained warmth.

Her reconstruction tables went onto the public board: bridge tolerances for moving grades, flex-shelter clearances, anchor-release intervals, safe distance from living corestone, and identifying dimensions of every command plate she had designed. She omitted no measurement to preserve professional value.

Copies left by five different routes before dusk. One went with Avenor's quarry council, another with the Noll guild. Vaun and River couriers took separate rolls west. Nesh carried a fifth to the Cinder archive. Destroying one table would no longer restore secrecy. Meris signed every copy with the two shortened fingers of her right hand visible beside the ink.

Each courier named a replacement in case injury stopped the first journey.

Kivik read the tables through once. "Your third gimbal tolerance conflicts with the Red Hollow drawing."

"Red Hollow widened it to fit hurried castings."

"Publish both. A forbidden plate built badly remains forbidden."

Meris added the variant.

At sunset, delegates of the seven parties gathered around the stripped roadstone. Vaun, Sarn, Cinder Cloister, River Rauk, Green Mantle workers, Noll maintenance guild, and Split River communes amended their corridor pact into temporary movement law.

No supreme command appeared in it.

Each route retained its own civilian authority. Military forces could request passage but could not seize a lane without named emergency witnesses and a claim afterward. Clinical decisions remained independent. Maintenance ledgers stayed open. Settlements received rights to detach, remain on carried ground by informed choice, or petition for fixed sites outside the corridor. Worldback routes could be cleared and observed, never directed through a throat-nail. The law expired after one migration season unless all seven parties renewed or replaced it through their own procedures.

Avenor signed as an observing city rather than an eighth pact sovereign. Its

resident councils retained the 6,300 shelter rolls and claims for the 34,700 evacuated. White Canopy and Cendar received no automatic seat; their communities could send witnesses and negotiate entry later.

The signatures took two hours because River challenged Sarn's emergency wording, Noll demanded inspection access, and Green Mantle refused a phrase that treated medical stores as military supply. Meris trusted the argument. Each delay exposed a joint that might otherwise break under load.

Their first dispute under the new law arrived before the ink dried.

Orun's southeastern bed had opened a warm spring below Avenor's moving slope. Shelter liaisons needed the water for cooling pipes. River camps had already marked its downstream channel for drinking. Sarn cavalry wanted a crossing above it to reach their wounded on Volda. Each use remained defensible. Combined without order, they would foul the spring or collapse its soft bank.

Under the old field code, a crown engineer would have assigned hours and posted soldiers. Meris possessed enough information to do exactly that. She also knew how quickly an expert schedule became ownership.

"Structural limit first," she said. "No horse or loaded cart comes within thirty paces until the bank compacts. That is a tolerance, not route authority."

The River delegate tasted the water, checked heat against a clinic strip, and claimed drinking flow below the first settling pool. Avenor's liaison requested a temporary pipe from the upper spill, subject to daily measurement. Beroch withdrew mounted crossing rights after his scouts found a longer dry shelf. In exchange, River crews agreed to ferry Sarn litters across the lower channel without weapon confiscation. Green Mantle workers took joint custody of contamination tests.

Nobody received every convenience. The spring reached shelter pipes before midnight, River filled its first clean barrels downstream, and Sarn wounded traveled an extra mile. Witnesses posted the arrangement with an expiration at sunrise, when changed flow would require another decision.

Meris watched three arguments continue around the notice. Temporary law had not ended conflict. It had given conflict edges, records, and a time when consent had to be asked again.

Night reached the basin before the final marks dried.

A Cinder listening team called from the western signal post. They had set plain shedstone contacts along cleared ancient corridors, using touch only to sense pulse and direction. No plate linked the stations. No response carried speech.

Esseth's interval had shortened as it entered the northern Reed route. Morra leaned southeast toward a corridor opened by three farming towns. Galn and Tirava traveled on widely separated lines. Osk had turned around a settled ridge after crews cleared an older grade. Bel moved slowest, still many days from the eastern plains.

None approached the battle field under an order.

Meris walked to the isolation trench and checked all nine red posts. The plates lay separated from continuous ground. Crown key and manual plate had gone to public evidence storage. Ivara remained under witnessed custody. Three Worldbacks rested in distinct hollows while water darkened the salt around them.

At the stripped roadstone, bolt holes from Meris's temporary housing remained in the wooden frame, not the ancient shedstone. Kivik poured sand into the empty key socket and packed it level.

"What goes here?" they asked.

Meris looked toward the route boards where tomorrow's crews had already begun disputing grades.

"Nothing that turns," she said.

Chapter 28 — Roads Made for Moving Ground

Three years later, Korra kicked the bridge's public release lever and nothing happened.

"Good," she said.

The twelve apprentices around her looked less pleased. Dawn rain ran from their hooded cloaks onto the inspection deck. Beneath them, the reopened northern migration corridor descended from Kharad's basin bed through two miles of black reeds. The bridge joined Harth's last carried district to a ground pier on the eastern bank. By midday it had to detach cleanly from the Worldback beneath them.

A human apprentice named Rell bent over the lever housing. "We failed the test."

"I pulled the red pin before I kicked." Korra showed him the safety pin in her right hand. "One person cannot release an occupied bridge by mistake or office."

"You told us to watch the load flags."

"I told you to watch the whole mechanism."

The paired release required two levers on opposite banks, a clear deck, and witnesses from both route authorities. No crown key fit the housing. No concealed engineer's catch could override the public pins. Korra had spent six months arguing against the hidden brace she would once have considered prudent.

Rell returned the red pin. Across the span, a River keeper raised a white flag to confirm her deck count. Korra checked for feet, carts, dropped tools, and animals. Her stiff left hand rested inside a leather cradle at her waist, four fingers fixed in their shallow curve. Rain collected along the mineral-gray nails. Cold made the wrist ache, though it did not bend any less than in summer.

"Test two," she called.

Rell and the far-bank keeper pressed their levers together. Wooden screws withdrew paired shedstone tongues from the abutments. The deck settled one finger width onto temporary rope stays. Apprentice teams caught the change on tension drums.

Nothing cracked. Nobody issued a direction into living stone.

"Reset," Korra said. "Then do it with the south stay slack, because weather rarely respects demonstration plans."

Behind her, Harth took itself apart.

The city no longer spread continuously across Kharad's upper plates. Flexible streets linked twelve seasonal districts during the colossus's residence in Dawn Basin. Each spring, before migration, crews lifted street ribs, folded water skins, separated root beds, and rolled entire light-roof quarters onto ground terraces. Anchor housings touched only naturally shed plate fitted over skin; their catches

opened mechanically before Kharad moved.

Some people called the result diminished Harth. Others called it the first honest version.

Sava Vaun supervised the unloading yard from a chair mounted on a cargo sled. At sixty-five she still spotted a crooked sling faster than three standing riggers. She struck her measuring stick against a crate of roof tiles.

"That load belongs to fixed Eastbank," she said. "Seasonal Orchard uses green cord."

Pela Orr checked the inventory. "The crate carries Eastbank marks over old Orchard paint."

"Then ask the owner instead of debating pigments while rain enters the grain cloth."

The owner chose Eastbank, a permanent ground settlement built above the reed flood line. Her family had lived on Kharad for eleven generations and did not want another moving floor. Two neighboring households had chosen Seasonal Orchard, returning to Kharad during its basin rest and detaching for each departure. A third had joined a mobile district that traveled beside the corridor on wheel sledges, neither carried nor fixed.

No census column labeled one choice loyal and another afraid.

Changing categories remained possible. At the west counting shed, residents posted next season's choices on three boards. Twelve mobile households requested carried garden plots during Kharad's next rest. Seven seasonal families applied to settle permanently after losing relatives on the road. Eastbank's council could refuse a building site for flood or corridor reasons, never because an applicant had once chosen movement. Denials went to a mixed route court with public maps.

The clinic detached by rooms rather than institution. Surgical stores had already crossed to ground. Fever cots moved that morning under Green Mantle custody. One recovery ward remained aboard until its patients could tolerate the lift, with a second medical team choosing to travel through Kharad's first three steps. Their consent sheets named the greater risk and the point where ground litters would meet them.

Orchard transfer caused louder disputes. Some root beds could survive repeated lifting. Older trees could not. Green Mantle workers had grafted cuttings for ground gardens while leaving mature orchards on Kharad to travel without owners claiming permanent attachment. Fruit from those trees fed carried residents during basin seasons; excess entered a common winter store. White Canopy descendants had filed restitution claims against three beds. The movement court preserved the trees first and sent ownership arguments to winter sessions.

Pela's grain ledgers treated each form of residence separately because hauling costs differed. Mobile districts contributed road labor. Seasonal districts maintained

release gear. Fixed settlements stored duplicate reserves. People unable to perform those duties paid no invented debt; common levies covered age, illness, and injury. Every system attracted evasion. Public books made the evasion arguable before hunger arrived.

Korra crossed the unloading yard to inspect anchor tags. White tags marked structures already released. Yellow required witness. Red identified a disputed claim or unsafe mechanism. A house with carved Green Mantle shutters carried red on its forward corner.

The resident, an Ilaith root keeper, stood beside a ground carpenter and a Vaun release worker. Each held a different drawing.

"The foundation owner says this rib belongs to Kharad's carried frame," the carpenter explained. "Household receipt lists it as removable property."

Korra examined the join. The rib came from shedstone, fitted through two dry sockets without entering living plate. Either structure could use it. Property law offered less certainty because the household's grandparent had paid maintenance while an orchard court claimed original title.

"Safety first," Korra said. "Release it before the next pulse. Store it at the yellow yard. Your claims travel with it to mediation."

The root keeper frowned. "Where does my family sleep tonight?"

"Guest frame seven has room. If you reject that, Eastbank offers three roof bays for labor credit."

"And if I reject both?"

"Pitch your own shelter outside the rain trench. I will show you the dry ground."

Choice did not require Korra to like the third option. It required the option to remain possible.

Harth's seasonal city used more rope, more duplicated kitchens, and more public argument than the fixed capital model. It also left no district trapped because a ruler controlled one gate. Six outward roads from the basin had become permanent protected corridors, widened in places and narrowed by consent elsewhere. Farm crossings used lift bridges. Towns kept evacuation commons free of hereditary building claims. Violations still occurred. The movement courts spent half their year ordering warehouses removed from land everybody had promised not to occupy.

A horn from the west announced the witness caravan.

Thalen reached the yard walking beside a clinic cart rather than riding in it. A wool cap covered the bare left side of his scalp. No mantle had regrown across that skin. The remaining right mantle grew thinner than Korra remembered from the war, its greens carefully layered around a face that tired sooner.

"You are late," she said.

"A child at Glass Crossing swallowed a bridge tally."

“Wood or copper?”

“Wood. She objected to observation and offered a professional opinion of pathwright labeling.”

Korra took his travel case with her right hand. Their friendship had accumulated enough routine to leave his shortened life unspoken for several minutes. Then she noticed the gray fatigue beneath his eye.

“Dormancy interval?”

“Eight days this winter. I required twenty before the cutting.”

“Your record predicted ten.”

“My record also instructed colleagues to revise from evidence.”

He had spent three years traveling between Green Mantle clinics, operator families, fixed-ground settlements, and Ilaith hearings. Every court received the same account of his falsified pulse sheets and White Canopy's bargains. Some Bare-Bough circles treated his missing mantle as a reform emblem. He refused their ceremonial invitations when they turned injury into purity.

“How many seasons?” Korra asked.

“No honest physician will give me a year.” Thalen looked toward Kharad, where damp mist caught on repaired terraces. “The shortened life remains mine to schedule badly.”

She handed him the case without offering contradiction.

Meris arrived beneath a public works banner bearing seven oversight seals. She had no imperial rank and no private drafting room. Two apprentice auditors accompanied every inspection, one chosen by the structure's users and one by the movement council. Her dark hair had gone mostly white. The two missing fingertips on her right hand remained exactly where the old forge accident had taken them.

“South stay slack?” she asked after one glance at the bridge.

“Test condition.”

“Your west drum compensates too smoothly. An untrained crew may assume the stay carries load.”

Korra called Rell over. “Did you?”

He looked offended, then looked at the line. “Yes.”

Meris measured the drum clearance with her thumb knuckle. “Paint reveals wear poorly in rain. Cut a physical notch at the unsafe position. Publish the change before fitting it elsewhere.”

One auditor recorded the correction. The other asked why the original table had allowed the clearance. Meris explained her error in front of the apprentices and signed the revision.

Her published tolerances had allowed hundreds of towns to recognize crown

parts hidden in old foundation works. The last intact command plate had come out of Osk's western gallery eleven months earlier. Public crews separated it from living stone and placed it beside Ivvara's manual plate in the Avenor evidence house. No new throat-nail had been forged after Red Hollow.

The tribunal had concluded its central criminal findings eighteen months ago. Ivvara remained alive, permanently removed from office and held under a civil sentence near Avenor, away from continuous living stone. Judges found her culpable for forced command, concealed exposure, the punitive school exclusion, and attempted convergence. They rejected charges that treated every imperial civilian death as her act alone. Reconstruction claims continued by design, each attached to a named order, institution, contract, or injury rather than one convenient monster.

Orinel lost White Canopy office after Ilaith proceedings. She worked under clinic supervision cataloguing masking cultures, prohibited from custody decisions. Sarn had settled two River claims and contested five more. Meris's own contract earnings funded operator care after a tribunal accepted her liability agreement without pretending payment erased design.

Accountability had produced no clean people. It had produced records that could be argued without a crown deciding which survived.

Beroch rode into Harth at the head of twelve Sarn witnesses, not an occupying column. Blue clay still marked his lower tusks. He had replaced his old imperial mantle with a short dark coat carrying the Sarn road clauses inside its hem.

"Your cavalry arrives after the physician," Korra said.

"My cavalry stopped at the corridor post because your apprentice wrote a weight limit three hundred pounds below the bridge charter."

Rell reddened.

"Which limit governed?" Korra asked.

"The lower until witnessed inspection. We crossed in groups."

"Then the system worked."

"The system made a commander walk in rain."

"Put the suffering in your next claim."

Beroch's scarred lip twitched. He remained Sarn commander and a peer signatory, answerable to his drumhold rather than Korra. Their rivalry had changed subjects. They now disputed grazing detours, military loads, and whether seasonal road labor counted against settled compensation. Neither mistook recurring cooperation for merged authority.

He signed the Kharad clearance beside Vaun, River, and Cinder witnesses. The document granted no one permission to move the Worldback. It confirmed that people had cleared designated ground, carried disputed property off living plates, and opened alternate routes if Kharad refused the surveyed grade.

At midday, the bridge test finally passed under slack-stay conditions.

Both banks pressed their levers. Shedstone tongues withdrew. Teams lowered the deck onto ground trestles while Kharad's carried end separated from the abutment. The entire span remained usable as a free-standing bridge after the Worldback departed. Rell found the deceptive drum position and cut Meris's new notch under witness.

Korra signed with her right hand. Beside the mark, she pressed the leather cradle holding her stiff left hand into ink and left its outline. The disability had ended her rope work and changed every task requiring two grips. It had not become painless through usefulness. On cold mornings, Sava buckled the cradle for her because Korra could not fasten its lowest strap alone.

The memorial gathering began on Eastbank after the unloading crews ate.

Kivik stood beside a low brass cabinet with their good left ear turned toward the crowd. Their right-ear hearing had not returned. A newer funnel there served only as protection from sharp noise, not amplification. Forty-one small brass pins covered the cabinet door, one for every Red Hollow worker named on Day 42.

Inside lay public copies of exposure rolls, forge shifts, family claims, and the still-unresolved record of remains found in Kharad's underheart. Kivik unveiled the memorial ledger without speeches about sacrifice. Nobody had volunteered to die unseen so cities could command mountains.

Families touched names or did not. Forge survivors corrected two work dates on an open amendment sheet. The cabinet accepted revision without allowing an old clerk to erase the original entry.

Behind it, Noll crews had built a non-command listening station.

The station used nine removable shedstone pads laid along a ground frame. Each pad touched one continuous corridor stone through a mechanical lowering screw. A listener placed a palm on dry shedstone, sensed pulse interval, direction of pressure, fracture, or motion, then raised the pad to break contact. No fresh corestone entered the structure. No linked crown amplified a response. The design contained no plate capable of sending one.

Kivik asked a quarry child to test Kharad's pad. "Tell us only what reaches your hand."

The child lowered the contact and waited. "Pressure. Slow. Moving toward us?"

"Again. Direction depends on which face bears weight."

She shifted her palm. "Past us. North edge."

Korra felt no message in that observation. Kharad had not chosen a child as interpreter. Its pulse produced material pressure through stone, and a trained station made the pressure easier to compare. Route crews still needed scouts, open ground, and the willingness to be wrong.

Volda's pad carried no present contact. The damaged Worldback had left its

southern basin bed the previous autumn, following a cleared route toward the low salt marshes. Its imperial fortress came apart over two seasons. Some former garrison families traveled in detachable districts; others founded a fixed settlement beyond the corridor. Volda's old throat-nail had been removed only after the network stayed dark, local anchors released, and its chosen path remained open. The surgical work took four months and killed no operator because nobody commanded the body to brace.

Orun had completed one short eastern circuit and returned to a different hollow. Avenor rebuilt as a linked group of ground wards and carried shelter districts, smaller than its old fixed capital. Its assemblies rotated across six gate communities. No regent inherited Ivara's office.

Kharad waited until late afternoon.

New springs had risen around its seed beds during three basin seasons. They did not refill every western aquifer or restore the map. Pellin survived through canal rationing and a northward relocation of two wards. Sova never reopened one copper district. Elsewhere, seed-stones rooted water under land with no old claim to abundance.

Eastbank farmers and River camps had spent two years disputing the largest new spring. The movement court granted neither side ownership of the source. It set measured withdrawals, downstream minimums, seasonal review, and a protected strip wide enough for Kharad's return. Both parties still called the allotment unfair from opposite banks.

Children planted reed filters along its overflow. Benefits required maintenance as stubbornly as injuries did.

The first departure pulse reached Harth through released foundations. It came under one minute after the previous beat, deep enough to rattle unlatched crockery. White flags rose from every seasonal district. Red remained over the disputed house rib until workers placed it in the yellow yard. Then that flag changed too.

Korra climbed the ground pier beside Thalen, Meris, Beroch, and Kivik. None touched a command contact. Route scouts had cleared both the north corridor and a wider eastern alternative. Kharad could take either or turn elsewhere across the open plain.

Its forward plates lifted from the basin mud.

Water poured from fissures that had held salt all winter. Harth's remaining carried gardens flexed on released frames. Kharad shifted north, paused at a ridge, then angled toward the broad eastern grade no survey team had marked as preferred. Scouts moved their flags. Nobody tried to correct the choice.

"East alternative," Korra called. "Lift farm crossings two through seven. Hold the north route open until the hind plates clear."

Beroch relayed the notice to Sarn pasture crews under his own authority. River

keepers opened their flood bridges. Seasonal Harth stood on ground and watched the living country it had burdened for three centuries depart without its streets locked to skin.

Thalen leaned against Korra when fatigue took him. She braced him with her right shoulder. Her left hand remained stiff in its cradle between them.

By sunset, Kharad had crossed beyond the old basin rim. No ruler named its destination. The listening station recorded interval and direction, then Kivik raised the contact pad.

Korra walked back onto the detached bridge. Rainwater shone inside the new safety notch. Behind her, the released span settled on its ground piers and held.